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# Major Problems in Asian American History

## SECOND EDITION



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LON KURASHIGE • ALICE YANG

# Major Problems in Asian American History

*MAJOR PROBLEMS IN AMERICAN HISTORY SERIES*

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# Major Problems in Asian American History

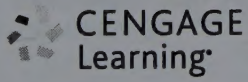
## Documents and Essays

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# Preface

The 2010 U.S. Census identified Asian Americans as the fastest growing racial population within the United States. Between 2000 and 2010, the number of individuals who identified as Asian, either alone or in combination with one or more races, grew almost 50% to reach 17.3 million (nearly 6% of the total U.S. population). Although concentrated in California, New York, Washington, and Hawai'i, the Asian American population grew in all states, especially in Nevada, Arizona, North Carolina, North Dakota, Georgia, and other places where few had settled before. The largest self-identified Asian ethnic group was Chinese Americans (4.0 million), followed by Filipino Americans (3.4 million), Asian Indian Americans (3.2 million), and Vietnamese Americans and Korean Americans (1.7 million each). Japanese Americans (1.3 million) were notable because almost one third were of mixed race heritage. Other major Asian American ethnic groups included Pakistanis, Cambodians, Laotians, Hmong, Thais, Indonesians, and Malaysians. Pacific Islander groups included native Hawaiians, Samoans, and Guamanians.

Before the 1960s the classification "Asian American" did not exist. During the social movements of that decade, students, activists, and scholars began using the term to promote solidarity among people of Asian ancestry. Programs in Asian American studies, the first of which was founded in 1969, as well as early scholarship, often emphasized a common history of struggle by primarily Chinese and Japanese immigrants and their descendants. Since the 1980s, research has uncovered the histories of Korean Americans, Filipino Americans, Southeast Asian Americans, South Asian Americans, native Hawaiians, and mixed race individuals. What is striking about research on Asian American history today is the increased diversity of groups, topics, and issues examined. This burgeoning field includes studies on all major Asian ethnic groups in terms of their ethnicity, migration, politics, work, self-employment, class, legal issues, community, family, education, religion, gender, sexuality, and culture. Attention to transnational flows of people, goods, and ideas—as well as their boundaries—has been a particularly exciting development since we published the first edition of this reader in 2003.

*Major Problems in Asian American History* invites readers to explore the dramatic growth in scholarship through primary and secondary sources on the rich history of Asian Americans. Our main goal in this volume is to present outstanding research that portrays the variety and complexity of Asian American experiences from the eighteenth to the twenty-first centuries while paying attention to core narratives and historical trends. Most of our contributors are historians, but we also include journalists, sociologists, anthropologists, and interdisciplinary scholars who provide thoughtful analyses of historical and contemporary issues. Essential documents, such as General John L. DeWitt's rationale for Japanese American internment (1942), are placed alongside less conventional primary sources, such as ethnic press articles and unpublished oral histories that offer intimate views of Asian American agency and showcase individuals with diverse backgrounds.

Expanding the boundaries of what is considered Asian American history, we take great pains to encourage the comparative analysis of ethnic groups and individual experiences, paying particular attention to the significance of gender, sexuality, geographical region, and economic, political, and cultural conditions. In each chapter, we include documents and essays that focus on a wide variety of Asian American experiences, while at the same time making sure that the leading groups and issues in the designated period remain central. We perform this same balancing act to ensure that the voices and experiences of women and Asian Americans outside the West Coast are validated and included in the historical analysis. The book also facilitates comparison across different time periods. For example, the post-1965 migrations highlighted in Chapter 12 can be compared with the nineteenth-century labor migrations addressed in Chapter 2, while the national security fears after Pearl Harbor in Chapter 8 can be compared with the national security fears after 9/11 in Chapter 15.

The book's first chapter provides an introduction to historiographical issues and allows readers to make a personal connection to the material through three essays recounting biographical and autobiographical experiences. Chapters 2 through 7 cover the period from the seventeenth century to the mid-twentieth century, beginning with the Pacific dimension to early China trade in which ships sailed between the Spanish colonies of Mexico and the Philippines. Over two centuries later, American commercial relations bought the kingdom of Hawai'i into the U.S. orbit and created an avenue for Chinese immigration to the United States and Hawai'i. Subsequent chapters address the causes and consequences of the exclusion of Chinese immigrants, as well as that of Asian Indians, Japanese, and Filipinos. They also address the agency of Asian American actors opposing exclusion and other forms of discrimination and responding to new Pacific empires by the United States and Japan. The first half of the book ends at the precipice of the Pearl Harbor attack with a discussion of the Americanization of immigrants and the U.S.-born generations within the context of shifting international relations in the face of growing instability between the United States, Japan, and China.

The second half of the book examines the period during and after America's participation in World War II. Selections address debates about Japanese American cooperation or resistance to World War II internment policies and the impact of

the Cold War on Asian American labor activism, suburbanization, interracial marriages, and adoption policies. These chapters look at how Asian American communities have been transformed by the influx of new immigrants following the Immigration Act of 1965, the arrival of refugees from Southeast Asia, and changing relations with other racial groups, including conflict between African Americans and Korean Americans during the Los Angeles civil disturbance of 1992. They challenge depictions of Asian Americans as "model minorities" and include a celebration of the 1960s "yellow power," a critique of heterosexism and patriarchy by an lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) activist, an account of transnational alliances against the trafficking of women and children in the Philippines, and a 2012 denunciation of the Pew Research Center's failure to acknowledge Asian American socioeconomic diversity. They also explore Asian American and Pacific Islander experiences outside the West Coast and Hawai'i with research on Arizona, Texas, Louisiana, Minnesota, Wisconsin, and Guam. A chapter on memory politics includes redress campaigns by Japanese Latin Americans, Filipino veterans, Hawaiian sovereignty advocates, and Guamanian independence activists. The book ends with a discussion of how Asian Americans have been policymakers, victims of racial profiling, and protesters during the War on Terror.

This book follows the same general format as other volumes in the Major Problems in American History series. Each chapter includes a short introduction that provides a general historical context, a selection of primary documents, and two essays. Headnotes to the document and essay sections explain the historical themes and interpretive issues in the selections. We provide a "Further Reading" list at the end of each chapter for students interested in additional research.

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We welcome comments, suggestions, and criticisms from students and instructors so that we can improve this book.

L.K.

A.Y.

# About the Authors



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CHAPTER 1



# Asian American History by the Generation

*Studying Asians in U.S. history is both an old and new endeavor. Early in the twentieth century, social scientists began to document the experiences of Asian immigrants to explain their impact on American society. Sociologists, who by profession were concerned with the negative effects of rapid industrialization, were especially interested in figuring out how a relatively small number of these newcomers provoked intense and widespread fears fueling anti-Asian stereotypes, practices, legislation, and violence. Scholarly studies came in two types. One type of study focused on the differences that set off Asian nations and their immigrants from Western peoples, civilizations, and standards of living. These studies emphasized the inability of Asian immigrants, due to race, culture, and civilization, to fit into American society. The other type of study, which was more racially liberal, documented ways in which the immigrants and their children were adapting to the host society and culture. This scholarship saw racial conflict not as a sign of permanent incompatibility, but, rather, as a stage in the long-term process of cultural adaptation through which Asians and whites eventually would reconcile their differences to reach a state of racial understanding and miscegenation.*

*A later generation of scholars emerging after World War II dismissed both types of earlier studies. The first type was seen as justifying popular and scientific theories of racism and racial hierarchy that had informed the Holocaust in Nazi Germany and thus had been soundly discredited. The second, liberal type was seen as an overly optimistic view of U.S. race relations that ignored the persistence of anti-Asian racism, as well as the efforts made by Asian Americans to retain their ethnic identities, cultures, and affinities. This was an understandable critique from a generation that during the 1960s and 1970s experienced the explosive atmosphere of racial unrest and animosity across the nation, in urban neighborhoods, in agricultural fields, and on college and university campuses. While earlier in the century the idea that Asian Americans were assimilating to white society was a liberal stance, it became conservative when the concept of white society became viewed as a site of "Anglo conformity" or "cultural genocide."*

*The study of Asian American history took off during this time when a critical mass of political activists reimagined the position and representation of Asian Americans in U.S. society. They catalyzed a social movement that revolutionized the conception of Asian Americans as silent, "model minorities" by casting them as vocal opponents to "white society" who stood in solidarity with black, Latino, Native American, and other radicals, as well as with overseas anticolonial revolutionaries, especially those fighting against U.S. forces in Southeast Asia. This explains the self-consciously political nature of much research on Asian American history, which has continued to the present.*

*By the 1980s, much, but not all, of the new scholarship began to orbit around the new scholarly field of Asian American Studies, within which a specialty on history emerged. By this time, many of the activists had become professors, and their PhD dissertations, books, journal articles, and teaching would produce the most robust scholarly attention that Asian Americans had ever received. By the 1990s, Asian American Studies had all the features of an academic discipline: its researchers could publish findings in two academic journals dedicated to their field, join a professional association, attend an annual conference, and teach in a sizable number of degree-granting academic programs and departments. Another sign of professionalization was the emergence of new and competing perspectives. These perspectives stem in part from a focus on different Asian American groups and time periods, but, in a more fundamental sense, they are rooted in different ways of approaching the past based on changing conditions in the present. Ever since the early twentieth century, pressing issues in a given historical period have influenced the approaches scholars have taken in studying the history of Asian Americans.*

## ESSAYS

The first essay, by journalist Helen Zia, reveals the rise of a new consciousness in the 1960s and 1970s in which she transformed from knowing "nothing" about being Asian American to becoming a political activist fighting for the group's empowerment. Zia discusses her lack of a political consciousness as a girl and racial minority growing up in suburban New Jersey in the 1950s, attributing this to the invisibility of Asians in her hometown and to the male-centric cultural traditions of her Chinese parents. The second essay, by Trinity College historian Vijay Prashad, discusses the ways in which the efforts of Indian immigrants to achieve the American Dream and become white have costs both for those immigrants and for the larger U.S. society. As an immigrant coming to the United States in the 1980s, Prashad became aware that pursuing such a dream reinforced white supremacy by requiring that Asian Americans not just embrace whiteness but also stigmatize African Americans. In the third essay, writer Wesley Yang offers a more recent view of Asian American identity dilemmas that sees desires for academic success and cultural assimilation as sheepish conformity. Whereas Zia and Prashad emphasize the importance of developing a political consciousness, Yang celebrates critical individuality that seeks to escape from obligation to politics, family, tradition, or ethnic group. What can explain the different responses to Asian American identity by Zia, Prashad, and Yang?

The final two essays turn to the scholarly field of Asian American history. The first, by U.C. Santa Barbara historian Paul Spickard, discusses limits to the political coalition among Asian Americans by asking what it would mean to include peoples who were not originally considered "Asian American." In the last essay, University of Minnesota historian Erika Lee and Brown University historian Naoko Shibusawa explore the need to broaden the vision of Asian American history beyond the borders of the United States. They question the predominantly national focus of research in this field. Yet theirs is not simply a global vision, but a "transnational" one that follows circulatory flows of people, goods, and ideas within the Asia-Pacific region.

## From Nothing, a Consciousness

HELEN ZIA

"Little China doll, what's your name?"

This question always made me feel awkward. I knew there was something unwholesome in being seen as a doll, and a fragile china one at that. But, taught to respect my elders at all times, I would answer dutifully, mumbling my name.

"Zia," they would cluck and nod. "It means 'aunt' in Italian, you know?"

To me, growing up in New Jersey, along the New York–Philadelphia axis, it seemed almost everyone was a little Italian, or at least had an Italian aunt.

One day in the early 1980s, the routine changed unexpectedly. I was introduced to a colleague, a newspaper editor. Making small talk, he said, "Your name is very interesting..." I noted his Euro-Anglo heritage and braced myself for yet another Italian lesson.

"Zia, hmm," he said. "Are you Pakistani?"

I nearly choked. For many people, Pakistan is not familiar geography. In those days it was inconceivable that a stranger might connect this South Asian, Pakistani name with my East Asian, Chinese face.

Through the unscientific process of converting Asian names into an alphabetic form, my romanized Chinese last name became identical to a common romanized Pakistani name. In fact, it was homonymous with a much despised ruler of Pakistan. Newspaper headlines about him read: "President Zia Hated by Masses" and "Pakistanis Cry, Zia Must Go." I'd clip out the headlines and send them to my siblings in jest. When President Zia's plane mysteriously crashed, I grew wary. After years of being mistaken for Japanese and nearly every other East Asian ethnicity, I added Pakistani to my list.

I soon discovered this would be the first of many such incidents. Zia Maria began to give way to Mohammad Zia ul-Haq. A new awareness of Asian Americans was emerging.

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Excerpts from "Nothing, a Consciousness" from ASIAN AMERICAN DREAMS by Helen Zia. Copyright © 2000 by Helen Zia. Reprinted by permission of Farrar, Straus and Giroux, LLC.

The abrupt change in my name ritual signaled my personal awakening to a modern-day American revolution in progress. In 1965, an immigration policy that had given racial preferences to Europeans for nearly two hundred years officially came to an end. Millions of new immigrants to America were no longer the standard vanilla but Hispanic, African, Caribbean, and—most dramatically for me—Asian. Though I was intellectually aware of the explosive growth in my community, I hadn't yet adjusted my own sense of self, or the way I imagined other Americans viewed me.

Up until then, I was someone living in the shadows of American society, struggling to find some way into a portrait that was firmly etched in white and, occasionally, black. And there were plenty of reminders that I wasn't relevant. Like the voices of my 1960s high school friends Rose and Julie. Rose was black, and Julie was white. One day we stood in the school yard, talking about the civil rights movement swirling around us, about cities engulfed in flames and the dreams for justice and equality that burned in each of us.

As I offered my thoughts, Rose abruptly turned to me and said, "Helen, you've got to decide if you're black or white." Stunned, I was unable to say that I was neither, that I had an identity of my own. I didn't know the words "Asian American." It was a concept yet to be articulated.

Somewhere between my school yard conversation and the confrontation with my Pakistani namesake, Asian Americans began to break through the shadows. By then we had already named ourselves "Asian American" and we were having raging debates and fantastic visions of an America *we* fit into. But few outside of Asian America cared about our shadow dreams.

Gradually we began to be visible, although not necessarily seen the way we wished. Then we had to discover what it meant to be in the light.

When I was growing up in the 1950s and 1960s, there were barely a half-million Asian Americans in the nation. Of those, only 150,000 were Chinese Americans—not enough to populate a small midwestern city. We made up less than 0.1 percent of the population. Most of us lived on the islands of Hawaii or in a few scattered Chinatown ghettoes....

On a clear day the Manhattan skyline is visible from Newark, but the insular familiarity of Chinatown was worlds away. Outside of Chinatown it was rare to encounter another person of Chinese or other Asian descent. In Newark and the various New Jersey communities where we later moved, the only way to meet Asians was to stop complete strangers on the street, while shopping, or at the bus stop—anywhere that we happened to see the occasional person who looked like us. At an A&P supermarket checkout counter, my mother met her friend Sue, who came to the United States as a war bride, having married a GI during the postwar occupation of Japan. The animosity between China and Japan that brought both women to New Jersey was never an issue. Each was so thrilled to find someone like herself.

Auntie Sue and her son Kim, who was of mixed race, white and Japanese, were regular visitors to our home. Though our mothers bonded readily, it was harder for their Asian American kids to connect simply because we looked alike. Mom and Auntie Sue had the shared experience of leaving their war-ravaged

Asian homes for a new culture, but Kim and I shared little except for our Asian features; we stuck out like yellow streaks on a white-and-black canvas. Outside of Chinatown, looking Asian meant looking foreign, alien, un-American. The pressure on us was to fit in with the "American" kids we looked so unlike, to conform and assimilate. Why would we want to be around other Asian kids who reminded us of our poor fit? At the tender age of six, I already felt different from the "real" Americans. I didn't feel comfortable with Kim and sensed his ambivalence to me. But the joke was on us, because no matter how hard we might try to blend in with the scenery, our faces gave us away.

Still, I was proud to be Chinese. Mom and Dad filled us with stories about their childhoods in China. Dad was born in 1912, one year after the founding of the Chinese Republic, and was imbued with a deep love for his native country. He was the second son of a widow who was spurned by her in-laws. His mother sold her own clothes to pay for his schooling. She beat my father every day so that he would study harder—this he told us proudly whenever we slacked off. Dad modeled his life after the ideal of the Confucian scholar-official: by studying assiduously he won academic honors and scholarships and achieved recognition as a poet and writer. China's system of open examinations was the foundation of the civil service—a Chinese creation, Dad pointedly reminded us as he turned the TV off. Studying hard, he said, was a time-honored route to advancement for even the poorest Chinese.

Mom grew up in Shanghai under the Japanese occupation. From the time she was a small child she lived with a fear and dislike of Japanese soldiers. Because of the war, her education was disrupted and she never went beyond the fourth grade—a source of regret that made her value education for her children. Mom's childhood memories were of wartime hardships and days spent picking out grains of rice from the dirt that had been mixed in as a way to tip the scales. Her stories taught me to be proud of the strength and endurance of the Chinese people.

Dad told us about our heritage. When other children made fun of us, or if news reports demeaned China, he reminded us that our ancestors wore luxurious silks and invented gunpowder while Europeans still huddled naked in caves. Of course, I knew that Europeans had discovered clothing, too, but the image was a reassuring one for a kid who didn't fit. My father wanted us to speak flawless English to spare us from ridicule and the language discrimination he faced. He forbade my mother to speak to us in Chinese, which was hard, since Mom spoke little English then. We grew up monolingual, learning only simple Chinese expressions—*che ve le*, "Come and eat"—and various Shanghainese epithets, like the popular phrase for a naughty child—*fei si le*, or "devilish to death." Dad also expected us to excel in school, since, he said, our Asian cranial capacities were larger than those of any other race. Pulling out the *Encyclopaedia Britannica* to prove his point, he'd make us study the entry, then test us to make sure we got the message. He told us about the Bering Strait and the land bridge from Asia to America, saying that we had a right to be in this country because we were cousins to the Native Americans.

These tidbits were critical to my self-esteem. In New Jersey, it was so unusual to see a person of Asian descent that people would stop what they were doing to

gawk rudely at my family wherever we went. When we walked into a store or a diner, we were like the freak show at Barnum & Bailey's circus, where Chinese were displayed as exotic creatures in the late 1800s, along with the two-headed dog. A sense of our own heritage and worth gave us the courage and cockiness to challenge their rudeness and stare down the gawkers.

What Mom and Dad couldn't tell us was what it meant to be Chinese in America. They didn't know—they were just learning about America themselves. We found little help in the world around us. Asians were referred to most often as Orientals, Mongols, Asiatics, heathens, the yellow hordes, and an assortment of even less endearing terms. Whatever the terminology, the message was clear: we were definitely not Americans.

There is a drill that nearly all Asians in America have experienced more times than they can count. Total strangers will interrupt with the absurdly existential question "What are you?" Or the equally common inquiry "Where are you from?" The queries are generally well intentioned, made in the same detached manner that you might use to inquire about a pooch's breed.

My standard reply to "What are you?" is "American," and to "Where are you from?" "New Jersey." These, in my experience, cause great displeasure. Eyebrows arch as the questioner tries again. "No, where are you really from?" I patiently explain that, really, I am from New Jersey. Inevitably this will lead to something like "Well then, what country are your people from?" Sooner or later I relent and tell them that my "people" are from China. But when I turn the tables and ask, "And what country are your people from?" the reply is invariably an indignant "I'm from America, of course."

The sad truth was that I didn't know much about my own history. I knew that Chinese had built the railroads, and then were persecuted. That was about it. I didn't know that in the 1700s a group of Filipinos settled in Louisiana, or that in 1825 the first Chinese was born in New York City. I didn't know that Asian laborers were brought to the Americas as a replacement for African slaves—by slave traders whose ships had been rerouted from Africa to Asia. I didn't even know that Japanese Americans had been imprisoned only a decade before my birth. Had I known more about my Asian American history I might have felt less foreign. Instead, I grew up thinking that perhaps China, a place I had never seen, was my true home, since so many people didn't think I belonged here.

I did figure out, however, that relations between America and any Asian nation had a direct impact on me. Whenever a movie about Japan and World War II played at the local theater, my brothers and I became the enemy. It didn't matter that we weren't Japanese—we looked Japanese. What's worse, by now my family had moved to a new housing development, one of the mass-produced Levittowns close to Fort Dix, the huge army base. Most of our neighbors had some connection to the military.

At the Saturday matinee, my brothers and I would sit with all the other kids in town watching the sinister Zero pilots prepare to ambush their unsuspecting prey, only to be thwarted by the all-American heroes—who were, of course, always white. These movies would have their defining moment, that crescendo of emotion when the entire theater would rise up, screaming, "Kill them, kill

them, kill them!"—them being the Japanese. When the movie was over and the lights came on, I wanted to be invisible so that my neighbors wouldn't direct their patriotic fervor toward me.

As China became the evil Communist menace behind the Bamboo Curtain, and the United States was forced to deal with its stalemate in the Korean War, the Asian countries seemed interchangeable. Back when Japan was the enemy, China was the good ally—after all, that's how my mom and dad got to come to America. But now, quixotically, Japan was good and China was evil.

Chinese in America were suspected to be the fifth column of Chinese Communists, as J. Edgar Hoover frequently said before Congress and throughout the McCarthy era witch-hunts. In the 1950s, while Japanese American families attempted to return to normalcy after their release from American concentration camps during the war, the FBI switched its surveillance eye onto hundreds of Chinese Americans. My father was one.

Our mail routinely arrived opened and damaged, and our phone reception was erratic. I thought everyone's mail service and phone lines were bad. Polite FBI agents interviewed our neighbors, asking if my father was up to anything suspicious. What attracted the attention of the FBI was Dad's tendency to write letters to newspapers and politicians when he disagreed with their views on China or anything else. Nothing ever came of the FBI investigations of my father, nor was a ring of Chinese American spies ever found—but I later learned that the probes succeeded in intimidating the Chinese American communities of the 1950s, creating a distrust of and inhibiting their participation in politics.

The FBI queries hardly bolstered our acceptance in our working-class housing tract. Neighbor kids would nose around and ask, "So what *does* your father do?" It didn't help that my father had instructed us to say, "He's self-employed." This only added to our sense of foreignness.

Like so many Asian immigrants unable to break into the mainstream American labor market, my father had to rely on his own resourcefulness and his family's labor. In the back room of our house we made "baby novelties" with little trinkets and baby toys and pink or blue vases that my father then sold to flower shops. Every day, in addition to doing our schoolwork, we helped out in the family business.

Our home was our workplace, the means to our livelihood, and therefore the center of everything. This conveniently matched the Confucian notion of family, whereby the father, as patriarch, is the master of the universe. In our household it was understood that no one should ever disobey, contradict, or argue with the patriarch, who, in the Confucian hierarchy, is a stand-in for God. My mother, and of course the children, were expected to obey God absolutely.

This system occasionally broke down when my mother and father quarreled, usually about my father's rigid expectations of us. But in the end, God always seemed to win. Growing up female, I [could see the Confucian order of the Three Obediences] in action: the daughter obeys the father, the wife obeys the husband, and, eventually, the widow obeys the son. The Confucian tradition was obviously stacked against me, as a girl.

I found similar lessons in the world beyond our walls. Mom's best friend from the Chinatown Shanghainese clique had followed us to New Jersey, attracted by the low home costs and the fact that we already lived there. Auntie Ching and her husband opened a Chinese restaurant at a major intersection of the highway. In those days, there were few places outside Chinatown to get real Chinese food. After they had spent their own money to upgrade the kitchen and remodel the restaurant, business was booming. But Auntie Ching had no lease for the restaurant—and the German American owner, sensing an opportunity for himself, evicted the Chings and set up his own shop.

Our tiny Chinese American community was horrified that the Chings would be treated so unjustly. My cantankerous dad urged them to fight it out in court. But they chose not to, believing that it would be better not to make waves. Chinese cannot win, they said, so why make trouble for ourselves? Such defeatism disturbed my father, who would often say in disgust, "In America, a 'Chinaman's chance' means no chance." He felt that the Chinese way of dealing with obstacles—to either accept or go around them, but not to confront them directly—would never get us very far in the United States.

As a child, I didn't see Chinese or other Asian Americans speaking up to challenge such indignities. When my parents were denied the right to rent or buy a home in various Philadelphia neighborhoods, they had to walk away despite my father's outrage. We could only internalize our shame when my mother and her troop of small children were thrown out of supermarkets because we were wrongly accused of opening packages and stealing. Or when Henry was singled out of a group of noisy third graders for talking and he alone was expelled from the lunchroom for the rest of the year. Or when my younger brother Hoyt and the few other Asian boys in school were rounded up because another kid said he thought he saw an "Oriental" boy go into his locker.

Other times the discomfort was less tangible. Why did my fifth-grade teacher, a Korean War veteran, become so agitated when topics of China and Asian culture came up? Was there a reason for his apparent dislike of me and my brothers, who also had him as a teacher? After my Girl Scout troop leader asked all the girls to state their religions, what caused her to scowl in disgust at me when I answered Buddhist? My family didn't practice an organized religion, so I didn't know what else to say.

Absorbing the uncertainty of my status in American society, I assumed the role that I observed for myself—one of silence and invisibility. I enjoyed school and, following my father's example, studied hard and performed well academically, but I consciously avoided bringing attention to myself and rarely spoke up, even on matters related to me.

For example, there was Mrs. George. From second grade until I graduated from John F. Kennedy High School, Mrs. George was my physical education teacher. She was the aunt of Olympic track star Carl Lewis and was always kind to me. But for those ten years, Mrs. George called me Zi, as though it rhymed with "eye." One day, when I was in twelfth grade, she yelled over at

me, "Zi, come over here." A classmate standing nearby said, "Mrs. George, Helen's name isn't Zi, it's Zia." Mrs. George looked at me and let out a huge laugh. "Zi," she said, then corrected herself. "I mean, Zia, how come you never told me how to say your name after all these years?"

I didn't know how to answer. It had never occurred to me to correct my teacher. In the Confucian order of the world, teachers were right up there with parents in commanding respect and obedience. I simply had no voice to raise to my teacher.

Despite my deference to traditional Chinese behavior, the day finally came when I had to disobey my father. I had received several offers of full scholarships to attend college. Like the Chinese who lined up for the imperial civil service examinations in hopes of a new life, I viewed college as my means of escape from the narrow life of making flower shop baby novelties in our dull New Jersey town.

Though my father was proud of my educational achievement, he didn't want me to leave for college. He had already stated his desire for me to attend the closest school to home. When the time came for him to sign the college registration forms, he refused. "The proper place for an unmarried daughter is at home with her parents," he insisted. He wanted to keep me out of trouble until I found a husband to do the overseeing.

I could see the doors to my future slamming shut. At age seventeen, I had never knowingly disobeyed my father. I policed myself, turning down dates, invitations to parties, and even educational opportunities away from home, because I thought Dad would disapprove. I was caught between two conflicting Asian ideals. The Three Obediences demanded subservience from females, but the primacy of education taught me to seek advancement through study. My American side told me to heed my own call.

Somehow I mustered the courage to shout, "No! I'm going to college." I don't know who was more surprised by my outburst, my father or me. He said nothing more about the subject, and I continued my preparations to leave. I also finally learned that the world wouldn't end if I challenged authority, a lesson I would take with me to college.

## The Forethought: Raw Skin

VIJAY PRASHAD

My sense of being an Indian in the world is mediated through the struggles of South Africans for liberation. So much are they a part of me that when Chris Hani, head of the South African Communist Party and a major figure in the ANC, was assassinated in 1994, I was brought to tears. As a teenager, I remember joining my classmates in emotional discussions about the battles against

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Vijay Prashad, "The Forethought: Raw Skin," in *Everybody Was Kung Fu Fighting: Afro-Asian Connections and the Myth of Cultural Purity* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2001). Retrieved from http://zombie-popcorn.com. Reprinted by permission.

apartheid. We talked about Gandhi's time in that far-off land and of the relationship between India and Africa. We sang, "*Amar raho, Nelson Mandela*" ("Be eternal, Nelson Mandela").

When I came to the United States, I fell into this tradition, first in the anti-apartheid movement of the early 1980s and then with El Salvador solidarity work. I and many of my immigrant friends put our shoulders to the wheel of these struggles, to join the diverse world of the U.S. Left. Names like Sanjay Anand, Anna Lopez, Noel Rodriquez, Karen May, Sid Lemelle, and so many others complicated our identification with the main fights of the day. Those of us who came from other nations found our America in the heart of the global fights for justice. This tendency to work across the lines that divide us continues in the fabric of the social justice movements in the United States, whether through the concept of "allies" in the queer liberation movement or else in cross-ethnic formations such as Asians for Mumia and the Center for Third World Organizing.

But all people of color do not feel that their struggle is a shared one. Some of my South Asian brethren, for example, feel that we should take care of our own and not worry about the woes of others, that we should earn as much money as possible, slide under the radar of racism, and care only about the prospects of our own children. To many of us from India, this is an uncomfortable bargain, but nonetheless it is one that is not unfamiliar in our times among all people.

White supremacy reigns, as it did then, and blackness is reviled. Who can begrudge the desire among people to seek fellowship in their new society, to throw themselves into the cultural worlds of the place in which they live? Since blackness is reviled in the United States, why would an immigrant, of whatever skin color, want to associate with those who are racially oppressed, particularly when the transit into the United States promises the dream of gold and glory? The immigrant seeks a form of vertical assimilation, to climb from the lowest, darkest echelon on the stepladder of tyranny into the bright whiteness. In U.S. history the Irish, Italians, Jews, and—in small steps with some hesitations on the part of white America—Asians and Latinos have all tried to barter their varied cultural worlds for the privileges of whiteness.

Yet all people who enter the United States do not strive to be accepted by the terms set by white supremacy. Some actively disregard them, finding them impossible to meet. Instead, they seek recognition, solidarity, and safety by embracing others also oppressed by white supremacy in something of a horizontal assimilation. Consider the rebel Africans, who fled the slave plantations in the Americas and took refuge among the Amerindians to create communities such as the Seminoles'; the South Asian workers who jumped ship in eighteenth-century Salem, Massachusetts, to enter the black community; Frederick Douglass's defense of Chinese "coolie" laborers in the nineteenth century; the interactions of the Black Panther Party with the Red Guard and the Brown Berets in the mid-twentieth century; and finally the multiethnic working-class gathering in the new century.

When people actively or tacitly refuse the terms of vertical integration they are derisively dismissed as either unassimilable or exclusionary. We hear "Why do the black kids sit together in the cafeteria," instead of "Why do our

institutions routinely uphold the privileges of whiteness?" There is little space in popular discourse for an examination of what goes on outside the realm of white America among people of color.

I have chosen to discuss the peoples who claim the heritage of the continents of Asia and Africa, not only because they are important to me, but because they have long been pitted against each other as the model versus the undesirable. I hope by looking at how these two cultural worlds are imbricated in complex and varied ways through five centuries and around the globe that I can help us rethink race, culture, and the organization of our society. This book is, if you will, a search for a new skin.

We begin our journey in the Indian Ocean region, with the destruction of the economic and cultural traffic that defined the premodern world. The birth of Atlantic racism superseded and (through fascism) transformed earlier xenophobic ideas into the cruelty of biological hierarchy. White supremacy emerged in the throes of capitalism's planetary birth to justify the expropriation of people off their lands and the exploitation of people for their labor. Of course, the discussion of the birth of racism begs the question of its demise: What is a useful antiracist ideological framework? The conservative theory of the color blind and the racialist theory of the indigenous, in their own way, smuggle in biological ideas of race to denigrate the creativity of diverse humans. The best liberal response to the color blind and to racialism comes from those who refuse to believe in the biological weight given to skin. This position, the liberalism of the skin, suggests that there are different skins, and we must learn to respect and tolerate one another.

Liberalism of the skin, which we generically know as multiculturalism, refuses to accept that biology is destiny, but it smuggles in culture to do much the same thing. Culture becomes the means for social and historical difference, how we differentiate ourselves, and adopt the habits of the past to create and delimit social groups. The familiar dichotomy between nature-nurture becomes the basis for distinction between the white supremacists and the liberals. Culture, unlike biology, should allow us to seek liberation from cruel and uncomfortable practices. But instead, culture wraps us in its suffocating embrace. If we follow liberalism of the skin, then we find ourselves heir to all the dilemmas of multiculturalism: Are cultures discrete and bounded? Do cultures have a history or are they static? Who defines the boundaries of culture or allows for change? Do cultures leak into each other? Can a person from one culture critique another culture? These are the questions that plague both social science and our everyday interactions. Those who subscribe to the liberalism of the skin want to be thought well of, to be good, and therefore, many are circumspect when it comes to the culture of another. The best intentions (of respect and tolerance) can often be annoying to those whose cultures are not in dominance: we feel that we are often zoological specimens.

To respect the fetish of culture assumes that one wants to enshrine it in the museum of humankind rather than find within it the potential for liberation or for change. We'd have to accept homophobia and sexism, class cruelty and racism, all in the service of being respectful to someone's perverse definition of a culture. For comfortable liberals a critique of multiculturalism is close to heresy,

but for those of us who have to tussle both with the cruelty of white supremacy and with the melancholic torments of minoritarianism, the critique comes with ease. The orthodoxy of below bears less power than that from above, but it is unbearable nonetheless. We have already begun to grow our own patchwork, defiant skins.

These defiant skins come under the sign of the polycultural, a provisional concept grounded in antiracism rather than in diversity. Polyculturalism, unlike multiculturalism, assumes that people live coherent lives that are made up of a host of lineages—the task of the historian is not to carve out the lineages but to make sense of how people live culturally dynamic lives. Polyculturalism is a ferocious engagement with the political world of culture, a painful embrace of the skin and all its contradictions.

## Paper Tigers: What Happens to All the Asian-American Overachievers When the Test-Taking Ends?

WESLEY YANG

Sometimes I'll glimpse my reflection in a window and feel astonished by what I see. Jet-black hair. Slanted eyes. A pancake-flat surface of yellow-and-green-toned skin. An expression that is nearly reptilian in its impassivity. I've contrived to think of this face as the equal in beauty to any other. But what I feel in these moments is its strangeness to me. It's my face. I can't disclaim it. But what does it have to do with me?

Millions of Americans must feel estranged from their own faces. But every self-estranged individual is estranged in his own way. I, for instance, am the child of Korean immigrants, but I do not speak my parents' native tongue. I have never called my elders by the proper honorific, "big brother" or "big sister." I have never dated a Korean woman. I don't have a Korean friend. Though I am an immigrant, I have never wanted to strive like one.

You could say that I am, in the gently derisive parlance of Asian-Americans, a banana or a Twinkie (yellow on the outside, white on the inside). But while I don't believe our roots necessarily define us, I do believe there are racially inflected assumptions wired into our neural circuitry that we use to sort through the sea of faces we confront. And although I am in most respects devoid of Asian characteristics, I do have an Asian face.

Here is what I sometimes suspect my face signifies to other Americans: an invisible person, barely distinguishable from a mass of faces that resemble it. A conspicuous person standing apart from the crowd and yet devoid of any individuality. An icon of so much that the culture pretends to honor but that it in fact patronizes and exploits. Not just people "who are good at math" and play the violin, but a mass of stifled, repressed, abused, conformist quasi-robots who simply do not matter, socially or culturally.

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Wesley Yang, "Paper Tigers: What Happens to All the Asian-American Overachievers When the Test-Taking Ends?" *New York Magazine*, May 8, 2011. Reprinted by permission.

I've always been of two minds about this sequence of stereotypes. On the one hand, it offends me greatly that anyone would think to apply them to me, or to anyone else, simply on the basis of facial characteristics. On the other hand, it also seems to me that there are a lot of Asian people to whom they apply.

Let me summarize my feelings toward Asian values: Fuck filial piety. Fuck grade-grubbing. Fuck Ivy League mania. Fuck deference to authority. Fuck humility and hard work. Fuck harmonious relations. Fuck sacrificing for the future. Fuck earnest, striving middle-class servility.

I understand the reasons Asian parents have raised a generation of children this way. Doctor, lawyer, accountant, engineer: These are good jobs open to whoever works hard enough. What could be wrong with that pursuit? Asians graduate from college at a rate higher than any other ethnic group in America, including whites. They earn a higher median family income than any other ethnic group in America, including whites. This is a stage in a triumphal narrative, and it is a narrative that is much shorter than many remember. Two thirds of the roughly 14 million Asian-Americans are foreign-born. There were less than 39,000 people of Korean descent living in America in 1970, when my elder brother was born. There are around 1 million today.

Asian-American success is typically taken to ratify the American Dream and to prove that minorities can make it in this country without handouts. Still, an undercurrent of racial panic always accompanies the consideration of Asians, and all the more so as China becomes the destination for our industrial base and the banker controlling our burgeoning debt. But if the armies of Chinese factory workers who make our fast fashion and iPads terrify us, and if the collective mass of high-achieving Asian-American students arouse an anxiety about the laxity of American parenting, what of the Asian-American who obeyed everything his parents told him? Does this person really scare anyone?...

A few months ago, I received an e-mail from a young man named Jefferson Mao, who after attending Stuyvesant High School had recently graduated from the University of Chicago. He wanted my advice about "being an Asian writer." This is how he described himself: "I got good grades and I love literature and I want to be a writer and an intellectual; at the same time, I'm the first person in my family to go to college, my parents don't speak English very well, and we don't own the apartment in Flushing that we live in. I mean, I'm proud of my parents and my neighborhood and what I perceive to be my artistic potential or whatever, but sometimes I feel like I'm jumping the gun a generation or two too early."...

Mao has a round face, with eyes behind rectangular wire-frame glasses. Since graduating, he has been living with his parents, who emigrated from China when Mao was 8 years old. His mother is a manicurist; his father is a physical therapist's aide. Lately, Mao has been making the familiar hour-and-a-half ride from Flushing to downtown Manhattan to tutor a white Stuyvesant freshman who lives in Tribeca. And what he feels, sometimes, in the presence of that amiable young man is a pang of regret. Now he understands better what he ought to have done back when he was a Stuyvesant freshman: "Worked half as hard and been twenty times more successful."

Entrance to Stuyvesant, one of the most competitive public high schools in the country, is determined solely by performance on a test: The top 3.7 percent of all New York City students who take the Specialized High Schools Admissions Test hoping to go to Stuyvesant are accepted. There are no set-asides for the underprivileged or, conversely, for alumni or other privileged groups. There is no formula to encourage "diversity" or any nebulous concept of "well--roundedness" or "character." Here we have something like pure meritocracy. This is what it looks like: Asian-Americans, who make up 12.6 percent of New York City, make up 72 percent of the high school.

This year, 569 Asian-Americans scored high enough to earn a slot at Stuyvesant, along with 179 whites, 13 Hispanics, and 12 blacks. Such dramatic overrepresentation, and what it may be read to imply about the intelligence of different groups of New Yorkers, has a way of making people uneasy. But intrinsic intelligence, of course, is precisely what Asians don't believe in. They believe—and have proved—that the constant practice of test-taking will improve the scores of whoever commits to it. All throughout Flushing, as well as in Bayside, one can find "cram schools," or storefront academies, that drill students in test preparation after school, on weekends, and during summer break. "Learning math is not about learning math," an instructor at one called Ivy Prep was quoted in the *New York Times* as saying. "It's about weightlifting. You are pumping the iron of math." Mao puts it more specifically: "You learn quite simply to nail any standardized test you take."...

Somewhere near the middle of his time at Stuyvesant, a vague sense of discontent started to emerge within Mao. He had always felt himself a part of a mob of "nameless, faceless Asian kids," who were "like a part of the décor of the place." He had been content to keep his head down and work toward the goal shared by everyone at Stuyvesant: Harvard. But around the beginning of his senior year, he began to wonder whether this march toward academic success was the only, or best, path.

"You can't help but feel like there must be another way," he explains over a bowl of phô. "It's like, we're being pitted against each other while there are kids out there in the Midwest who can do way less work and be in a garage band or something—and if they're decently intelligent and work decently hard in school..."...

Mao was becoming clued in to the fact that there was another hierarchy behind the official one that explained why others were getting what he never had—"a high-school sweetheart" figured prominently on this list—and that this mysterious hierarchy was going to determine what happened to him in life. "You realize there are things you really don't understand about courtship or just acting in a certain way. Things that somehow come naturally to people who go to school in the suburbs and have parents who are culturally assimilated." I pressed him for specifics, and he mentioned that he had visited his white girlfriend's parents' house the past Christmas, where the family had "sat around cooking together and playing Scrabble." This ordinary vision of suburban-American domesticity lingered with Mao: Here, at last, was the setting in which all that implicit knowledge "about social norms and propriety" had been transmitted. There was no cram school that taught these lessons....

While he was still an electrical-engineering student at Berkeley in the nineties, James Hong visited the IBM campus for a series of interviews. An older Asian researcher looked over Hong's résumé and asked him some standard questions. Then he got up without saying a word and closed the door to his office.

"Listen," he told Hong, "I'm going to be honest with you. My generation came to this country because we wanted better for you kids. We did the best we could, leaving our homes and going to graduate school not speaking much English. If you take this job, you are just going to hit the same ceiling we did. They just see me as an Asian Ph.D., never management potential. You are going to get a job offer, but don't take it. Your generation has to go farther than we did, otherwise we did everything for nothing."

The researcher was talking about what some refer to as the "Bamboo Ceiling"—an invisible barrier that maintains a pyramidal racial structure throughout corporate America, with lots of Asians at junior levels, quite a few in middle management, and virtually none in the higher reaches of leadership.

The failure of Asian-Americans to become leaders in the white-collar workplace does not qualify as one of the burning social issues of our time. But it is a part of the bitter undercurrent of Asian-American life that so many Asian graduates of elite universities find that meritocracy as they have understood it comes to an abrupt end after graduation. If between 15 and 20 percent of every Ivy League class is Asian, and if the Ivy Leagues are incubators for the country's leaders, it would stand to reason that Asians would make up some corresponding portion of the leadership class.

And yet the numbers tell a different story. According to a recent study, Asian-Americans represent roughly 5 percent of the population but only 0.3 percent of corporate officers, less than 1 percent of corporate board members, and around 2 percent of college presidents. There are nine Asian-American CEOs in the Fortune 500. In specific fields where Asian-Americans are heavily represented, there is a similar asymmetry. A third of all software engineers in Silicon Valley are Asian, and yet they make up only 6 percent of board members and about 10 percent of corporate officers of the Bay Area's 25 largest companies. At the National Institutes of Health, where 21.5 percent of tenure-track scientists are Asians, only 4.7 percent of the lab or branch directors are, according to a study conducted in 2005. One succinct evocation of the situation appeared in the comments section of a website called Yellowworld: "If you're East Asian, you need to attend a top-tier university to land a good high-paying gig. Even if you land that good high-paying gig, the white guy with the pedigree from a mediocre state university will somehow move ahead of you in the ranks simply because he's white."

Jennifer W. Allyn, a managing director for diversity at PricewaterhouseCoopers, works to ensure that "all of the groups feel welcomed and supported and able to thrive and to go as far as their talents will take them." I posed to her the following definition of parity in the corporate workforce: If the current crop of associates is 17 percent Asian, then in fourteen years, when they have all been up for partner review, 17 percent of those who are offered partner will be Asian. Allyn

conceded that PricewaterhouseCoopers was not close to reaching that benchmark anytime soon—and that "nobody else is either."

Part of the insidious nature of the Bamboo Ceiling is that it does not seem to be caused by overt racism. A survey of Asian-Pacific-American employees of Fortune 500 companies found that 80 percent reported they were judged not as Asians but as individuals. But only 51 percent reported the existence of Asians in key positions, and only 55 percent agreed that their firms were fully capitalizing on the talents and perspectives of Asians.

More likely, the discrepancy in these numbers is a matter of unconscious bias. Nobody would affirm the proposition that tall men are intrinsically better leaders, for instance. And yet while only 15 percent of the male population is at least six feet tall, 58 percent of all corporate CEOs are. Similarly, nobody would say that Asian people are unfit to be leaders. But subjects in a recently published psychological experiment consistently rated hypothetical employees with Caucasian-sounding names higher in leadership potential than identical ones with Asian names.

Maybe it is simply the case that a traditionally Asian upbringing is the problem. As Allyn points out, in order to be a leader, you must have followers. Associates at PricewaterhouseCoopers are initially judged on how well they do the work they are assigned. "You have to be a doer," as she puts it. They are expected to distinguish themselves with their diligence, at which point they become "super-doers." But being a leader requires different skill sets. "The traits that got you to where you are won't necessarily take you to the next level," says the diversity consultant Jane Hyun, who wrote a book called *Breaking the Bamboo Ceiling*. To become a leader requires taking personal initiative and thinking about how an organization can work differently. It also requires networking, self-promotion, and self-assertion. It's racist to think that any given Asian individual is unlikely to be creative or risk-taking. It's simple cultural observation to say that a group whose education has historically focused on rote memorization and "pumping the iron of math" is, on aggregate, unlikely to yield many people inclined to challenge authority or break with inherited ways of doing things.

Sach Takayasu had been one of the fastest-rising members of her cohort in the marketing department at IBM in New York. But about seven years ago, she felt her progress begin to slow. "I had gotten to the point where I was overdelivering, working really long hours, and where doing more of the same wasn't getting me anywhere," she says. It was around this time that she attended a seminar being offered by an organization called Leadership Education for Asian Pacifics.

LEAP has parsed the complicated social dynamics responsible for the dearth of Asian-American leaders and has designed training programs that flatter Asian people even as it teaches them to change their behavior to suit white-American expectations. Asians who enter a LEAP program are constantly assured that they will be able to "keep your values, while acquiring new skills," along the way to becoming "culturally competent leaders."

In a presentation to 1,500 Asian-American employees of Microsoft, LEAP president and CEO J.D. Hokoyama laid out his grand synthesis of the Asian

predicament in the workplace. "Sometimes people have perceptions about us and our communities which may or may not be true," Hokoyama told the audience. "But they put those perceptions onto us, and then they do something that can be very devastating: They make decisions about us not based on the truth but based on those perceptions." Hokoyama argued that it was not sufficient to rail at these unjust perceptions. In the end, Asian people themselves would have to assume responsibility for unmaking them. This was both a practical matter, he argued, and, in its own way, fair.

Aspiring Asian leaders had to become aware of "the relationship between values, behaviors, and perceptions." He offered the example of Asians who don't speak up at meetings. "So let's say I go to meetings with you and I notice you never say anything. And I ask myself, 'Hmm, I wonder why you're not saying anything. Maybe it's because you don't know what we're talking about. That would be a good reason for not saying anything. Or maybe it's because you're not even interested in the subject matter. Or maybe you think the conversation is beneath you.' So here I'm thinking, because you never say anything at meetings, that you're either dumb, you don't care, or you're arrogant. When maybe it's because you were taught when you were growing up that when the boss is talking, what are you supposed to be doing? Listening."

Takayasu took the weeklong course in 2006. One of the first exercises she encountered involved the group instructor asking for a list of some qualities that they identify with Asians. The students responded: upholding family honor, filial piety, self-restraint. Then the instructor solicited a list of the qualities the members identify with leadership, and invited the students to notice how little overlap there is between the two lists.

At first, Takayasu didn't relate to the others in attendance, who were listing typical Asian values their parents had taught them. "They were all saying things like 'Study hard,' 'Become a doctor or lawyer,' blah, blah, blah. That's not how my parents were. They would worry if they saw me working too hard." Takayasu had spent her childhood shuttling between New York and Tokyo. Her father was an executive at Mitsubishi; her mother was a concert pianist. She was highly assimilated into American culture, fluent in English, poised and confident. "But the more we got into it, as we moved away from the obvious things to the deeper, more fundamental values, I began to see that my upbringing had been very Asian after all. My parents would say, 'Don't create problems. Don't trouble other people.' How Asian is that? It helped to explain why I don't reach out to other people for help." It occurred to Takayasu that she was a little bit "heads down" after all. She was willing to take on difficult assignments without seeking credit for herself. She was reluctant to "toot her own horn."

Takayasu has put her new self-awareness to work at IBM, and she now exhibits a newfound ability for horn tooting. "The things I could write on my résumé as my team's accomplishments: They're really impressive," she says.

The law professor and writer Tim Wu grew up in Canada with a white mother and a Taiwanese father, which allows him an interesting perspective on how whites and Asians perceive each other. After graduating from law school, he took a series of clerkships, and he remembers the subtle ways in which

hierarchies were developed among the other young lawyers. "There is this automatic assumption in any legal environment that Asians will have a particular talent for bitter labor," he says, and then goes on to define the word *coolie*, a Chinese term for "bitter labor." "There was this weird self-selection where the Asians would migrate toward the most brutal part of the labor."

By contrast, the white lawyers he encountered had a knack for portraying themselves as above all that. "White people have this instinct that is really important: to give off the impression that they're only going to do the really important work. You're a quarterback. It's a kind of arrogance that Asians are trained not to have. Someone told me not long after I moved to New York that in order to succeed, you have to understand which rules you're supposed to break. If you break the wrong rules, you're finished. And so the easiest thing to do is follow all the rules. But then you consign yourself to a lower status. The real trick is understanding what rules are not meant for you."

This idea of a kind of rule-governed rule-breaking—where the rule book was unwritten but passed along in an innate cultural sense—is perhaps the best explanation I have heard of how the Bamboo Ceiling functions in practice. LEAP appears to be very good at helping Asian workers who are already culturally competent become more self-aware of how their culture and appearance impose barriers to advancement. But I am not sure that a LEAP course is going to be enough to get Jefferson Mao or Daniel Chu the respect and success they crave. The issue is more fundamental, the social dynamics at work more deeply embedded, and the remedial work required may be at a more basic level of comportment....

Sometime during the hundreds of hours he spent among the mostly untouched English-language novels at the Flushing branch of the public library, Jefferson Mao discovered literature's special power of transcendence, a freedom of imagination that can send you beyond the world's hierarchies. He had written to me seeking permission to swerve off the traditional path of professional striving—to devote himself to becoming an artist—but he was unsure of what risks he was willing to take. My answer was highly ambivalent. I recognized in him something of my own youthful ambition. And I knew where that had taken me.

Unlike Mao, I was not a poor, first-generation immigrant. I finished school alienated both from Asian culture (which, in my hometown, was barely visible) and the manners and mores of my white peers. But like Mao, I wanted to be an individual. I had refused both cultures as an act of self-assertion. An education spent dutifully acquiring credentials through relentless drilling seemed to me an obscenity. So did adopting the manipulative cheeriness that seemed to secure the popularity of white Americans.

Instead, I set about contriving to live beyond both poles. I wanted what James Baldwin sought as a writer—"a power which outlasts kingdoms." Anything short of that seemed a humiliating compromise. I would become an aristocrat of the spirit, who prides himself on his incompetence in the middling tasks that are the world's business. Who does not seek after material gain. Who is his own law.

This, of course, was madness. A child of Asian immigrants born into the suburbs of New Jersey and educated at Rutgers cannot be a law unto himself.

The only way to approximate this is to refuse employment, because you will not be bossed around by people beneath you, and shave your expenses to the bone, because you cannot afford more, and move into a decaying Victorian mansion in Jersey City, so that your sense of eccentric distinction can be preserved in the midst of poverty, and cut yourself free of every form of bourgeois discipline, because these are precisely the habits that will keep you chained to the mediocre fate you consider worse than death.

Throughout my twenties, I proudly turned away from one institution of American life after another (for instance, a steady job), though they had already long since turned away from me. Academe seemed another kind of death—but then again, I had a transcript marred by as many F's as A's. I had come from a culture that was the middle path incarnate. And yet for some people, there can be no middle path, only transcendence or descent into the abyss.

I was descending into the abyss.

All this was well deserved. No one had any reason to think I was anything or anyone. And yet I felt entitled to demand this recognition. I knew this was wrong and impermissible; therefore I had to double down on it. The world brings low such people. It brought me low. I haven't had health insurance in ten years. I didn't earn more than $12,000 for eight consecutive years. I went three years in the prime of my adulthood without touching a woman. I did not produce a masterpiece.

I recall one of the strangest conversations I had in the city. A woman came up to me at a party and said she had been moved by a piece of writing I had published. She confessed that prior to reading it, she had never wanted to talk to me, and had always been sure, on the basis of what she could see from across the room, that I was nobody worth talking to, that I was in fact someone to avoid.

But she had been wrong about this, she told me: It was now plain to her that I was a person with great reserves of feeling and insight. She did not ask my forgiveness for this brutal misjudgment. Instead, what she wanted to know was—why had I kept that person she had glimpsed in my essay so well hidden? She confessed something of her own hidden sorrow: She had never been beautiful and had decided, early on, that it therefore fell to her to "love the world twice as hard." Why hadn't I done that?

Here was a drunk white lady speaking what so many others over the years must have been insufficiently drunk to tell me. It was the key to many things that had, and had not, happened. I understood this encounter better after learning about LEAP, and visiting Asian Playboy's boot camp. If you are a woman who isn't beautiful, it is a social reality that you will have to work twice as hard to hold anyone's attention. You can either linger on the unfairness of this or you can get with the program. If you are an Asian person who holds himself proudly aloof, nobody will respect that, or find it intriguing, or wonder if that challenging façade hides someone worth getting to know. They will simply write you off as someone not worth the trouble of talking to.

Having glimpsed just how unacceptable the world judges my demeanor, could I too strive to make up for my shortcomings? Practice a shit-eating grin until it becomes natural? Love the world twice as hard?

I see the appeal of getting with the program. But this is not my choice. Striving to meet others' expectations may be a necessary cost of assimilation, but I am not going to do it.

Often I think my defiance is just delusional, self-glorifying bullshit that artists have always told themselves to compensate for their poverty and powerlessness. But sometimes I think it's the only thing that has preserved me intact, and that what has been preserved is not just haughty caprice but in fact the meaning of my life. So this is what I told Mao: In lieu of loving the world twice as hard, I care, in the end, about expressing my obdurate singularity at any cost. I love this hard and unyielding part of myself more than any other reward the world has to offer a newly brightened and ingratiating demeanor, and I will bear any costs associated with it.

The first step toward self-reform is to admit your deficiencies. Though my early adulthood has been a protracted education in them, I do not admit mine. I'm fine. It's the rest of you who have a problem. Fuck all y'all.

## Whither the Asian American Coalition?

PAUL SPICKARD

By the 1980s the idea that Asian Americans were a single panethnic group whose members had a lot in common across lines of ancestral ethnic nationality had become a fairly unremarkable feature of life, not only on the West Coast but in communities all across the nation. Yet it was always the case that some peoples were closer to the heart of the Asian American coalition than others. In the 1970s the core ethnic groups were Chinese and Japanese Americans, with Filipino Americans relegated to a second circle.

The Immigration Act of 1965 removed the racial bar against Asian immigration, and the numbers of Asian immigrants soared. By the 1990s Asian Americans had become the fastest-growing American racial minority (in percentage terms), and the countries from which they or their ancestors came multiplied. Chinese and Filipinos continued to arrive in large numbers, but hundreds of thousands of others came from Korea, Taiwan, Vietnam, and other countries in Southeast Asia. The forces of globalization brought many more from India, Pakistan, and elsewhere in South and Southwest Asia. By the end of the twentieth century the Asian American coalition had grown in size and in the number of its constituent parts, but some groups were still generally regarded to be near the center of Asian American identity and others to be further away. Korean Americans had joined Chinese and Japanese Americans at the core of the Asian American coalition; Filipinos, Vietnamese, and some multiracial people of part-Asian parentage formed a second circle; and other Southeast Asians and South Asians were still more loosely connected to the coalition (Figure 1.1).

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Spickard, Paul. "Whither the Asian American Coalition?" *Pacific Historical Review*, 76, no. 14 (November 2007). © 2007 by the Regents of the University of California. Published by the University of California Press.

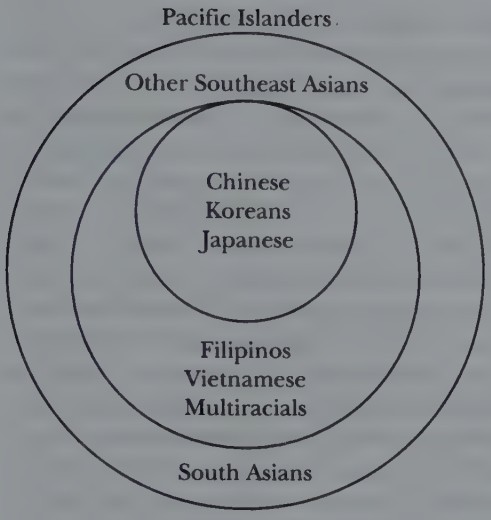



**FIGURE 1.1** Centrality and marginality of Asian American groups, 1990s.

## Are These Asian Americans?

Let us consider how four groups of people—Pacific Islander Americans, multiracial people of part-Asian descent, international adoptees, and Arab and other Middle Eastern Americans—might or might not be regarded as members of, or connected to, the Asian American coalition, now and in the years to come.

***Pacific Islander Americans.*** Pacific Island peoples in the United States have long been lumped together with Asian Americans by non-Pacific Islanders. The U.S. Census long included Hawaiians, Samoans, Tongans, Maori, Chamorros, and other Pacific Island peoples in their aggregate numbers for Asian Americans. Sometimes the lumping has been done by Asian Americans, but very seldom by Pacific Islanders. Some histories, textbooks, and anthologies on Asian American subjects have routinely included treatment of Pacific Islanders. Others have routinely ignored them. There were plenty of Pacific Islanders in the United States when the Asian American coalition was founded, but they were not then part of that coalition....

Early in the [21st] century, several Pacific Islander American scholars proposed to re-engage Asian America. Debbie Hippolite Wright called for a frank, open, mutually respectful, and mutually supportive dialogue between Asian and Pacific Islander Americans, with a goal to build a working coalition to support each other's issues, from antiracism to immigration reform to Hawaiian sovereignty. Several scholars, noting that Hawaiians, Maori, Chamorros, Samoans, and other Pacific Islanders had long been active in the Association for Asian American Studies (AAAS), asked that the name of the scholarly association be changed again, to include Pacific Islanders—but this time, to really include them. Scholars like Vicente Diaz, Davianna Pomaika'i McGregor, Amy Ku'uleialoha Stillman, and Joanne Rondilla cited the long, intertwined history of

people who have conventionally been regarded as Pacific Islanders and those regarded as Asians. They pointed to the manifest linkages between how American colonialism has been experienced by some Pacific Island peoples such as Hawaiians, Samoans, and Chamorros, and how it has been experienced by some Asians (Filipinos, especially, but also Japanese, Vietnamese, and others). They pointed to the large numbers of Filipinos, Japanese, Chinese, and other Asians who have been in the Pacific in the modern era, as well as to ancient trade and cultural links between island and continental peoples.

The panethnic concepts "Asian" and "Pacific Islander" mask profound differences between some of their constituent groups. Punjabis and Koreans share very little history or experience, yet they are in the Asian American coalition. Hawaiians and Solomon Islanders likewise have very little common history or experience, yet they are both Pacific Islanders. On the other hand, Filipinos are considered to be in the Asian American coalition and Chamorros in the Pacific Islander coalition, despite the fact that Filipinos and Chamorros share vast amounts of common history, culture, and social placement. Not all the history between Asian and Pacific Islander Americans is common history; sometimes it has been a history of oppositional interests and actions, as the ongoing discussion of "Asian settler colonialism" in Hawai'i suggests. But Asian Americans and Pacific Islanders have had a great deal of intertwined history, and it will be useful as we go forward to explore the intertwining, even as we recognize that Pacific Islanders are not a subset of Asian America.

What would it mean for historians of Asian America consciously to ask ourselves: How do the issues that I think I am seeing in my study of Asian Americans look different if I consider the situations of Pacific Island peoples as well? I think we might well have a much greater appreciation for the flexible and contingent nature of ethnic coalitions, as well as for the role played by American (and perhaps other nations') colonialism. We might want to open up our inquiry to talk about the links between the American colonial projects in California, in Hawai'i, in the Philippines, and in Southwest Asia into the twenty-first century. We might want to think critically about Asian immigrants' complicity in Japanese colonialism in Micronesia and in American colonialism in Hawai'i.

***Multiracial Asian Americans.*** Multiracial people are also part of Asian America and have been from the beginning, although the monoracially framed histories of Asian America have generally lost sight of their existence. In the mid-1990s a tall, slim, pale, chestnut-haired, hazel-eyed student stood up and accosted the instructor of an Asian American studies class at a renowned West Coast university. The professor had been speaking about Asian Americans as if they were a racially pure people, as if there had been no mixing and blending between Asians and other Americans. The student declared: "Look at me. I am the face of Asian America."

The student had a point. Outmarriage by several Asian American groups—particularly Filipinos, Japanese, and Vietnamese—has been increasing since the latter 1940s. The rate now hovers around 50 percent for those three groups, and other groups are not far behind. Maria Root talks of an "interracial baby boom" following the *Loving v. Virginia* U.S. Supreme Court decision of 1967, which overturned state antimiscegenation laws....

In writing a book about skin-tone preferences among Asian Americans, my fellow researchers and I found that, when we asked almost any Asian American to go back in his or her family history more than a few generations, they were almost uniformly surprised to find out that there was someone two or three generations back who was mixed with another Asian nationality, or with someone White or Black or Latino, whose story had been erased from official family memory. Chinese have been mixing with most of the peoples of Southeast Asia for centuries, to the point where most Filipino, Cambodian, Vietnamese, Thai, Lao, and Burmese Americans have at least some Chinese ancestry. Many Vietnamese and Cambodian Americans have elements of the other group's ethnic ancestry within their family lines. Throughout the first half of the twentieth century, Punjabi men made families with Mexican American women in California's San Joaquin and Imperial valleys. Filipino and Mexican Americans have been living in the same towns and neighborhoods, working at the same jobs, and often being members of the same families since at least the 1930s. Most Pacific Islander Americans have multiple ancestries—mixed Tongan and Samoan, Maori and Pakeha, Hawaiian and Haole, Chamorro and Filipino, and so on and on.

What would it mean for historians of Asian America consciously to ask ourselves: How do the issues that I think I am seeing among Asian Americans look different if I consider the situations of multiracial Asian Americans as well? It may be that the options and ambiguities surrounding an individual's identity will be as important as the single-group commitments. It will surely be that the nature and prospects of any group will immediately look very much more complex. If we explore racial and ethnic multiplicity in Asian American history, we open ourselves up to thinking about connections between groups, and not just between groups that have traditionally been included in the Asian American coalition.

***Adoptees.*** One of the places in Asian American history where the multiracial story must be told is with respect to international and transracial adoption. According to the online adoption service Adoption.com, each year more than 20,000 people come to the United States as international adoptees—in 2005, more than 8,000 from China alone. By far the majority of such people become part of multiracial families; many of them join White families in the American heartland. At various times since World War II, Japan, Korea, and Vietnam have sent large numbers of multiracial adoptees—presumably the children of U.S. GIs—to the United States. The rule of thumb in Korean adoptee activist circles is that one in ten Korean Americans is an adoptee (I don't know of any authoritative figure on this). Yet no one has written the history of international adoptees as Asian Americans, nor even as immigrants. The field has been left to social workers, novelists, anthropologists, and adoptees themselves to tell their stories. Those stories, as told by such people, almost never explore whether and how such people might be considered part of Asian America. Certainly, none of the mainstream historians of Asian America treats adoptees as part of the Asian American story.

What would it mean for historians of Asian America consciously to ask ourselves: How do the issues that I think I am seeing among Asian Americans look different if I consider the situations of internationally and transracially adopted Asian Americans as well? Talking about Asian American adoptee history forces us to think transnationally, for the history of the birth country and its relationship with the United States is inevitably part of the adoptee story. As with Pacific Islanders and multiracial people, adoptee history invites us to think more deeply and critically about the implications of U.S. colonial involvement in Asia and in Asian America. What is more, considering adoptees as Asian Americans opens up the Asian American story to embrace multiple definitions of group membership. Does one need to have grown up in an Asian American family and community in order to be an Asian American? Or does Asian biological ancestry suffice? Ought adoptees from Korea be treated as part of Korean American history? Or should they be thought of, along with adoptees from Japan, China, and Vietnam, as part of a pan-Asian adoptee experience?

***Arab and Middle Eastern Americans.*** I don't know anyone who asserts that Arab, North African, Persian, or other Middle Eastern-derived Americans are a subset of Asian Americans. Yet growing numbers of Arab and Middle Eastern American scholars have regularly been part of the Association for Asian American Studies, have contributed to Asian American publications, and have wanted to talk about whether, and in what ways, Arab or other Middle Eastern Americans might connect with the Asian American coalition. Perhaps it is partly that, as with Pacific Islander Americans, there is nowhere else on the ethnic studies map for such people to find a home, and the Asian American coalition has always shown some flexibility and welcome.

Let me point to issues where the experiences of Asian Americans and Arab and Middle Eastern Americans have considerable resonance, even commonality. The first is Orientalism. Arab and other Middle Eastern Americans experienced the European-generated, eastward-looking Orientalism about which Edward Said wrote and that was defined mainly by images of Turkey, Arabia, and Persia. That is quite a different thing from the westward-looking Orientalism, built on contemplation of China and Japan, that focused American Orientalist thinkers. White Americans may call both Japanese Americans and Arab Americans Orientals, but they do not really think of them as the same sort of people, whereas they do think of Japanese and Chinese as pretty much the same. Yet the two Orientalisms overlap and come together in many places, not least in the study of Asian religions in America (which must be distinguished from the study of the religious experiences of Asian Americans).

A connected Orientalism contributes to the fact that Asian Americans and Middle Eastern Americans are the two largest immigrant groups who have never quite overcome their immigrant status, no matter how many generations they may have lived in the United States. Other Americans see Asians, Arabs, Persians, and other Middle Eastern peoples as eternal foreigners, much as White Americans treat U.S. citizens of East and South Asian descent as if they were from a foreign land. Vincent Chin was murdered because his attackers took

him for a citizen of Japan. In 1996 a Seattle newspaper combed the records of contributors to American-born Gary Locke's gubernatorial campaign for non-citizen Chinese names; they did not look for non-citizen English or Scandinavian names in his opponent's contributor lists. Asian American scientists have lost their jobs, and one was incarcerated without cause, in a racist scare campaign in the 1990s that alleged Asian Americans were giving secrets to the People's Republic of China. Just as numerous are the cases of people of Middle Eastern ancestry being cast as foreigners by White Americans. If one asks the average American to describe an Arab, a Muslim, or someone whose ancestors are from the Middle East, out comes a chilling description of a terrorist or sinister oil baron. Almost no one talks about Ralph Nader, John Zogby, and Danny Thomas as Arab Americans.

Arab and Asian Americans have a linked history with regard to a series of court cases from the 1910s and 1920s that decided definitively who was White (and therefore allowed to become a naturalized citizen) and who was not. The answers then were different: George Dow, a Lebanese immigrant, was judged first not White, but then the federal court reversed the decision and ruled that he was White after all. The court never had any question about Japanese-born Takao Ozawa or Bhagat Singh Thind, an immigrant from India: They were not White. Yet in the years after the oil shocks of 1974, and especially after the rise of violence in the 1990s by people whom White Americans chose to call Muslim terrorists, Arab and Middle Eastern Americans grew darker and darker in the White American imaginary.

In recent years, especially since September 11, 2001, several South Asian and Arab American scholars have begun to explore commonalities between their groups' experiences and ways in which they might form intellectual and political coalitions. One aspect of both communities is the large minority of Muslims in each. Another has to do with the ways in which both Asians and Middle Eastern Americans have experienced American colonialism at home and abroad. Then there is the conflation in White American minds of Middle Eastern and South Asian-descended peoples. It is tragic, but not accidental, that several of the people murdered or attacked in hate crimes just after September 11 were not Muslims, nor Arabs, nor Middle Eastern Americans at all, but rather Sikhs. As journalist Tram Nguyen wrote of immigrants in the years since 9/11: "We are all suspects now."

What would it mean for historians of Asian America consciously to ask ourselves: How do the issues that I think I am seeing in my study of Asian Americans look different if I consider the situations of Arab and other Middle Eastern Americans as well? Surely, there is important historical work to do at the intersection of the experiences of Asian Americans and of Arab and other Middle Eastern Americans.

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In the end, I suppose I am calling for a less essentialist, more flexible vision of who is an Asian American. The lives and experiences of Pacific Islander Americans have much in common with those of certain groups such as Filipinos who have long been part of the Asian American coalition. The multiracial aspect

of many Asian Americans, and the persons of many multiracial people, have been for the most part unacknowledged in Asian American history. Adoptees from Asian countries have also been left out of Asian American history. Likewise, there is a good bit of common experience and current political positioning between Arab Americans, other Middle Eastern Americans, and South Asian Americans. The commonalities of inquiry may be tied to the politics of particular historical moments, whereas the Asian American coalition has up until now been quite durable and has evolved only slowly.

The one issue that seems to tie all these threads together is U.S. colonialism around the world, and its creation of racial hierarchies both abroad and at home. American colonialism, Orientalism, and racism may make it necessary that historical inquiry be made on the basis of larger and shifting coalitions, rather than the simpler Asian American coalition of old. If historians of Asian America take up a more complex and shifting idea of who is an Asian American, we will have to make conscious, explicit choices of who we will regard as an Asian American as we address each project.

## What Is Transnational Asian American History?

ERIKA LEE AND NAOKO SHIBUSAWA

Beginning IN THE 1990S, THE TERM "globalization" became a catchall phrase to explain a multitude of economic, cultural, and political transformations taking place around the world in everything from finance markets and technologies to fast food and popular culture. Pundits and laypeople alike asserted that internet technology, cell phones, and faster and more frequent air travel made the world a smaller place. People were on the move, too, migrating not only along the older patterns of south to north and east to west, but also in newer and unpredictable patterns of remigration and secondary migration. Scholars generally recognized globalization as an intensification and acceleration of centuries-old patterns of trade and migration, and nearly everyone—regardless of whether they decried or celebrated globalization—saw it as a process that denied the centrality of the nation-state. In the age of globalization, consumer products, capital, and people supposedly traveled, or should be able to travel, across national boundaries "freely," without undue state hindrance.

Within academia, the call came loud and clear from many different fronts that it was time to examine and explain these changes by widening the traditional focus on the nation-state to a transnational framework. In the field of U.S. history, the Organization of American Historians sponsored a working group devoted to "rethinking American history in a global age." In 2000, the resulting LaPietra Report to the profession urged scholars to "extend our analysis of [national histories] to incorporate an awareness of larger, transnational contexts, processes, and identities." The *Journal of American History* encouraged the

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field to consider transnational U.S. history with its special issue in 1999. Similarly, the American Studies Association sponsored conferences with themes emphasizing crossing borders and national, transnational, and postnational issues. In 2004, Shelly Fisher Fishkin noted the "transnational turn" in American Studies, explaining that the field was an "increasingly important site of knowledge ... a place where borders both within and outside the nation are interrogated and studied, rather than reified and reinforced." And as a sign of the growing scholarship on transnationalism within the field of Asian Studies, the *Journal of Asian Studies* also began to include a section on "Comparative and Transnational" work in its book review section beginning in 2001.

The term "transnational" has admittedly now become an academic buzzword. Scholars in different disciplines and areas of studies have used the term so loosely that its very meaning is in danger of being diluted. This special issue ... is an attempt to define what we mean by "transnational Asian American history," to give recent examples, and to start exploring its possibilities and challenges.

First, it is useful to think about the terminology more carefully. The terms "transnational," "global," "international," and "diaspora" are also often used interchangeably and often complement each other. But, they are best understood as describing distinct, though often related, processes and phenomena. As Nina Glick-Schiller explains, "global" refers to processes, such as the development of capitalism, that are "not located in a single state but happen throughout the entire globe." "Transnational," on the other hand, refers to "political, economic, social and cultural processes that extend beyond the borders of a particular state, include actors that are not states, but are shaped by the policies and institutional practices of states." David Thelen, editor of a special issue on transnational U.S. history in the *Journal of American History,* offers an even broader definition of "transnational" that would "interrogate, and not assume the centrality of the nation-state as an organizing theme in American history." Scholarship would explore how "people and ideas and institutions and cultures moved above, below, through, and around, as well as within, the nation-state." "Transnational" processes should also be understood as related to, but distinct from, "international" and "diasporic" ones. Daniel Mato defines "international" as referring to "those relations maintained between governments (or their agencies) which invoke the nation-states they are supposed to represent in the mutually supportive so-called international system." The term "diaspora," as it has been commonly used in recent academic writings, is less tied to the biblical, Jewish model of forced exile from a homeland and instead places emphasis on what Jigna Desai has explained as the "heterogeneous connections to both the homeland and to other diasporic locations through such forms as political commitment, imagination, memory, travel and cultural production."

Situated at the intersections of U.S. history, American Studies, and Asian Studies, Asian American historians have arguably always been transnational in outlook by integrating transnational, diasporic, and global perspectives into analyses of the Asian American past. Initially foregrounded in social history, Asian American histories have primarily focused on non-state actors—the Asian migrants and their descendants—as well as on transnational networks in which

they participated, demonstrating that such processes are not only a product of our contemporary, globalized world, but in fact have deep historical roots. But during the first decades of Asian American Studies as a formal field of study, Asian Americanist historians emphasized the U.S. side of their narratives. This was an understandable strategy at a time when our professors and colleagues routinely confused Asian American Studies with Asian Studies. Although this problem has not entirely disappeared, the marked increase of campuses offering courses and even degrees in Asian American subjects and, quite significantly, the number of tenure-track and tenured Asian Americanist positions attest to its establishment as a legitimate and distinct field of study. We should thus consider this greater academic acceptance of Asian American Studies, as well as the larger trend of examining the rapid changes in our world, to account for the recent "transnational turn" in Asian American historiography.

Transnational Asian American history can and has taken many different forms, encompassing a huge variety of projects, ethnic groups, nations, questions, and methodologies, but we believe it would be useful to begin specifying and identifying the hallmarks of transnational Asian American history. These are works that incorporate some or all of the following characteristics:

- Relate histories about Asians in the Americas and their ongoing economic, cultural, ethnic, and political networks and relationships with those in Asia.
- Provide substantial focus on the stories and historical contexts in Asia as well as in the Americas. This characteristic presumes non-English language training and multinational archival research.
- Examine Asian migration to the Americas and its impact on Asia and on U.S.-Asia relations.
- De-center the state, but do so without ignoring state power.
- Investigate migratory circuits and border crossings—not only across the Pacific but also across the Atlantic and within the Western hemisphere.
- Emphasize the mutual, interactive nature of cultural, institutional, and economic flows. In this respect, transnational histories are not merely comparative, looking at parallel developments across national borders. They seek as well to illuminate the connections that bind people and places to each other.

Within the field of Asian American history, scholars have employed transnational frameworks to re-examine a multitude of issues. First, there is work that is explicitly and traditionally transnational in scope and methodology, meaning that it focuses on migrant social, economic, cultural, and political networks, processes, or institutions that transcend national borders. These works, researched in multiple locations and sometimes multiple languages, pay close attention to one immigrant group's ongoing negotiation between the U.S. and their homeland—or the ways in which developments in one nation are inextricably linked to migrant lives in another. One good recent example is Madeline Hsu's *Dreaming of Gold, Dreaming of Home,* which illustrates how Chinese immigrants lived interconnected lives between the United States and China, made possible through

remittances and transnational communication and transportation systems. Hsu's work explicitly draws our attention to one of the key aspects of transnationalism: the migrants' simultaneous incorporation into their states of origin and settlement and the interconnected and transnational "social fields" that result. Similarly, Adam McKeown's work focuses on transnational migrant networks in order to understand how "social formations ... are directly embedded in social processes at a global scale."

Another type of transnational scholarship uses the international context—the state relations between two or more nations—to examine their impact on Asian Americans. Ji-yeon Yuh's study of Korean camptown prostitution, Korean military brides, and the unequal and "neoimperialist relationship" between the U.S. and South Korea is one excellent example that connects private lives to international relations. As Yuh argues, "Korean military brides have been on the front line of Korea-U.S. cultural and social contact for the past half-century." This type of work usually requires a methodology that Catherine Ceniza Choy calls a "two shores" approach. Her work on Filipina nurse migration employed extensive archival research, ethnographic fieldwork, and oral histories on both sides of the Pacific Ocean to explain how American colonialism in the Philippines shaped the migration of nurses to the U.S. beginning in the early twentieth century and continuing into the present.

The analysis in Christina Klein's *Cold War Orientalism* is also located in an international context. She illustrates how representations of Asia that promoted integration, adoption, and assimilation during the Cold War justified the growth of U.S. power in Asia. But while her work is definitely valuable, even complimentary, to Asian Americanists doing transnational history, should it be categorized as transnational? Klein thinks it should be, with good cause. Even though she looks at U.S. public discourse, culture, and foreign policies in her book, she explores "the idea of America in the world" and "America as it relates to other countries and peoples." Yet this argument still raises the issue of whether we should categorize cultural histories that look primarily—if not entirely—at one nation as transnational if the histories do not substantively study the reception of culture, ideas, or policies in other countries. Must transnational histories denote some sort of mutual exchange and influence? We are not decided about this question, but thought it important to raise this issue for further discussion.

One last category of transnational Asian American history is diasporic in nature and seeks to define and track migrant streams, networks, and cultural production, among other things, on a broad, even global scale. Encyclopedic projects, such as Lynn Pan's *Encyclopedia of the Chinese Overseas* (Harvard, 1999) or Akemi Kikumura-Yano's *Encyclopedia of Japanese Descendants in the Americas: an Illustrated History of the Nikkei* (Alta Mira, 2002) represent the first stage in simply documenting the various migrant communities and in interpreting these groups on larger geographic scales. Adam McKeown's work on the Chinese diaspora compares migrant networks within a global framework in order to serve as a corrective to Chinese-language scholarship that emphasizes enduring ties to China and to Asian American history, which he critiques as being "America-centered."

As the examples above show, a transnational framework deepens Asian American history and has allowed Asian Americanists to make their narratives more complex, nuanced, and historically accurate. There are many other works not mentioned here that have greatly contributed to our understandings of transnational Asian American history. The fact that we cannot survey all of them is evidence of the strength of the field.

The transnational framework, moreover, encourages Asian Americanist historians to ask and research different questions, as well as challenge presumptions inherent in U.S.-centric studies. Paying more attention to the story beyond U.S. borders forces us to rethink established narratives about the Asian American experience. Sucheta Mazumdar demonstrates, for example, that a transnational focus on the historical context in China and India disputes the notion that the existence of racist restrictions primarily explains why Chinese and Indian women did not emigrate to the U.S. in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. As Mazumdar points out, Chinese and Indian women were not emigrating in large numbers to any place at this time. Vital to household economies that would collapse without them, lower-class and lower-caste women were indispensable on Guangdong and Punjabi farms. But since men's labor was more replaceable, a common family strategy had sons—especially younger sons—sojourn abroad and send remittances to buy more land or ensure "survival in an economy where the cash nexus had been amplified through global economic processes." Thus, by analyzing historical contexts beyond a single nation-state, transnational studies have been heralding a paradigmatic shift about border flows and migratory circuits in Asian American history.

Although it has been important to encourage scholars to shift their perspectives away from the nation, there is a danger, however, in eschewing the salience of the nation and of national borders altogether. As Erika Lee has written elsewhere, prior to World War Two and during an era of increased regulation of international migration by nation-states, the maintenance of transnational migration patterns, ties, and networks by Asian migrants was certainly possible, but only under certain prescribed limitations." Sau-ling Wong has also criticized diasporic studies that celebrate the crossing of borders while ignoring the continuing salience of race and racism produced by nation-states.

An approach that considers diasporic communities and transnational migration, networks, and culture *within* an Asian American Studies framework recognizes the continuing importance of the nation on and to Asian American subjects. Here, lessons from the work of cultural studies scholars such as Jigna Desai are instructive. In *Beyond Bollywood,* Desai locates the South Asian diaspora and diasporic film in the "Brown Atlantic" between India (and other parts of South Asia), Britain, the United States, and Canada. Approaching the transnational through the lens of post-national American Studies, Desai calls for the "foregrounding of transnational and international dimensions of the United States and the Americas," rather than foregoing the nation-state altogether. She suggests that we should explore the relationship between racialization and transnationality in order to produce Asian American Studies scholarship that moves

"beyond simple claims of nationalism or generalized disavowals of the nation-state," and instead "recognizes their mutual implications and dependencies."...

The challenge for Asian Americanists is clear. We must continue to preserve and reclaim lost and marginalized histories, placing them within a larger framework of race, class, gender, and sexuality in the United States. But whenever possible, we should also expand our vision beyond U.S. borders to explain why and how transnational linkages were maintained across the Pacific with Asia, north and south within the Americas, and around the world.

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CHAPTER 2



# Transpacific Crossings, 1688–1883

*The narrative of Asian American history has three primary starting points. The earliest is in the sixteenth century, when large wind-powered Spanish ships (galleons) began transporting sailors, travelers, and captives from the Philippines to the New World. Another is two centuries later with the inauguration of trade relations between China and the new nation of the United States in the 1780s. And the third is in the mid-nineteenth century with the start of sustained labor migrations from Asia to the United States and Hawai'i. The common denominator for each of these starting points is the long-term global transformations set in motion by Christopher Columbus's historic voyages across the Atlantic Ocean, beginning in 1492. Columbus, who was seeking a new trade route from Europe to East and Southeast Asia, opened up the modern era of transoceanic exploration and commerce, which contributed to Europe's rise over and above the great civilizations of East Asia, Africa, Mesoamerica, Peru, and the Middle East. Asian American history was made possible by the development of this ocean world as it played out in and across the Pacific.*

*In colonizing what would be called the Philippine Islands, Spain created the conditions through which 40,000 to 100,000 peoples from Asia would end up in the country's New World territories. Some of these migrants came as slaves locked away in the holds of Spanish galleons crossing the Pacific to Mexico. Known collectively as "chinos" (Chinese), the slaves in Mexico were actually from diverse backgrounds, and included indigenous peoples and Muslims (*Moros*) in the Philippines, Southeast Asians, and South Asians. One of the most famous slaves, Catarina de San Juan, was originally from India. Soon after her death in 1688, the chinos were reclassified as "Indians" in Mexico, which ended their status as slaves. In death, Catarina became a beloved saint, known for originating the still renowned Mexican woman's dress—the colorful* China poblana. *Legend has it that a few of the Filipinos who crossed with the galleons in the late eighteenth century made their way to what would become the state of Louisiana to establish what might be one of the first Asian American communities. While this community was real, evidence suggests that it originated from the mid-nineteenth century, much later than has been believed and decades after the galleon trade ended in 1815.*

*After its founding in 1776, the United States looked to the Pacific as a key source of commerce. Americans played an active role in the China trade and Pacific whaling ventures, which made it possible for individual Chinese and Pacific Islander sailors to venture to the new nation on American ships. Beginning in the early nineteenth century, contract laborers from China and India were brought to work on Latin American and Caribbean plantations. Known as "coolies,"[1] these highly exploited laborers provided an alternative to African slavery, which before then had been abolished in the French empire and which, by the 1830s, would be banned in newly independent Latin American nations like Mexico and throughout the British Empire.*

*Some coolies were exported to Hawai'i sugar plantations. Brought into the transpacific world system in the late eighteenth century by the British explorer Captain James Cook, the Kingdom of Hawai'i underwent dramatic social, economic, and political changes after contact with foreigners. Like indigenous peoples everywhere, Hawaiians suffered from deadly diseases, which precipitated major population decline. In addition, they experienced resource depletion and the introduction of foreign enterprises, work routines, languages, lifestyles, schooling, and religions. In Hawai'i, unlike in the United States, Asians, by the late nineteenth century, constituted a numerical majority.*

*The vast majority of Asian workers who came to the United States were free migrants, not coolies. The economic development of the nation's West Coast also spurred Asian migration, which for most of the nineteenth century came from China. Perhaps the best known of all the early Asian migrants were the Chinese attracted by the California Gold Rush and recruited to build the first Transcontinental, Railroad. These migrants created ethnic communities that became nodes in a network spreading across the Americas and back to southern China, from which almost all overseas Chinese descended. This Chinese* diaspora *(those living outside the homeland) also included communities in Australia, Japan, and especially Southeast Asia—the site of the largest and oldest Chinese diasporic communities. By the late nineteenth century, trade routes from California to China, which included refueling in Hawai'i, had become busy transpacific highways in which massive, reliable, and relatively fast steam-powered ships carried migrants and traders, as well as goods, ideas, and cultures. Such transportation networks provided the infrastructure that shaped Asian American history in the modern Pacific world.*

## DOCUMENTS

From 1565 to 1815, Spanish galleons circulated in the Pacific one or two times per year. The ships departed from Acapulco, Mexico, loaded with silver and gold mined in New Spain that Chinese traders in Manila exchanged as payment for spices, porcelain, ivory, lacquerware, processed silk cloth, and other valuable commodities that would make the return voyage back to Mexico. In Document 1, a seventeenth-century Spanish visitor, Jesuit Father Colín, describes the remarkable

[1] A term, which many scholars think originated in India and was put into currency by Portuguese traders in Asia, describing the lowest class of workers.

global port of Manila, where goods and slaves from across Asia and the Americas were exchanged. The growth of this thriving port city was due to the lucrative galleon trade that centered on the exchange of Mexican currency (silver and gold) for Chinese merchandise.

The transpacific China trade remained popular after the Manila galleons ceased operations. In the late eighteenth century, founders of the United States, such as Benjamin Franklin, were hopeful that a robust trade with China would give the new nation a solid economic foundation to compete with England's dominant East India Company. Document 2 is a report of the first U.S. vessel to trade with China, a voyage sponsored by private investors that carried national significance. While leaders during the early republic saw China as a great economic hope for their nation, they did not see the need for Chinese immigrants because the original thirteen colonies, now states, benefitted from the labor of African slaves, as well as from contract labor in the form of British and European indentured servants. Document 3 reveals that the nation's founders granted eligibility to U.S. citizenship only for a "free white person" of "good character." Such criteria were designed to exclude free blacks, white indentured servants, convicts, and the poor; they unwittingly also barred Asians.

The next two documents address the impact that heightened transpacific traffic had on the Hawaiian Islands. Some of the changes wrought by foreign trade were welcomed by the native Hawaiians, while others raised concerns, as Document 4 shows in the debate between the Hawaiian Privy Council and the common people. By 1848, the debate was settled in favor of foreign landholding through the enactment by King Kamehameha III of land redistribution (Mahele). Document 5 shows that American and other foreign ambitions to transform Hawai'i into a profitable sugar economy undergirded land reform efforts.

Given the diseases that decimated Native Hawaiian populations, foreign agriculture on the islands came to rely upon Chinese and other Asian labor. Labor shortages throughout the U.S. West also compelled the country's leaders to imagine developing this vast frontier region with Chinese immigrant workers. Document 6 offers the fantastic vision of one influential New York senator, William Seward, who, like Benjamin Franklin and others of the founding generation, saw Chinese trade, and now immigration, as key for enabling the United States to surpass the power of the almighty British Empire. How the Chinese immigrants felt about developing the western frontier was altogether different and is largely lost to history because of the lack of records left behind by those who ventured across the Pacific. Documents 7 and 8 are songs written by the Chinese that provide glimpses of the anxieties they and their wives left behind in China faced as they sought to get rich in "Gold Mountain."

Equally difficult to research are the supposed Filipino descendants of the Manila galleon trade who founded one of the first Asian American communities. Document 9, written in 1883 by a white journalist who was more interested in exotic adventure than historical accuracy, is one of the earliest accounts of Filipino Americans in Louisiana.

## 1. Spanish Visitor Describes the Philippine Market, 1663

Manila is the equal of any other emporium of our monarchy, for it is the center to which flows the riches of the Orient and the Occident, the silver of Peru and New Spain; the pearls and precious stones of India; the diamonds of Narsinga and Goa; the rubies, sapphires and topazes, and the cinnamon of Ceylon; the pepper of Sumatra and the Javas; the cloves, nutmegs and other spices of the Moluccas and Banda; the fine Persina silks and wool and carpets from Ormuz and Malabar; rich hangings and bed coverings of Bengal; fine camphor of Borneo; balsam and ivory of Abada and Cambodia, [...] and from Great China silks of all kinds, raw and woven in velvets and figured damasks, taffetas and other cloths of every texture, design and colors, linens and cotton fabrics, gilt-decorated articles, embroideries and porcelains, and other riches and curiosities of great value and esteem; from Japan, amber, varicolored skills, writing desks, boxes and tables of precious woods, lacquered and with curious decorations; and very fine silverware.

## 2. Manager of Cargo Reports on First U.S. Ship to Trade with China, 1785

On the 22 February 1784, the ship sailed from New York, and arrived the 21 March at St. Iago, the principal of the Cape de Verd Islands. Having paid our respects to the Portuguese Vice Roy, and with his permission, taken such refreshments as were necessary, we left those Islands on the 27th and pursued our voyage. After a pleasant passage, in which nothing extraordinary occurred, we came to anchor in the Streights of Sunda, on the 18th of July. It was no small addition to our happiness on this occasion, to meet there two ships belonging to our good Allies the French. The commodore, Monsieur D'Ordelin, and his officers, welcomed us in the most affectionate manner, and as his own ship was immediately bound to Canton, gave us an invitation to go in company with him. This friendly offer we most cheerfully accepted, and the Commodore furnished us with his signals by day and Night, and added such instructions for our Passage through the Chinese Seas, as would have been exceedingly beneficial, had any unfortunate accident occasioned our separation. Happily we pursued our route together. On our arrival at the Island of Macao, the French Consul for China, Monsieur Vieillard, with some other Gentlemen of his Nation came on board to Congratulate and Welcome us to that part of the World, and kindly undertook the introduction of the Americans to the Portuguse Governor. The little time that we were there was entirely taken up by the good offices of the Consul, the Gentlemen of his Nation, and those of the Swedes and

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Excerpt from Evelyn Hu-DeHart and Kathleen Lopez, "Asian Diasporas in Latin America and the Caribbean: An Historical Overview," *Afro-Hispanic Review 27*, 1 (Spring 2008), p. 9.

From Samuel Shaw to John Jay, May 19, 1785, in *Papers of the Continental Congress*, item 120, v. 1, pp. 281–289 (letterbook copy); M40, reel 1, *National Archives*; reprinted, Mary A. Guinta (ed.), *Documents of the Emerging Nation: U.S. Foreign Relations*, 1775–1789 (Wilmington, DE: Scholarly Resources, 1998), 241–245.

Imperialists, who still remained at Macao. The other Europeans had repaired to Canton. Three Days afterwards we finished our outward bound Voyage....

The Day of our arrival at Canton, August 30th and the two following Days, we were visited by the Chinese Merchants, and the Chiefs and Gentlemen of the several European Establishments and treated by them in all respects as a free and independent Nation. As such during our stay we were universally considered. The Chinese themselves were very indulgent towards us, though our being the first American ship that had ever visited China, it was some time before they could fully comprehend the distinction between English men and us. They styled us the *New People* and when by the map we conveyed to them an Idea of the extent of our Country, with its present and increasing population, they were highly pleased at the prospect of so considerable a market for the productions of theirs.

The Situation of the Europeans at Canton is so well known as to render a detail unnecessary. The good understanding commonly subsisting between them and the Chinese was in some degree interrupted by two occurrences, of which, as they were extraordinary in themselves, and led to a more full investigation of the American Character, by both Parties, than might otherwise have taken place, I will, with your permission, give a particular Account.

The Police at Canton is at all times extremely strict, and the Europeans residing there are circumscribed within very narrow limits. The latter had observed with Concern some circumstances which they deemed an encroachment upon their rights. On this consideration they determined to apply for redress to the Hoppo, who is the head officer of the Customs, the next time he should Visit the Shipping. Deputies accordingly attended from every Nation, and I was desired to represent ours. We met the Hoppo on board an English ship, and the causes of complaint were soon after removed.

The other occurrence of which I beg leave to take notice gave rise to what was commonly called the Canton War, which threatened to be productive of very serious Consequences. On the 25 November an English ship, in saluting some Company that had dined on board, killed a Chinese, and wounded two others, in the Mandarine's Boat along side. It is a Maxim of the Chinese Law that Blood must answer for Blood, in pursuance of which they demanded the unfortunate Gunner. To give up this Poor man was to consign him to certain Death. Humanity pleaded powerfully against the measure. After repeated conferences between the English and the Chinese, the latter declared themselves satisfied, and the affair was supposed to be entirely settled. Notwithstanding this, on the morning after the last Conference, (the 27th) the supercargo [manager] of the Ship was seized, while attending his Business, thrown into a Sedan Chair, hurried into the City and committed to Prison. Such an outrage on personal Liberty spread a general alarm, and the Europeans unanimously agreed to send for their Boats with armed men from the shipping, for the security of themselves and Property, until the matter should be brought to a conclusion. The Boats accordingly came, and ours among the number; one of which was fired on and a man Wounded. All Trade was stopped, and the Chinese men of war drawn up opposite the Factories [trading posts]. The Europeans demanded the restoration of Mr. Smith, which the Chinese refused, until the Gunner should be given up. In the mean while, the Troops of the Province were collecting in the Neighbourhood

of Canton—the Chinese servants were ordered by the Magistrates to leave the factories—the Gates of the suburbs were shut—all intercourse was at an end—the Naval force was increased—many Troops were embarked in boats, ready for landing—and every thing wore the appearance of War. To what extremities matters might have been carried, had not a negociation taken place, no one can say. The Chinese asked a conference with all the Nations, except the English. A deputation, in which I was included for America, met the *Fuen* who is the head Magistrate of Canton, with the principal officers of the Province—After setting forth, by an interpreter, the power of the Emperor, and his own determination to support the Laws, he demanded that the Gunner should be given up within three days, declaring that he should have an impartial examination before their Tribunal, and if it appeared that the affair was accidental he should be released unhurt. In the mean time he gave permission for the Trade, excepting that of the English, to go on as usual, and dismissed us with a present of two pieces of silk to each, as a mark of his friendly disposition. The other Nations, one after another, sent away their Boats, under protection of a Chinese flag, and pursued their Business as before. The English were obliged to submit—the Gunner was given up—Mr. Smith was released—and the English, after being forced to ask pardon of the Magistracy of Canton, in presence of the other Nations, had their Commerce restored. On this occasion, I am happy that we were the last who sent off our boat, which was not disgraced with a Chinese Flag; nor did she go until the English themselves thanked us for our concurrence with them, and advised to the sending her away. After peace was restored, the Chief and four English Gentlemen visited the several Nations, among whom we were included, and thanked them for their assistance during the Troubles. The Gunner remained with the Chinese—his fate undetermined.

Notwithstanding the treatment we received from all parties was perfectly Civil and respectful, yet it was with peculiar satisfaction that we experienced, on every occasion, from our good Allies the French the most flattering and substantial proofs of their friendship. "If, said they, we have in any instance been serviceable to you, we are happy—and we desire nothing more ardently than further opportunities to convince you of our affection." The harmony maintained between them and us was particularly noticed by the English, who more than once observed, that it was [a] matter of astonishment to them, that the descendants of Britains would so soon divest themselves of prejudices, which they had thought to be not only hereditary, but inherent in our Nature.

We left Canton the 27 December, and on our return refreshed at the Cape of Good Hope, where we found a most friendly reception. After remaining there five Days, we Sailed for America and arrived in this Port on the 11$^{th}$ Instant.

To every Lover of his Country, as well as to those more immediately concerned in Commerce, it must be a pleasing reflection, that a communication is thus happily opened between us and the Eastern Extreme of the Globe; and it adds very sensibly to the pleasure of this reflection, that the Voyage has been performed in so short a space of time, and attended with the loss only of one man....

Permit me, Sir, to accompany this Letter with the two pieces of silk, presented to me by the *Fuen* of Canton, as a mark of his good disposition towards the American Nation. In that view, I consider myself as peculiarly honored in being

charged with this testimony of the friendship of the Chinese for a People, who may in a few Years prosecute a Commerce with the Subjects of that Empire, under advantages equal if not superior to those enjoyed by any other Nation whatever.

## 3. U.S. Bases Citizenship on Race, 1790

*An Act to establish an uniform Rule of Naturalization.*

SECTION 1. *Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled*, That any alien, being a free white person, who shall have resided within the limits and under the jurisdiction of the United States for the term of two years, may be admitted to become a citizen thereof, on application to any common law court of record, in any one of the states wherein he shall have resided for the term of one year at least, and making proof to the satisfaction of such court, that he is a person of good character, and taking the oath or affirmation prescribed by law, to support the constitution of the United States, which oath or affirmation such court shall administer; and the clerk of such court shall record such application, and the proceedings thereon; and thereupon such person shall be considered as a citizen of the United States. And the children of such persons so naturalized, dwelling within the United States, being under the age of twenty-one years at the time of such naturalization, shall also be considered as citizens of the United States. And the children of citizens of the United States, that may be born beyond sea, or out of the limits of the United States, shall be considered as natural born citizens: *Provided*, That the right of citizenship shall not descend to persons whose fathers have never been resident in the United States: *Provided also*, That no person heretofore proscribed by any state, shall be admitted a citizen as aforesaid, except by an act of the legislature of the state in which such person was proscribed.(*a*)

APPROVED, March 26, 1790.

## 4. Hawaiians Petition the Privy Council to Halt Foreign Influence in the Islands, and Council Replies, 1845

Translated from the Elele, for the Friend.

A PETITION TO YOUR GRACIOUS MAJESTY, KAMEHAMEHA III., AND TO ALL YOUR CHIEFS IN COUNCIL ASSEMBLED.

To His Majesty Kamehameha III., and the Premeir Kekauluohi, and all the Hawaiian Chiefs in council assembled; on account of our anxiety, we petition you, the father of the Hawaiian kingdom, and the following is our petition.

1. Concerning the independence of your kingdom.

2. That you dismiss the foreign officers whom you have appointed to be Hawaiian officers.

3. We do not wish foreigners to take the oath of allegiance and become Hawaiian subjects.

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From *An Act to Establish an Uniform Rule of Naturalization*, March 26, 1790, in Public Laws, 1st Congress, 1 Stat. 103 (chapter 3).

From *The Friend*, August, 1845.

4. We do not wish you to sell any more land pertaining to your kingdom to foreigners.

5. We do not wish taxes in a confused obscure manner to be imposed in your kingdom.

6. This is the cause of our wishing to dismiss these foreign officers. On account of difficulties and apprehensions of burdens that will come upon us. There are your chiefs, who may be officers under you, like as their fathers were under your father, Kamehameha I., and good and intelligent men, in whom you have confidence; let these be officers.

Therefore we make known unto your most gracious Majesty, and to the Premeir Kekauluohi, and to all the chiefs of the Hawaiian kingdom, some of our thoughts relative to the above named articles.

1. Concerning the independence of the Hawaiian kingdom.

We assure your Majesty, and the Premeir Kekauluohi, and the Chiefs and all your common people that we understand your kingdom to be independent. You and your Chiefs perceived the perilous situation of the Hawaiian kingdom in reference to foreigners. Therefore you sent one of your own men and a foreigner, viz: T. Haalilio and Mr. Richards, respectfully to beseech large independent nations that your nation might be independent. These large nations, viz: the United States, Great Britain, France and Belgium, have declared your kingdom to be independent. By this distinct expression, that these large nations have declared the independence of the Hawaiian kingdom, therefore it is very clear to us, that it is not proper that any foreigner should come in and be promoted in your kingdom, among your Chiefs, and your people. But that it be according to the petition of the ministers, whom you sent to these large nations, praying that the Hawaiian kingdom might be independent by itself.

This is independence; that your gracious Majesty, Kamehameha III. be King, and the Chiefs of your kingdom be your assistants, and also your own people.

Thus may you and your Chiefs act, that your kingdom and all your people may be blessed.

On account of these our thoughts, we petition and beseech you and your Chiefs.—

We the common people of your kingdom hereby subscribe our names.

[It is said that over 1600 names were subscribed to this petition.]

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REPLY OF THE COUNCIL ASSEMBLED TO THE PETITION.

JULY 3d, 1845.

To His Majesty and to the Nobles of the Council assembled, and to the delegates of the common people.

This is our reply to the petition of the common people of Lahaina, and Wailuku and Kailua, and it is submitted for your approbation or disapprobation.

1. "Concerning the independence of your kingdom."

This is the meaning of independence;— that Kamehameha III. be King of the Hawaiian Islands, and there be no other King over him. This is the reason of

the independence; Great Britain and France, America and Belgium say that "the Hawaiian government are qualified to transact business with foreigners."

How can they transact business with foreigners? In this way only; let His Majesty select persons skilful like those from other lands to transact business with them.

2. "That you dismiss the foreign officers whom you have chosen to be Hawaiian officers."

If these shall be dismissed, where is there a man who is qualified to transact business with foreigners? There is no one to be found at the present time; hereafter perhaps the young chiefs will be qualified, when they have grown up to manhood, and shall have completed their education.

3. "We do not wish foreigners to take the oath of allegiance and become Hawaiian subjects."

Shall foreigners who become officers take the oath? If not, then they have a chief in another land, and Kamehameha III. is not their proper sovereign, and they will not act righteously between the King and their own countrymen. But if they take the oath of allegiance to Kamehameha III., will they not be faithful to him. And will they not cease to have regard for the chief they have forsaken!

Shall other foreigners take the oath of allegiance? This is a land which lies where ships in the Pacific ocean often come. Shall not foreigners come on shore? They do come on shore. Can they not be permitted to live on shore?—According to the treaties they can. Who shall be their proper sovereign? Will not difficulties arise between some of them and the Hawaiians? Difficulties will arise, for formerly there were many difficulties, and the land was taken; it was not taken because the government was really in the wrong, but because evil was sought. Here is the difficulty which ruins the government, viz: the complaint of foreign governments followed by the infliction of punishment. Foreigners who take the oath of allegiance can apply to only one sovereign, viz: Kamehameha III.; he will adjust their difficulties in a proper manner, and they will render important services to Hawaii, their land.

Some say, let none but good foreigners take the oath of allegiance. How then shall it be with those who are not good? Shall they not live on shore? How can they be driven off? Shall they be put on board another man's ship? If so, the owners will forsake the ship, and the government must pay the damages. Messrs. Bachelot and Short were thus treated, and the result was a fine of $20,000.

Let no one have apprehensions concerning those who take the oath of allegiance. It they conduct properly, then the land is blessed by them. If they transgress, here are laws to punish them, and there is no other nation which will interfere in behalf of wicked foreigners, when we punish them. Here is wherein other nations will favour us; they will not take the part of their people, who transgress our laws, neither will they punish us without a cause, as they did formerly.

4. "We do not wish you to sell any more land pertaining to your kingdom to foreigners."

This is our opinion; it is by no means proper to sell land to aliens, nor is it proper to give them land, for the land belongs to Kamehameha III.; there is no chief over him. But we think it is proper to sell land to his Majesty's people, that

they may have a home. But if these persons wish to sell their lands again, they cannot sell to aliens, for there is only one sovereign over those who hold lands; but if the people wish to sell to those who have taken the oath of allegiance, they can do so, for Kamehameha III. is King over them. If his Majesty thinks it expedient to sell lands to his own people, is it proper for him to refuse another, who has forsaken the land of his birth, and his first chief, and become a Hawaiian subject? By no means, for this would be using partiality. There has not been much land sold, but foreigners have heretofore occupied lands through favor, without purchasing. It is better to sell. The people have not thought much about purchasing lands; but those who have been to the Columbia River [in the Pacific Northwest], see the advantage of purchasing land, and they will hereafter wish to purchase lands....

This is our reply to the petition laid before you, with due reverence.

JOHN YOUNG.

JOHN II

This reply was corrected and approved by the assembly of chiefs and delegates of the common people in the hall of legislation, on the 8th of July, 1845, with no dissenting voice.

KAMEHAMEHA.

## 5. Foreign Experts Stress Optimism for Agriculture in Hawai'i, 1850

For years past the agricultural interests of these islands have been insignificant and their pursuit unprofitable. With an uncertain and distant market—with little or no encouragement or facilities given to foreign tillers of the soil, without proper knowledge of that soil, or sufficient capital to experiment upon its capabilities, most of the agricultural enterprises here have languished or utterly failed.

Within the last two years, however, a great nation has grown up, and a sudden change has taken place in the prospects of this group. The extension of the territory and government of the United States to the borders of the Pacific, the wonderful discoveries in California, and the consequent, almost instantaneous creation of a mighty state on the western front of the American Union has, as it were, with the wand of a magician, drawn this little group into the very focus of civilization and prosperity. We find ourselves suddenly surrounded by intelligent, enterprising neighbors who call loudly to us to furnish of our abundance and receive in exchange of theirs. Our coffee and sugar no longer remain piled in our warehouses. Our fruits and vegetables no longer decay on the spot where they were grown. We are not even compelled to seek for them a market, but clamorous purchasers come to our very doors and carry off our supplies with an eagerness that has caused us to feel a scarcity ourselves, and we are assured that not only for all these, but for any other products of the soil that we will raise, a ready and increasing demand may be relied

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From Josephine Sullivan, *A History of C. Brewer and Company, Limited: One Hundred Years in the Hawaiian Islands, 1826–1926* (Boston: Walton Advertising and Printing, 1926), 104–105.

on from our enterprising neighbors. The native government is relaxing its former tenacious grasp on the arable lands of the islands, and even inviting and encouraging their cultivation by foreign skill and capital.

With these brilliant prospects suddenly opening to these islands ... we find the agricultural operations checked and embarrassed by the insufficiency of the four great requisites—capital, experience, proper implements, and labor.

It is a fact worthy of remark that as your committee believe, without a single exception, all the sugar plantations that have been commenced at these islands have been so commenced by persons possessing neither experience in the business they were undertaking, nor the requisite capital and knowledge of the soil, to carry it through to a successful result.

Large sums of money have been thrown away, experiments which the experience of persons acquainted with the business would have enabled them to avoid, and no system of intercourse between the planters has been established by which the experience of one could be rendered available to another. And these are the great drawbacks from progress now.

To meet these difficulties, to provide for these wants, to render the experience of other countries available to this, to supply by a combined action, facilities and information *to all*, which cannot be procured by individuals, to encourage and foster agricultural operations in every form, are the main objects of the proposed association.

The improvement of the breed of cattle, horses, swine, sheep, poultry, etc., is another great object of the [new agricultural] society. Stated annual exhibitions could be held, and encouragement given to farmers and planters, by premiums being awarded for superior specimens of their products.

Another subject of great importance before this association is that of *Labor.* The introduction of coolie labor from China to supply the places of the rapidly decreasing native population is a question that is already agitated amongst us, and should such a step become necessary, the aid of such an association in accomplishing this object would be of great benefit.

## 6. Senator Wants Millions of Chinese Laborers in the United States, 1852

Sir, have you looked recently at the China trade? It reaches already seven millions in value annually. Have you watched the California trade? Its exports in bullion alone already exceeds $50,000,000 annually, and as yet the mineral development of that State has only begun. The settlement of the Pacific coast is in a state of sheer infancy. There is, speaking relatively, neither capital nor labor there adequate to exhibit the forces of industry that might be employed in that wonderful region. Nor is California yet conveniently

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From William H. Seward, "Commerce in the Pacific Ocean Speech," *Congressional Globe*, 32nd Congress, 1st Session, July 30, 1852.

accessible. The railway across Panama is not yet completed. The passage through Nicaragua is not perfect; that which leads through Tehuantepec [in Mexico] is not begun; nor have we yet extended, even so far as to the Mississippi, the most important and necessary one of them all, the railroad across our own country to San Francisco. The emigrant to the Atlantic coast arrives speedily and cheaply from whatever quarter of the world; while he who would seek the Pacific shore, encounters charges and delays which few can sustain. Nevertheless, the commercial, social, and political movements of the world are now in the direction of California. Separated as it is from us by foreign lands, or more impassable mountains, we are establishing there a custom-house, a mint, a dry-dock, Indian agencies, and ordinary and extraordinary tribunals of justice. Without waiting for perfect or safe channels, a strong and steady stream of emigration flows thither from every State and every district eastward of the Rocky Mountains. Similar torrents of emigration are pouring into California and Australia from the South American States, from Europe, and from Asia. This movement is not a sudden, or accidental, or irregular, or convulsive one; but it is one for which men and nature have been preparing through near four hundred years. During all that time merchants and princes have been seeking how they could reach cheaply and expeditiously, "Cathay," "China," "the East," that intercourse and commerce might be established between its ancient nations and the newer ones of the West. To these objects Da Gama, Columbus, Americus [Amerigo], Cabot, Hudson, and other navigators, devoted their talents, their labors, and their lives. Even the discovery of this continent and its islands, and the organization of society and government upon them, grand and important as those events have been, were but conditional, preliminary, and ancillary to the more sublime result, now in the act of consummation—the reunion of the two civilizations, which, having parted on the plains of Asia four thousand years ago, and having traveled ever afterwards in opposite directions around the world, now meet again on the coasts and islands of the Pacific ocean. Certainly no mere human event of equal dignity and importance has ever occurred upon the earth. It will be followed by the equalization of the condition of society and the restoration of the unity of the human family. We see plainly enough why this event could not have come before, and why it has come now. A certain amount of human freedom, a certain amount of human intelligence, a certain extent of human control over the physical obstacles to such a reunion, were necessary. All these conditions have happened and concurred. Liberty has developed under improved forms of government, and science has subjected Nature in Western Europe and in America. Navigation, improved by steam, enables men to outstrip the winds, and intelligence conveyed by electricity excels in velocity the light. With these favoring circumstances there has come also a sudden abundance of gold, that largely relieves labor from its long subjection to realized capital. Sir, this movement is no delusion. It will no more stop than the emigration from Europe to our own Atlantic shores has stopped, or can stop, while labor is worth there twenty cents and here fifty cents a day. Emigration from China cannot stop while labor is worth

in California $5 a day, and in the West Indies $10 a month, and yet is worth in China only $5 for that period. Accordingly we have seen sixty-seven ships filled, in three months of the present year, with seventeen thousand emigrants in the ports of Hong Kong, Macao, and Whampao, and afterwards discharge them on the shores of California, and of Cuba, and other islands of the West Indies.

Sir, have you considered the basis of this movement, that this country and Australia are capable of sustaining, and need for their development, five hundred millions, while their population is confined to fifty millions, and yet that Asia has two hundred millions of excess? As for those who doubt that this great movement will quicken activity and create wealth and power in California and Oregon, I leave them to consider what changes the movements, similar in nature but inferior in force and slower in effect, have produced already on the Atlantic coast of America. As to those who cannot see how this movement will improve the condition of Asia, I leave them to reflect upon the improvements in the condition of Europe since the discovery and colonization of America. Who does not see, then, that every year hereafter, European commerce, European politics, European thoughts, and European activity, although actually gaining greater force, and European connections, although actually becoming more intimate, will, nevertheless, ultimately sink in importance; while the Pacific ocean, its shores, its islands, and the vast regions beyond, will become the chief theater of events in the world's great Hereafter? Who does not see that this movement must effect our own complete emancipation from what remains of European influence and prejudice, and in turn develop the American opinion and influence, which shall remould constitutional laws and customs in the land that is first greeted by the rising sun?...

Commerce is the great agent of this movement. Whatever nation shall put that commerce into full employment, and shall conduct it steadily with adequate expansion, will become necessarily the greatest of existing States; greater than any that has ever existed.

## 7. Song Captures Reasons for Chinese Sojourn to United States, 1852

In the second reign year of Haamfung [1852], a trip to Gold Mountain was made.
With a pillow on my shoulder, I began my perilous journey:
Sailing a boat with bamboo poles across the seas,
Leaving behind wife and sisters in search of money,
No longer lingering with the woman in the bedroom,
No longer paying respect to parents at home.

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## 8. Two Songs Reveal Concerns of Wives Left in China, n.d. [late 1800s]

YIK JOOK, YEE JOOK [Song 1]

I beg of you, after you depart, to come back soon,
Our separation will be only a flash of time;
I only wish that you would have good fortune.
In three years you would be home again.

Also, I beg of you that your heart won't change,
That you keep your heart and mind on taking care of your family;
Each month or half a month send a letter home.
In two or three years my wish is to welcome you home.

[Song 2]
O, just marry all the daughters to men from Gold Mountain:
All those trunks from Gold Mountain—you can demand as many as you want!
O, don't ever marry your daughter to a man from Gold Mountain:
Lonely and sad—a cooking pot is her only companion!

## 9. Journalist Reveals Filipino Roots of American Community, 1883

For nearly fifty years there has existed in the southeastern swamp lands of Louisiana a certain strange settlement of Malay fishermen—Tagalas from the Philippine Islands. The place of their lacustrine village is not precisely mentioned upon maps, and the world in general ignored until a few days ago the bare fact of their amphibious existence. Even the United States mail service has never found its way thither, and even in the great city of New Orleans, less than a hundred miles distant, the people were far better informed about the Carboniferous Era than concerning the swampy affairs of this Manila village. Occasionally vague echoes of its mysterious life were borne to the civilized centre, but these were scarcely of a character to tempt investigation or encourage belief. Some voluble Italian luggermen once came to town with a short cargo of oysters, and a long story regarding a ghastly "Chinese" colony in the reedy swamps south of Lake Borgne.... In order to offer *Harper's* artist a totally novel subject of artistic study, the *Times-Democrat* of New Orleans chartered and fitted out an Italian lugger for a trip to the unexplored region in question—to the fishing station of Saint Malo. And a strange voyage it was. Even the Italian sailors knew not whither they were going, none of them had ever beheld the Manila village, or were aware of its location....

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From "Yik Jook, Yee Jook," in ed. Tin-Yuke Char, *The Sandalwood Mountains: Readings and Stories of the Early Chinese in Hawaii* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1975), 67; reprinted in Judy Yung, Gordon H. Chang, and H. Mark Lai (eds.), *Chinese American Voices: From the Gold Rush to the Present* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006), 8. Reprinted by permission of the University of Hawaii.

Lafcadio Hearn, "St. Malo: A Lacustrine Village in Louisiana," *Harper's Weekly*, March 31, 1883, 198–199.

Out of the shuddering reeds and banneretted grass on either side rise the fantastic houses of the Malay fishermen, poised upon slender supports above the marsh, like cranes or bitterns watching for scaly prey. Hard by the slimy mouth of the bayou extends a strange wharf, as ruined and rotted and unearthly as the timbers of the spectral ship in the "Rime of the Ancient Mariner." Odd craft huddle together beside it, fishing-nets make cobwebby drapery about the skeleton timber-work. Green are the banks, green the water is, green also with fungi every beam and plank and board and shingle of the houses upon stilts. All are built in true Manila style, with immense hat-shaped eaves and balconies, but in wood; for it had been found that palmetto and woven cane could not withstand the violence of the climate....

Such is the land: its human inhabitants are not less strange, wild, picturesque. Most of them are cinnamon-colored men; a few are glossily yellow, like that bronze into which a small proportion of gold is worked by the moulder. Their features are irregular without being actually repulsive; some have the cheek-bones very prominent, and the eyes of several are set slightly aslant. The hair is generally intensely black and straight, but with some individuals it is curly and browner. In Manila there are several varieties of the Malay race, and these Louisiana settlers represent more than one type. None of them appeared tall; the greater number were under-sized, but all well knit, and supple as fresh-water eels. Their hands and feet were small; their movements quick and easy, but sailorly likewise, as of men accustomed to walk upon rocking decks in rough weather. They speak the Spanish language; and a Malay dialect is also used among them. There is only one white man in the settlement—the ship-carpenter, whom all the Malays address as "Maestro." He has learned to speak their Oriental dialect, and has conferred upon several the sacrament of baptism according to the Catholic rite; for some of these men were not Christians at the time of their advent into Louisiana. There is but one black man in this lake village—a Portuguese negro, perhaps a Brazilian maroon. The Maestro told us that communication is still kept up with Manila, and money often sent there to aid friends in emigrating. Such emigrants usually ship as seamen on board some Spanish vessel bound for American ports, and desert at the first opportunity. It is said that the colony was founded by deserters—perhaps also by desperate refugees from Spanish justice....

There is no woman in the settlement, nor has the treble of a female voice been heard along the bayou for many a long year. Men who have families keep them at New Orleans, or at Proctorville, or at La Chinche; it would seem cruel to ask any woman to dwell in such a desolation, without comfort and without protection, during the long absence of the fishing-boats....

And nevertheless this life in the wilderness of reeds is connected mysteriously with New Orleans, where the head-quarters of the Manila men's benevolent society are—*La Union Philipina*. A fisherman dies; he is buried under the rustling reeds, and a pine cross planted above his grave; but when the flesh has rotted from the bones, these are taken up and carried by some lugger to the metropolis, where they are shelved away in those curious niche tombs which recall the Roman *columbaria*.

How, then, comes it that in spite of this connection with civilized life the Malay settlement of Lake Borgne has been so long unknown? Perhaps because of the natural reticence of the people. There is still in the oldest portion of the oldest quarter of New Orleans a certain Manila restaurant hidden away in a court, and supported almost wholly by the patronage of Spanish West Indian sailors. Few people belonging to the business circles of New Orleans know of its existence. The *menu* is printed in Spanish and English; the fare is cheap and good. Now it is kept by Chinese, for the Manila man and his oblique-eyed wife, comely as any figure upon a Japanese vase, have gone away....

The most intelligent person in Saint Malo is a Malay half-breed, *Valentine*. He is an attractive figure, a supple dwarfish lad almost as broad as tall, brown as old copper, with a singularly bright eye. He was educated in the great city, but actually abandoned a fine situation in the office of a judge to return to his swarthy father in the weird swamps. The old man is still there—*Thomas de los Santos*. He married a white woman, by whom he had two children, this boy and a daughter, *Winnie*, who is dead.

## ESSAYS

The first essay, by Hawai'i-born, former University of California, Berkeley, historian Ronald Takaki, describes the development of the first sugar plantation in Hawai'i. Takaki, who died in 2009, shows how the islands' multiracial workforce, consisting mainly of Asian immigrants, by the late nineteenth century embodied U.S. attempts to control Hawai'i's political economy. In the second essay, former University of Hong Kong historian Elizabeth Sinn reveals the transpacific business and migration networks through which the Chinese diaspora extended to California.

### Hawai'i and the Global Labor Market

RONALD TAKAKI

In Koloa, "a mere hamlet, seldom visited by even a missionary," the Hawaiian natives noticed in 1835 the arrival of William Hooper of Boston, Massachusetts. They had seen white men before: in 1778, some of them had travelled to Waimea, sixteen miles away, to get a glimpse of Captain James Cook, or had heard stories about the English explorer's momentous visit—how he had sailed into the bay in two huge ships with billowing white sheets, how his men had carried awesome weapons of fire and destruction, and how they had left behind them, with the native women, a dreadful disease. Many of the natives still

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From Takaki, "An Entering Wedge: The Origins of the Sugar Plantation and Multi-ethnic Working Class in Hawaii," *Labor History* 23, no. 1 (Winter 1982): 34–46. Copyright © 1982 Taylor & Francis Ltd. Used with permission. www.tandf.co.uk/journals.

possessed souvenirs of Cook's visit, the iron nails they had ripped from his landing boats and the butcher's cleaver one of them had stolen.

As the natives curiously scrutinized their new visitor, they compared Hooper to the other white men at Waimea: the merchants shipping the fragrant sandalwood to China and supplying whaling vessels with water and provisions, and the missionaries building a new church there and spreading Christianity among the natives. But the people of Koloa did not realize that Hooper, more than the merchants and the missionaries, represented the beginning of a new era in the history of Hawaii. Sent to Koloa by Ladd and Company of Honolulu to establish the first plantation in the Sandwich Islands and to cultivate sugar cane as a cash crop, he was there to remake Hawaii in his own image: to advance American capitalism and civilization to a new Pacific frontier, undermining in the process the feudal society of Hawaii and the people's traditional relationship with their land.

During the next century, the Hawaiian sugar industry, which Hooper had initiated, transformed both the ethnicity of the people and the economy of the islands. In 1835, nearly the entire population was Hawaiian: foreigners constituted only .55 percent of the total, or only 600 out of a population of 108,000. In 1920, persons of Hawaiian ancestry made up only 16.3 percent of the population, while Caucasians represented 19.2 percent, Chinese 9.2 percent, Japanese 42.7 percent, Koreans 1.9 percent, Puerto Ricans 2.2 percent, and Filipinos 8.2 percent. Eighty years after Hooper had planted his first field of sugar cane, Hawaiian plantations produced 556,871 tons of sugar, representing the leading industry of the islands and providing the basis of five large and powerful corporations—American Factors, Castle and Cooke, C. Brewer and Company, T. H. Davies and Company, and Alexander and Baldwin.

While the relationship between the ethnic diversity of the people of Hawaii and the development of the sugar industry is readily apparent, little is known about the early origins of both of them. Fortunately, we have documents which can help to unshroud much of this history—the handwritten diary of Hooper and the extensive collection of his correspondence with Ladd and Company. Together they can enable us to reconstruct the critical early years of modern plantation Hawaii.

As a young man of twenty-six years, William Hooper keenly understood the significance of his enterprising venture in Koloa. Only two years earlier, he had landed in Honolulu with Peter Brinsmade and William Ladd; together they had opened a mercantile trading house named Ladd and Company. The company had leased from King Kamehameha III a tract of land, 980 acres on the east side of the Waihohonu Stream in Koloa, for 50 years at $300 a year, for the cultivation of sugar cane. The company had also secured permission to hire natives to work on the plantation. It had agreed to pay Kauikeouli, the King of Kauai, and Kaikioewa, the Governor of Kauai, a tax for each man employed, and to pay the workers satisfactory wages. The King and Governor, in return, would exempt the workers from all taxation except the tax paid by their employer.

As Hooper surveyed the newly leased land and the natives to be inducted into his work force, he must have thought Koloa was a fitting place for the beginning of the sugar industry in the islands, for the name itself meant "Great Cane"—"Ko" (cane) and "loa" (great). Everywhere, Hooper could see, wild

cane flourished on the fertile land of Koloa, nourished by the rains falling first on towering Kahili Mountain, almost always shrouded in mist, and then sweeping toward the plains of Koloa and finally the beaches of Poipu. Far away from American civilization, Hooper lived initially in a grass hut and was obliged to eat taro, a root which the natives pounded into "poi"; he even jokingly described himself as becoming a *"real kanaka."*...

Within one year, the young man from Boston had transformed both the land and native society in Koloa. On September 12, 1836, he proudly listed his accomplishments. He had 25 acres of cane under cultivation; in addition, he had erected twenty houses for the natives, a house for the superintendant, a carpenter's shop, a blacksmith's shop, a mill dam, a sugar house, a boiling house, and a sugar mill. Pleased with the progress of his plantation, Hooper recorded in his diary his thoughts on the meaning of the Koloa experience:

> Just one year to day since I commenced work on this plantation, during which I have had more annoyances from the chiefs and difficulty with the natives (from the fact of this land being the first that has ever been cultivated, on the plan of *free* labour, at these islands) than I ever tho't it possible for one white man to bear, nevertheless I have succeeded in bringing about a place, which if followed up by other foreign residents, will eventually emancipate the natives from the miserable system of "chief labour" which ever has existed at these Islands, and which if not broken up, will be an effectual preventitive to the progress of civilization, industry and national prosperity.... The tract of land in Koloa was [developed] after much pain ... for the purpose of breaking up the system aforesaid or in other words to serve as an entering wedge ... [to] upset the whole system.

A sense of mission lay behind Hooper's energetic enterprise. More than profits were at stake. In building his plantation, Hooper viewed himself as a "white man," as a pathfinder or an advance guard of "other foreign residents," introducing the system of "*free* labour" in order to "emancipate" the natives from the miserable system of "'chief labour.'" For young Hooper, the Koloa plantation was the "entering wedge" of capitalism, designed to split apart, irrevocably, the ancient system of feudalism in Hawaii.

As they watched Hooper begin his enterprise, the natives of Koloa must have felt a profound ambivalence. They undoubtedly viewed his new operation very apprehensively, fearful of the negative effects the plantation system would have on their culture and way of life. They also saw him as a *haole,* an outsider, and identified him with the destruction of the sandalwood forests, the denuding of the *aina* or land, and with the sailors who were infecting native women with venereal diseases. But the natives also must have hoped Hooper would offer them an escape from the old Hawaiian system of exploitation and fear. Hawaii for the common people, the *makaainana,* was hardly paradise. The king owned all of the lands, and chiefs holding land did so in return for payment of feudal dues. Common people, in order to secure the use of small tracts of land, had to labor for the king or local chiefs, the *alii. Kapus,* or tabus, strictly enforced by the *ilamuku* or police, severely restricted their activities and ambitions. Commoners, reported the

Hawaiian historian David Malo who had been educated by missionaries and who was forty-two years old when Hooper founded the Koloa plantation, were subjected to hard labor, heavy taxation, and cruelty. If they were slack in performing labor for their chief, they were expelled from the land, or even put to death. They held the chiefs in "great dread," living in a state of "chronic fear." Theirs was a "life of weariness ... constantly burdened by one exaction after another."

Seeking to improve their lot, twenty three natives went to work for Hooper on September 13, 1835. But two days later, they suddenly stopped working. "The kanakas having discovered the chiefs were to pay and not me," Hooper wrote in his diary, "concluded that 'all work and no pay' was poor business, therefore spent most of the forenoon in idleness." Apparently Hooper's workers thought they were to be paid through their chiefs and refused to work, doubting they would be paid at all. They were quickly offered an "inducement." They were promised to be paid directly "one real" or 12½ cents per day, and "they sprang to it, and at sundown finished their stint." Workers were also given food and shelter, in addition to their wages.

But Hooper did not pay his workers in reals or cash. Rather he issued coupons or script for 12½, 25, and 50 cents, which he wrote by hand on pieces of cardboard and which his workers could exchange for goods only at his plantation store. Thus Hooper was able both to pay his workers and to make a profit from their purchases.... In this process, he had created both a wage earning labor force and a consumer class dependent on a plantation-owned market which had to expand consumer needs constantly.

Native families, reported Hooper's neighbor James Jarvis, readily "volunteered" to have their taxes paid for them and to work for the Koloa plantation for wages. "The inducement of regular wages, good houses, and plenty of food, when compared with their usual mode of living," was one few natives resisted. Hooper's work force increased from twenty five in September of 1835 to forty in May of 1836. In March of 1838, Hooper noted that one hundred men, women, and children looked to him for their "daily Poe [poi]." By the end of the year, he counted four hundred workers in his employ.

Among Hooper's workers were native women. Employed to strip the cane and assist in grinding and boiling operations, they proved to be such effective workers that Hooper wrote to Ladd and Company on June 12, 1838: "I am in want of no more Sugar Boys. The women on the plantation now make good ones and it is best that I should keep them constantly at work." They were not only worked constantly; they were also paid less than the men, only six cents per day while the men received twelve and one half cents. Hooper justified this dual wage system by saying that it kept the women employed and allowed them to make "more than enough to support their families."

No longer peasants, Hooper's laborers found themselves in a new world of modern industrial agriculture. They no longer worked on their traditionally held small plots of land, sharing their crops with the *alii*. They no longer directed their own labors, making their own decisions regarding what to plant and when to work, rest, or go fishing. As plantation laborers, they found their time controlled by unfamiliar workday sounds, schedules, and rhythms....

As plantation workers, they performed a myriad of tasks. Under Hooper's direction, they first cleared grass from tracts of land for cane cultivation, and used a plough pulled by oxen to prepare the soil for the planting of cane cuttings. When one of the oxen died, "from the injury recd. by overwork," Hooper replaced the oxen with men. "At one time," Jarvis reported, "in lieu of cattle, he was obliged to employ forty natives, to drag a plough."...

Drawn away from their feudal lands and traditional homes, Hooper's native workers entered a new plantation community. They lived on the plantation, in houses allotted to them by Hooper. Assigned plots of land to cultivate crops for their own food and allowed time on weekends to work their gardens, they also received from Hooper a barrel of fish every third week. This system in which the workers supplemented their own subsistence needs enabled Hooper to minimize both wages and production costs. On Saturday, Hooper's workers visited the plantation store to sell vegetables and crafts and to purchase goods with their coupons....

Plantation workers not only labored, lived, and shopped on the Koloa plantation; they also received medical care when they became ill. Initially Hooper himself attended the medical needs of his workers. On April 29, 1836, he reported to Ladd and Company: "They are often ailing.... They are troubled with sore eyes etc etc which need & ought to have advice & medicine."...

Though they were dependent on Hooper for their "daily Poe" and other needs, native workers refused to give him the control and loyalty he expected. Time and again Hooper found himself in a state of exasperation over his inability to exact from his workers satisfactory obedience and sustained labor. Throughout his Koloa diary, he described his workers with great disgust as undependable, as children, as "dull asses," and as "Indians." His letters to Ladd and Company chronicled the frustrations he felt as the supervisor of recalcitrant laborers....

Hooper's laborers required constant surveillance or else they would not work. They became skillful pretenders, and Jarvis often "amusingly" watched them practice their art of deception. While working in the fields, natives were always ready to deceive their employer and escape from work. If an overseer left for a moment, down they would squat and pull out their pipes. Then the "longest-winded fellow" would begin a story, "a sort of improvisation" which would entertain everyone with "vulgar" humor and which would often "mimic the haole (foreigner)." As soon as the overseer came back within sight, they would seize their spades and quickly "commence laboring with an assiduity" that baffled description and "perhaps all the while not strain a muscle."

But Hooper did not find their behavior amusing. Irritated and impatient, he castigated his native workers for their inefficiency and doubted they would ever become useful as plantation workers. Their "habits and customs" which had been handed down to them from their forefathers and which they preserved so tenaciously would remain "the great obstacle to their employment" as agricultural wage laborers. Centuries, at least, Hooper lamented, would intervene before they would understand that it was a part of their "duty" to serve "their masters faithfully." He conceded that there were many good men among the natives who would take hold and turn themselves into "white kanakas" for one or two years. But he had no

confidence that their patience would hold out. As long as the plantation depended on native labor, the superintendant would have to be a "*Slave Driver.*"

Frustrated because he could not convert the natives into docile and efficient modern agricultural workers, Hooper turned to the Chinese as a solution to his labor problem. He had first noticed their presence in Waimea: there a few of them were grinding wild cane, brought to them by natives, in a small sugar mill owned by William French. After visiting this mill in the spring of 1835, Hooper wrote to Ladd and Company:

> I have seen the Chinese sugar works in successful operations; although extremely crude, yet they are doing well. They have worked 6 days in the week ever since its first establishment, making abt 210 lb sugar per day & molasses by the cord. They could make four times as much by increasing the size of kettles. Mr. F. is much elated with its success and from what I learn from Mr. Whitney you may expect a Host of Chinese.... Mr. French's establishment at Waimea is a great eye sore to the natives. They have to work *all* the time—and no regard is paid to their complaints for food, etc., etc. Slavery is nothing to it.

Shortly after the completion of the construction of his own mill, Hooper projected the need for Chinese labor. "We may deem it," he advised Ladd and Company, "at a future day, necessary to locate some halfdozen Chinese on the land, if the establishment grows it will require them. The Supt. cannot feed the mill, boil the juice, make the sugar, etc etc, and to trust it to the natives is worse than nothing—they are alas, children, boys, and always will be."

In a letter to Ladd and Company on December 1, 1838, Hooper insisted that the Koloa plantation needed a source of labor from other countries, and that no other country offered itself but China. "A colony of Chinese would, probably, put the plantation in order, to be perpetuated, sooner and with less trouble than any other class of husbandmen." By this time, several Chinese were already working for Hooper: they had probably been recruited from French's mill which had been put out of business due to competition from the Koloa mill. A pattern of ethnic labor segmentation was already evident, for Hooper tended to assign his Chinese laborers to the mill and Hawaiian laborers to the fields. Unlike the native workers, who lived on the plantation with their families in individual houses, the Chinese workers seemed to be all male and were housed together in a barrack-type structure. In April 1838, Hooper informed Ladd and Company that a "large comfortable building" had been erected for the "Chinamen." "They are highly pleased," he added, "and by their fixtures on doors I should suppose they intend to spend their days in it." Thus, Chinese workers, too, now looked to Hooper for their "daily Poe." Early in 1839, Hooper ordered from Ladd and Company a supply of rice for them.

But the use of Chinese workers did not mean the end of labor difficulties. Hooper's workers, Hawaiian and Chinese, found new ways to resist management and avoid work. Some of the natives simply helped themselves to merchandise in the plantation store without paying for them. On January 28, 1837, Hooper angrily scribbled into his diary: "[Detected] the natives stealing—therefore paid out no

goods to day." And three days later, he wrote: "5 natives taken before Hukiko [Hukiku, the headman at Koloa]—convicted of stealing and sentenced to work on the roads." But by this time, some of his workers had devised a more ingenious way to acquire goods from the plantation store: they used counterfeit coupons. As the natives learned how to read and write from a young schoolmaster in the village, some of them utilized their newly acquired knowledge and skills to make artful reproductions of Hooper's medium of exchange. The counterfeit coupons, according to Jarvis, were "so strikingly like the original, imitating the signatures with scrupulous exactness, that it was some time before the fraud was detected."

But the fraud was eventually discovered. On June 11, 1836, Hooper, surprised and dismayed, wrote in his diary: "Some native has attempted to counterfeit the papers which I issued for dollars." Some of the counterfeiters were Chinese. The problem caused Hooper much distress: unless it were checked, the counterfeit conspiracy could undermine his entire enterprise. His laborers would have little incentive to work, for they would have their own source of script. Determined to outwit his workers, Hooper asked Ladd and Company to have paper bills engraved in Boston. In its letter to the printer on November 15, 1837, Ladd and Company gave instructions to have the currency printed from a copper plate in order to be certain it could not be duplicated....

The founding of the Koloa plantation had been a very trying experience for Hooper. The new land did not yield easily. The rainy seasons, with their howling winds and pelting showers, forced him to stay indoors, and the enveloping dampness agitated his rheumatism. Cut off from family and friends and from the security and comfort of Boston, he suffered from intense isolation, finding his new life in Koloa "lonesome" and "dull as death." And the people of the new land had not been as pliant as he had hoped: they were difficult to manage and often drove him to dispair. They seemed to resist him at almost every point. They were also more intelligent than he had assumed, able to avoid work and to extract extra compensation in creative and devious ways. Psychically exhausted from his constant struggle with his workers, Hooper vented his frustrations to Ladd and Company in 1838: "No galley slave looks forward to the day when he is to be made free with half so much satisfaction as I do when I shall bid a *final* adieu to intercourse with Hawaiians! Gracious Anticipations!"

A year later, Hooper was granted his wish, but he left behind him, in Koloa, a place transformed. In a sense, Hooper may remind us of William Shakespeare's Prospero and Mark Twain's Connecticut Yankee: Prospero had settled on an island and inducted a native, Caliban, into his service, his work force; and Hank Morgan had travelled to another island, Arthurian England, where he had imposed a modern industrial order. Reflecting the expansionist culture portrayed in Prospero and Morgan, Hooper had removed himself to an island. There, employing native labor, he had cleared the wild grass from the land in order to plant ordered rows of cane; he had altered the very character of the tiny hamlet of Koloa, bringing to it the dark smoke and the loud and dissonant mechanical sounds of a modern factory. He had integrated economic and moral motives, seeking both to earn corporate profits for Ladd and Company and liberate natives from an oppressive feudalism. Converting them into free laborers,

he had removed them from their farms and villages to his plantation where he offered them housing and paternal care. He had opened the way for the development of a corporate dominated sugar economy and a paternalistic racial and class hierarchy of social relations in the islands.

Setting in motion dynamic forces which would transform the ethnicity of Hawaii's population, he had initiated the making of a multiethnic and transnational plantation labor system which would draw into the plantation work force not only people from Hawaii itself but also from China, Japan, Portugal, Norway, Germany, Korea, Puerto Rico, the Philippines, and even Russia. Though he had been at Koloa for only four years, Hooper had proven it was possible to induce the natives to labor as wage earners and to produce sugar as a cash crop. His invoices for 1837-38 showed that he had shipped to Honolulu approximately 30 tons of sugar and 170 barrels of molasses—a small but nonetheless portentous beginning of a new plantation economy which would penetrate Hawaiian society like an "entering wedge."

## Chinese Emigration to California

ELIZABETH SINN

The Pacific Ocean can be—and has been—represented in many different ways. Here, we will look at it in the context of Chinese migration. In the mid-nineteenth century, a series of stunning gold discoveries were made, first in California (1848), then Australia (1851), western Canada (1858), and New Zealand (1861). By coincidence, these places were all on the Pacific Rim, and tens of thousands of Chinese from the Pearl River Delta sailed across the immense watery expanse to reach the Gold Mountains. Until the California Gold Rush transformed it into a hot, happening ocean, the Pacific had been largely irrelevant to Hong Kong, despite its being situated on the ocean's very edge. Gradually, as Chinese migrants embarked at Hong Kong for the gold countries and disembarked there on their way home, the British colonial port became the gateway to the Pacific as well as a pivot in the Cantonese diaspora....

The flow of people with different interests and desires was accompanied by the flow of goods, money (as capital and remittances), communication, information, and the bones and coffins of deceased emigrants. These flows—intricately intertwined, multidirectional, and often circular—created all kinds of networks that in turn facilitated further movements and transactions across the Pacific. "Network" can be a vague word, and too often projects a static image. To flesh out the networks, I examine how they operated on the ground and find that the transpacific networks were not only multidirectional, but also multileveled, interactive, interpenetrating, overlapping, and interlinked. Far from static, they were vibrant and constantly reconfigured....

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Sinn, Elizabeth, "Highway to Gold Mountain, 1850–1900," *Pacific Historical Review*, 83, no. 2, (May 2014): 220–237. © 2014 by the Regents of the University of California. Published by the University of California Press.

## Shipping networks and the flow and circulation of people

The story of transpacific shipping in the mid-nineteenth century is often told in terms of steamliners ... The transpacific route was a circular one, reflecting the circular nature of Chinese migration in the nineteenth century. While in general the ultimate goal was to return to China, there was great variation in how migrants actually circulated. Some made a single trip to California and returned home after making a fortune (or when they could no longer bear the loneliness), while others made multiple trips across the Pacific, returning to China from time to time to visit parents, impregnate wives, and, for merchants, to buy and sell before returning to California once more....

## Flow of goods from China

The Chinese presence in California promoted a California-China trade, although it should not be assumed that the trade was only in Chinese hands. Some of the goods imported into California were specifically for Chinese consumption, such as prepared opium and opium pipes, rice, joss paper, bird's nest and shark's fin, salted eggs, fungus, pots and pans, clothing, and Chinese medicine. Impressarios even sent out Cantonese opera troupes and actors to entertain the Chinese there. Other goods from China were imported for sale to non-Chinese consumers as well, like tea and sugar, paintings, furniture, and all kinds of silk goods. The Chinese curio shop has been a Chinatown feature from the very earliest days.

We know very well that not every Chinese in California prospered, but, compared to Chinese in contemporary China or even Southeast Asia, even the most menial laborers enjoyed a much higher income in the United States. The Gold Rush created a stock figure in the minds of people in South China that resonates even today. He was the *gum saan haak* or "Gold Mountain sojourner," the high-income, big-spending Chinese emigrant in California. He was keenly sought after as a husband and son-in-law, but no less as a customer, investor, and business partner. The *gum saan haak*'s consumption pattern to a large extent dictated the composition and the value of the import-export trade between China and California, with far-reaching consequences for the transpacific economy. For example, his preference for Hong Kong's prepared opium, which was the most highly regarded and expensive opium, led directly to the high price of the opium monopoly in Hong Kong. His preference for no. 1 China rice led to the illegal export of the finest rice from Guangdong province, with the result that cheap rice had to be imported to Guangdong from Siam and Annam to feed the poor. This high-end consumption in California boosted the value of the China-California trade and other trades linked to it.

## Flow of goods from California

In the early days of the Gold Rush, almost everything had to be imported to feed and clothe the emigrants arriving from all corners of the earth, but California was soon able to produce certain commodities for export, thus redressing somewhat

the imbalance of trade. Abalone and dried shrimps, ginseng, quicksilver, flour, and treasure, both silver and gold, were major California exports....

## Flow of *qiaohui*

Besides being a consumer, the Chinese migrant was also a sender of funds, either from savings or profits. Clearly migrants from other countries also sent money home, but the degree and scale of Chinese remittance practices were exceptional. The majority of Chinese emigrants sent money home as a primary duty. The image of the free-spending *gum saan haak* should not blind us to the fact that many Chinese in California were poor. Nevertheless, it was rare for a man, however poor, not to be scrimping and saving in order to send a few dollars home to China every month. The wealthy sent enormous sums to buy land and build houses, to make donations to public projects, and to invest in modern enterprises, such as railroads and electricity companies. Whether sent by poor or rich, the remittances collectively formed an enormous source of income for South China....

Funds could be remitted in different ways. Returning migrants could take their gold with them. Alternatively, the money could take a more tortuous journey. It was common for a Chinese laborer in California to take his few dollars to a shop that undertook to send the money for him, usually accompanied by a letter to his family. After a sizable amount had accumulated, the shopkeeper would send the funds onward to Hong Kong through a variety of means, including by a bank draft or in the form of goods to be sold on arrival. In Hong Kong, the money was converted to silver before being forwarded by couriers or other means to the sender's home. This sounds a lot easier than what happened on the ground, since the sender could live in some very remote part of California, and his home in China could be equally remote and isolated. It could take months before the money reached the recipient, and, in the process, many people had a chance to dip into it, using it either as capital or to ease their own cash flow. In some cases, the money might never have left California at all, as long as shops or firms in California and Hong Kong were able to settle their accounts against goods, passage money, chartering costs, commissions, or other assets.

All these import-export and remittance activities were undertaken by Chinese and non-Chinese firms of different sizes. Very often Chinese and non-Chinese merchants worked closely together; even though this article focuses on Chinese networks, it is important to remember that they were seldom exclusively Chinese.

## Networks of firms and the circulation of capital

Chinese firms in Hong Kong (and Guangzhou) had always been closely connected with those in California. They collaborated in different ways. For example, in the early days Hong Kong firms extended credit on goods while the California firms collected the proceeds and other debts for their Hong Kong counterparts and collected *qiaohui*; they also acted as agents for each other's ships. A number of California firms started as branches and *lianhao* (explained

below) of Hong Kong firms; as the California firms expanded, they in turn established branches and *liaohao* in Hong Kong and other cities in China, creating a counter-trend and making the transpacific connections more complex....

Let me illustrate such a network of firms with the story of Chiu Yu Tin's firm, Chong Wo. Chiu Yu Tin, a native of Nanhai, founded Chong Wo in Hong Kong around 1849, soon after the California Gold Rush. The firm was an active exporter, sometimes acting as agent for others, sometimes trading on its own account. Over time, the goods that Chong Wo exported included shawls, bed covers, lacquered ware that might be classified as "fancy Chinese goods" catering to Westerners, and also rice, opium, clothing, medicinal roots, vegetables, women's shoes, and so on, which were clearly for Chinese consumption. Through the 1850s, as Chong Wo's cargoes grew in value, the firm expanded its business through a series of *lianhao* and other associated companies in California and other localities.

There is reason to believe that Chong Wo originally set up a branch in San Francisco in the early 1850s, managed by a brother or close relative of Chiu's. Later, however, it formed a new firm in San Francisco called Wing Wo Sang with several partners and seems to have done a lot of its business through it. Chong Wo probably held shares in other firms in California as well. Together and separately, Chong Wo and Wing Wo Sang carried on a thriving and large-scale trade, with Chong Wo in Hong Kong frequently sending Wing Wo Sang large amounts of rice, opium, and cooking oil and Wing Wo Sang shipping flour and quicksilver in return. Wing Wo Sang was a major exporter of quicksilver and was listed as a shipper on almost every ship that carried the mineral. The establishment of Wing Wo Sang and other firms in which Chong Wo had an interest benefited Chong Wo in multiple ways, far beyond just facilitating its import-export trade. Through Wing Wo Sang, for instance, Chong Wo was able to invest in gold mines, an opportunity that many Chinese in Hong Kong must have craved but that would have been impossible without the proper agent.

Chong Wo's commercial network spread in all directions, and Chiu Yu Tin was credited with having assisted, through his generosity and connections, "over a thousand" relatives, neighbors, and friends to set up businesses abroad. Even assuming this to be an exaggeration, one can still imagine the pivotal position he must have occupied in a network that covered Hawai'i and spanned the east coast of the Pacific from California to Panama, Peru, and Chile. San Francisco no doubt played a major role in the expansion, serving as the springboard for Hong Kong trade with other parts of North and South America, in the same way that Hong Kong became San Francisco's gateway to China, Southeast Asia, and beyond. The Hong Kong-California corridor became the concourse from which many tributary corridors emerged, directed and re-directed by the movements of Chinese migration and attendant trades.

At the same time that he was looking east across the Pacific, Chiu Yu Tin was also busy trading with China and Southeast Asia through his Nam Pak Hong firm, Kwong Mou Tai. In China he had *lianhao* in many cities all along the China coast, including Shantou, Shanghai, Jiaozhou, Yingkou, and Dalian.

Such multidirectional operations, centering like spokes around Hong Kong's hub, created immense synergy.

In China, the trade with California was known as Gold Mountain trade and the firms as *gum saan jong*. It became an important and iconic trade in Hong Kong. Besides import and export, *gum saan jong* typically engaged in shipping, *qiaohui*, and, later in the century, insurance, and it offered a wide range of personal services to customers, especially migrants and their families.

The Wo Hang firm illustrates these myriad functions very well and shows how the network of firms achieved both vertical and horizontal integration. Besides the California trade, Hong Kong was also a major hub of the valuable Nam Pak trade. This was the trade between the north (North China and Japan) and the south (South China and Southeast Asia), a trade that covered an immense array of commodities. With these two important trading systems intersecting in Hong Kong, the East Asian economy was greatly stimulated....

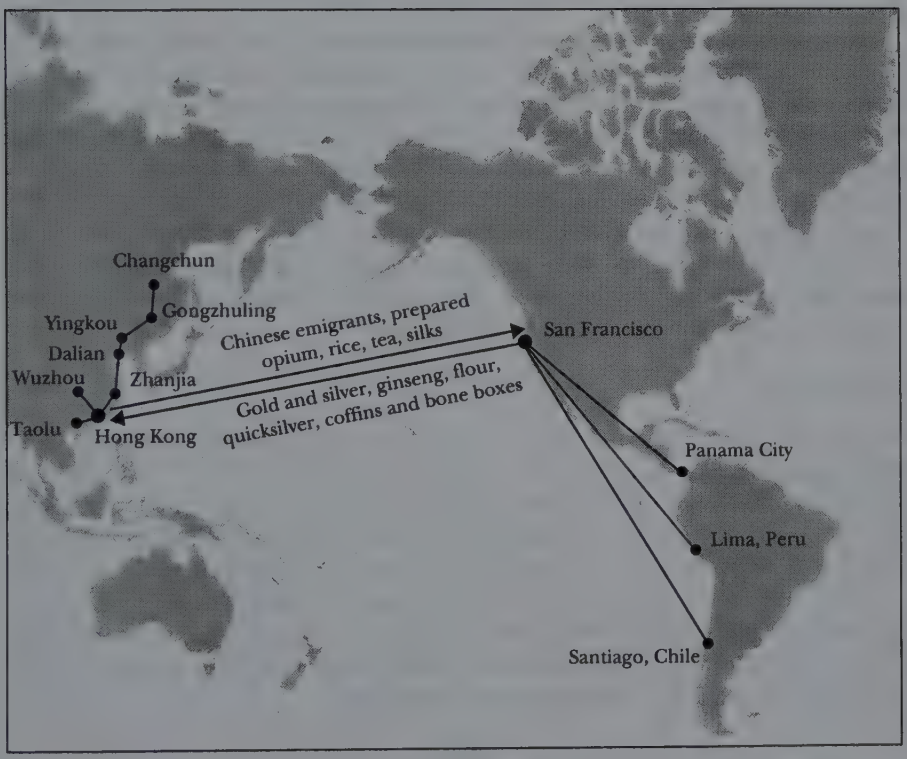



**FIGURE 2.1** An impressionistic map showing the geographical span of Chiu Yu Tin's commercial networks. Map created by Jacquelyn C. Ferry and used with permission.

## The flow of coffins and bones

Profit and consumption were not the only impetus for transpacific flows. Let us look at another kind of flow. A distinctive activity among Chinese migrants in

California was the repatriation of the bones and coffins of those who had died abroad, an activity requiring not just money and labor, but also trust and goodwill. The work was often undertaken by native-place organizations, the *huiguan* (or "companies," as some of them were misleadingly called in California) on both sides of the Pacific.

Chinese migrants in the nineteenth century generally expected to return and spend their last days in comfort in their home villages, not to settle overseas permanently; even when they died overseas, they hoped to be buried at home. As a result, the practice of sending home the remains of deceased migrants emerged in California. The purpose was to let the deceased be buried among their descendants who would make offerings at their graves for generations to come; the greatest fear was that those left abandoned in graves in America would be unattended to and become wild and hungry ghosts.

When a Chinese migrant died in California, the body was usually first buried *in situ*; after five to seven years, the bones were exhumed, cleaned, and boxed for the voyage home. This was a labor-intensive exercise that frequently involved locating isolated graves in regions far from the main cities; on occasions when someone was known to have died but his burial place could not be found, the bone collector would summon the soul of the deceased and collect it in a *zhaohun xiang* (spirit box) that would be sent home and buried just like the coffins and bone boxes. In the nineteenth century, thousands of deceased emigrants returned to China in these boxes. Yet, although the activity of bone repatriation was full of social, cultural, and emotional meaning, the complicated operational and financial arrangements were tightly intertwined with business and financial networks, reinforcing and deepening the transpacific connections. All these comings and goings kept the Pacific a busy highway.

### Conclusion

When the Pacific Ocean turned into a highway for Chinese seeking Gold Mountain, it marked a new era for the history of South China, California, and the ocean itself. With the constant to-ing and fro-ing of people (dead and alive), goods, letters, and money, transpacific relationships became intricate and interdependent. The overlapping personal, family, financial, and commercial interests of Chinese and merchants in California and those in Hong Kong energized the connections and kept the Pacific busy and dynamic while shaping the development of regions far beyond the ocean's shores. It also makes the ocean an exciting historical site, full of opportunities for research.

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CHAPTER 3



# Debating Chinese Immigration, 1860–1899

*The new Republic's egalitarian creed, "all men are created equal," combined with its need for human capital to fuel its ever-expanding economy, fostered liberal immigration policies that welcomed anyone in the world, with the exception of convicts, paupers, and, after 1807, slaves. While Asian immigrants could not become U.S. citizens, U.S. employers, especially those seeking to develop Hawai'i and the Western frontier as discussed in Chapter 2, sought them out. White populations on the West Coast, however, bitterly opposed Asian immigration to that region. Californians, in particular, enacted numerous state and local public policies discriminating against Chinese immigrants in order to discourage their immigration and to encourage those who had already arrived to return home. These policies included special taxes charged upon arrival and on "foreign miners" in the state's gold mining regions; bans on Asians testifying in a court of law or intermarrying with whites; and prohibitions against Chinese businesses, group living quarters, and even the long ponytail or queue hairstyle required by the Qing dynasty.*

*In contrast to California, the federal government did little to lessen free Chinese immigration, and in some cases it overruled state laws, such as "head taxes" on arrivals from China, as interfering with international commerce. The pro-business Republican Party, which controlled the nation's politics from 1860 to 1877 during Civil War and Reconstruction, defended Chinese immigration as part of the nation's egalitarian creed and as necessary labor for developing the U.S. West. William Seward, who had lauded Chinese immigrants as a senator, brokered a historic U.S.-China accord in 1868 when he served as secretary of state. A key provision of this Burlingame Treaty was to grant China "most favored nation" status and to promise the Chinese the right to free immigration and travel within the United States and the protection of Chinese citizens. The Burlingame Treaty expressed a commitment to the principle of equality between the United States and China but, at the urging of a California senator, made an exception regarding naturalization rights so that Chinese immigrants still could not become U.S. citizens.*

*During Reconstruction, when southern states returned to the Union and in so doing boosted the power of the Democratic Party, the Republicans' inclusive immigration policies*

*and friendship with China were tested. A major economic depression in the 1870s added to Republican woes as labor unions found in Chinese immigrants a scapegoat for the nation's ills. Western nativists joined Democrats and labor unions to push Congress to enact a series of immigration policies that singled out the Chinese for discrimination. A landmark act in 1882 overturned the spirit, if not the letter, of the Burlingame Treaty and restricted Chinese laborers from immigrating to the United States for a ten-year period. Subsequent legislation and treaty revision through 1904 transformed the restriction of laborers into the near total exclusion of all classes of Chinese immigrants.*

*Scholarship on the causes of Chinese exclusion has identified the relative significance of three factors: class, race, and politics. The class argument portrays Chinese immigrants as tools of big business used to undermine the rising power of labor unions. Exclusion, from this perspective, is seen as a victory for the white working class. The race argument, on the other hand, underscores the common class position of Asian and white workers and thus attributes exclusion to the race, not class, consciousness of the U.S. labor movement. The politics argument recognizes the importance of both class and race factors but casts exclusion as fundamentally rooted in party politics during a time when sparsely populated Western states like California came to have heightened power over national elections. Another dimension of the politics perspective looks at the implementation of Chinese exclusion through the policing of entry points, such as the Angel Island immigration station and the borders of Canada and Mexico. In these sites, a whole new set of actors emerged that reveal both the draconian enactment of racist policies by immigration and border patrol officers and the crafty maneuverings by lawyers, Chinese advocates, and the immigrants themselves to get around exclusion.*

## DOCUMENTS

While congressional efforts to restrict free Chinese immigrants did not come to fruition for over two decades after they began arriving in the United States, prohibitions against the coolie trade came earlier, in 1862, as part of the Republican Congress's anti-slavery stance. In Document 1, the *New York Times* describes two types of coolies. The good type are "Hindoos" brought to the British and French Caribbean to work on sugar plantations; the bad type are slave-like Chinese forced labor in Spanish-held Cuba and Peru. Note that the voluntary Chinese immigrants who came to California were not considered coolies and thus were not seen as a threat. But exclusionists in California firmly disagreed and pushed to ban Chinese free laborers as a form of coolie labor detrimental to white workers. By 1875, as Document 2 reveals, exclusionist concerns about unfree Chinese immigration grew to include Chinese prostitutes, who were banned because of a fear that they would "cause disease and immorality among white men." Document 3 shows that Chinese immigrant leaders accommodated the increased calls to exclude even free immigration from China by urging the Qing government to curtail the flow of laborers to the United States.

In 1879, Congress held hearings to study the causes of a severe economic depression that damaged businesses and labor opportunities for much of that decade. In Document 4, a white merchant in San Francisco blames Chinese immigrants for the depression in California, testifying to the congressional committee that Chinese do not assimilate to U.S. standards and, as a result, do damage to both white workers

and businesses. The testimony was typical of the hearings, which were a decidedly anti-Chinese affair. Document 5, a graphic depiction of the Chinese as a tool of big business, captures the widespread fear at the time that these immigrants were contributing to a dystopian society in which monopoly capitalism was destroying the American Dream. As the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 was being debated on Capitol Hill, Massachusetts senator George Hoar denounced it as violating U.S. egalitarian principles and offending China and the spirit of the liberal Burlingame Treaty. Excerpted in Document 6, Hoar's speech is consistent with both the Burlingame Treaty and William Seward's earlier pro-China stance.

The push for Chinese exclusion in Congress reflected widespread anti-Chinese sentiment that was particularly acute in the U.S. West. Vigilante campaigns in that region murdered scores of Chinese immigrants and drove countless numbers of them from their homes and workplaces. Document 7 reports on one of the worst instances that occurred in the mining town of Rock Springs, Wyoming, where, in 1885, striking white workers rioted against Chinese laborers who refused to join their strike. The riot left twenty-eight Chinese dead and fifteen injured and forced the U.S. government to pay a substantial indemnity to China for the Chinese losses incurred. The indemnity proved a victory for the Chinese diplomatic corps, which worked closely with elite Chinese immigrant merchants in protesting acts of anti-Chinese discrimination. Much of the time, the merchants sought to appease Americans by declaring their love for the United States and even supporting the restriction of Chinese laborers as long as merchants and other elite classes of Chinese were permitted entry. Yet Document 8, a letter to the editor of the *New York Sun*, shows that some Chinese immigrants blamed white Americans, not Chinese laborers, for discrimination. The author of this document became disillusioned with the nation's egalitarian creed when he was asked to contribute money to building a pedestal for the Statue of Liberty.

The experience of discrimination for Chinese immigrants differed by gender as well as class. Document 9, written by a white investigative reporter, exposes the world of a Chinese woman who owned a brothel and was engaged in immigration smuggling and human trafficking. The predominance of men in Chinese immigrant communities (nearly seven for every woman in San Francisco Chinatown in 1910) created the conditions in which prostitution became a lucrative business controlled by organized crime and its henchmen ("highbinders"). Some poor or unfortunate families in China sold their daughters into slavery and some of these slaves were smuggled into diasporic communities in the United States.

## 1. Newspaper Distinguishes Between Good Coolies, Bad Coolies, and Free Asian Immigrants, 1860

### The American Coolie-Trade

By a curious coincidence, which we trust may not be altogether unprofitable to the cause of humanity, the Legislatures of England and America have been

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From "The American Coolie-Trade," *New York Times*, April 21, 1860, p. 4.

almost simultaneously called upon to consider the abuses of the Coolie-trade in the East. The report of Mr. ELIOT, of Massachusetts, upon this traffic, has just been laid before the House of Representatives, and through the press before the people of the United States. In this report it was proved with terrible distinctness that in the absence of any regulations weighted with the national authority to restrain them from violating the instincts of humanity, American merchants and ship-masters have been gradually drawn into the most atrocious practices in connection with the Coolie-trade on the coasts of the Chinese Empire. The traditional horrors of the African middle-passage have been reënacted, are indeed continually reënacting, under the American flag in the Chinese ports and on the Indian seas. Men are kidnapped by the agents of American mercantile houses, huddled into the unventilated holds of American clipper-ships, restrained of their liberty by force of arms, transported thousands of miles to foreign lands, there disposed of under instruments which they cannot comprehend to masters whose language they do not speak, and condemned to labors which in nine cases out of ten can have no end but death, and to a life from which death is a welcome and desirable release....

Nor is this all. We are even now preparing to receive with unwonted pomp the first embassy which any great Power of Eastern Asia has ever sent to a Christian State, since the then mighty empire of Siam dispatched its envoys to the Court of LOUIS XIV. The Japanese Ministers are to be welcomed as the forerunners of a wonderful expansion in the intercourse of maritime Asia with the United States; and we are already confidently counting upon our growing influence with the Chinese and Japanese nations, to give us certain immense future advantages over our European rivals in the opulent commerce of the Orient. It should be clear to the meanest capacity, that if we suffer our flag to become identified in the Eastern seas with the excesses and outrages now perpetrated almost exclusively under its starry folds, we shall seriously compromise our position in that quarter of the world. All considerations of Christianity and civilization apart, it may perhaps be doubted whether the profits which half-a-dozen reckless shipowners may make for themselves by selling the bodies and souls of a few thousand Mongols, yearly, to the sugar-planters of Cuba and the guano-workers of Peru, can compensate us for this national risk.

The Coolie-trade, upon which we now desire to see the energetic action of Congress concentrated, needs, perhaps, a clearer definition than it has yet received, to the popular apprehension. It has no sort of connection either with the voluntary Chinese emigration which has filled the ranches and cañons of California with the patient disciples of CONFUCIUS, or with the Hindoo Coolie-trade which has produced such marvelous results of prosperity in the English Colonies of the Mauritius, Guiana and Trinidad, and of which the French Emperor is now seeking to extend the advantages to the Indian and Caribbean Colonies of France. The Chinese emigrants to California and Australia, like the Irish and German emigrants to America, pay their own passage-money, command their own labor, and are the architects of their own good or ill fortune. The Hindoo Coolies, whose industry, honestly rewarded, has raised the sugar crop of the Island of Mauritius in a single year of freedom to five times the

amount which it attained in the last year of Slavery, are persons engaged to labor for a term of five years in that colony, under the constant supervision of Government agents charged to protect their rights, to secure them the payment of their wages, a proper allowance of food and medical attendance in case of illness, and at the end of their stipulated term of service to provide them, if required to do so, with a free passage back to India. This emigration is not the ally, but the enemy of Slavery. It has been carried on with ever increasing results of good to all parties concerned, not only with the Mauritius, but with the remoter American Colonies of Great Britain; and so far as the jealousy of the Anglo-Indian Government would permit, with the French Antilles and the *Isle de la Réunion*.

The Chinese Coolie-trade, on the other hand, is prosecuted by entirely irresponsible persons, with no control from any Government, Asiatic or European; and is a creation of European shipping-agents, acting in combination with Chinese contractors, no more decent or scrupulous than the emigrant-runners of New-York. The Imperial Chinese Government in 1855 issued proclamations forbidding the trade to be carried on, under the severest penalties. But thanks to domestic rebellion and foreign intervention, the Chinese Government has been reduced to a state of practical paralysis; and its fulminations have been found powerless against the cruel greed of the Coolie-dealers. In the same year, 1855, the British Government was appealed to on the subject, and Parliament passed an act confiscating all British vessels found engaged in this traffic within the British jurisdiction in the China seas. The only effects of this act have been to drive the traffic from the open ports of China into the smuggling port of Swatow, about two hundred miles above Hong-Kong; and to transfer the burden of the business from British to American vessels. Our only present rivals of importance in the nefarious traffic are the Peruvians, Chilians and North Germans. Peru, in 1856, followed the example of China and England, and made the trade illegal. But, so long as the American flag covers this cruel and cowardly commerce, it must continue to be carried on with all its actual incidents of shame and sin. Immediate and vigorous action on the part of Congress must result in its almost instantaneous suppression; and that action should clothe our civil agents in China with authority to put the enormity down with all the power of our naval forces in those seas. Circumstances having finally shifted the responsibility of this great wrong mainly upon our shoulders, it rests with ourselves to vindicate our national reputation, by acting at once in the premises as becomes our Christianity and our civilization.

## 2. Congress Excludes Un-free Asians, Prostitutes, and Felons, 1875

*Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled*, That in determining whether the immigration of any subject of China, Japan, or any Oriental country, to the United States, is free and

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An Act supplementary to the acts related to immigration, Congressional Record, 43rd Congress, Sess. 11, Ch. 141 (1875) 477–478.

voluntary, as provided by section two thousand one hundred and sixty-two of the Revised Code, title "Immigration," it shall be the duty of the consul-general or consul of the United States residing at the port from which it is proposed to convey such subjects, in any vessels enrolled or licensed in the United States, or any port within the same, before delivering to the masters of any such vessels the permit or certificate provided for in such section, to ascertain whether such immigrant has entered into a contract or agreement for a term of service within the United States, for lewd and immoral purposes; and if there be such contract or agreement, the said consul-general or consul shall not deliver the required permit or certificate.

SEC. 2. That if any citizen of the United States, or other person amenable to the laws of the United States, shall take, or cause to be taken or transported, to or from the United States any subject of China, Japan, or any Oriental country, without their free and voluntary consent, for the purpose of holding them to a term of service, such citizen or other person shall be liable to be indicted therefor, and, on conviction of such offense, shall be punished by a fine not exceeding two thousand dollars and be imprisoned not exceeding one year; and all contracts and agreements for a term of service of such persons in the United States, whether made in advance or in pursuance of such illegal importation, and whether such importation shall have been in American or other vessels, are hereby declared void.

SEC. 3. That the importation into the United States of women for the purposes of prostitution is hereby forbidden; and all contracts and agreements in relation thereto, made in advance or in pursuance of such illegal importation and purposes, are hereby declared void; and whoever shall knowingly and willfully import, or cause any importation of, women into the United States for the purposes of prostitution, or shall knowingly or willfully hold, or attempt to hold, any woman to such purposes, in pursuance of such illegal importation and contract or agreement, shall be deemed guilty of a felony, and, on conviction thereof, shall be imprisoned not exceeding five years and pay a fine not exceeding five thousand dollars.

SEC. 4. That if any person shall knowingly and willfully contract, or attempt to contract, in advance or in pursuance of such illegal importation, to supply to another the labor of any cooly or other person brought into the United States in violation of section two thousand one hundred and fifty-eight of the Revised Statutes, or of any other section of the laws prohibiting the cooly-trade or of this act, such person shall be deemed guilty of a felony, and, upon conviction thereof, in any United States court, shall be fined in a sum not exceeding five hundred dollars and imprisoned for a term not exceeding one year.

SEC. 5. That it shall be unlawful for aliens of the following classes to immigrate into the United States, namely, persons who are undergoing a sentence for conviction in their own country of felonious crimes other than political or growing out of or the result of such political offenses, or whose sentence has been remitted on condition of their emigration, and women "imported for the purposes of prostitution." Every vessel arriving in the United States may be inspected under the direction of the collector of the port at which it arrives, if

he shall have reason to believe that any such obnoxious persons are on board; and the officer making such inspection shall certify the result thereof to the master or other person in charge of such vessel, designating in such certificate the person or persons, if any there be, ascertained by him to be of either of the classes whose importation is hereby forbidden.

## 3. Chinese Immigrant Leaders Discourage Further Immigration from China, 1876

The Chinese Six Companies is asking our fellow clansmen not to make the long sea voyage to the United States so as to avoid bringing trouble on the community. The reason we have been subjected to all kinds of harassment by the white people is that many of our Chinese newcomers are taking jobs away from them. And yet, if we take a look at the wages of the Chinese workers in the various trades, we can see that they are shrinking day by day. This is also due to the large number of our fellow clansmen coming here. If up to 10,000 people come here, even if they do not take away 10,000 white men's jobs, they will still drive down the wages of 10,000 workers in various trades. It's inevitable. If this trend is not stopped, not only will the white men's harassment continue, causing a great deal of trouble for our community, but even skilled Chinese workers will have difficulty finding jobs and will lose their livelihood. If it is hard for the Chinese who are already here, imagine how much worse it will be for the newcomers.

Therefore, in an effort to prevent disaster before it strikes, the members of the Six Companies believe that the best course of action is to have each person in California write a letter home exhorting his clansmen not to come to America. And who would doubt such advice when it originates from a kinsman? This is much better than our posting thousands and thousands of notices. If the trend should cease and fewer clansmen come here, first, further trouble from the white people would be avoided; second, wages will stop shrinking; third, there will be no worry about newcomers being detained. Everyone will benefit. Just a single word from you will do a world of good. For this reason we are urging every one to write home.

The Chinese Six Companies
15th day of the 3rd month, Guangxu 2nd year [April 9, 1876]

## 4. White Merchant Testifies Against Chinese Immigration, 1879

Mr. JOHN F. SCHAEFER came before the committee. He said in reply to preliminary questions: I am a resident here [San Francisco, CA]; I crossed the plains in

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Reprinted in Judy Yung, Gordon H. Chang, and H. Mark Lai (eds.), *Chinese American Voices: From the Gold Rush to the Present* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006), 25.

From House Select Committee, *The Causes of the General Depression in Labor and Business. Chinese Immigration*, San Francisco, CA, August 15, 1879 (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1879), 263–264.

1850, when I was but twelve years of age. We are manufacturing clothing in New York and selling it here. We also sell piece goods, woolens, & c.

The CHAIRMAN. Give us your views in reference to the question of Chinese labor as brought into competition with your own.

Mr. SCHAEFER. My views are that the Chinese are going to ruin the country. They will not only ruin the Pacific States, but as soon as they get through here they will go to the East. I have fought for the Chinese for ten years. I thought that they would make good American citizens, that they would be like other people and would adapt themselves to American customs, but I find that I was mistaken. Even the Chinese merchants and the Chinese millionaires who are here are just as much Chinese to-day as they were when they came here. I know one Chinaman who dresses in American clothes. He talks English pretty well. I said to him some time ago, while the excitement on this subject was high, "Why do you not tell your intelligent people to wear American clothes and to adapt themselves to American customs? They all look like stuffed monkeys in their clothes." "To tell you the truth," said he, "I wear American clothes because I make my living here, but the other Chinamen look upon me as a degraded slave, and they do not admit me into their houses and families because I wear American clothes."

The CHAIRMAN. In your intercourse with them as a merchant, have you learned that there is any affinity or any common feeling between them and the American people, or whether the feeling that exists between them is a feeling of hostility?

Mr. SCHAEFER. I do not know one white man to-day who is in favor of the Chinese coming here.

Mr. CHAIRMAN. Why?

Mr. SCHAEFER. Because he has found out by experience that the Chinese will drive us out by starvation. It is a question of starvation. I talked not long ago to a Chinaman. I said, "Chinaman, you must go." He said, "Me no go; white man go." The Chinese drive us out by degrading labor. Even the manufacturers of cigars and of boots and shoes who employed them at first find out that the Chinese have taken away their business, and that the Chinese can sell at 25 per cent. less than they can. It is merely a matter of time. Chinatown is increasing, and the property of the white people in the vicinity is depreciating. The rich people lose much more by the Chinese than the poor do, on account of the depreciation of property. I have a good deal of property here which I cannot sell for half what it cost me ten years ago.

The CHAIRMAN. Does the presence of the Chinese here prevent immigration from other parts of the United States?

Mr. SCHAEFER. Most assuredly. People cannot get anything to do here. I know young men who are offering to work for me at almost any price. I have got a clerk in the store whom I keep out of sympathy. He has the best of recommendations, and yet he works for me at $2 a day as clerk and bookkeeper, because he cannot get a better situation. I knew another man, a telegraph

operator, who ran around unemployed for six months, and who finally went to work at $1 a day in a sawmill, and he had to pay one of those intelligence offices to get that place. Last week I begged a friend of mine who has a mill in the country to take that man, and he says that when he has a vacant place he will let me know. He employs seventy men. Practical miners get $3 a day, but they have got a society which prevents any man working under that rate....

The CHAIRMAN. What do you think ought to be done with the Chinese?

Mr. SCHAEFER. That is a hard question to answer. I have been thinking that as the people East do not know and will not learn the merits of the question, we ought to send all these Chinese East, and give the people of the East a trial of them. I have been always a steady Republican, but this idea of wanting to sell out (as I may say) our country and homes to the Chinese goes against my grain.

The CHAIRMAN. Have you ever met with a Chinaman whom you could make a citizen of so that he would be creditable to the American standard?

Mr. SCHAEFER. You might just as well try to Christianize the Chinaman. A Chinaman once said to me, "If you give me four bit I will play to Jesus, and for four bit more I will take it all back." It is so in regard to Americanizing them. They will not even leave their bones here. They come out under contract that they shall be sent back to China, or if they die here that their bones shall be sent back.

The CHAIRMAN. Then it is your conviction that you cannot make a civilized American out of a Chinaman?

Mr. SCHAEFER. I thought at first that you could, and I have fought for them many a time and quarreled about them, but I find out that I was mistaken. As to making them American citizens, it is impossible. In different islands in the South Pacific Ocean, where the Chinese have been for one hundred years, the natives have had to clear them out, but the Chinese came back, and the natives did not drive them out a second time. And now the Chinese have these countries, and there are just as many Chinese there as there were one hundred years ago. They will stick to their ideas and their religion just as long as they live.

## 5. Graphic Comic Depicts Chinese Labor Threat, 1881




Choy, Philip P., Lorraine Dong, and Marlon Hom. *The Coming Man: 19th Century American Perceptions* of the Chinese © 1995. Reprinted with permission of the University of Washington Press.

## 6. U.S. Senator Declares Chinese Exclusion Un-American, 1882

Nothing is more in conflict with the genius of American institutions than legal distinctions between individuals based upon race or upon occupation. The framers of our Constitution believed in the safety and wisdom of adherence to abstract principles. They meant that their laws should make no distinction between men except such as were required by personal conduct and character. The prejudices of race, the last of human delusions to be overcome, has been found until lately in our constitutions and statutes, and has left its hideous and ineradicable stains on our history in crimes committed by every generation. The negro, the Irishman, and the Indian have in turn been its victims here, as the Jew and the Greek and the Hindoo in Europe and Asia. But it is reserved for us at the present day, for the first time, to put into the public law of the world and into the national legislation of the foremost of republican nations a distinction inflicting upon a large class of men a degradation by reason of their race and by reason of their occupation.

The bill which passed Congress two years ago and was vetoed by President Hayes, the treaty of 1881, and the bill now before the Senate, have the same origin and are parts of the same measure. Two years ago it was proposed to exclude Chinese laborers from our borders, in express disregard of our solemn treaty obligations. This measure was arrested by President Hayes. The treaty of 1881 extorted from unwilling China her consent that we might regulate, limit, or suspend the coming of Chinese laborers into this country—a consent of which it is proposed by this bill to take advantage. This is entitled "A bill to enforce treaty stipulations with China."

It seems necessary in discussing the statute briefly to review the history of the treaty. First let me say that the title of this bill is deceptive. There is no stipulation of the treaty which the bill enforces. The bill where it is not inconsistent with the compact only avails itself of a privilege which that concedes. China only relaxed the Burlingame treaty so far as to permit us to "regulate, limit, or suspend the coming or residence" of Chinese laborers, "but not absolutely to prohibit it." The treaty expressly declares "such limitation or suspension shall be reasonable." But here is proposed a statute which for twenty years, under the severest penalties, absolutely inhibits the coming of Chinese laborers to this country. The treaty pledges us not absolutely to prohibit it. The bill is intended absolutely to prohibit it....

Here is a declaration made by a compact between the two greatest nations of the Pacific, and now to be re-enforced by a solemn act of legislation, which places in the public law of the world and in the jurisprudence of America the principle that it is fit that there should hereafter be a distinction in the treatment of men by governments and in the recognition of their rights to the pursuit of happiness by a peaceful change of their homes, based not on conduct, not on character, but upon race and upon occupation. You may justly deny to the

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From George Hoar, "Chinese Immigration," *Congressional Record*, 13: 200, March 1, 1882.

Chinese what you may not justly deny to the Irishman. You may deny to the laborer what you may not deny to the scholar or to the idler. And this declaration is extorted from unwilling China by the demand of America. With paupers, lazzaroni [beggars], harlots [prostitutes], persons afflicted with pestilential diseases, laborers are henceforth to be classed in the enumerations of American public law.

Certainly, Mr. President, this is an interesting and important transaction. It is impossible to overstate or to calculate the consequences which are likely to spring from a declaration made by the United States limiting human rights, especially a declaration in a treaty which is to become the international law governing these two great nations. As my friend from California [Mr. MILLER] well said, it is of the earth earthy. The United States within twenty years has taken its place as the chief power on the Pacific. Whatever rivalry or whatever superiority we may be compelled to submit to elsewhere, our advantage of position, unless the inferiority be in ourselves, must give us superiority there. Are we to hold out two faces to the world, one to Europe and another to Asia? Or are we to admit that the doctrine we have proclaimed so constantly for the first century of our history is a mere empty phrase or a lie?

For myself and for the State of Massachusetts, so far as it is my privilege to represent her, I refuse consent to this legislation. I will not consent to a denial by the United States of the right of every man who desires to improve his condition by honest labor—his labor being no man's property but his own—to go anywhere on the face of the earth that he pleases....

The number of immigrants of all nations was 720,045 in 1881. Of these 20,711 were Chinese. There is no record in the Bureau of Statistics of the number who departed within the year. But a very high anti-Chinese authority places it above 10,000. Perhaps the expectation that the hostile legislation under the treaty would not affect persons who entered before it took effect stimulated somewhat their coming. But the addition to the Chinese population was less than one-seventy-second of the whole immigration. All the Chinese in the country do not exceed the population of its sixteenth city. All the Chinese in California hardly surpass the number which is easily governed in Shanghai by a police of one hundred men. There are as many pure blooded Gypsies wandering about the country as there are Chinese in California. What an insult to American intelligence to ask leave of China to keep out her people, because this little handful of almond-eyed Asiatics threaten to destroy our boasted civilization....

The Chinese are in many particulars far superior to our own ancestors as they were when they first came forth into the light of history. Our British forefathers, at a time far within the historic period, remained in a degradation of superstition and a degradation of barbarism to which China never descended. Centuries after the Chinese philosopher had uttered the golden rule, and had said, "I like life and I like righteousness; if I cannot keep the two together I will let life go; and choose righteousness," the Druids of Britain were offering human sacrifices to pagan deities. We must take a race at its best in determining its capacity for freedom. This race can furnish able merchants, skillful diplomatists, profound philosophers, faithful servants, industrious and docile laborers. An eminent member of the other House told me that he had dealt with Chinese merchants to the amount of hundreds of thousands, perhaps millions, and that they had never deceived him....

Humanity, capable of infinite depths of degradation, is capable also of infinite heights of excellence. The Chinese, like all other races, has given us its examples of both. To rescue humanity from this degradation is, we are taught to believe, the great object of God's moral government on earth. It is not by injustice, exclusion, caste, but by reverence for the individual soul that we can aid in this consummation. It is not by Chinese policies that China is to be civilized. I believe that the immortal truths of the Declaration of Independence came from the same source with the Golden Rule and the Sermon on the Mount. We can trust Him who promulgated these laws to keep the country safe that obeys them. The laws of the universe have their own sanction. They will not fail. The power that causes the compass to point to the north, that dismisses the star on its pathway through the skies, promising that in a thousand years it shall return again true to its hour, and keeps His word, will vindicate His own moral law. As surely as the path on which our fathers entered a hundred years ago led to safety, to strength, to glory, so surely will the path on which we now propose to enter bring us to shame, to weakness, and to peril.

## 7. Chinese Laborers Report on Race Riot at Rock Springs, Wyoming Territory, 1885

From a survey of all the circumstances, several causes may be assigned for the killing and wounding of so many Chinese and the destruction of so much property:

1. The Chinese had been for a long time employed at the same work as the white men. While they knew that the white men entertained ill feelings toward them, the Chinese did not take precautions to guard against this sudden outbreak, inasmuch as at no time in the past had there been any quarrel or fighting between the races.
2. On the second day of September 1885, in Coal Pit No. 6, the white men attacked the Chinese. That place being quite a distance from Rock Springs, very few Chinese were there. As we did not think that the trouble would extend to Rock Springs, we did not warn each other to prepare for flight.
3. Most of the Chinese living in Rock Springs worked during the daytime in the different coal mines, and consequently did not hear of the fight at Coal Pit No. 6, nor did they know of the armed mob that had assembled in "Whitemen's Town." When twelve o'clock came, everybody returned home from his place of work to lunch. As yet the mob had not come to attack the Chinese; a great number of the latter were returning to work without any apprehension of danger.
4. About two o'clock the mob suddenly made their appearance for the attack. The Chinese thought that they had only assembled to threaten, and that some of the company's officers would come to disperse them. Most of the Chinese, acting upon this view of the matter, did not gather up their money or clothing, and when the mob fired at them they fled precipitately. Those Chinese who were in

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From "Memorial of Chinese Laborers at Rock Springs, Wyoming Territory, to the Chinese Consul at New York," September 18, 1885; reprinted in *"Chink": A Documentary History of Anti-Chinese Prejudice in America*, ed. Cheng-Tsu Wu (New York: World Publishing, Times Mirror, 1972), 152–159.

the workshops, hearing of the riot, stopped work and fled in their working clothes, and did not have time enough to go home to change their clothes or to gather up their money. What they did leave at home was either plundered or burned.

5. None of the Chinese had firearms or any defensive weapons, nor was there any place that afforded an opportunity for the erection of a barricade that might impede the rioters in their attack. The Chinese were all like a herd of frightened deer that let the huntsmen surround and kill them.
6. All the Chinese had, on the first of September, bought from the company a month's supply of provision and the implements necessary for the mining of coal. This loss of property was therefore larger than it would be later in the month.

We never thought that the subjects of a nation entitled by treaty to the rights and privileges of the most favored nation could, in a country so highly civilized like this, so unexpectedly suffer the cruelty and wrong of being unjustly put to death, or of being wounded and left without the means of cure, or being abandoned to poverty, hunger, and cold, and without the means to betake themselves elsewhere.

To the great President of the United States, who, hearing of the riot, sent troops to protect our lives, we are most sincerely thankful.

In behalf of those killed or wounded, or of those deprived of their property, we pray that the examining commission will ask our minister to sympathize, and to endeavor to secure the punishment of the murderers, the relief of the wounded, and compensation for those despoiled of their property, so that the living and the relatives of the dead will be grateful, and never forget his kindness for generations.

Hereinabove we have made a brief recital of the facts of this riot, and pray your honor will take them into your kind consideration.

(Here follow the signatures of 559 Chinese laborers, resident at Rock Springs, Wyoming Territory.)

## 8. Chinese Immigrant Objects to the Hypocrisy of the Statue of Liberty, 1885

Sir:

A paper was presented to me yesterday for inspection, and I found it to be specially drawn up for subscription among my countrymen toward the Pedestal Fund of the Bartholdi Statue of Liberty. Seeing that the heading is an appeal to American citizens, to their love of country and liberty, I feel that my countrymen and myself are honored in being thus appealed to as citizens in the cause of liberty. But the word liberty makes me think of the fact that this country is the land of liberty for men of all nations except the Chinese. I consider it as an insult to us Chinese to call on us to contribute toward building in this land a pedestal for a statue of Liberty. That statue represents Liberty holding a torch which lights

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From Saum Song Bo, *Letter to the New York Sun*, n.d., 1885, reprinted in American Missionary, Oct. 1885, 290.

the passage of those of all nations who come into this country. But are the Chinese allowed to come? As for the Chinese who are here, are they allowed to enjoy liberty as men of all other nationalities enjoy it? Are they allowed to go about everywhere free from the insults, abuse, assaults, wrongs and injuries from which men of other nationalities are free?

If there be a Chinaman who came to this country when a lad, who has passed through an American institution of learning of the highest grade, who has so fallen in low with American manners and ideas that he desires to make his home in this land, and who, seeing that his countrymen demand one of their own number to be their legal adviser, representative, advocate and protector, desires to study law, can he be a lawyer? By the law of this nation, he, being a Chinaman, cannot become a citizen, and consequently cannot be a lawyer.

And this statue of Liberty is a gift to a people from another people who do not love or value liberty for the Chinese. Are not the Annamese and Tonquinese [Tonkinese] Chinese, to whom liberty is as dear as to the French? What right have the French to deprive them of their liberty?

Whether this statute against the Chinese or the statue to Liberty will be the more lasting monument to tell future ages of the liberty and greatness of this country, will be known only to future generations.

Liberty, we Chinese do love and adore thee; but let not those who deny thee to us, make of thee a graven image and invite us to bow down to it.

## 9. Journalist Exposes Activities of Chinese Brothel Owner, 1899

SUEY HIN, a Chinese slave-owner, who has been importing Chinese girls into San Francisco for years, has just been converted to Christianity. To show her sincerity she has freed the seven girls in her possession, valued by her at $8,500, and will endeavor to see them safely married. Several of the girls were kidnaped and they will be returned to their parents. In the light of her new faith, Suey Hin uncovers the whole nefarious Chinese girl slave trade in San Francisco, and describes how the girls are sold here among the Chinese for a few hundred dollars. She herself when only five years old was sold into the trade by her own father, and lived out the whole dreadful life to the time when she adopted Christianity.

Suey Hin, importer, seller, keeper of slave girls, has become a Christian. She says her seven girls may go free if they will live a right life. She is the first woman slave-keeper in Chinatown ever known to give up her business for the Christian religion.

She did not intend to become a Christian. She wanted the "white teachers" to be friends because sometimes her girls were sick, sometimes they were kidnaped. Then, shrewd Chinese believe that the white teachers are good friends to have in a contest with highbinders. Suey Hin reasoned that way, and she went about gaining their friendship in the usual shrewd Chinese way.

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From Judy Yung, *Unbound Voices: A Documentary History of Chinese Women in San Francisco*. Reproduced with permission of University of California Press via Copyright Clearance Center.

She went to the lassies of the Salvation Army and asked them to come and pray for her. She returned with them to her little sitting-room, with its great carved and canopied bed, with its shrine and burning punk sticks and prayers on scarlet paper pasted at the side of the altar. "May honorable guests constantly visit this house," and the punctured red paper which makes the money god happy. Only two of the seven slave girls were in the room, and they knelt while the lassies prayed. They could not understand English, so their slaveowner thought the prayers could not hurt them, but it was a way to gain the good will of the lassies. Suey Hin did not understand the prayers herself at first, but the more she did understand them the better she remembered her mother and the old home in Shantung, and how life was before she began to buy and sell young girls....

It took Suey Hin five months to "get" so much conversion that she reached the point where she could give up her trade. Then she went back to her home where the seven girls had been under the care of a woman she called her sister.

It was in this home I listened to her story, partly in her own pigeon English and the rest from the lips of an interpreter. And this is the story she told me in her broken pigeon English:

"I am old, very old, too old to be an American. I like Americans, and if I were younger I would be one. Long, long ago I was born in Shantung, where the flowers are more beautiful and the birds sing more sweetly than in any other place. But my people were poor. There was not enough for all our stomachs. Two baby girls had been left exposed—that is, to die, you know. They were born after me and my father said often, 'She is too many.'

"Once there was an old woman came to our house and she looked at me. I was 5 that year, 6 the next. When she looked at me I was afraid and I hid myself behind my mother. My father told the old woman to go away.

"But that night she came back again and talked to my father and mother. She put a piece of gold money in my hand and told me to give it to my father. I did, for I wanted nothing to do with her. I had enough; yes, I had plenty to eat!

"But that night the old woman carried me away, and I kicked and screamed and said I would not go. I do not remember much more about the beginning. I remember the ship, and I remembered playing with other little girls. We were brought to San Francisco, and there were five or ten of us and we all lived with a woman on Ross alley. Every little while some one would come and see us, and as we grew older the girls were sold.

"One day it was my turn. They said I was 14 years old, but I was really 12. I don't know how much I cost, but I know both my hands were filled three times with all the gold they would hold. The money, you know, is always put in a girl's hand when she is sold.

"Well, then I was a slave for ten years. There was a man who loved me, but he was a poor washman, and he worked eight years and saved all, all the time. I saved all I could get, too, but it took eight years before we had saved $3000. Then we bought me from my owner and we were married.

"Then, ah, it's all of my life I like to think about. It wasn't but two next years, three years. My husband got sick and didn't get any better, and then he died. I didn't have anything but just myself, and I had to live, and I could not

live on nothing. No, I had to have things, so I got a little house; you know, one with a little window over the door.

"Then pretty soon I went back to China, but I did not go to my own village. No, my parents would not want to see me. I went to Hongkong and I bought three girls. Two of them are dead, but Ah Moy, that's Ah Moy, she was a baby, and I paid her father 50 cents for her. After I had returned here a few months I went back to China again. I wanted to see my village, always I wanted to go back to my home. So I went, but I didn't let anybody know I was there. I went to the place where they put the babies to die. There was a baby there. A little bit of a brown baby, and she didn't look much good anyway. But I wanted some one from my own village, and so I took the baby, and she is Ah Lung. Don't you think she is a pretty girl now? She's not a slave you know. She's a good girl, just the same as white girls. She comes from Shantung, so I say she shall never be like the others. Slave girls most all die soon. It's bad, yes, and only the girls who want to be good and the dear Jesus knows about that. You see she is a girl and her people sold her, so what can she do?

"That trip I brought home four girls besides Ah Lung. You see it was not hard to smuggle the girls into this country then. You can't do it so easy now. Sometimes they come, only sometimes now. You see the Hop Sing tong fix it with the Custom House. They swore to the officers that the children were born here and went to China to visit. Some witnesses come and they say they knew the girl who wants to land was born here, and they tell all about it. Then they say they know she is the same because they saw her when they went back to China. It was not hard to swear them into this country.

"Then I went back once more. That was only a year ago and I brought back six girls. They did not seem to be with me when we got to the landing, but I watched them. I made the girls learn the answers to the questions the highbinders said would be asked by the Custom House. I told the girls if they made any mistakes the white devils would get them. I said white men liked to eat China girls, they like to boil them and then hang them up to dry and then eat them.

"Oh, the girls didn't make any mistakes when the inspector asked them questions and when they were landed they didn't want to run away. I told them that the girls only stayed at the missions till they got very fat and then Miss Cameron and Miss Lake sold them. Oh, I was bad—wasn't I bad? But I love Jesus now.

## ESSAYS

In the first essay, Princeton University historian Beth Lew-Williams examines the causes of Chinese restriction in 1882 and explains how and why Chinese labor migration to the United States did not end until more draconian exclusion policies were implemented later. The ambiguities of anti-Chinese discrimination are also revealed in the second essay, in which Massachusetts Institute of Technology historian Emma Teng describes representations of mixed-race Chinese Americans. Some of the depictions, she argues, supported popular racial theories at the time that saw such race mixing as detrimental as detrimental to the individual and society. Yet others saw them as a sign of "hybrid vigor" and the benefits of race mixing.

# From Chinese Restriction to Exclusion

BETH LEW-WILLIAMS

## Re-examining the Chinese Restriction Act of 1882

Although West Coast sinophobes began demanding the end of Chinese immigration in the 1850s, it took decades before the federal government enacted immigration restriction, both because of diplomatic entanglements and because the electorate was highly divided on the advisability of banning the Chinese. Three primary groups argued in favor of Chinese immigration: Radical Republicans, who opposed exclusion on the grounds of racial equality; Protestant missionaries, who believed exclusion would undermine their conversion efforts; and capitalists, who argued that "cheap" Chinese labor was essential to the development of the West. These constituencies had clout in Congress and made exclusion far from a foregone conclusion. However, the largest impediment to legislation barring Chinese immigration came not from interest groups on American soil, but from U.S. diplomatic agreements with China.

Through the first half of the nineteenth century, Americans habitually likened immigrants to imports and assumed that the governance of migration was a diplomatic matter. American treaties with European nations routinely granted the free movement of people between nations, along with the free movement of goods. In 1868 the United States negotiated a similar relationship with China in the Burlingame Treaty, whereby it recognized China as "an equal among the nations" and agreed to "free migration and emigration" between the two countries. The surprisingly egalitarian nature of the treaty derived from American economic anxiety. As U.S. territorial expansion slowed and industrial expansion increased in the mid-nineteenth century, industrialists believed that finding overseas markets for their products was imperative. Through this agreement with China, U.S. diplomats curried favor with the Chinese in order to secure a vast market, provide U.S. capitalists with a flow of inexpensive labor, and give U.S. missionaries access to millions of potential converts. At the time, the treaty had widespread support: The Senate unanimously ratified it, and the press lauded its "vast commercial importance."

Although well received in 1868, the Burlingame Treaty—and the sentiment behind it—ceased to have unanimous support in the 1870s as it became a stumbling block for congressional attempts to restrict Chinese immigration. In 1879 Congress passed the Fifteen Passenger Bill, which proposed to limit the number of Chinese immigrants who could disembark from a given vessel in the United States to fifteen. But President Rutherford Hayes vetoed this attempt at restriction, explaining that "our treaty with China forbids me to give the bill my approval." Hayes recognized Congress's prerogative to abrogate a treaty, but he argued that Congress should contravene treaties only in times of "highest necessity." Furthermore, he argued, Congress could not strike out one section of the treaty and leave

Lew-Williams, Beth, "Before Restriction Became Exclusion: America's Experiment in Diplomatic Immigration Control," *Pacific Historical Review*, 83, no. 1 (February 2014): 24–56. © 2014 by the Regents of the University of California. Published by the University of California Press.

the rest in place, because this would undermine executive diplomatic power. In his judgment, Congress could not restrict Chinese immigration without abrogating all diplomatic agreements with China, so Hayes pushed to secure a new treaty with China. After contentious negotiations, the 1880 Angell Treaty provided that the United States "may regulate, limit, or suspend" Chinese immigration but "not absolutely prohibit it." The treaty also stated, "the limitation or suspension shall be reasonable and shall apply only to Chinese who may go to the United States as laborers." The treaty contained another key limitation: "Chinese laborers who are now in the United States shall be allowed to go and come of their own free will and accord." The Angell Treaty permitted the United States to begin closing the gate that the Burlingame Treaty let open.

Soon after the new treaty was ratified, more than a dozen anti-Chinese bills were introduced in Congress, but it was California's Republican Senator John Miller's bill that got the attention of the Senate. Senate Bill 71 suspended the immigration of Chinese laborers for twenty years. To avoid violating treaty stipulations, Senate Bill 71 made an exception for Chinese workers currently residing in the United States and for Chinese who were present in the United States before November 17, 1880 (the day that the Angell Treaty was signed). All future Chinese immigrants—whether laborers or not—would be required to secure a passport from the Chinese government and approval from a U.S. diplomat before embarking from China. Any Chinese found entering illegally would be convicted of a misdemeanor, fined up to $100, subject to one year in prison, and then deported by the U.S. government. Chinese found to have forged their passports could be fined $1,000 and imprisoned for up to five years.

Most Democrats and western Republicans supported the bill, passionately repeating that the Chinese degraded American labor and contaminated white American civilization. But a sizable minority—mostly Republicans from northeastern and Atlantic states—opposed the legislation, arguing that it was an "extreme... sweeping and oppressive" bill that breached the new Angell Treaty with China. Congress claimed a constitutional right to contravene the treaty, but most Republicans feared that unilateral abrogation of a treaty would jeopardize America's national honor and relations with China. Connecticut Republican Orville Platt reminded the Senate, "We made this contract which we call a treaty with the Chinese Government.... We must keep it or stand forever disgraced in the eyes of the world." Some congressmen went further, questioning Congress's unilateral right to exclude Chinese immigrants. Senator George F. Hoar (Republican of Massachusetts) pointed out that the United States had described immigration as an "inalienable right of man" in the Burlingame Treaty....

Although they did not defend the merits of Chinese immigration, these Republican holdouts fought to amend the bill to make it less severe. They argued that the length of twenty years should be shortened and the passport section dropped, or that the law should only apply to certain undesirables (such as contract laborers, criminals, paupers, and the diseased). This fight for amendments reveals that by 1882 the vast majority of congressmen agreed that some form of restriction was needed, but there was no consensus for complete exclusion. In the end, Republicans did not appreciably weaken the bill. "An Act to Execute Certain Treaty Stipulations relating to the

Chinese" passed the Senate with Democrats voting in favor (twenty to one) and Republicans divided (nine to fourteen). Soon after, the House also passed the bill. Again, Democrats united in favor of the act, and Republicans split their votes, with sixty in favor and sixty-two opposed.

But Republican President Chester Arthur vetoed Senate Bill 71, explaining to Congress that the legislation was "a breach of our national faith" and threatened U.S. commercial interests in Asia. Arthur wrote to Congress, "Experience has shown that the trade of the East is the key to national wealth and influence.... It needs no argument to show that the policy which we now propose to adopt must have a direct tendency to repel Oriental nations from us and to drive their trade and commerce into more friendly hands." Although Arthur vetoed Senate Bill 71, he made it clear that he would favor a more limited form of Chinese restriction that did not threaten the U.S. relationship with China. In his veto message, he argued that the twenty-year suspension was unreasonable, but he encouraged Congress to consider "a shorter experiment." Congress might have had the constitutional right to unilaterally abrogate the Angell Treaty and exclude Chinese laborers, but President Arthur, like President Hayes, denied them the power to do so.

Given the sizable number of Republican holdouts, Congress could not hope to pass the law over Arthur's veto....

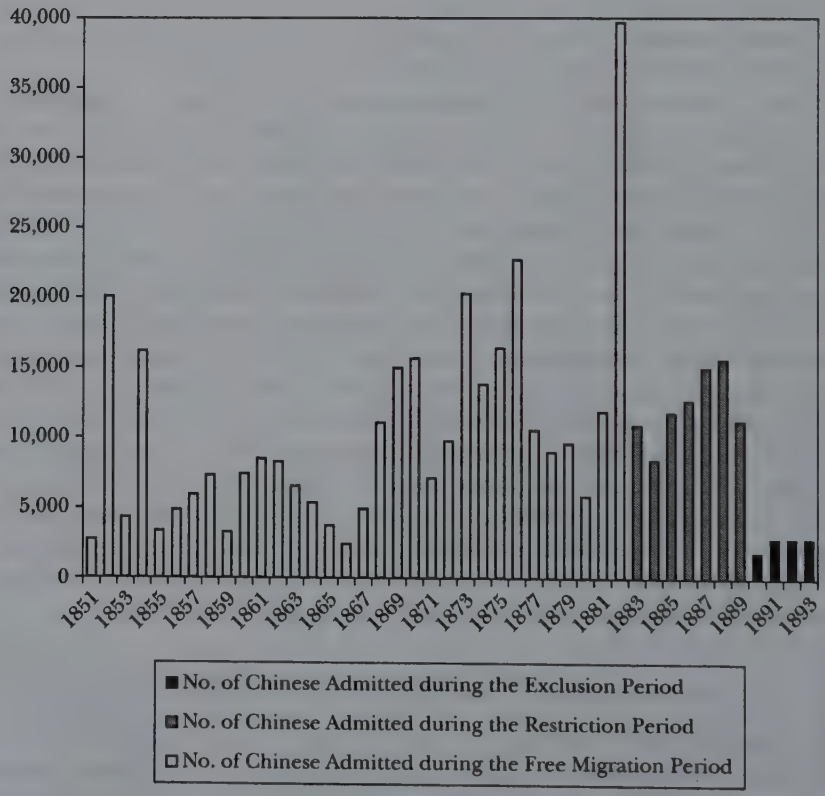
Only a few weeks after President Arthur's veto, Congress considered a new Chinese bill that was a watered-down version of its predecessor. The vetoed Bill 71 had already made significant efforts to avoid angering the Chinese government: Chinese who were not laborers were free to come and go as they pleased, and Chinese laborers who had arrived before the 1882 act or had visited the United States before the 1880 treaty were also allowed free entry. The new bill went further to place diplomatic concerns above the desire to limit Chinese immigration. Not only did Congress shorten the term of restriction to ten years, it also eliminated section seven, which instituted an internal registration and passport system, and section fourteen, which made illegal immigration a crime punishable by imprisonment and a fine. Some congressmen, especially those representing the West Coast, may have earnestly hoped the bill would stop the immigration of Chinese workers. For others, however, this was clearly a temporary solution that they hoped would placate western sinophobes without eliciting retribution from the Chinese government. With additional Republican support, Congress passed the weakened bill. On May 6, 1882, President Arthur signed the Chinese Restriction Act into law.

## Documented Immigration during Chinese Restriction, 1882–1888

The Restriction Act was not the "near total victory for the exclusionists" that some scholars have claimed. Tempered by Republicans' fears of violating U.S. treaties with China, the Restriction Act was deliberately narrow in scope. Without an internal passport system to register and identify Chinese in America, it was nearly impossible to determine whether a Chinese immigrant was legal or illegal. Furthermore, Congress virtually ensured the act's failure by appropriating a paltry $5,000 per year to implement its provisions. Inadequate enforcement

mechanisms and inadequate funding guaranteed that the act would have only limited effect on the flow of Chinese immigration. No law could have suddenly and completely closed the borders to Chinese workers, but it is striking that the 1882 act left the doors intentionally propped open....

After 1882, tens of thousands of Chinese workers continued to enter California by claiming to be members of the exempt classes (i.e., a merchant, diplomat, tourist, or student), travelers who were merely "in-transit" across the United States, or workers who had previously resided in America. Some Chinese presented real or fabricated certificates to make these claims, but admission did not even require such papers. The Restriction Act, in compliance with the Angell Treaty, allowed free entry to Chinese who had resided in the United States before the Restriction Act went into effect. This meant that Chinese workers could claim they had resided in the country before 1880 and had left before the customs department started issuing return certificates. Congress had deliberately created the category of "return immigrant" as a diplomatic concession that would respect U.S. treaty stipulations and




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**FIGURE 3.1** Total Number of New and Return Chinese Admitted to the United States by Year, 1851–1893. This figure offers a visual representation of the flow of documented Chinese immigration when Chinese were allowed free migration (1851–1882), when the Chinese Restriction Act was enforced (1883–1889), and when the 1888 Chinese Exclusion Act was enforced (1890–1893).

avoid antagonizing China. The law intended to hold the gate open for cyclical immigrants who had resided in the United States before, but it ended up also allowing many who were newcomers who had learned how to bypass the law. California Congressman William Morrow complained, "The practical effect of leaving our doors open to Chinamen who will assert and prove this claim of prior residence is to defeat the whole purpose of the treaty stipulations and legislation." During the Restriction period, the primary way that Chinese entered the United States was by claiming they were returning immigrants....

When returning immigrants are included in the annual totals of Chinese arrivals, the ineffectiveness of Restriction becomes clear. During the period of free Chinese migration, between 1851 and 1882, the mean annual number of Chinese entries was 10,388. During the period when Restriction was enforced (1883–1889), the mean number was 8,746. This represents only a 16 percent decrease in the annual number of Chinese immigrants as a result of the law....

## Undocumented Immigration during Chinese Restriction, 1882–1888

The most visible stream of Chinese immigrants came through San Francisco, but the Chinese had another major illegal avenue into the United States. When drafting the Restriction Act, congressmen had conceived of western border control in terms of discrete points of entry at seaports, like San Francisco, where all immigrants could be stopped and questioned. They failed to appreciate the porous nature of thousands of miles of land and sea borders. This made little difference in California, because relatively few Chinese entered across the Mexican border in the 1880s. But in the north, thousands of Chinese lived in British Columbia and crossed into Washington Territory, which had a more robust economy at the time. Congress's failure to address the vast northern border made the U.S.-Canadian boundary an open back door into the United States. No law could have completely closed this long border, but the specifics of the 1882 act undermined a credible attempt.

The Restriction Act was impossible to enforce.... In 1884, the head U.S. immigration officer for the Northwest, summarized his desperate situation to his superiors: "This Chinese immigration is no fiction now. I believe they are coming over to our side every day, by water and by land, and by boats and canoes ... between British Columbia, and this country, it seems to me the Restriction Act is almost worthless."...

## From Restriction to Exclusion

The failure of Restriction was clear not only to local customs officials, but also becoming clear to Congress, the President, and the general American public. In 1886 the *Philadelphia Press* observed:

> A trial of nearly four years of the restriction act has shown that it is little better than a rope of sand as a bulwark against the Mongolians. The frauds that can be practiced under it are numerous and the wily Chinese

were not slow to find the loopholes and take advantage of them. The knowledge of these facts has aroused the people of the Pacific slope as they were never aroused before on the subject.

In 1885 and 1886, the U.S. West erupted in violent local crusades to drive out the Chinese, and anti-Chinese vigilantes vehemently petitioned Congress to finally pass an exclusion law. The violence drew attention on both sides of the Pacific. In June 1886, in the wake of the violence, Congress debated the future of Chinese Restriction and its funding.... varied from $5,000 to $5,500. He complained, "The insufficiency of this appropriation compelled the Treasury Department to exercise such rigid economy in providing the machinery for executing the provisions of the act that the law has been evaded in a most shameful manner."

As Congress united against Chinese immigration, the treaty with China remained a roadblock to exclusion. But the anti-Chinese violence and the failings of the Restriction Act had also gained the attention of the Chinese government. In 1886, Cheng Tsao Ju, the Chinese minister stationed in Washington, D.C., wrote to the U.S. Secretary of State, Thomas Francis Bayard, "to bring ... immediate and urgent attention" to the fact that "Chinese have been driven by violence out of many places, their dwellings burned, their property robbed, and, in some instances, the people murdered, without any serious attempt being made by the authorities to prevent these acts or afford protection." Cheng demanded an end to the violence and redress for all financial losses. After months when complaints about the violence had drawn little response, Chinese diplomats tried a new tactic. They proposed a treaty (later called the Bayard-Zhang Treaty) designed to reduce attacks on Chinese by self-prohibiting the emigration of Chinese workers. Economically and politically subjugated by western countries, China did not have the power to force the United States to follow treaty stipulations and protect Chinese citizens. The Chinese government hoped that self-prohibition—preventing Chinese workers from boarding ships bound for the United States—would provide an alternate way to end anti-Chinese violence, increase American respect, and construct Chinese exclusion on Chinese terms.

The Bayard-Zhang treaty finally had the potential to prohibit Chinese workers from immigrating to America. The treaty would have excluded all Chinese laborers for the following twenty years, unless the laborer had a return certificate *and* either $1,000 in property or a direct relative (wife, child, or parent) in the United States. The United States eagerly ratified the treaty in May 1888, but in September rumors crossed the Pacific that the Chinese government was backing out of the accord. This news came two months before a highly contentious presidential election, and the Democratic administration rushed to contain the fallout. Through connections in Congress, President Grover Cleveland pushed forward a bill that would unilaterally exclude the Chinese even though it abrogated existing treaties. With his eyes likely trained on the swing state of California, Cleveland wished "to answer the earnest popular demand for the absolute exclusion of Chinese laborers."

Before 1888, fear of diplomatic and commercial repercussions had tied the U.S. government's hands. But now, from the perspective of the U.S. government, the Chinese had blinked. By proposing the Bayard-Zhang treaty, the Chinese government had revealed that it would be willing to accept some form of exclusion. Cleveland and Congress thus had reason to hope that they could close the door to Chinese workers while continuing to pursue an open door in China. Signing the 1888 Exclusion Act (also known as the Scott Act) into law, President Cleveland openly acknowledged that the law abrogated U.S. treaties with China. He justified this bold action, stating that "the unexpected and disappointing refusal of the Chinese Government" to ratify the Bayard-Zhang Treaty at the eleventh hour had driven the United States to act in "self-defense by exercise of legislative power."

Despite the long U.S. history of bilateral negotiations of immigration law through treaties with foreign nations, Cleveland now asserted that immigration control was a sovereign U.S. right. In his official message to Congress, he argued that "exclud[ing] from its border all elements of foreign population which for any reason retard its prosperity" was "the admitted and paramount right and duty of every Government" and "must be regarded as a recognized canon of international law and intercourse." Cleveland drew on the precedent of seventeenth-century international law, but the sovereign right of exclusion had not been explicitly part of U.S. law until Cleveland signed the Exclusion Act and the Supreme Court upheld its constitutionality the following year. In *Chae Chan Ping v. United States* (1889), the Supreme Court held that "the power of exclusion of foreigners" was an "incident of sovereignty belonging to the government of the United States as a part of ... the Constitution" and that this right "cannot be granted away or restrained on behalf of any one." The Court's ruling recognized Congress's absolute power to exclude foreigners.

The United States had violated the spirit of Sino-American treaties before, but it had never blatantly and knowingly abrogated a treaty with China through federal legislation. Other western powers openly wondered if the United States were trying to provoke war with China in order to advance U.S. imperial ambitions. The Chinese minister in America expressed shock and dismay, writing, "I was not prepared to learn that there was a way recognized in the law and practice of [the United States] whereby your country could release itself from treaty obligations without consultation or consent of the other party." But the Chinese government did little but lodge protest after protest. The Exclusion Act of 1888 cemented into law the imbalance of power between the United States and China.

The 1888 Exclusion Act also represented a dramatic shift in the objectives of U.S. immigration policy and achieved a significant tightening of U.S. borders. Whereas the Restriction Act had allowed Chinese laborers who resided in the United States to return, the Exclusion Act ended this exception. It declared null and void approximately 30,000 return certificates that had been issued to Chinese laborers since 1882, leaving tens of thousands of men and women who had temporarily left the United States unable to return. By ending the use of return certificates, the law also closed a major avenue of immigration fraud. The only diplomatic concession the law retained was unrestricted immigration for upper-class Chinese, including students, diplomats, and merchants.

The Exclusion Act also dramatically slowed documented Chinese migration. Between 1888 and 1893 when the act was in place, the mean annual number of Chinese admitted to the United States dropped to 2,527, which represented a 75 percent decrease from pre-1882 admission levels.

As documented avenues of entering the country narrowed, Chinese migrants turned to illegal entry, increasing undocumented immigration along U.S. borders with Canada and Mexico. The Exclusion Act failed to close these illegal avenues (a failure repeated in many immigration laws since) or eliminate the possibility of fraud, but it is noteworthy that Congress intended the law to erect a new level of border control. The appropriations committee allocated $50,000 to enforce the Exclusion Act during its first year—ten times the yearly appropriation for the Restriction Act—and this allocation doubled in subsequent years. Along the U.S.-Canadian boundary, this meant the customs service could employ and train specially designated "Chinese inspectors" for the first time. These inspectors began to monitor the movement of Chinese on both sides of the border, with the help of their Canadian counterparts.

The funding also meant a change in the U.S. ability to punish illegal immigrants. Starting in 1890, the Department of the Treasury stopped deporting convicted Chinese in the Pacific Northwest to Canada and began sending them to China, regardless of the additional cost. In addition, the new language of the law, according to Attorney General William Miller, put "the burden of proof upon the Chinese applicant for admission [and] the evidence must be convincing." With the Exclusion Act came a change in federal attitude that made "exclusion the rule and admission the exception."

The tightening of U.S. immigration policy did not end with the Exclusion Act. Once Congress had breached its treaties with China without consequence, it became easy to do so again. Chinese officials and immigrants launched protests of the Exclusion Act of 1888, but they did little to disrupt U.S. trade or diplomatic relations with China. Without the approval of China, the United States passed additional legislation in 1892, 1902, and 1904 designed to constrain further the immigration of Chinese to the United States. In 1888 the federal government made exclusion its goal, marking a major shift in its conception of U.S. sovereignty and immigration law, but it continued to work out the practicalities of achieving full exclusion for years to come.

## Debating Mixed Marriage in the United States and China

EMMA JUNHUA TENG

The most famous Eurasian in America during the 1890s was a criminal. A notorious pickpocket and "green-goods man," George Washington Appo (1856–1930) regularly appeared in newspaper stories of the time. After he testified in the sensational Lexow Committee investigation of New York police corruption,

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Emma Junhua Teng, *Debating Mixed Marriage in the U.S. and China.* From Teng, *Eurasian: Mixed Identities in the United States, China, and Hong Kong, 1842–1943* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2013).

the *New York Times* dubbed George "one of the country's most picturesque criminals," while the [Chinese-friendly] *Hartford Courant* unfailingly chronicled the "half-breed's" trials and testimony. George Appo even turned up on the stage, playing himself in George Lederer's theatrical melodrama, *In the Tenderloin*, to national acclaim. To cap it all off, the *World* voted him among "the People Who Made the History of 1894."

Journalist Louis J. Beck devoted a chapter to this colorful character, son of Quimbo Appo, the infamous Chinese tea merchant turned murderer, in his *New York's Chinatown: An Historical Presentation of Its People and Places* (1898). Part tourist guidebook, part amateur ethnography, part muckraking exposé, Beck's volume was the first full-length book on New York's Chinese Quarter and would in time become a frequently quoted source for Chinatown history. Beck promised his audience that his book would shed light on the vexed Chinese Question by presenting the city's Chinese residents through the unbiased lens of the reporter. At the heart of the Chinese Question was this: Could the Chinese in time become assimilated, and patriotic, American citizens, or did their "racial traits" render this impossible, warranting their exclusion from the nation? Beck offered George Appo's biography as food for thought: "George Appo was born in New York City, July 4, 1858 [*sic*], and is therefore an American citizen, and should be a patriotic one, but he is not. His father was a full-blooded Chinaman and his mother an Irishwoman. He was an exceedingly bright child, beautiful to look upon, sharp-witted and quick of comprehension. For ten years he was the pet of the neighborhood where his parents dwelt.... At the age of ten he became a pickpocket."

Beck's decision to dedicate an entire chapter to the celebrity criminal can be explained not only by sensationalism, but also by the special significance he saw in George Appo's life story. Beck considered this "noted Chinese character" a valuable case study in "heredity and racial traits and tendencies," one well worth investigating, he claimed, for he was only the first of the emerging "new hybrid brood" to come to popular notice. As such, Beck argued, "The question which naturally presents itself to the thinker is, 'What part will the rest of his tribe take in our national development?'"

It was a question that was on the minds of many journalists, social reformers, travelers, and others as they toured America's Chinatowns and saw growing numbers of "half-castes" on the streets and in doorways, Indeed, by the late nineteenth century, such "mixed" children could be found in virtually every Chinese American community, from Boston to Chicago and San Francisco (see introduction). When pioneering Chinese American journalist Wong Chin Foo reported on the New York Chinese for the *Cosmopolitan* in 1888, he asserted that there were more than a hundred "half-breed" Chinese children in that city alone. Although their absolute numbers were small, their anomalous looks drew attention and aroused curiosity. Observers attached a special significance to these children that went beyond their numbers. For many, they represented the future shape of the Chinese American population, for better or worse. Some regarded these "hybrids" as living specimens who offered a chance to see firsthand the biological consequences of race mixing, a subject of intense scientific debate and social concern.

This essay examines discourses on Chinese Eurasians as a "problem" in late nineteenth-century American society. Using Louis Beck's account of George Appo as a starting point, I explore the ways in which racial theories regarding the consequences of racial amalgamation (which were overwhelming dominated by discussions of white–black miscegenation) informed perceptions of Eurasians as a potential threat to the nation's development. George Appo's case reveals that while the figure of the "half-caste" was frequently connected to dystopian visions of the future—the threat of the Yellow Peril or the specter of mongrelization—representations of Eurasians from this era were not always uniformly derisive, as has often been assumed. Rather, as we will see from a closer reading of Louis Beck's account of Appo, such representations often reveal an underlying ambivalence toward this "half-white/half-Chinese" figure. This ambivalence made the Eurasian a locus of anxiety and desire in an age of increasing global interpenetration and migration....

## The Eurasian as Problem

From the very beginning of Chinese immigration to the United States, nativists warned against miscegenation as an inevitable outcome of the Chinese presence in American society.... John Kuo Wei Tchen's study of the Chinese in pre-Exclusion era New York reveals that intermarriage between Chinese men and Irish women ... was prevalent in the early years of Chinese immigration. By 1900, Chinese immigrants in New York were marrying women of diverse backgrounds, but intermarriages still greatly outnumbered Chinese-Chinese marriages, 82 to 51. Indeed, owing in large part to the strictures on the migration of Chinese women to the United States during this era, interracial marriage would remain the predominant marriage pattern for Chinese in New York City until 1925.

The children of mixed couples increasingly drew the attention of journalists and reformers. In 1890, a *Harper's Weekly* feature on New York's "Chinese Colony" included a description of Chinese–Irish intermarriages, as evidenced by the sight of mixed-race children: "Around the gutters, playing on terms of equality with the other gamins, may be seen a few boys whose features betray their mingled blood." The writer pondered the fact that "it is only about 12 or 15 years since these marriages began, so that the children are all yet young. What kind of people the hybrids will prove to be is yet an unsolved problem." When Harry Wilson reported on the "Children of Chinatown" for the *New York Times* in 1896, he similarly represented mixed children as a "problem." Such children, he wrote, present "a view that is at once bewildering—a problem for which there is no solution.... They were the result of marriage between a Chinaman and an American woman." For those who perceived these "hybrids" as a problem, Beck's account must surely have been alarming. According to Beck, there were only thirty-two "full blooded Chinese children" in Chinatown, compared to forty-seven mixed children. This was the "new hybrid brood" that Beck warned the public would "hear more from ... as time rolls on."

Why was the Eurasian a problem for American society? A problem for which there was no solution? In Wong Chin Foo's eyes, the "half-breed children" were successful examples of Chinese assimilation into American society. As he wrote, "[They] speak the English language, adopt the American ways and dress." In sharp contrast, the two journalists cited displayed particular anxiety concerning racial mixing as an unknown. Although the *Harper's* writer confidently described the "Chinaman" and "Hibernians" as racial types, it remained for him an open question "what kind of people the hybrids will prove to be." What would be the effects, biological and cultural, of "mingled blood"? Building on long-standing American concerns over white–black and white–Native American interracialism that dated back to the colonial era (see introduction), such were the questions that the Eurasian "half-breed" frequently raised in the minds of curious observers.

Despite the long history of Euro-Asian interracialism in Asia, the New York press generally tended to look close at hand for answers, portraying Eurasian hybridity as a "new" phenomenon and an unknown, a rhetorical move that had the effect of sensationalizing this offshoot of the Chinese Question. The visual scrutiny of Eurasian faces and bodies was part of the anxious search for clues. The *Harper's Weekly* article of 1890, for example, was accompanied by a full-page illustration of a scene on Mott Street: the focal point is an Irishwoman standing next to her Chinese husband, holding a baby in her arms, two older mixed-race children playing beside them. Vividly visualizing the mixed character of Chinatown life, the illustration prompted readers to consider the yet "unsolved problem" of what such hybrids would become as they matured. Similarly, Wilson's *New York Times* article was illustrated with photographs of "Chinese Half-Castes." Wilson found one girl, a "Red-Headed Chinese-American Girl," to be a particular curiosity, and she was featured in several of the photographs. The "half-caste" as visual spectacle thus emerged as a feature of this time period.

With a naturalist's eye for hereditary patterns, Wilson ventured some curious rules as to the effects of this "Chinese-American" intermixing. "Half-caste" boys, he claimed, invariably looked Chinese, but the girls might "incline in resemblance toward their mothers." Mentally, he asserted, the children inherited "the qualities of both nations." Hence Wilson depicted these interracial households as "mixed up" and eclectic. In one family, the younger son wears American dress while the older son wears Chinese. Bilingualism is similarly presented as a strange curiosity of the "mixed" family. As a reporter for the *New York Daily Tribune* had written in 1869, "It is very curious to hear the little half-bred children running about the rooms and alternately talking Irish to their mothers and Chinese to their fathers." For some, the bilingualism/biculturalism displayed by the interracial family was more than a simple curiosity, for it represented a threat to the idealized homogeneity of American society.

Eurasians thus presented a problem in part because of their indeterminacy and liminal [in-between] status. At once Chinese and European, Sinophone and Anglophone, what place could they be assigned in the American hierarchy of race and ethnicity that was evolving at the turn of the twentieth century?

Straddling the boundary between white and non-white, Eurasians were troublesome for, like others of "mixed race," they disrupted the notion of a clearly delineated color line. The ambiguity of Eurasian identity during this era is suggested in the story of one child encountered by a reporter for the *World* in 1877: "'Joe is his name,' said the proud [Irish] mother. 'He don't look like a Chinaboy, does he, when he's asleep! His eyes show it, though, when he's awake.'"

One can only imagine the confusion faced by census enumerators confronted with a child like Joe: Should such a child be classed as "white"? Or "Chinese"? It is perhaps no wonder that the New York census displayed the inconsistencies that John Kuo Wei Tchen first identified regarding the classification of Eurasian children, who were sometime categorized as "Chinese," sometimes as "white," and sometimes as "mulatto." These inconsistencies would persist well into the twentieth century despite the Census Bureau's attempt to formulate rules regarding persons of "mixed-race". If Eurasians could manage to fool census enumerators into classifying them as "white," was there a danger that such racially indeterminate peoples would attempt "racial migration" ("crossing the color line")? Or, even worse, "play both sides"?...

## The "Human Hybrid": Amalgamation in Western Racial Theory

Even before the advent of "human hybridity" as a scientific concept in the mid-nineteenth century, racial intermixing was long associated with anomalies, abnormalities, and monstrosity. In 1799, for example, British surgeon Charles White reported numerous instances of "irregularities" in the offspring of white-black unions, including piebald children, twins of opposite racial phenotype, and children who were quite literally half-black and half-white—one white on the right side of his body and black on the left, another white from the navel upward and black on his lower body. While such associations with monstrosity or physical abnormalities did not disappear, the nineteenth century ushered in a new body of scientific racial theory on the question of amalgamation and related discourses on the historical effects of "race mixing" on civilizations. As demonstrated by George Stocking and Robert Young, the issue of so-called human hybridity was at the center of nineteenth-century debates over race, pitting monogenists against polygenists, abolitionists against slaveholders—positions that again can be seen as inclusionary versus exclusionary discourses. Young identifies five possible positions that emerged from these debates: (1) the polygenist denial that productive crossing could occur between human races; (2) the amalgamation thesis that racial intermixing produces a new mixed race; (3) the decomposition thesis that mixed-race progeny inevitably revert to parental type; (4) the variable hybridity thesis that unions between "proximate" races are fertile, whereas unions between "distant" races are infertile or degenerate; and (5) the mongrelization thesis that miscegenation produces "raceless chaos."

I add to this list a sixth thesis: that of hybrid vigor. As Nancy Stepan has demonstrated, although this position was a minority one, it nonetheless remained a constant in debates on racial amalgamation throughout the nineteenth century, playing a central role in Quatrefages's discussions of racial hybridity, for example,

and even surfacing in Darwin's *The Descent of Man* (1871) among other texts. Indeed, the notion of what Stepan calls "constructive miscegenation" assumes greater historical importance when we extend our attention beyond the Anglo-American sphere to French colonial debates concerning acclimatization; to Latin American eugenics as studied by Stepan; and to Chinese racial theorists, as the next chapter will show. Among Anglo-American theorists, the idea that racial amalgamation was dysgenic remained the dominant view between the 1850s and the 1930s, Nonetheless, it is important to take stock of hybrid vigor as an alternative thesis, as we will see following, for the continuing (if submerged) influence of this viewpoint—which was made plausible through commonplace experiences with plant and animal breeding—helps to explain the deep-seated ambivalence toward the miscegen as a symbol alternatively of mongrelization or of assimilation.

One of the most prominent early proponents of hybrid degeneracy was American polygenist Josiah Nott, who warned of the "Probable Extermination of the Two Races If the Whites and Blacks Are Allowed to Intermarry" in the *American Journal of the Medical Sciences* in 1843. Theorizing the "laws" of human hybridity, Nott declared that "the Mulatto or Hybrid is a degenerate, unnatural offspring, doomed by nature to work out its own destruction." Edinburgh anatomist, Robert Knox, a polygenist like Nott, elaborated the laws of human hybridity in his influential book *The Races of Men*, declaring that "the hybrid was a degradation of humanity and was rejected by nature." Asserting that hybridity was unviable, Knox argued that miscegens either were infertile or reverted to one of the parental types after a few generations. From New York, the polygenist physician John H. van Evrie asserted in 1864 that the "facts" proved "the crossing of distinct races produces a mongrel population, which ... has less powers of virility, greater tendency to disease, and hence is shorter lived ... that the condition is an abnormalism, and one of unspeakable wrong and suffering." If unchecked, van Evrie warned, miscegenation would lead to the inevitable downfall of American civilization.

Demonstrating its staying power, Stepan writes, the theory of hybrid degeneracy even survived the revolution of evolutionary biology. The opinion that "crossed races of men are singularly savage and degraded" found support in no less a man than Darwin himself, who speculated that the "degraded state of so many half-castes is in part due to reversion to a primitive and savage condition, induced by the act of crossing, even if mainly due to the unfavorable moral conditions under which they are generally reared." Although Darwin explained "half-caste" degradation in terms of *both* environmental *and* biological factors, it was the latter notion that found most traction during his time.

Nativists in California and elsewhere invoked pseudoscientific ideas of the horrors of biological degeneracy to justify segregating, and ultimately excluding, Chinese immigrants, as we saw from chapter 1. At the Constitutional Convention of the State of California in 1878 delegates warned that "the result of the amalgamation [of Chinese and white] would be a hybrid of the most despicable, a mongrel of the most detestable that has ever afflicted the earth." Decades later the authors of a pamphlet *For the Re-enactment of the Chinese Exclusion Law* (1901)

would similarly declare that "the offspring [of intermarriages] has been invariably degenerate. It is well-established that the issue of the Caucasian and the Mongolian do not possess the virtues of either, but develop the vices of both. So physical assimilation is out of the question." Hybrid degeneracy was thus taken as final proof of the unassimilability (biological and cultural) of the Chinese. Even scientific authorities like Herbert Spencer expressed approval for Chinese exclusion in light of the question of amalgamation. Spencer saw only two possible outcomes of Chinese immigration to the United States: either the Chinese would "remain unmixed" and thereby constitute a separate and slave-like class, "or if they mix they must form a bad hybrid." Either scenario would be damaging for American national development....

## The Worst of Both Worlds: The Dual Nature of the Hybrid

By far the most popular expression of a belief in hybrid degeneracy was the pithy saying, "The half-caste inherits the vices of both parents, and the virtues of neither." Although its origins are obscure, this cliché had become well worn by the time *New York's Chinatown* was published—and even given the stamp of scientific authority by men like van Evrie. Beck certainly resorts to this chestnut in his portrait of George Appo, identifying specific traits and vices that the "half-breed" inherited from his Chinese father and Irish mother, respectively. From his father, Beck asserted, George inherited "mental cunning and duplicity" and a "cynicism which is particular to the Eastern character"; from his mother, a general "flyness," which also served him well as a professional thief. Combining the worst of (stereotypical) Chinese and Irish vices, Appo was set from birth to become a larger-than-life criminal.

One particular threat embodied by "half-castes" like George Appo was their putative ability to play both sides. Beck asserts that the "young halfbreed" carved out a role for himself as a go-between or interpreter between "Americans" and Irish, on one hand, and Chinese on the other. He worked for a time as a Chinatown guide, catering to sightseers eager to taste the exotic vices of the Quarter, but under the safety of an escort. Beck claimed that Appo's racial inheritance enabled him to function as the perfect inside guide to this mysterious and inscrutable world: "Appo had always, by virtue of his blood on his father's side, enjoyed to a certain extent the confidence of the Chinese—a confidence which the strange, secretive people seldom give to any one not of their own race." If Appo served as a cultural interpreter, in Beck's eyes he was also an agent of transmission of Chinese vices to the non-Chinese community. Indeed, Beck blamed Appo, with his specialized "Chinese" knowledge of the art of cooking opium and his familiarity with the Chinatown "joints," for introducing a taste for the drug to the "New York roughs and crooks" who soon came to frequent Chinatown's opium dens, bringing other white patrons in their wake. Hence the "half-caste" represents not only a corruption of white racial purity, but also a corrupting moral influence. Racial pollution, moral contamination, vice unbalanced by virtue—such were the associations of "half-caste" status. In fact,

Timothy Gilfoyle's detailed study of George Appo's criminal career demonstrates that he did have connections, and even financial backing, from criminal establishments both within Chinatown and beyond. According to Gilfoyle, however, it was the latter that played the major role in Appo's life.

The idea of the Eurasian's dual nature had earlier served as the premise for T.S. Denison's comedic drama, *Patsy O'Wang: An Irish Farce with a Chinese Mix-up* (1895). The play centers on the character of Patsy O'Wang, a.k.a. Chin Sum, a Eurasian of Chinese-Irish descent. As the playwright directed, "The key to this capital farce is the remarkable transformation of which Chin Sum is capable. Born of Irish father and Chinese mother and brought up in barracks in Hong Kong he has a remarkable dual nature." The transformation is effected when Chin Sum imbibes whiskey, "the drink of his father," and undergoes a metamorphosis into a "true Irishman." Strong tea, "the drink of his mother," restores Patsy's "Chinese character," which is that of a sober and industrious Chinese cook. The ideas of hybrid reversion and latent racial traits (blood will tell) are thus enacted in this farce through the bifurcated character of Patsy/Chin Sum, who reverts to parental type based on the drink he consumes.

Hybridity may be farcical, but it is also a cause of chaos, confusion, and disorder—a case for the police and a psychiatrist. In the final act, Patsy/Chin Sum's frustrated employer crossly asks him, "What are you now? Irish or Chinese?" When Patsy declares his choice to be Irish, he is immediately dismissed, roundly castigated for his "ambition" by the doctor's Irish assistant. The ultimate message of this ludicrous comedy is that the races should stay in their place....

## Degenerate but Beautiful? Hybrid Vigor and Strains of Ambivalence

Given that his work is a case study in "heredity and racial traits and tendencies," Beck may have intended the lesson of George Appo as a warning. Yet, even as he portrayed Appo as the embodiment of hybrid degeneracy, degradation, and monstrosity, Beck also expressed a grudging respect for the man—a man who was, in fact, as Gilfoyle demonstrates, an inside informant who assisted the journalist in the compilation of *New York's Chinatown*. In particular, Beck lauds Appo's intelligence and cleverness, even if these traits were not put to good uses. As evident in the opening of Beck's biographical sketch, one of the first things he tells us is that George "was an exceedingly bright child, beautiful to look upon, sharp-witted and quick of comprehension." While Beck goes on to narrate Appo's fall from grace, he nonetheless repeatedly insists on the man's physical beauty. Seemingly unable to let go of this point, Beck returns to Appo's unusual attractiveness again paragraphs later: "The reference to his beauty is no exaggeration. Throughout his long and varied career of crime he retained the handsome features and charming manners which characterized him as a boy, and were it not for the scars of knife and bullet wounds that are visible on his face he would now be a handsome man of striking appearance."

This assertion of Appo's particular beauty, as one whose face showed the "characteristics of both his parents," confirmed yet another stereotype of the racial hybrid, one that paradoxically coexisted with that of racial degeneracy. As Robert Young points out, at the same time "as being instanced as degenerate, and literally, degraded (that is, lowered by racial mixture from pure whiteness, the highest grade), those of mixed race were often invoked as the most beautiful human beings of all." French racial theorist Quatrefages, for example, praised the beauty of "women of colour, mulattoes and quadroons," who exercised a peculiar charm on European travelers. For Quatrefages, this beauty was compelling evidence that mixed races were not inferior to the "pure" in all respects and actually exhibited a degree of hybrid vigor.

While Beck's offhand references to Appo's beauty strike a chord of dissonance with his dominant theme of hybrid degeneracy, this very dissonance calls our attention to a motif that figures in Beck's text as an instance of what we might regard as the "return of the repressed." What is repressed in Beck's sketch is the attraction exerted by the figure of the hybrid—an allure epitomized by the lovely Afong girls, daughters of the "Chinese Merchant Prince of Honolulu."

In the second half of the nineteenth century, boosters were promoting Hawaii's image as a paradise of harmonious intermixing, which some extended even to the notion of constructive miscegenation. This idea would become so compelling that by the first decades of the twentieth century American sociologists were treating the islands as a virtual "living laboratory" of racial fusion (see chapter 5). Already in the 1880s, the American press were lauding the Afong girls, widely said to be "beautiful and intelligent," as testaments to the success of constructive miscegenation as a vehicle for assimilation—cultural and biological. As the *New York Times* described the girls in 1885: "The mother and the daughters maintain a rigid adherence to the rules of fashion, and appear in the dress of white ladies and girls. When occasion demands, the lady and her older daughters are clad in as elegant raiment as the wealthiest lady on the islands ... as the family is received cordially into the best society in Honolulu.... A close observer of the merry quintet on their afternoon drive could not tell that they were not the offspring of some wealthy Caucasian."

Wealthy, beautiful, cultured, and by this account virtually "Caucasian" to the eye (echoing early depictions of George Appo as a veritable Yankee boy), the Afong girls were frequently depicted by mainland media as "very much sought after," several distinguished for having married "prominent men." When Henrietta, the "belle of the islands," was wed to Naval Commander William Henry Whiting in 1893, the marriage shook Honolulu naval society but was acclaimed by Sanford Dole, head of Hawaii's provisional government, as a symbol for the potential union of Hawaii and the United States. Indeed, the beauty and eligibility of the Afong girls loomed so large in American press coverage of the family that when the "merchant prince" died in 1906, the *New York Times* gave his obituary the following title: "AFONG DIES IN CHINA; FATHER OF 13 [*sic*] BEAUTIES—Chinese Merchant Made Millions in Honolulu. DAUGHTERS MARRIED WELL."

The juxtaposition of the Afongs in Hawaii and the Appos in New York demonstrates the complex intersections of class, gender, and place in representations of Eurasian mixed race. If we consider place, in particular, the difference between Honolulu and the world of Manhattan's lower wards is striking. By comparison to New York's Five Points in particular, where anxieties surrounding social and sexual intercourse across racial, religious, and linguistic lines ran high during Appo's age, the discourse of constructive miscegenation came much more readily to the fore in Hawaii, where intermarriage was connected to U.S. imperial aspirations.

Hawaii was clearly a different context from New York, and yet we find that the discourse of constructive miscegenation is not entirely absent from representations of Chinese–white intermixing in the great metropolis, especially in the era before Chinese exclusion. Indeed, as we have seen, Beck was not alone in his portrayal of Appo's physical attractiveness, a trait commonly taken by racial theorists as evidence of hybrid vigor. As mentioned previously, the *New York Times* reporter who chronicled George's birth described him as a handsome boy, as white as his mother. Journalists also described other New York–born Eurasians in a similar fashion. An article in the *New York Daily Tribune*, for example, asserted, "As a rule the children [of Chinese fathers and Irish mothers] are decidedly well looking, which is more than one can say for their fathers." When a reporter for the *World* investigated that city's "Celestial colony" in 1877, he expressed surprise at finding a number of young Irish women married to Chinese. Unnerved by the phenomenon, the reporter nonetheless gave a favorable physical description of one of the babies: "It was sleeping in a tidy crib, and was certainly a beautiful child, being fair and chubby and healthy in appearance." Noticeably, all these descriptions associate the Eurasians' beauty with their partial whiteness: their fair skin, their fashionable "white" dress, their maternal inheritance. It is an "infusion of whiteness" that produces the good looks of Eurasian children, an infusion that overcomes the homeliness of Chinese fathers and their racial Otherness, transforming their offspring toward Sameness. In contrast to Quatrefages, who clearly valued the exotic and dusky beauty of the mulatto, these press accounts indicate that the notion of exceptional mixed-race beauty also contains within itself a privileging of whiteness. The mysterious charm exerted by mixed-race figures thus stems from their not-white/like-white physiognomy.

Here is where ambivalence rises to the surface in Beck's account: where the journalist cannot let go of Appo's beauty, despite his monstrous wickedness. Beck may regard Appo "better off dead," but he remains enthralled by his "striking appearance," unable to write him off entirely. In the end, George Washington Appo was a paradigmatic example of the contradiction Robert Young identifies in nineteenth-century Western racial theory: that is, the degenerate racial hybrid who is simultaneously invoked as a creature of great beauty. It is this doubleness that rendered the hybrid a figure of fascination and horror, of desire and anxiety.

Without a doubt, hybrid degeneracy is the dominant theme in Beck's biographical sketch of Appo, as it was among Anglo-American scientific discourses

of the time. Yet I have emphasized the notion of underlying ambivalence even within this demonizing portrait in order to draw attention to alternate discourses of hybrid vigor that also circulated during this era. The notion of "constructive miscegenation" may have been a minority position, but hybrid vigor was taken seriously as an issue of scientific *debate* by men of no less stature than Gobineau, Quatrefages, and Darwin and continued to inform lay representations like Beck's even if only as an undercurrent of ambivalence. Hence, this counter-discourse should not be dismissed too readily from our readings of the period, as, I argue, is the case in Jayne O. Ifekwunigwe's characterization of the nineteenth century as the Age of Pathology in mixed-race studies. Harriet Ritvo has compellingly cautioned against monodimensional understandings of the past, which highlight dominant opinions of the age while obscuring alternative opinions and intense disagreement among experts, and in doing so force us to lose sight of the true variety of thought from the time. Such would be the danger for the intellectual genealogy of "mixed race" if we were to see in Beck's sketch of Appo nothing more than a case study of hybrid degeneracy without its complicating ambivalence.

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CHAPTER 4



# Pacific Empires and New Migrations, 1894–1919

*The United States was a late-developing imperial power. In 1898, it annexed Hawai'i, and later that year claimed the Philippines, Puerto Rico, and Guam from a decaying Spanish Empire. These moves fit widely held beliefs that the Pacific Ocean would become the center of global economic activity in the twentieth century and that nations needed to protect Pacific shipping lanes. Consequently, the United States developed military bases in the Caribbean to oversee traffic flowing through the Panama Canal, which opened in 1914. By this time, the British Empire stretched across much of the Asia-Pacific region, including the prized colony of India, while the French and Dutch were also major players in this imperial Pacific World. Meanwhile, Germany developed into an imperial power as it shared the islands of Samoa with the United States, took over other Pacific Islands, and competed for control in northeastern China.*

*Japan was another late-developing imperial power. Japan staked its claims in the Pacific by taking Taiwan in 1895 and later claiming Korea and strategic areas of the Chinese mainland. Fresh off the victory over China in 1895, Japan was the first Asian nation to overcome the unequal treaties that Western powers imposed throughout Asia. Significantly, the United States and Britain gave Japan most favored nation status as a sign of mutual respect; this was the status that the United States had taken away from China in order to exclude its immigrants. In their stead, Japanese immigrants became the principle labor force in Hawai'i and were also counted on by growers and businesses on the West Coast.*

*Although Americans were new to colonialism, they were old hands at territorial expansion and managing subordinated populations within North America. In light of the Indian Wars of the late nineteenth century, U.S. imperialists, like President Theodore Roosevelt, portrayed Filipinos as another group of Indians to be subdued and, if possible, Americanized. The imperialists, however, faced powerful opponents within the U.S. who branded as un-American the conquest of territory that would be held in perpetuity as colonies and not incorporated into the United States. Catalyzing the opposition was the Anti-Imperialist League, which reported having over half a million members including*

*the famous writer Mark Twain, editor E.L. Godkin, labor leader Samuel Gompers, and African American scholar and activist W.E.B. Du Bois. It was through the league that Americans learned about atrocities committed by U.S. soldiers in military campaigns to suppress armed insurrections by Filipinos struggling against U.S. colonization.*

*The Anti-Imperialist League signaled that some Americans were coming to accept the principle of national self-determination that President Wilson in 1919 would formalize as a general philosophy in the peace settlement ending World War I. This anti-imperialist sentiment was also evident among Indian and Korean immigrants in the United States. They saw the United States as a safe place from which to draw the world's attention to the repressive colonization of their homelands. In India, the anticolonial movement featured Mohandas Gandhi, who, after leading successful opposition to white rule in the British colony of South Africa, sought Indian independence through nonviolent means. Meanwhile, in Korea, millions of people proclaimed their nation's independence in March 1919, only to face violent repression by Japanese colonial authorities.*

## DOCUMENTS

Japan's leading proponent of Westernization, Yukichi Fukuzawa, encouraged his countrymen to migrate across the Pacific so as to prove to Americans that the Japanese were a first-rate people. Document 1 is an article from Fukuzawa's newspaper *Jiji Shimpo* that gives reasons for Japanese immigrants to be proud of their country and not to feel inferior to Westerners. Document 2, a comic strip drawn by a Japanese immigrant, shows the nationalist fervor among a group of ambitious students who came to San Francisco to work their way through school. Their optimism stands in stark contrast to the glimpse they get of the repressive experience of Chinese immigrants through poems written on the walls of the Angel Island immigration station in the San Francisco Bay.

The next three documents address U.S. colonization of the Philippines. In Document 3, Senator Albert Beveridge argues that taking the islands was both an economic necessity for U.S. trade with Asia and a moral imperative because the "barbarous" Filipinos were incapable of self-government. Document 4 is a song sung by U.S. soldiers detailing the torture of Filipino insurgents. Anti-imperialists exposed such brutality to turn the U.S. public not only against the war in the Philippines but also against the entire project of U.S. colonization there. In the face of anti-imperialist activism, U.S. officials in the Philippines cast their mission as uplifting, not subjugating, Filipinos. Document 5 reveals how a U.S. colonial official condemned racial prejudice exhibited by the U.S. military and civilians in the Philippines.

Documents 6 and 7 are taken from a book written by Indian exile Tarnaknath Das, who opposed the colonization of his homeland. The book's foreword, Document 6, is a broad plea by Das for Asians to resist the Western colonization of their countries, while the book's introduction, Document 7, was written by a Chinese leader who builds on Das's pan-Asianism in calling for Asian peoples to unite in overthrowing Western rule. Such calls for Asian

unity, while pipe dreams that went unfulfilled, revealed frustrations with colonialism that were common across Asia.

The final two documents focus on Korea and Korean immigrants. Document 8 is a transcript from the Korean Congress in 1919, which brought delegates from around the world to Philadelphia's Independence Hall to draw attention to the plight of colonial Koreans. The main speaker is Dr. Syngman Rhee, one of the best-known leaders within the Korean immigrant community and the first Korean to receive a PhD from Princeton University. Document 9 provides an intimate look at the Korean independence movement following the experience of a Korean immigrant from Hawai'i who returns to her homeland to participate in the uprisings of March 1, 1919.

## 1. Japanese Newspaper *Jiji Shimpo* Views Emigration as Sign of Japan's Military Power, 1896

The recent victory in war not only demonstrated to the world the military power of Japan but it has convinced the Japanese people that in vitality and spirit, they are outstanding by far among Eastern nations and are among the outstanding races of the world. If the politicians and leaders, as such, give guidance to this deeply held belief of the people and draw up a major plan, they will probably realize that, right before their eyes, there are new homes for the Japanese race, everywhere in the Orient and in the South Seas. The dreams of people in olden times of expanding overseas need no longer end as dreams, but can now be certainly realized. This is indeed the one chance in a thousand years. We can hardly bear the happiness in our heart.

Though it is an incontrovertible fact that the Japanese race is not inferior to the peoples of the West in ability and vitality, the Japanese are unable to free themselves of narrow-minded propensities simply because by accident of nature their country is positioned in a distant corner of the Far East and thus was delayed in riding the currents of modern civilization. They view the civilized nations of the West as the penniless do the extremely rich; outwardly they talk big, saying they are people and we are people, but if their innermost thoughts are probed, they fear Western capability, power and knowledge and are resigned to the thought that they possibly cannot ever win in competition with them....

To urge a weakling who has no confidence in his own strength to cross the boundless seas to set up a new home is like urging a cripple to run. Thus, in spite of the earnest debate to date over emigration, it is no coincidence that it has not succeeded. However, the single fact that Japan has defeated the ancient and great country of China has opened the minds of the conservative, diffident Japanese people and has convinced them that in capability and in vigor, they are not inferior to any race in the world....

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Jiji Shimpo, Feb. 3, 1986; reprinted in Yasuo Wakatsuki, "Japanese Emigration to the United States, 1866–1924: A Monograph," *Perspectives in American History* 12 (1979): 443.

## 2. Japanese Immigrant Comic Reveals Reasons for Emigration, 1904 (1929)




From Henry (Yoshitaka) Kiyama, *The Four Immigrants Manga: A Japanese Experience in San Francisco, 1904–1924*, trans. Frederik L. Schodt (Berkeley, CA: Stonebridge Press, 1998), 30–31.




## 3. Senator Albert Beveridge Champions Philippine Colonization, 1900

Mr. President, the times call for candor. The Philippines are ours forever, "territory belonging to the United States," as the Constitution calls them. And just

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From Congressional Record, Senate, January 9, 1900, 704–711; reprinted in *The Philippines Reader: A History of Colonialism, Neocolonialism, Dictatorship, and Resistance*, ed. Daniel B. Schirmer and Stephen Rosskamm Shalom (Boston: South End Press, 1987), 23–26.

beyond the Philippines are China's illimitable markets. We will not retreat from either. We will not repudiate our duty in the archipelago. We will not abandon our opportunity in the Orient. We will not renounce our part in the mission of our race, trustee, under God, of the civilization of the world. And we will move forward to our work, not howling out regrets like slaves whipped to their burdens, but with gratitude for a task worthy of our strength and thanksgiving to Almighty God that He has marked us as His chosen people, henceforth to lead in the regeneration of the world.

### Philippines Command the Pacific

This island empire is the last land left in all the oceans. If it should prove a mistake to abandon it, the blunder once made would be irretrievable. If it proves a mistake to hold it, the error can be corrected when we will. Every other progressive nation stands ready to relieve us.

But to hold it will be no mistake. Our largest trade henceforth must be with Asia. The Pacific is our ocean. More and more Europe will manufacture the most it needs, secure from its colonies the most it consumes. Where shall we turn for consumers of our surplus? Geography answers the question. China is our natural customer. She is nearer to us than to England, Germany, or Russia, the commercial powers of the present and the future. They have moved nearer to China by securing permanent bases on her borders. The Philippines give us a base at the door of all the East.

Lines of navigation from our ports to the Orient and Australia; from the Isthmian Canal to Asia; from all Oriental ports to Australia, converge at and separate from the Philippines. They are a self-supporting, dividend-paying fleet, permanently anchored at a spot selected by the strategy of Providence, commanding the Pacific. And the Pacific is the ocean of the commerce of the future. Most future wars will be conflicts for commerce. The power that rules the Pacific, therefore, is the power that rules the world. And, with the Philippines, that power is and will forever be the American Republic.

### Value of China's Trade

China's trade is the mightiest commercial fact in our future. Her foreign commerce was $285,738.300 in 1897, of which we, her neighbor, had less than 9 per cent, of which only a little more than half was merchandise sold to China by us. We ought to have 50 per cent, and we will. And China's foreign commerce is only beginning. Her resources, her possibilities, her wants, all are undeveloped. She has only 340 miles of railway. I have seen trains loaded with natives and all the activities of modern life already appearing along the line. But she needs, and in fifty years will have, 20,000 miles of railway.

Who can estimate her commerce, then? That statesman commits a crime against American trade—against the American grower of cotton and wheat and tobacco, the American manufacturer of machinery and clothing—who fails to put America where she may command that trade.... The Philippines command the commercial situation of the entire East....

## Resources and Immense Size of the Islands

But if they did not command China, India, the Orient, the whole Pacific for purposes of offense, defense, and trade, the Philippines are so valuable in themselves that we should hold them. I have cruised more than 2,000 miles through the archipelago, every moment a surprise at its loveliness and wealth. I have ridden hundreds of miles on the islands, every foot of the way a revelation of vegetable and mineral riches.

No land in America surpasses in fertility the plains and valleys of Luzon. Rice and coffee, sugar and cocoanuts, hemp and tobacco, and many products of the temperate as well as the tropic zone grow in various sections of the archipelago. I have seen hundreds of bushels of Indian corn lying in a road fringed with banana trees. The forests of Negros, Mindanao, Mindora, Paluan, and parts of Luzon are invaluable and intact. The wood of the Philippines can supply the furniture of the world for a century to come. At Cebu the best informed man in the island told me that 40 miles of Cebu's mountain chain are practically mountains of coal. Pablo Majia, one of the most reliable men on the islands, confirmed the statement. Some declare that the coal is only lignite; but ship captains who have used it told me that it is better steamer fuel than the best coal of Japan.

I have a nugget of pure gold picked up in its present form on the banks of a Philippine creek. I have gold dust washed out by crude processes of careless natives from the sands of a Philippine stream. Both indicate great deposits at the source from which they come....

Nothing is so natural as trade with one's neighbors. The Philippines make us the nearest neighbors of all the East. Nothing is more natural than to trade with those you know. This is the philosophy of all advertising. The Philippines bring us permanently face to face with the most sought-for customers of the world. National prestige, national propinquity, these and commercial activity are the elements of commercial success....

## Character of the People

It will be hard for Americans who have not studied them to understand the people. They are a barbarous race, modified by three centuries of contact with a decadent [Spanish] race. The Filipino is the South Sea Malay, put through a process of three hundred years of [Spanish] superstition in religion, dishonesty in dealing, disorder in habits of industry, and cruelty, caprice, and corruption in government. It is barely possible that 1,000 men in all the archipelago are capable of self-government in the Anglo-Saxon sense.

My own belief is that there are not 100 men among them who comprehend what Anglo-Saxon self-government even means, and there are over 5,000,000 people to be governed....

But, Senators, it would be better to abandon this combined garden and Gibraltar of the Pacific, and count our blood and treasure already spent a profitable loss, than to apply any academic arrangement of self-government to these

children. They are not capable of self-government. How could they be? They are not of a self-governing race. They are Orientals, Malays, instructed by Spaniards in the latter's worst estate.

They know nothing of practical government except as they have witnessed the weak, corrupt, cruel, and capricious rule of Spain. What magic will anyone employ to dissolve in their minds and characters those impressions of governors and governed which three centuries of misrule has created? What alchemy will change the oriental quality of their blood and set the self-governing currents of the American pouring through their Malay veins? How shall they, in the twinkling of an eye, be exalted to the heights of self-governing peoples which required a thousand years for us to reach, Anglo-Saxon though we are?...

### People Indolent—No Competition with Our Labor

No one need fear their competition with our labor. No reward could beguile, no force compel, these children of indolence to leave their trifling lives for the fierce and fervid industry of high-wrought America. The very reverse is the fact. One great problem is the necessary labor to develop these islands—to build the roads, open the mines, clear the wilderness, drain the swamps, dredge the harbors. The natives will not supply it. A lingering prejudice against the Chinese may prevent us from letting them supply it. Ultimately, when the real truth of the climate and human conditions is known, it is barely possible that our labor will go there. Even now young men with the right moral fiber and a little capital can make fortunes there as planters.

But the natives will not come here [as immigrants]. Let all men dismiss that fear....

### The Whole Question Elemental

Mr. President, this question is deeper than any question of party politics; deeper than any question of the isolated policy of our country even; deeper even than any question of constitutional power. It is elemental. It is racial. God has not been preparing the English-speaking and Teutonic peoples for a thousand years for nothing but vain and idle self-contemplation and self-admiration. No! He has made us the master organizers of the world to establish system where chaos reigns. He has given us the spirit of progress to overwhelm the forces of reaction throughout the earth. He has made us adepts in government that we may administer government among savage and senile peoples. Were it not for such a force as this the world would relapse into barbarism and night. And of all our race He has marked the American people as His chosen nation to finally lead in the regeneration of the world. This is the divine mission of America, and it holds for us all the profit, all the glory, all the happiness possible to man. We are trustees of the world's progress, gnardians of its righteous peace. The judgment of the Master is upon us: "Ye have been faithful over a few things; I will make you ruler over many things."

What shall history say of us? Shall it say that we renounced that holy trust, left the savage to his base condition, the wilderness to the reign of waste, deserted

duty, abandoned glory, forget our sordid profit even, because we feared our strength and read the charter of our powers with the doubter's eye and the quibbler's mind? Shall it say that, called by events to captain and command the proudest, ablest, purest race of history in history's noblest work, we declined that great commission? Our fathers would not have had it so. No! They founded no paralytic government, incapable of the simplest acts of administration. They planted no sluggard people, passive while the world's work calls them. They established no reactionary nation. They unfurled no retreating flag.

## 4. American GIs Sing About Using Water Cure Torture, 1902

Get the good old syringe boys and fill it to the brim
We've caught another nigger and we'll operate on him
Let someone take the handle who can work it with a vim
Shouting the battle cry of freedom

[Chorus]
Hurrah Hurrah We bring the Jubilee
Hurrah Hurrah The flag that makes him free
Shove in the nozzel [*sic*] deep and let him taste of liberty
Shouting the battle cry of freedom.

## 5. U.S. Civilian Officer Condemns Racial Prejudice in Philippines, 1902

Many people find in our occupation of the Philippine Islands the threat of a radical change in American character and ideals. Even if we look only on the evil side of things, it is hard to see how American character and social ideas can thus be radically altered. That it is a step of transcendent importance, involving new and various political difficulties, is true. But it draws us into a field in which ultimately our prejudices may broaden out, and in which our provincialisms must disappear.

Meanwhile, however, it must be admitted, the prospect of such beneficent results seems spoiled by two untoward phases of our new venture: we have carried into the Philippines a petty race prejudice, the offspring of past provincialism and the inheritance of slavery with its residue of unsettled problems; and we are betraying a tendency to swagger under the "white man's burden," sometimes in the garb of commercialism, sometimes in the raiment of science.

As might be expected, the petty prejudices are first to exhibit themselves, and are also, just at present, the more serious obstacles to a general good understanding in the Philippines. Relying upon the common sense of the reader not

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From Paul Kramer, *The Blood of Government: Race, Empire, the United States, and the Philippines* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2006), 141.

From James LeRoy, "Race Prejudice in the Philippines," *Atlantic Monthly* 90, 537 (July 1902).

to draw any hysterical conclusions of general "oppression" in the Philippines, it may be worth while to cite instances and facts to show how race prejudice has been doing us harm in the islands. Only instances for which I can personally vouch will be employed....

Before the arrival of the second Philippine Commission at Manila and the inauguration by Judge Taft and its other members of social gatherings in which the natives were in the majority, practically nothing had been done in the way of providing an informal meeting ground for representative Filipinos and Americans. The first Philippine Commission had given a ball in 1899, which was a landmark for Filipino matrons and belles in their discussions and misapprehensions as to what Americans were like socially. With two or three very notable exceptions, officers whose wives had joined them did not think of meeting any residents but some of the wealthy Spanish "left-overs" on anything like terms of social equality....

Force of circumstances has from the first, through the necessarily closer contact and the lack of other society, brought about more social mingling in the provincial towns. In general, however, the attitude of the army women in the islands is typified by that one in Manila who, in discussing affairs in her first call on the wife of a member of the Commission, exclaimed in horror: "Why, surely you don't propose to visit these people and invite them to your own home just the same as you would white people!" Time has perhaps brought a little more catholicity, at any rate the custom of entertaining natives has come to be received without a shock; but few army women in Manila have Filipinas on their calling list, and in the provinces they often take it on themselves to caution American women sent out as teachers against mingling with the people of their towns. This attitude is also that of the great majority of officers in the army, though the men, like men everywhere, are less formal about a social rule and less rigid in their likes and dislikes of persons.

An instance of this attitude was the attempt to exclude from the Woman's Hospital at Manila (founded by a donation of Mrs. Whitelaw Reid) all Filipinos as patients, as well as to keep off the list of patronesses the names of Filipino women. At about the same time the board of ladies to whose energy the American Library of Manila was due asked to have it made a public library, to be helped out by funds from the Philippine treasury, and made very strenuous protests against having it also thrown open to Filipinos for a share in its management and use. They contended that it had been established as a monument to American soldiers who lost their lives in the Philippines, and that it was unfitting that Filipinos should have anything to do with it, though Philippine taxes might support it....

This and the other instances do not, of course, reveal a prejudice grounded entirely on color, yet this is the chief factor. It may be worth while remarking that, judging by one man's personal observation, this attitude of contempt is less noticeable among officers from the South than among those from the North. Doubtless this is due to their having had closer contact with people of another color, and to a greater tolerance through the staling of custom, although the conviction of the other's inferiority may yet be deeper bred.

On the other hand, an experience to be remembered was hearing some Southern as well as Northern officers rate the Filipino higher than the American negro, greatly to the indignation of a colored chaplain of the army who overheard

them. And these officers were rather more tolerant of the presence among the first-class passengers of an army transport of a Filipino mestizo from the Visayan islands than of the same chaplain, who was finally given a seat by himself because some very important young lieutenants would not sit next him....

The writer was one of a group of American civilians halted in the street of a Philippine town by an ugly sentinel and ordered, in gruff terms at the bayonet's point, to salute a minute American flag on the top of a fifty-foot pole. Not one, of course, had seen it. The pole had purposely been set some hundreds of feet from the barracks, almost in the street itself, and the order was enforced against every one who passed. A protest to the officer in command, a gray-haired captain, brought the reply that he was "teaching the niggers a lesson." This province was a leader in the revolt against Spain, first because of the friars, and second because of the abuses suffered at the hands of the Spanish civil guard. One need not add that the hatred felt toward our troops is intense....

Recent revelations have focused attention on the conduct of the army in the Philippines, and some have tried to make out that downright brutality was the rule of campaign there. Cases of actual inhumanity have been, I am convinced, the exceptional ones. It must be admitted, however, by any one who really knows things as they now are in the islands, that at least three fourths of the army, rank and file, entertain a more or less violent dislike for the Filipinos and a contempt for their capacity, moral and intellectual. This feeling in the army has grown during the past two years. Perhaps it may be dated back to the early days of 1900, when guerrilla warfare had begun, and our troops had to contend with ambushes and a foe who was an excellent masquerader, and who practiced the art of assassination on his own fellow countrymen in forms of the most refined cruelty....

Attacks on the character of the native are usually made the basis of the white man's plea in the Philippines. For this purpose the natives are all treated as identical in kind and character, grouped into one, as it were. Upon such a hypothesis one can argue that, because one native known to him was deficient morally and seemed incapable mentally, therefore the Filipinos are a dishonest and inefficient race. But thus baldly stated, the proposition seems too ridiculous to emanate from any educated person; yet it is remarkable how commonly it is set forth by persons who consider themselves very well educated. We all know how indignant we become when a European writer of short experience among us proceeds to cut one suit of clothes to fit us all; yet the Filipinos are hardly a more homogeneous people than we, and there are just as strongly marked individual types in the East as in the West....

That instances of real brutality on the part of our troops have been the exception has been stated to be the opinion of the writer. On the confession of the officer who conducted it, the campaign in the island of Sámar from October to March last must be excepted from this general statement. He has met the charge of violating the rules of civilized warfare with the counter-charge that the people of Sámar are savages, and that it was necessary to suspend many of these rules in order to restore peace and quiet to that part of the archipelago. By inference, it then became a war of extermination till one side or the other should cry quits. It is hard to deal with this matter as yet in a strictly impartial

spirit, and full knowledge is one of the first requisites. One thing can at least be asserted, namely, that the classification of all the people of Sámar in one lump as savages will bear close scrutiny....

This digression as to matters of recent controversy will have been worth while if it shall serve to induce to a saner consideration of army conduct in the islands, and if it shall also emphasize the fact that the generally contemptuous attitude of army men and other Americans toward the natives—that feeling which gives itself vent in the term "niggers"—is what does us greatest harm. The Filipinos have grown, by hard experience, somewhat callous to measures that seem to us extreme, if not actually brutal. We do not make enemies for ourselves half so much by the occasional administration of the water cure or other forms of torture and barbarity as by a studied attitude of contempt, an assumption of racial and individual superiority, and the constant disregard of their petty personal rights and of the little amenities which count for so much with them....

It is wearisome to note how uniformly writers on the peoples of the Orient assume that they are inherently different from us in every respect,—that the ordinary Western ways of reasoning have no place in the East, must in fact be reversed. The familiar saying that the Chinese do everything backward is in point. Now, John seems to me one of the most unsparingly logical human beings in the world. [The British poet Rudyard] Kipling's jingles are responsible for much of that feeling that the Oriental is a wholly mysterious being, not given to be understood by other men, a curious psychological phenomenon. "Half-devil and half-child" comes trippingly to the tongue of many Americans in the Philippines, and their philosophy of the Filipino is thus summed up for them before their study of him has ever begun. What is less creditable, the same stock theory and a few facts, more or less, constitute the equipment of various university economists and world problem specialists.

## 6. Indian Nationalist Articulates an Anti-Imperial Vision for Asian Youth, 1917

### To The Asian Youth

The idea of slavery as advocated by Aristotle and others is a dead-letter to-day. The idea of dominance of a European nation, however insignificant it may be, by any other Power to-day faces the strongest active opposition of the civilized world. We expect that a day will also come when the idea of dominance of Asia by Europe or America will be abandoned by the present aggressors. This can be brought about only through effective and vigorous assertion of Asia in all fields of human activity, especially Politics. Every Asian youth—male or female—who possesses even a tiny bit of the feeling of self-respect should strive to achieve the goal of Assertion of Asia to the fullest sense of its meaning. Our method of assertion should not be mere imitation of the West. Our ambition is to draw our inspiration from the glorious past of Asia and rising above its present degraded

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From Taraknath Das, *Is Japan a Menace to Asia?* (Shanghai: Taraknath Das, 1917).

condition, preserving the best of our ancestral treasures from the attacks of vandals and assimilating the best of all that the modern world has to give to Humanity, to build up something higher than the best products of Modern civilization. It is your privilege to work for this noble cause.

## 7. Chinese Leader Urges Asian Unity, 1917

The future of Asia depends upon the ability of the Asiatic people to assert their rights politically. Political weakness of Asia has been the cause of many troubles and wars during the last century and a half. Asia as a whole, except Japan affords for the strong Powers unbounded natural resources, cheap labor, markets, defencelessness, and inefficient governments which give every incentive for aggression. About the modern imperialism among the Great Powers, Mr. Walter Lippman in his book "The Stakes of Diplomacy" rightly says: "It is not enough to say that they are 'expanding' or 'seeking markets' or 'grabbing resources.' They are doing all these things, of course. But if the world into which they are expanding were not politically archaic, the growth of foreign trade would not be accompanied by political imperialism. Germany has expanded wonderfully in the British Empire, in Russia, in the United States, but no German is silly enough to insist on planting his flag wherever he sells his dyestuffs or stoves. It is only when his expansion is into weak states—into China, Morocco, Turkey or elsewhere that foreign trade is imperialistic. This imperialism is actuated by many motives—by a feeling that political control insures special privileges, by a desire to play a large part in the world, by national vanity, by a passion for ownership, but none of these motives would come into play if the countries like China or Turkey were not politically backward."

Political backwardness is not inherent among the Asiatic people, though it is the current opinion among the western students. China in the past had her bright periods of history, her glorious days of Imperialism. In the field of culture and civilization China contributed her full share when she was politically strong. India of Asoka and Akbar was far ahead of any of the European countries of those ages. It is by contact with the Orient that Europe in the past has learnt many useful things for her present civilization. Prof. Benoy Kumar Sarkar in his excellent and critical work "The Chinese Religion Through Hindu Eyes" has very rightly said, The darkest period of European History known as the Middle Ages is the brightest period in Asiatic. For over a thousand years from the accession of Gupta Vicramaditya to the throne of Pataliputra down to the capture of Constantinople by the Turks the history of Asia is the history of continuous growth and progress. It is the record of political and commercial as well as cultural expansion—and the highest watermark attained by oriental humanity.... It was the message of this orient that was carried to Europe by the Islamites and led to the establishment of mediæval universities....

Among other things the Concert of the Great European Powers have had one motive before them—exploitation of Asia and Africa to their advantage. This aggression of Europe in Asia can be stopped for the good of Asia and Europe by

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From Taraknath Das, *Is Japan a Menace to Asia?* (Shanghai: Taraknath Das, 1917), i–vi.

a solid Asiatic unity not merely from a cultural standpoint but also from a political standpoint. This stupendous work of political regeneration of Asia by an Asian Concert has great moral and ethical aspects. There cannot be effective peace so long as one nation or a group of nations looks down upon the other as inferior and tyrannizes. Friendship and fellowship can be established on equal footing. Japan's demonstration of military strength forces the so-called superior nations to shake hands with her, though with great reluctance. Political assertion of Asia will make Europe and America more tolerant and respectful towards human rights.

Because Japan is politically strong, she is able to develop her country politically and culturally. China is struggling to be free and she should accept co-operation from any quarter that is truly friendly. Japan is China's disciple of the past and all far-sighted Japanese believe that "Japan without China and India, is, in the long run, without legs." I would say that China without Japan and India is without legs. The fulfilment of Indian aspiration depends upon a strong united Sino-Japanese Alliance....

Can there be anything more pathetic than the condition of the people of India, one-fifth of the population of the whole world? The cause of the three hundred and fifteen millions of the people of India is the cause of Asia and of Humanity. Japan and China, if far-sighted, should not be unmindful of the problems of the people of India, because a strong, free India will be a source of strength to them.

We have been tired of hearing that Japan is a menace to Asia. Now comes a Hindu scholar, Mr. Taraknath Das, well-versed in world politics, who tries to show that Japan is not a menace to Asia with Asian supremacy, but, rather, that Japan is a menace to European aggression in Asia. Some western author has recently said: "Japan is an international nuisance and she may easily grow to be an international peril." We, however, do not look at a rising Japan in the same spirit. We wish only that China and India be equally strong, that Japan hold her own on the Asiatic continent against European aggressors. Then the international nuisance, charged to Japan, but really traced to other outside forces, will cease to exist in Asia. The awakening of Asia is the most outstanding feature of the present age. The future of Asia is bright and glorious if the new spirit of Asia be rightly directed in co-operation with all the Asian people. We hope, though we may not live to see it fully accomplished, that Japan and China and India will work unitedly, standing for Asian Independence against all outside aggressions.

## 8. Korean Congress Declares Independence from Japanese Rule, 1919

### An Appeal to America

We, the Koreans in Congress, assembled in Philadelphia, April 14-16, 1919, representing eighteen million people of our race who are now suffering untold

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*Korean Congress Declares Independence from Japanese Rule*, 1919. From *First Korean Congress: Held in the Little Theatre, 17th and Delancey Streets* (Philadelphia), 1919 (Soul Tukpyolsi: Pomhan Sojuk Chusik Hoesa, 1986), 90–92, 31–36.

miseries and barbarous treatment by the Japanese military authorities in Korea, hereby appeal to the great and generous American people.

For four thousand years our country enjoyed an absolute autonomy. We have our own history, our own language, our own literature and our own civilization. We have made treaties with the leading nations of the world; all of them recognized our independence, including Japan.

In 1904, at the beginning of the Russo-Japanese war, Japan made a treaty of alliance with Korea, guaranteeing territorial integrity and political independence of Korea, to co-operate in the war against Russia. Korea was opened to Japan for military purposes and Korea assisted Japan in many ways. After the war was over, Japan discarded the treaty of alliance as a "scrap of paper" and annexed Korea as a conquered territory. Ever since she has been ruling Korea with that autocratic militarism whose prototype has been well illustrated by Germany in Belgium and Northern France.

The Korean people patiently suffered under the iron heel of Japan for the last decade or more, but now they have reached the point where they are no longer able to endure it. On March 1st of this year some three million men, mostly of the educated class composed of Christians, Heaven Worshipers, Confucians, Buddhists, students of mission schools, under the leadership of the pastors of the native Christian churches, declared their independence from Japan and formed a provisional government on the border of Manchuria. Through the news dispatches and through private telegrams we are informed that 32,000 Korean revolutionists have been thrown into dungeons by the Japanese and over 100,000 men, women and children have been either killed or wounded so far. The Koreans have no weapons with which to fight, as the Japanese had taken away from them everything since the annexation, even pistols and fowling pieces. What resistance they are offering now against the Japanese soldiers and gendarmery is with pitchforks and sickles. In spite of this disadvantage and the horrible casualty among the Koreans, these people are keeping up their resistance and this demonstration is now nation-wide, including nearly all provinces. Japan has declared martial law in Korea and is butchering by thousands these unfortunate but patriotic people every day.

The Koreans in the United States and Hawaii have sent their representatives to Philadelphia, the Cradle of Liberty, to formulate a concerted plan with a view to stop this inhuman treatment of their brethren by the "Asiatic Kaiser," and to devise ways and means to help along the great cause of freedom and justice for our native land.

We appeal to you for support and sympathy because we know you love justice; you also fought for liberty and democracy, and you stand for Christianity and humanity. Our cause is a just one before the laws of God and man. Our aim is freedom from militaristic autocracy; our object is democracy for Asia; our hope is universal Christianity. Therefore we feel that our appeal merits your consideration.

You have already championed the cause of the oppressed and held out your helping hand to the weak of the earth's races. Your nation is the Hope of Mankind, so we come to you.

Beside this, we also feel that we have the right to ask your help for the reason that the treaty between the United States and Korea contains a stipulation in article 1, paragraph 2, which states as follows:

"If other powers deal unjustly or oppressively with either government, the other will exert their good offices, on being informed of the case, to bring about an amicable arrangement, thus showing their friendly feelings."

Does not this agreement make it incumbent upon America to intercede now in Korea's behalf?

There are many other good and sufficient reasons for America to exert her good offices to bring about an amicable arrangement, but we mention only one more, which is a new principle recently formulated at the peace conference in Paris. We cannot do better than to quote President Wilson's words, who is one of the founders of this new international obligation:

"The principle of the League of Nations is that it is the friendly right of every nation a member of the League to call attention to anything that she thinks will disturb the peace of the world, no matter where that thing is occurring. There is no subject that touches the peace of the world that is exempt from inquiry or discussion."

We, therefore, in the name of humanity, liberty and democracy and in the name of the American-Korean treaty and in the name of the peace of the world, ask the government of the United States to exert its good offices to save the lives of our freedom-loving breathren in Korea and to protect the American missionaries and their families who are in danger of losing their lives and property on account of their love for our people and their faith in Christ.

We further ask you, the great American public, to give us your moral and material help so that our breathren in Korea will know that your sympathy is with them and that you are truly the champions of liberty and international justice.

## 9. Korean Immigrant Hee Kyung Joins the Korean Independence Movement, 1919 (1989)

Two years after she came to the new world Hee Kyung gave birth to her first child. She and her husband named her Chung Sook, meaning "straight and upright" and "clear and gentle like a brook." I was that daughter.

Although my father enjoyed learning his craft at the furniture shop, the wages he brought home still barely covered the necessities of life.

Home, church, and a society called the Youngnam Puin Hoe made up my mother's whole world. At her church she helped form the Methodist Ladies Aid Society, a powerful organization that provided a network of services reaching every Korean family in the community. Although the immigrants were all poor, so dedicated were the Society members that no family went without food or a roof over their heads (immigrant men often lost their jobs); a mother who became ill could depend on other mothers to help her; and a mother with a newborn baby did not have to rise from her bed until she was strong. All these

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From Margaret K. Pai, *The Dream of Two Yi-min*, 7–9, 11, 17–21. © 1989 University of Hawaii Press. Used with permission.

services were rendered despite the fact that every woman was burdened with heavy responsibilities of her own.

The Youngnam Puin Hoe was a society that a good number of the immigrant women belonged to. The members were *yimin*, from a province in Korea called Kyungsangdo. These lively, bright-eyed ladies laughed easily and talked incessantly when they got together. They met once a month on Sunday afternoons (they observed the Sabbath by attending church and by not working that day). They helped the poor and the sick as an extension of the Methodist Society's work but looked for other projects as well.

A project that captured their fancy and enthusiasm soon appeared. The desire for freedom of their country from Japanese rule was always in their hearts. They spoke often of possible ways Koreans could win liberty, and of hopes for Japan's ultimate destruction. One day they heard a rumor from Los Angeles that spread to Hawaii, Shanghai, Manchuria—wherever Koreans lived.

It was a plan for a massive demonstration in Korea that would bring freedom and relief from Japan's rule. The purpose of the demonstration was to show the imperialists of Japan that Koreans were a strong, unified people, not the weaklings the oppressors made them appear to be. The public expression would attract the world's attention and cause nations to come to the rescue of Koreans suffering from oppression and humiliation.

Month after month as new details of the plan were received by the Youngnam Puin Hoe, the members' interest grew. The women declared they would go to Korea and participate in the demonstration.

However, it wasn't long before their enthusiasm diminished and their group plans collapsed when they realized they lacked the funds to cover the boat fare. Furthermore, who would care for their husbands and babies while they were gone?

My mother begged her friends to find a way to Korea and persisted in fanning the fire of fighting for freedom. She told them of the disturbing letters from her parents, who reported that more and more oppressive measures were being imposed on Koreans by the Japanese military. She urged, "Let us go and do what we can to help. We cannot let these measures continue unchecked!"

But the ladies shook their heads. They admired my mother for her unflagging patriotism and determination to take part in the plan. They said, "Hee Kyung, we think you should go and represent all of us. We will pay for your trip."

In the summer of 1918 my parents agreed that I, then three-and-a-half years old, should accompany my mother to Korea while my father stayed behind. Because I had been ill for months with the whooping cough, I was thin and frail.

"I'm concerned about Chung Sook," Father said. "Hee Kyung, don't you think you should wait until she's stronger?"

"But we may not reach Korea in time for the demonstration." She was torn. Finally she added, "My brother is a physician back home. You know, we can't afford a doctor here. But as soon as we get there I will put our daughter under his care."

The Youngnam Puin Hoe publicly announced to the immigrant community that Hee Kyung Kwon was their emissary to the demonstration, although the date for it was yet unknown. The Koreans responded with generous

donations from their hard-earned wages to the cause, and the funds gathered were entrusted to my mother to take with her....

In September my mother decided to go to Seoul, the capital city. A week later she wrote to Grandmother that she was enrolling in Ewha College because that was where she found the people she needed to be with.

I did not know then that Ewha, a college for women, was seething with nationalism and that the majority of the students were revolutionaries. These young intellectual radicals detested the Japanese and were fomenting an overthrow of their rule. They secretly planned one day to join other political groups in the country in a massive show of patriotism.

"I don't know how long your mother will stay in Seoul," Grandmother said to me. "Shall we go and visit her?"

"Yes, yes," I answered. This was the first time I had been separated from my mother and I missed her.

One day in October when the weather was clear, with no anticipation of rain or snow, Grandmother and I, accompanied by one of the servant girls, Sook Cha, took the train to Seoul.

When we met my mother in her dormitory room, we found her in a blue military uniform. How strange she looked without her *chi-ma* and *cho-gori*. She removed the blue cap from her head and sat on the floor, crossing her legs as a man would. I wanted to be close to her and climbed on her lap.

"I'm so sorry you can't be with me every day, Chung Sook," she sighed, stroking my head.

"Please come home, Omoni," I begged.

Her chin grew hard. She looked tense. "Chung Sook, I can't. We're almost ready." She did not explain.

Grandmother seemed to understand. She did not say much. She did not try to persuade Mother to return home. She merely stared at her daughter with sad eyes....

The tense stillness of March 1 lingered through the next few days. Grandfather stayed at home. No one dared to go out to the street. The military commander's curfew rule forced people to remain in their homes.

But our servants were able to tread the back alleys and gather information, and they reported what they heard to my grandparents. They learned that the demonstrations for independence had taken place all over Korea, even in the small towns and outlying provinces. The largest parade, it was believed, was in Seoul. Thousands had joined in the marches, waved flags, cried for justice and an end to Japanese oppression. When the police started shooting and slaughtering the marchers, the Koreans wildly destroyed or damaged custom houses, police stations, and court buildings, especially those in the outskirts of the capital. The Japanese angrily retaliated by setting fire to many Korean churches and schoolhouses.

How quickly and brutally the Japanese suppressed the revolutionists! During the parade in Seoul a young woman's hand, proudly waving the Korean flag, was cut off by a Japanese sword. But before the flag touched the ground, she caught it with her other hand. More than 2,500 Koreans were thrown in prison in Seoul alone that day. Among the women activists incarcerated was my mother, Lee Hee Kyung.

# ESSAYS

The first essay, by University of Pennsylvania historian Eiichiro Azuma, places the immigration of Japanese to the United States and Hawai'i within the context of Japan's effort to move away from its unequal power vis-à-vis the West. Azuma identifies three types of immigrants—merchants, colonists, and laborers. The first two types were fired with nationalism to have their migration serve the Japanese Empire, while the third type was driven by dreams of personal fortune that were sometimes at odds with building a stronger Japan. In the second essay, Vanderbilt University historian Paul A. Kramer addresses the significance of race for the U.S. colonization of the Philippines. Rather than dismiss Filipinos as simply racially inferior, U.S. officials promoted an "inclusionary racial formation" that emphasized the ability of especially elite Filipinos to absorb American ideals and practices. The *pensionados*, students sent to the United States as models of America's "benevolent assimilation," were the prime example.

## Heterogeneous Origins of Japanese America

EIICHIRO AZUMA

Popularized after the Meiji Restoration of 1868, "emigration" and "colonization" were new concepts borrowed from the West, which the Japanese political elite and intellectual class came to use interchangeably in their discussion of the most pressing national tasks: national formation and expansion. The dissemination of these ideas to the emergent citizenry through the press, political organizations, and academia was central in the making of a modern empire in Japan. The very notion of emigration or colonization had not even existed under the closed-door policy of the Tokugawa feudal regime. The exodus of various classes of Japanese for Hawaii and the mainland United States after the 1880s prompted the intelligentsia for the first time to seriously contemplate the meaning of popular emigration in tandem with the nascent ideas of national expansion.

In order to explain the nature of early Japanese expansionism with which the practice of emigration was tightly intertwined, it is necessary to delve into three interrelated contexts: geopolitics in the Asia-Pacific region, Japan's incorporation into the international network of capitalist economies, and the formation of the modern nation-state. First, Meiji Japan's entry into modernity coincided with the era in which Western powers had been engaged in fierce colonialist competitions in East Asia and the Pacific Basin. During the 1880s, a new style of imperialism became the vogue as the West sought direct control of overseas territories, replacing the emphasis on hegemonic control in trade to link the metropolis and its colonies. In Southeast Asia, the French took over Indochina, and the British established footholds in Burma, while both powers

BETWEEN TWO EMPIRES: RACE, HISTORY, AND TRANSNATIONALISM IN JAPANESE AMERICA by Azuma (2005) 3400w from Chp.1 "Mercantilists, Colonialists, and Laborers: Heterogeneous Origins of Japanese America," pp. 17–34 © 2005 by Oxford University Press, Inc. By permission of Oxford University Press, USA.

scrambled for Africa. The Pacific and northeastern Asia subsequently emerged as another sphere of imperialist competition. During and after the Spanish-American War of 1898, the United States acquired Hawaii, the Philippines, and Guam, while the Germans took over the hitherto-neglected Spanish possessions of Pacific island chains in Micronesia and Melanesia. In the meantime, since the mid-1800s, China had become a major battlefield for Christian missionaries and merchants from Europe and the United States.

Meiji Japan, a latecomer, joined this international scramble for new territories and export markets, not only because its leaders felt that the "civilized" had to accept manifest destiny to partake in the practice of colonization, but also because they believed that proactive expansionist endeavors would be imperative in defense of Japan's fragile security. The nation had been on the receiving end of Western imperialism, when it had been forced to open to international commerce in 1854 by U.S. warships under Commodore Matthew Perry, but Japan had diverged from other Asian nations because of its quick "success" in acclimating to the geopolitical environment. No sooner had Emperor Meiji formed a new government in 1868 than imperial expansionism began internally and externally, resulting in the colonization of Hokkaido (1869) and Okinawa (1879); the seizures of Taiwan (1894), south Sakhalin (1905), and Kwantung Province (1905) in northern China; and then the annexation of Korea (1910). In the meantime, the country fought two successful foreign wars, first with China in 1894–1895 and then with Russia in 1904–1905....

Japan's late adoption of a capitalist economy further contributed to the blurring of the boundaries between emigration and colonization. Although the nation turned itself from a feudal society into a major military power within the span of a few decades, the development compounded the integration of Japan into the international capitalist network, rendering it perpetually dependent for markets and capital on more advanced industrial economies, particularly the United States. Given its relative underdevelopment, Japan often served as a source of cheap workers for the more advanced economies, transferring manual labor to Hawaii, the American West, and to a lesser degree, various European colonies in Southeast Asia and the plantation economies of Latin America. Insofar as it also enhanced the competitiveness of imperial Japan's economy, the cheapness of domestic labor dovetailed with Japan's own colonialist projects, leading to significant overlap in socioeconomic characteristics between Japanese immigrants in other countries and colonial settlers within the empire. Although the movement of Japanese across the Pacific transpired between the sphere of Japan's sovereign control and that of another nation-state, it was this overlap that caused U.S.–bound emigrants to be often confounded with colonialists who moved and lived "under the aegis of our national flag."

Tokyo's effort to consolidate state control over its populace provided the third context in which expansionism and emigration were interlocked. Aside from setting up formal state apparatuses and a unified capitalist economy, Meiji nation-building sought to make imperial subjects out of village-bound peasants, who would act voluntarily for the benefit of the emperor and the national

collectivity. In accordance with this mandate, as the Meiji elite often stressed, emigrants were expected to obey the call of their nation as citizen-subjects. Just as the state dictated that the obligations of every imperial subject included such acts as paying taxes from meager income, working fourteen hours a day under hazardous conditions, and dying while fighting a foreign war, so Meiji leaders defined emigration as a patriotic duty in support of Japan's expansionist cause, whether commercial, political, or territorial. The colonialist discourse therefore usually assigned a nationalist meaning to the act of emigration on the premise that the masses shared the same dedication to the state's collective purpose. Importantly, while it created another point of intersection between colonialism and emigration, the nationalist presumption blinded the elite to the fact that most emigrants of rural origin viewed their endeavors from the standpoint of personal interest without much regard to the purported duties of the imperial subject. Subsuming popular individualism under nascent nationalism, the elite vision of emigration-led expansionism contradicted the logic of most ordinary emigrants and planted the seeds for discord, which would later grow among Japanese residents in the American West.

During the years between 1885 and 1907, when most male emigrants left for Hawaii and the United States, the ideological terrain of Meiji Japan was indeed a diverse one, with competing ideas developing in tandem with the political process of nationalizing the Japanese people. There were three major currents of emigration thought that directly affected the early development of Japanese America. Roughly corresponding with the class origins and mental worlds of the Issei, they were mercantilist expansionism, Japanese-style manifest destiny, and an ideology of striving and success. The heterogeneity of the Japanese emigrant population also provided a background for contentious relations and identities within their communities, based on how individuals, with varied degrees of national consciousness, understood their ties to the homeland, as well as their role and place in their adopted country.

Mercantilist expansionism helped form what was to become the core of urban Issei leadership in the Pacific Coast states. Rather than seizing colonial territories by military force, proponents of this position aspired to establish footholds of international trade at foreign locations, to which Japan could send its export goods while exercising indirect forms of economic domination. The leading advocate was Fukuzawa Yukichi, who took the lead in the learning of things Western and the development of entrepreneurial culture in Meiji Japan. In 1884, dreaming of British-style commercial hegemony in the Pacific, Fukuzawa promoted Japanese export business by the way of entrepreneurial migration to the United States. Through his private Keio academy and commercial newspaper, this foremost scholar of "Western studies" sought to impress his ideas upon the emerging urban bourgeoisie in Tokyo.

Fukuzawa believed that there was an imminent need to shore up the Meiji policy of "enrich the nation, strengthen the military." With a weak industrial base and a small domestic market, Japan in the mid-1880s badly needed to increase its exports to develop foreign exchange holdings. While propagating trade as essential to solidifying the fiscal basis of the state and its military,

Fukuzawa defined emigration as a cardinal means of promoting commerce with the United States. Specifically, he anticipated that Japanese immigrants in key American trade ports would serve as a "commercial linkage between their homeland and their new country of residence."...

Not everyone, however, was capable of taking up such an endeavor, in Fukuzawa's opinion. He restricted the practitioners of entrepreneurial migration to the United States to a narrow range of educated, middle-class Japanese, for the national "enrichment of Japan" was contingent upon whether or not emigrants possessed the dispositions with which to remain loyal imperial subjects even on foreign soil. Fukuzawa believed that such individuals should be given an opportunity to leave for "the land of boundless opportunities," because he felt that their intellect, talent, and "superior racial qualities" would ensure their ascendancy in American society. Focusing on people of warrior background, Fukuzawa's emigration discourse offered no room for common people of rural origin, whom he frequently ridiculed as lacking national consciousness and modern sensibilities....

A more colonialist discourse on emigration overtook mercantilist expansionism from the 1890s on, when the international scramble for colonies reached its nadir in the Asia-Pacific region. The main theme of the new position revolved around the control of a foreign land through mass migration. Historian Akira Iriye aptly summarizes this Japanese-style manifest destiny:

> The line between emigration and colonization was rather tenuous. Most authors, advocating massive overseas emigration, were visualizing the creation of Japanese communities overseas as centers of economic and social activities closely linked to the mother country.... Though the outright use of force was not envisaged, such a situation would be much closer to colonization than to mere emigration—like the massive English colonization of the North American continent. Thus, "peaceful expansionism" did not simply mean the passive emigration of individual Japanese, but could imply a government-sponsored, active program of overseas settlement and positive activities to tie distant lands closer to Japan....

Toward the late 1890s, a clear pattern of domestic entrepreneurship emerged from the expansionistic Issei intelligentsia. Seeking capital consolidation and ethnic mobilization, many looked to integrate common Japanese laborers, who had hitherto lived in a separate world. In San Francisco, Seattle, and Portland, as well as in smaller regional towns, this ushered in the formation of a class of professional Issei labor contractors. Not only did they promote the influx of additional laborers from Japan, but they also played a major role in increasing landed Japanese communities by facilitating settlement farming in rural districts. In this way, Issei expansionists were being incorporated into the agricultural economy of the American West, conveniently filling the labor vacuum created by Chinese exclusion, as suppliers of farm hands and tillers of undeveloped land....

Unlike the ideas of emigration tied to trade and colonization, the third current of emigration thought, an ideology of striving and success, fit into the

mental world of many common emigrants. From the mid-1890s through the following decade, what contemporaries observed as a popular "success boom" swept Japanese society, and emigration to the United States was central to this new social phenomenon. As the print media exalted the American Dream, mass-produced magazines popularized stories of self-made white men, such as Andrew Carnegie, Theodore Roosevelt, Cornelius Vanderbilt, and John D. Rockefeller. Because "America" became synonymous with boundless opportunities in the Japanese vocabulary of the time, many unprivileged but ambitious youth projected onto these role models their own future trajectories. Portraying emigration to the United States as a crucial step, the success ideology catered to the aspirations of the indigent students to work their way through school in the American West and the desire of the rural farming class to make a quick fortune through manual labor there....

When addressed to student-emigrants, the ideology of striving and success was not divorced from the prevailing concern with the national whole that educated Japanese generally shared. Since it was urban literati ... who articulated the meaning of going to America, the success ideology was often worded in the familiar language of "extending national power."... Influenced by such an ideology, which subsumed self-interest under nationalism, it was not uncommon for many student-emigrants to merge into the earlier group of expansionist entrepreneurs once they arrived in the American West. Indeed, in the first two decades of the twentieth century, many immigrant farmers, business owners, and regional community leaders emerged from this population.

The ideology of success had another keen audience: Japan's rural masses. Unlike students, *dekasegi* emigrants of rural origin were mostly indifferent to the valorization of emigration beyond personal or family concerns. For example, a *dekasegi* returnee ascribed her family's emigration decision solely to the "rumor that [it] would pay off handsomely," while another sought to acquire land in his home village and build a "tile-roofed house"—a symbol of wealth in rural Japan. Upon his return from California, a migrant worker admitted that he had acted on the words of former migrant workers that one could "make a bundle of money in America." Despite his advanced age and family objections, the fifty-three-year-old took the journey to the unknown land, because he knew he could not have enjoyed "his fill of sweet *sake*" had he stayed put as a poor farmer in Japan. These accounts demonstrate no trace of concern for the state, or even for their village communities.

From the standpoint of the government elite and urban intelligentsia, rural Japanese were indeed a great trouble. When a large number of laborers crossed the Pacific for work, the process of molding them into imperial subjects had barely begun at home. Starting in the early 1870s, the Meiji state strove hard to integrate Japan's periphery into its centralized state apparatuses, while inculcating national identity in the population of feudalized peasants. This process entailed the development of suitable ideologies, such as state Shintoism, legally sanctioned patriarchy, and the orthodoxy of emperor worship, as well as the construction of corresponding institutions, including compulsory education and military service. The making of imperial subjects in rural areas was nonetheless

uneven and incomplete due partially to the often-strained relationships between the central elite and grassroots leaders. Not until after the Russo-Japanese War of 1904–1905 did the state achieve any notable integration of village Japanese....

The departure of *dekasegi* laborers for Hawaii and the United States between 1885 and 1908 signified the zenith of popular pragmatism among ordinary Japanese. In the context of the nation's incorporation into the international network of capitalist economies, the decade of the 1880s ushered in a drastic reconfiguration of its rural economy. What helped to encourage the farming population to emigrate was the overarching effect of commercial agriculture, which alienated so many villagers from their chief means of production, the farmland. These displaced peasants formed a pool of working-class people in need of wage labor. At the same time, the intrusion of market forces into villages opened up the world view of rural residents, allowing some to dream of upward mobility beyond what they could have had under the feudal regime. Depending on varying economic, political, and social circumstances, these developments made some groups of rural Japanese more receptive than others to the idea of going abroad as a way to material fulfillment. The resultant emigrants divide into two major types: distressed contract laborers and entrepreneurial laborers.

Known initially as "government-contract emigrants" (1885–1894) and later as "private-contract emigrants" (1894–1899), *distressed contract laborers* consisted mainly of individuals of "landless or small landowning farming households," who looked to earn American dollars through contract labor in Hawaii. Transportation to Hawaii and other initial expenses were paid for by the employer. In the two phases, there were 29,069 and 40,230 such emigrants, respectively, who were recruited to work on sugar plantations on three-year contracts....

Between 1895 and 1908, more than 130,000 Japanese—the majority of them *entrepreneurial laborers*—left for the continental United States and Hawaii. The typical emigrant of this group originated from a better-off rural household, and he preferred to go to the continental United States without his wife. An average immigrant in California could earn twice as much as a field hand in Hawaii. Given that even a plantation worker was paid four to six times more than a common laborer in Hiroshima, the benefits of choosing labor on the U.S. mainland far exceeded that of going elsewhere and was well worth the initial expenses, which amounted to at least $100. For the same reason, many Japanese laborers in Hawaii, "liberated" from three-year contracts as a result of U.S. annexation, opted to go to the Pacific Coast states after 1900 instead of continuing to work on sugarcane fields or returning home. From 1902 to 1907, there were reportedly about 38,000 Japanese remigrants from Hawaii to the American West.

Unlike the contract labor scheme, the new pattern of labor emigration soon came into conflict with the diplomatic agenda of the Japanese state. The massive influx of common laborers from Japan incited anti-"Oriental" agitation among white Californians, who had excluded Chinese immigrants on the pretext of their economic, cultural, and racial danger. Quickly gathering political momentum, the anti-Japanese movement in the West became such a liability to Tokyo that the Foreign Ministry was compelled to stop the departure of Japanese for the

U.S. mainland altogether in August 1900. A partial relaxation of the ban was effected in June 1902, but it excluded "laborers" categorically from the right of passage. Following this change in emigration policy, when rural Japanese applied for passports, many farmers posed as "businessmen," "merchants," or even "industrialists"—a practice that continued until 1908 with some degree of success. Others went to Mexico and Canada, from which they entered the continental United States. Stringent administrative restrictions only led to widespread popular defiance. Viewed from the perspective of officials, such fraudulent passport applications presented a challenge not only to the diplomatic affairs of the state but also to the very authority of the central government.

Military service formed another notable area of popular defiance by entrepreneurial emigrants. Since the 1870s, rural Japanese had resisted conscription in a variety of ways ranging from mass protests to feigned illness. *Dekasegi* emigration offered many youths a safer means to avoid giving up several years of their lives for something other than their personal benefit and family interests. By virtue of their sojourns abroad, emigrant laborers were able to enjoy annual draft deferments; but in exchange they would be subject to mandatory induction into the army upon their return to Japan without a chance of obtaining reserve status. Yet even this restriction could not match the genius of many emigrants, who simply overstayed in the United States until after their eligibility for active duty expired at the age of thirty-two. The Japanese government was particularly concerned with this problem in the early 1900s, for officials considered it to be not only embarrassing but also inimical to national security. During the crisis of the Russo-Japanese War, Tokyo was compelled to order local offices to scrutinize passport applications from *dekasegi* laborers and crack down on draft evasions, noting that "more and more adolescents due to be draftable in 1905 and 1906 have been attempting to go abroad." Popular individualism seriously challenged the elite/national mandate, producing rebellious rural folks who hardly fit the image of the self-effacing imperial subject.

The Gentlemen's Agreement of 1907–1908 between Washington and Tokyo was a logical culmination of the struggle between the state and rural emigrants. It primarily addressed the problem of anti-Japanese agitation in San Francisco, which demanded immigration exclusion, but also offered the Tokyo elite a solution to the uncontrollable proliferation of the success ideology among labor emigrants. Under the bilateral agreement, the entry routes from Mexico, Canada, and Hawaii into the U.S. mainland were shut down under an executive order of President Theodore Roosevelt, and Tokyo limited the issuance of America-bound passports to specific classes of individuals. Aside from international merchants and students of higher education, the qualified emigrants included only spouses and minor children of bona fide U.S. residents. Until the total exclusion of Japanese in 1924, a smaller scale of labor migration continued in the form of family chain migration, including the so-called picture brides, but after 1908 the control of rural emigrants posed far fewer challenges to the central government.

Thereafter, the main stage of struggle between the commanding state and the defiant emigrant shifted from the domestic sphere of Japan to the society of

Japanese immigrants. In the American West, Tokyo's diplomatic agents and the local Issei elite, including expansionistic mercantilists, colonialists, and patriotic students, formed a coalition to keep the immigrant masses in line, while ordinary laboring men and women remained largely oblivious to the imposition of nationalist dictates. And behind this tug-of-war stood white Americans, who, as the chief force of political intervention, inadvertently furnished the framework for the intraethnic contestation and ensuing community-building efforts in early Japanese America.

## Filipino Students and the Politics of Racial Inclusion

PAUL KRAMER

The opening and dedication of Manila's Santa Cruz bridge was pompously undertaken in March 1903, celebrating the "first outward and visible monument to American progress in the Philippines." By that year, the project was simply one element in the U.S. colonial regime's ongoing reform of the capital, aimed especially at commercial infrastructure, sanitary improvement, and police surveillance. But the bridge carried special symbolic weight that spoke to the peculiar predicaments of a colonial state still literally under construction. In reporting the occasion, Manila's English-language press and American colonial officials shared a somewhat obvious metaphorical vocabulary. The structure "not only bridges the Pasig," reported the *Manila American*, "but a chasm that has existed between the native Filipinos and their American fellow-citizens." The hope was for a one-way crossing, so that "over this bridge may come the hearts and minds of the former."...

The ritual would demonstrate how significantly the political, and racial, texture of American colonial politics had changed since the formal declaration of the end of the Philippine-American War. The new colonial state, with the Philippine Commission at its hub, would have civilians at its helm, although it would retain strong military elements. It would draw strength from, but also be challenged by, an American colonial civil society of merchants, businessmen, and adventurers. Most of all, it would be a regime of collaboration between Americans and Filipinos, one in which U.S. officials recognized provincial and metropolitan elites as unequal political partners. The process had, of course, begun during the war itself. Continued repression and the promise of amnesty had attracted both rural and urban elites away from the revolution and toward the U.S. military state. But the system of collaboration would become more extensive and formalized under the civilian regime, both more autonomous from Washington and more deeply rooted in Filipino social structures.

The new political configuration necessitated a new racial formation to organize and legitimate it. The broad-gauged, in some cases exterminist, racism of

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the U.S. military during the Philippine-American War was ill suited to the more subtle arts of compromise, feint, and manipulation that would characterize Filipino-American power-sharing under the Philippine Commission. What was needed was a racial formation that could somehow persuade its Filipino participants that they were "brothers" and not "serfs" and simultaneously explain to them why they were unready for the rigors and responsibilities of self-government. It must also be able to explain to racist anti-imperialists why the assimilation of Filipinos would be successful and pose no threat to the United States itself. The result was an inclusionary racial formation that brought metaphors of family, evolution, and tutelary assimilation into a gradualist, indeed indefinite, trajectory of Filipino "progress" toward self-government....

If the Filipino masses were superstitious, passive, and ignorant, if Filipino elites were venal, corrupt, and abusive, what was a colonial state to do? What was the inclusionary racial narrative of postwar colonialism in the Philippines to be about? Three interlocking narratives and metaphors went into the making of this inclusionary racism: familial, evolutionary, and tutelary-assimilationist. All three provided necessary frameworks for hierarchical participation and a progressive, if indefinite, time frame for political change. Each recognized Filipinos but predicated that recognition on Filipinos' demonstration of sociocultural features that only Americans could determine and evaluate. Each marked a path into the otherwise uncertain colonial future by drawing necessary, concrete calibrations. The unevenness of their deployment, and their inconsistencies when juxtaposed, were part of their collective power, if they also opened up spaces for resistance. At the same time, their underlying homologies—especially by promising and withholding authority—sustained the hegemony of inclusionary racism and the imperialism of process.

What made each of the narratives powerful was its success in colonizing the future. Filipino incapacities were deep obstructions in the present, but not immutable. "While there is to-day a palpable unfitness for self-government among [Filipinos]," Taft himself put it, "there is in them a capacity for future development, for future preparation for self-government." Each of these narratives came with its own progression into that future: children matured, the backward evolved, students learned. Each of these required outside authorities to accredit or deny progress. When asked to provide more specific timetables for U.S. colonialism, Taft and other colonialists drew boundaries far into the future. Filipinos would "need the training of fifty or a hundred years before they shall even realize what Anglo-Saxon liberty is," Taft wrote, for example. Oftentimes, American officials turned to an expansive language of "generation." There were, for example, Maud Jenks's necessary "fifty generations" of education. Taft believed it would take "at least two generations" to "educate" Filipinos for self-government. "Generation" used in this way combined an open-ended sense of time, a logic of family reproduction, and a neo-Lamarckian hope that self-government might be bred in.

Discourses of family were central to the new inclusionary racial formation. The idiom was encouraged, but not determined, by the arrival of American women and the establishment of new U.S. colonial domestic settings that included, in some cases, young children. Family was a metaphor of inclusion and belonging but also one of hierarchy, of natural inferiors and superiors.

In its elaborated form, the colonial state as "family" cast Filipinos on the whole as children; as such, they were credulous, irresponsible, undisciplined, unruly, and gendered as boys; they were also "educable," reinforcing the colonial state as "school." The colonial state sought graduated timelines for colonialism, which children's progressive maturation to adulthood could provide. But if they agreed Filipinos were "children," Americans in both the Philippines and the United States divided sharply over the broader organization of the colonial "family." Most Manila Americans, for example, especially those close to the military, defined Americans as Filipinos' metaphorical "fathers"; in this mode, the framing of colonialism as family was impelled by the desire to make the ongoing brutalities of war morally invisible by recasting them as legitimate, patriarchal, disciplinary family violence. Officials associated with the Philippine Commission, by contrast, represented themselves as Filipinos' elder "brothers"; the result was what might be called colonial fraternalism, most succinctly expressed in the term for Filipinos attributed to Taft, "little brown brothers." While often taken as a generic expression of colonial condescension, this term needs to be seen in the specific context of an emerging inclusionary Philippine-American racial politics. It invited Filipinos into an imagined household of U.S. empire; it remade them from "black"—the color often attributed to them during the war, into the softer "brown." The metaphor of "brotherhood" did not need to convey actual or potential equality, but it was nonetheless the most potentially subversive of the terms—a fact noted by the Morrison poem above—which made the two other modifiers necessary. While naturalizing and moralizing colonialism, familial metaphors were also problematic in racial terms; it remained unclear how American "fathers" ended up with Filipino "children," or how Americans became the elder siblings to "little brown brothers."

Of the three, evolutionary metaphors were the most abstract, confidently grounding the contested historicism of U.S. colonialism in widely held metanarratives of staged, progressive development. During the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, social-evolutionary historicism had reached the pinnacle of its authority within U.S. social science and public culture as a mode of narration and legitimation. But "evolution" had specific functions to achieve in the Philippines: most important, evolution grounded social processes in natural-historical time, which rooted U.S. colonialism in inescapable forces. Where anti-imperialists had challenged the legitimacy of colonialism as a violation of U.S. historical traditions, evolution promoted an alternative—and primordial—historical narrative. But as in other spheres, U.S. colonialists did not simply export existing U.S. social-evolutionary frameworks but rather reworked existing Philippine ones. U.S. colonialists drew on earlier wave-migration theories in casting Philippine history on the whole as a series of racial invasions by progressively more civilized elements; Spanish colonial history, for all its depravities, was recast as the steady, gradual retreat of savagery in the wake of a more progressive Christianity. Within the imagined present and future of U.S. colonial history, Filipinos as individuals would progress still further in evolutionary time. The specific axes of movement varied: they would "evolve" from ignorant peasants to English-speaking students; from filthy urban denizens to sanitary subjects; from

recalcitrant to disciplined laborers. Philippine society would also evolve as a whole: from the tribal chaos and fragmentation that was said to have characterized pre-Hispanic and Spanish colonial time, to the emergence—far in the future—of a nation characterized by "homogeneity," forged by transportation and communications infrastructure and by English as a common language. Not all the inhabitants of the Philippines were placed on the same evolutionary track: while evolution was said to characterize U.S. colonial time, Christians and non-Christians were progressing not only at different rates but in different directions. Evolutionary colonial progress, in fact, might widen rather than diminish difference among the islands' inhabitants.

More than any other, the new colonial state's defining metaphor would be tutelary and assimilationist, one that cast the colonial state in its entirety as a school and made its task the active transformation of Filipinos in an unsteady and necessarily indefinite movement toward "Americanism." Tutelage and assimilation were anchored in the actual construction and organization of schools during the first years of the Taft regime and the increasing number of American teachers. By 1904, there were hundreds of new school buildings erected at the center of villages throughout the archipelago; voluntary contributions by local elites for construction purposes rooted these novel institutions in Filipino power structures. The metaphor's greatest practical beneficiaries were the private English-language schools that sprung up in Manila and other cities, promising to train bright and enterprising young Filipinos in English for the civil service exams. The state as school, in other words, made sense in part because attending school facilitated entree into the state as a civil servant.

But the metaphor's power far outstripped the existence of actual public or civil service schools. There was virtually no state arena of Filipino-American interaction—from office clerkships to forced road labor—that was not conceived of as "education." On one level, it sublimated the wartime hatred that had often justified violence in the name of "teaching" Filipinos "a lesson." But "tutelage" was also a shorthand for "benevolence" and "uplift," the very messages the regime wanted to send to both Filipinos and domestic U.S. audiences. Even U.S. soldiers, officials emphasized, had opened schools in the garrisoned towns they had occupied during the war. Education organized the colonial state's myriad tasks into a single one: providing Filipinos the necessary, if elusive, political rationality required for successful self-government. If assimilation was the regime's long-term goal, tutelage was its process and policy. This pervasive metaphor—colonialism as tutelage in self-government—applied equally well, if differently, to still "incapable" Filipino elites and masses. Collaborating Filipino elites would receive "practical instruction" from the U.S. officials with whom they would share power in provincial and insular governments. In the new, American-run public school system, children of the Filipino masses would gain the manual and industrial training, literacy, discipline, and work ethic with which they might eventually exercise responsible "citizenship."

English-language instruction was central to the metaphor of colonialism as tutelage. The decision for English as the primary language of the state was partly structural. On the ground, there were small numbers of Americans who could

speak Spanish with the elites of Manila and other cities, and none who spoke any other Filipino languages that might take them farther into the countryside or further down the class scale. A regime so heavily reliant on Filipino collaborators, it might have been argued, should have opted to train the comparatively few Americans in Filipino languages, rather than the far more gigantic project of training Filipinos in English. But, as many observers pointed out, neither the U.S. government nor the academy had the capacity for training potential U.S. civil servants in Filipino languages.

The choice of English was also profoundly ideological, becoming invested with political and moral force in at least two ways. First was the notion of English as the linguistic counterpart of nation-building. What had been one of the central rationales of the U.S. invasion—that proliferating tribes were a sign of the impossibility of Philippine nationality—was now emerging as an organizing regime problem. If the Philippine Republic had been merely a Tagalog conspiracy, as many Americans believed, a genuine Filipino nation could only be constructed through the inculcation of a common language. Spanish might have presented itself as a candidate for the language of Filipino nationality, as the second language of much of the Filipino elite, especially in urban areas. But here, a second ideology was essential, one that invested English with transformative, liberating power. The inherent political superiority of English had been emphasized during the Anglo-Saxonist mobilizations that had proven so important during the annexation debate. English was not only the means to national unity but the necessary vehicle for tutelage. Only English could convey Anglo-Saxon morals and institutions of self-government, transforming its users.

English-language instruction became one element in the regime's broader national-exceptionalist claims. Explaining why American colonial civil servants were neither trained nor examined on Philippine languages, Everett Thompson, a civil service board examiner, noted the "radically different principle underlying the *raison d'etre* of the Philippine government" relative to India, Java, and Indochina. These colonies were "governed as sources of strength and revenue to the home power" and lacked an impulse "magnanimously to uplift" or "train the inhabitants for citizenship or to change their language or customs." As a result, European officials in them, "to better administer the necessary affairs of government," became "thoroughly imbued with the genius, the language, the laws, and customs of the subject peoples." "With the Philippines," he wrote, "all this is different." Since the Philippine government existed "primarily for the Filipinos," the "permeating spirit of the Philippine civil service is the training of the Filipino in the best methods of government." Filipinos compelled to speak English might become "thoroughly imbued" with the Anglo-Saxon genius, rather than the other way around. English might also have the more mundane benefit of encouraging compliance with the colonial state. "In mastering the English language the Filipinos not only fill their minds with a knowledge of its literature," wrote Thompson, "but are thus the better prepared to appreciate the high aims and purposes of the present government."

There was no better condensation of the projects of tutelage and assimilation than the *pensionado* program, inaugurated in 1903, which would eventually send

approximately 300 Filipino students to the United States for government-funded higher education. After receiving four years of college and living with American families, the *pensionados* would be required to return to the Philippines as teachers, engineers, or other civil servants for five years. The program arose out of the desire for higher-level Filipino civil servants and the complete absence of secular higher education in the Philippines capable of meeting American standards of expertise. It was also hoped that it would introduce "assimilating" Filipinos to the United States as advertisements for the regime's benevolence. It resembled empire-building educational programs elsewhere; indeed, U.S. officials compared it to "the efforts of the British Government to educate the people of India by sending them to England, and of the Japanese Government in behalf of its own people in sending them to notable foreign schools."

If the *pensionado* program was about reorienting the rising elite generation toward American customs and loyalties, it was also about putting forward the best and brightest Filipino youths before American eyes as symbols of successful assimilation. The requirement of high-school graduation, a goal achieved by only those few families that could sustain children in school, tended to deliver upper-class candidates. Where a poor but talented student might have squeaked through, Taft's instructions to provincial governors made clear that "[e]ach student must be of unquestionable moral and physical qualifications, weight being given to social status." William Sutherland, the program's first supervisor, would later recall that the program's goal was "to make a favorable impression" on Americans "who mostly thought theretofore that Filipinos wore gee strings and slept in trees."

If narratives of tutelage, family, evolution, and assimilation made headway in the Philippines, it was only because they were ideologies familiar and acceptable to select Filipino elites, some of whom emphasized that Filipino progress could only be achieved through U.S. colonialism. These elites were recognized and promoted by the colonial state and given a platform in official publications and in opinion journals in the United States. Such ideological congruence was most visible at the insular level, where collaboration between Americans and Filipinos allowed and required a mutual shaping of political discourses. T. H. Pardo de Tavera best represented the Filipino side of this dialogue in the early years of the Taft regime. His vision of Filipino progress through colonialism, and especially through U.S. secular education, was articulated, for example, in a 1906 address given before American and Filipino teachers entitled "The Filipino Soul." In it, Pardo criticized "conservatives" who would "preserve our customs and traditions" so that "our social conscience, poetically styled the Filipino soul, may remain unchanged." Only "uncivilized countries," he claimed, remained "immutable and petrified before the moving forces of history." As when barbarous Europeans long ago had become civilized by submitting to conquering Romans, Filipinos should submit to the tutelage of the "Anglo-Saxon race," the "trustee and the dictator of the highest civilization that we have ever known of."

Like the American architects of inclusionary racism, Pardo stated that he did "not believe that race-inferiority is a matter of permanence or of anthropology" nor "an inherent or a natural condition of any race." Indeed, it was those who

advocated a "Filipino soul" that were overcommitted to "racial" thinking. These "anthropo-sociologists" failed to acknowledge the "absurdity" of essential racial hierarchy, denying, for example, the historical rise and decline of races between positions of superiority and inferiority. Japan presented Pardo a "striking example" of social transformation through adoption of European ways; he prophesied that the day was "not far distant" when Philippine progress would "present one more practical example to the sociologists who deny the existence of inferior races, because our culture will also shed a luster on this world side by side with that of Japan."

Also like his American counterparts, Pardo sought to legitimate the U.S. occupation by indigenizing it, making it the historic extension of the late nineteenth-century *ilustrado* diaspora and Propaganda reform movement. Filipinos abroad in that period had sought "to acquire a new spirit, a new mentality," rather than to cling to a "Filipino soul." There was a certain irony, then, that "now that the civilization which we want to seek outside our country" had "come to visit our own homes in the form of the Anglo-Saxon public school instruction, a strange reactionary spirit and puzzling attitude of mind struggle to drive it away." Those who claimed that colonial education would undermine Filipino nationalism had to deal with an awkward historical fact: colonial education had historically promoted nation-building. "The Filipinos educated in Spanish schools in the Philippines, under a strictly Spanish system," he noted, "were the individuals who brought about the revolution which ended Spanish sovereignty in the Philippines." While it might seem that the "movement for Philippinism" emerged from the "uneducated classes," it was in fact the work of the educated, "whose souls had been 'profoundly adulterated.'" It was European-educated Filipinos that had learned "to respect the race, venerate the customs of the ancestors, discover the beauties of Nature in the Islands (in which other people found nothing but objects of ridicule and scorn), admire the land, and dream of the country's redemption." Pardo believed U.S. colonialism would continue this process. English-language education would create an awareness of "the oneness of our rights, the singleness of our duties, the harmony of our aspirations, and the unanimity of our ideals." Communications networks would spread civilization across physically isolated provinces, and "in place of heterogeneity, there will spring a homogeneity of ideas." Interregional contact and communication would "give rise to a sentiment of national fellowship which, in truth, hardly exists today."

While tutelage and assimilation found some Filipino advocates, they also produced American skepticism and anxiety. It would remain one of the regime's central tasks to persuade doubting domestic U.S. publics that Filipinos could be Americanized. Tutelage and assimilation were both fantasies of one-way cultural connection without unanticipated reflux: the colonized would learn from the colonizers without, in turn, teaching them; the colonized would become more similar to the colonizers without transforming them. If the new regime empowered Filipinos who believed in assimilation, there were nonetheless many American skeptics who feared what it might mean for the United States itself, as in Rebecca Taylor's 1903 critical essay, "Disposition of the Philippine Islands." Taylor's piece can be seen as taking up where Henry C. Rowland's

wartime account of the tragic "degeneration" of U.S. troops had left off. It evaluated the regime's policy of assimilation, which she defined as "nothing less than incorporation into the body politic." Pushing the metaphor to the point of extremity and dark satire, Taylor defined assimilation in digestive terms, in the process revealing just how important unincorporated status had been. Taylor redefined McKinley's "benevolent assimilation" to mean that the "Philippine prey must be captured by the great assimilating body, and devoured—ground to powder by the military force composing the strong teeth of that body; that Filipino mincemeat must be moistened by saliva of superior brand—spat upon, if you please, the mouth of the big assimilating body fairly 'watering' at the prospect of an Oriental meal. Down the American esophagus the mass must go."

Once devoured, the Philippines would become "'flesh of our flesh and bone of our bone.'" But the process would not merely change the Philippines. During actual, physical digestion, "[t]he assimilating body is also changed by the character of the substance assimilated. The purity of the blood, the strength of the muscles, the quality of the brain, the tension of the nerve, the texture of the skin, the temperature, and even the moral nature are strongly influenced by that which is assimilated." This would operate as well in the political sphere. In "assimilating the Filipino, the American people must accept the change that will be wrought in the national body by the very nature of the case." Continuing her striking description of digestive imperialism, she stated:

> This fine pulp must be passed through the Taft pylorus into the American duodenum, to be acted upon by the various superior fluids, notably American gall, after which the political villi will dip down into the Filipino-American chyle ... and finally the refined emulsion, when mixed with American blood, will pass to the heart of the nation, whence it will be pumped through the American arteries to all parts of the assimilating body, building up the new America.

Taylor predicted that, before assimilation was completed, the United States would have had "several centuries of frightful indigestion." More seriously, the nation would itself have been fundamentally disfigured. Americans would "scarcely recognize" the nation "because of its Oriental diet, so foreign to our American system," she wrote. An empire of recognition might become unrecognizable to itself. "We will find ourselves Malayed Americans, even as they shall have become Americanized Malays. It remains to be seen how far the change will improve either."

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CHAPTER 5



# New "Oriental Problems," 1900–1918

*Given the rising status of Japan as a world power, Japanese immigrants came to the United States expecting to receive better treatment than the excluded Chinese. But their hopes were dashed. U.S. workers viewed all Asian laborers as a threat to their jobs and standards of living, and they joined with nativists in preventing them from entering the nation. Making matters worse, according to the advocates of Japanese exclusion, was the fear that imperial Japan sought to use immigration as a nefarious means to conquer the United States in order to dominate the Pacific. In this scenario, Japanese immigrants were branded a "silent invasion" and "yellow peril." Such antagonism fueled a movement for Japanese exclusion that relied on many of the same arguments used against the Chinese, and California remained the hub of anti-Asian activity. In 1906, San Francisco officials approved the segregation of Japanese students in the city's public schools in an attempt to discourage Japanese immigration.*

*Leading federal officials opposed the discrimination of Japanese immigrants on the grounds that it was a violation of treaty rights and an offense to a nation with which the United States was on good terms. President Theodore Roosevelt genuinely respected Japan's military successes, especially after its defeat of Russia in 1905. He did not want nativists to damage trade relations in the Pacific or, even worse, to provoke an unwanted war with the formidable island nation. Consequently, Roosevelt tried to resolve the conflict in California through establishing the Gentlemen's Agreement in 1907 by which Japan agreed to restrict laborers from coming to the United States in return for San Francisco scrapping plans to segregate Japanese students. But the immigration of Japanese women and merchant classes, who were not restricted by the Gentlemen's Agreement, pushed the California state legislature in 1913 to discriminate against Japanese by preventing them from owning farmland. President Woodrow Wilson intervened at the behest of Tokyo officials, but to no avail. It took the eruption of World War I in Europe to calm tensions, as the United States and Japan found themselves fighting on the same side.*

*Preventing the immigration of Japanese laborers with the Gentlemen's Agreement created a need for workers along the West Coast that was met in part by immigrants from India. The newcomers followed the Japanese into agricultural labor and small farming.*

*But they too faced hostility from labor and nativist groups, and in some incidents, such as the 1907 riots in Bellingham, Washington, angry white mobs attacked them and drove them from their homes. In 1914, Congress held hearings to discuss the exclusion of Indian immigrants, and three years later sweeping legislation banned immigration from India and almost all of the Asia-Pacific region. In addition, the British government urged U.S. officials to keep close tabs on Indian nationalists, most of whom were students who used the United States as a base to advance the struggle for India's independence from British colonialism. During World War I, eight Indian independence activists were convicted in San Francisco for conspiring to engage in a military plot against British India.*

*Concerns about Asian criminal activity grew during this exclusion era. Foremost were ever-present fears that Asians were being smuggled into the country through schemes run by organized crime syndicates. As a result, immigration officers at West Coast stations like Angel Island placed Chinese newcomers under strict scrutiny as they searched to find false identities. Angel Island became more like a prison than a temporary immigration-processing center for many unlucky Chinese. Meanwhile, exclusionists saw Chinatowns throughout the West as notorious places for gambling, drugs, and prostitution.*

## DOCUMENTS

Documents 1 to 5 concern efforts to exclude Japanese immigrants. Author Jack London wrote Document 1 while serving as a newspaper correspondent for the Russo-Japanese War in 1904. Japan's victory in that war compelled London to alert the West of the potential for a Japanese–Chinese alliance that could menace the world. President Roosevelt dismissed such alarmism, and Document 2 is an excerpt of his State of the Union address in 1906 that extols Japanese civilization while condemning San Francisco exclusionists for irresponsibly damaging U.S.–Japan relations. Note that the president also wants to change the nation's naturalization law to allow Japanese immigrants to become U.S. citizens, a position from which he later retreated. Document 3, written by a leading exclusionist organization, captures the intense anti-Asian animosity that the president sought to defuse by defending Japanese immigrants, while Document 4 provides the perspective of Japanese immigrants regarding the approval of an exclusionist alien land law in California. In Document 5, a prominent Californian publisher compares the state's Japanese population to antebellum black slavery in the South. He argues that the Japanese should be excluded before their population grows and becomes permanent, lest the nation go down the same troubled road of Southern race relations that led to the Civil War, Reconstruction, and the seemingly perpetual oppression of African Americans.

Documents 6 and 7 show two sides of a debate over the exclusion of Indian immigrants, as expressed in a 1914 congressional hearing. In Document 6, an educated Indian immigrant defends the virtues of his community and countrymen, while assuring the committee that they are not Mongolians like the Chinese and Japanese. He also assures the committee that Indians can assimilate and become good Americans without needing to intermarry with whites. In Document 7,

a U.S. immigration official disagrees with the testimony in Document 6, stating that the vast majority of Indian immigrants are uneducated workers who are not able to assimilate into U.S. society. His views are seemingly corroborated by findings from a Canadian report on Indian immigrants.

Documents 8 and 9 address Chinese immigrants. Document 8 consists of two poems carved into the wooden barracks at the Angel Island immigration station by Chinese waiting to learn whether they would be allowed to enter the United States or be returned home. Both poems convey the helplessness and desperation of those held at Angel Island. Document 9 is an editorial, published in Vancouver, British Columbia, that outlines the problems related to gambling in that city's Chinatown. Key here is the editorial's focus on a petition by Chinese merchants that did not protest against their discrimination in as much as it bemoaned the lawlessness by Chinese immigrants. This position is similar to the stances of earlier Chinatown leaders who supported the exclusion of Chinese laborers.

## 1. American Writer Decries the New Yellow Peril, 1904

HERE WE HAVE THE CHINESE, four hundred million of him, occupying a vast land of immense natural resources—resources of a twentieth century age, of a machine age; resources of coal and iron, which are the backbone of commercial civilization. He is an indefatigable worker. He is not dead to new ideas, new methods, new systems. Under a capable management he can be made to do anything. Truly would he of himself constitute the much-heralded Yellow Peril were it not for his present management. This management, his government, is set, crystallized. It is what binds him down to building as his fathers built. The governing class, entrenched by the precedent and power of centuries and ... by the stamp it has put upon his mind, will never free him. It would be the suicide of the governing class, and the governing class knows it.

Comes now the Japanese. On the streets of Antung, of Feng-Wang-Chang, or of any other Manchurian city, the following is a familiar scene: One is hurrying home through the dark of the unlighted streets when he comes upon a paper lantern resting on the ground. On one side squats a Chinese civilian on his hams, on the other side squats a Japanese soldier. One dips his forefinger in the dust and writes strange, monstrous characters. The other nods understanding, sweeps the dust slate level with his hand, and with his forefinger inscribes similar characters. They are talking. They cannot speak to each other, but they can write. Long ago one borrowed the other's written language, and long before that, untold generations ago, they diverged from a common root, the ancient Mongol stock.

There have been changes, differentiations brought about by diverse conditions and infusions of other blood; but down at the bottom of their being, twisted into the fibres of them, is a heritage in common—a sameness in kind

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From Jack London, "The Yellow Peril" (1904), in *London, Revolution and Other Essays* (New York: Macmillian, 1910), 277–289; reproduced in S. T. Joshi, ed. *Documents of American Prejudice* (New York: Basic Books, 1999), 439–444.

which time has not obliterated. The infusion of other blood, Malay, perhaps, has made the Japanese a race of mastery and power, a fighting race through all its history, a race which has always despised commerce and exalted fighting.

To-day, equipped with the finest machines and systems of destruction the Caucasian mind has devised, handling machines and systems with remarkable and deadly accuracy, this rejuvenescent Japanese race has embarked on a course of conquest, the goal of which no man knows. The head men of Japan are dreaming ambitiously, and the people are dreaming blindly, a Napoleonic dream. And to this dream the Japanese clings and will cling with bull-dog tenacity. The soldier shouting "Nippon, Banzai!" on the walls of Wiju, the widow at home in her paper house committing suicide so that her only son, her sole support, may go to the front, are both expressing the unanimity of the dream.

The late disturbance in the Far East marked the clashing of the dreams, for the Slav [Russian], too, is dreaming greatly. Granting that the Japanese can hurl back the Slav and that the two great branches of the Anglo-Saxon race do not despoil him of his spoils, the Japanese dream takes on substantiality. Japan's population is no larger because her people have continually pressed against the means of subsistence. But given poor, empty Korea for a breeding colony and Manchuria for a granary, and at once the Japanese begins to increase by leaps and bounds.

Even so, he would not of himself constitute a Brown Peril, He has not the time in which to grow and realize the dream. He is only forty-five millions, and so fast does the economic exploitation of the planet hurry on the planet's partition amongst the Western peoples that, before he could attain the stature requisite to menace, he would see the Western giants in possession of the very stuff of his dream.

The menace to the Western world lies, not in the little brown man, but in the four hundred millions of yellow men should the little brown man undertake their management. The Chinese is not dead to new ideas; he is an efficient worker; makes a good soldier, and is wealthy in the essential materials of a machine age. Under a capable management he will go far. The Japanese is prepared and fit to undertake this management. Not only has he proved himself an apt imitator of Western material progress, a sturdy worker, and a capable organizer, but he is far more fit to manage the Chinese than are we. The baffling enigma of the Chinese character is no baffling enigma to him. He understands as we could never school ourselves nor hope to understand. Their mental processes are largely the same. He thinks with the same thought-symbols as does the Chinese, and he thinks in the same peculiar grooves. He goes on where we are balked by the obstacles of incomprehension. He takes the turning which we cannot perceive, twists around the obstacle, and, presto! is out of sight in the ramifications of the Chinese mind where we cannot follow....

We have had Africa for the Africander, and at no distant day we shall hear "Asia for the Asiatic!" Four hundred million indefatigable workers (deft, intelligent, and unafraid to die), aroused and rejuvenescent, managed

and guided by forty-five million additional human beings who are splendid fighting animals, scientific and modern, constitute that menace to the Western world which has been well named the "Yellow Peril." The possibility of race adventure has not passed away. We are in the midst of our own. The Slav is just girding himself up to begin. Why may not the yellow and the brown start out on an adventure as tremendous as our own and more strikingly unique?

The ultimate success of such an adventure the Western mind refuses to consider. It is not the nature of life to believe itself weak. There is such a thing as race egotism as well as creature egotism, and a very good thing it is. In the first place, the Western world will not permit the rise of the yellow peril. It is firmly convinced that it will not permit the yellow and the brown to wax strong and menace its peace and comfort. It advances this idea with persistency, and delivers itself of long arguments showing how and why this menace will not be permitted to arise. To-day, far more voices are engaged in denying the yellow peril than in prophesying it. The Western world is warned, if not armed, against the possibility of it.

In the second place, there is a weakness inherent in the brown man which will bring his adventure to naught. From the West he has borrowed all our material achievement and passed our ethical achievement by. Our engines of production and destruction he has made his. What was once solely ours he now duplicates, rivalling our merchants in the commerce of the East, thrashing the Russian on sea and land. A marvellous imitator truly, but imitating us only in things material. Things spiritual cannot be imitated; they must be felt and lived, woven into the very fabric of life, and here the Japanese fails.

It required no revolution of his nature to learn to calculate the range and fire a field-gun or to march the goose-step. It was a mere matter of training. Our material achievement is the product of our intellect. It is knowledge, and knowledge, like coin, is interchangeable. It is not wrapped up in the heredity of the new-born child, but is something to be acquired afterward. Not so with our soul stuff, which is the product of an evolution which goes back to the raw beginnings of the race. Our soul stuff is not a coin to be pocketed by the first chance comer. The Japanese cannot pocket it any more than he can thrill to short Saxon words or we can thrill to Chinese hieroglyphics. The leopard cannot change its spots, nor can the Japanese, nor can we. We are thumbed by the ages into what we are, and by no conscious inward effort can we in a day rethumb ourselves. Nor can the Japanese in a day, or a generation, rethumb himself in our image....

The colossal fact of our history is that we have made the religion of Jesus Christ our religion. No matter how dark in error and deed, ours has been a history of spiritual struggle and endeavor. We are preëminently a religious race, which is another way of saying that we are a right-seeking race.

## 2. President Roosevelt Warns Against Anti-Japanese Racism, 1906

The countries bordering the Pacific Ocean have a population more numerous than that of all the countries of Europe; their annual foreign commerce amounts to over three billions of dollars, of which the share of the United States is some seven hundred millions of dollars. If this trade were thoroly understood and pushed by our manufacturers and producers, the industries not only of the Pacific slope, but of all our country, and particularly of our cotton growing States, would be greatly benefited. Of course, in order to get these benefits, we must treat fairly the countries with which we trade....

Not only must we treat all nations fairly, but we must treat with justice and good will all immigrants who come here under the law. Whether they are Catholic or Protestant, Jew or Gentile; whether they come from England or Germany, Russia, Japan, or Italy, matters nothing. All we have a right to question is the man's conduct. If he is honest and upright in his dealings with his neighbor and with the State, then he is entitled to respect and good treatment. Especially do we need to remember our duty to the stranger within our gates. It is the sure mark of a low civilization, a low morality, to abuse or discriminate against or in any way humiliate such stranger who has come here lawfully and who is conducting himself properly. To remember this is incumbent on every American citizen, and it is of course peculiarly incumbent on every Government official, whether of the nation or of the several States.

I am prompted to say this by the attitude of hostility here and there assumed toward the Japanese in this country. This hostility is sporadic and is limited to a very few places. Nevertheless, it is most discreditable to us as a people, and it may be fraught with the gravest consequences to the nation. The friendship between the United States and Japan has been continuous since the time, over half a century ago, when Commodore Perry, by his expedition to Japan, first opened the islands to western civilization. Since then the growth of Japan has been literally astounding. There is not only nothing to parallel it, but nothing to approach it in the history of civilized mankind. Japan has a glorious and ancient past. Her civilization is older than that of the nations of northern Europe—the nations from whom the people of the United States have chiefly sprung. But fifty years ago Japan's development was still that of the Middle Ages. During that fifty years the progress of the country in every walk in life has been a marvel to mankind, and she now stands as one of the greatest of civilized nations; great in the arts of war and in the arts of peace; great in military, in industrial, in artistic development and achievement. Japanese soldiers and sailors have shown themselves equal in combat to any of whom history makes note. She has produced great generals and mighty admirals; her fighting men, afloat and ashore, show all the heroic courage, the unquestioning, unfaltering loyalty, the splendid

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From Theodore Roosevelt, "Sixth Annual Message," December 3, 1906, in *House of Representatives, Papers Relating to the Foreign Relations of the United States* (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1909), XL.

indifference to hardship and death, which marked the Loyal Ronins; and they show also that they possess the highest ideal of patriotism. Japanese artists of every kind see their products eagerly sought for in all lands. The industrial and commercial development of Japan ... was accepted with gratitude by our people. The courtesy of the Japanese, nationally and individually, has become proverbial. To no other country has there been such an increasing number of visitors from this land as to Japan. In return, Japanese have come here in great numbers. They are welcome, socially and intellectually, in all our colleges and institutions of higher learning, in all our professional and social bodies. The Japanese have won in a single generation the right to stand abreast of the foremost and most enlightened peoples of Europe and America; they have won on their own merits and by their own exertions the right to treatment on a basis of full and frank equality. The overwhelming mass of our people cherish a lively regard and respect for the people of Japan, and in almost every quarter of the Union the stranger from Japan is treated as he deserves; that is, he is treated as the stranger from any part of civilized Europe is and deserves to be treated. But here and there a most unworthy feeling has manifested itself toward the Japanese—the feeling that has been shown in shutting them out from the common schools in San Francisco, and in mutterings against them in one or two other places, because of their efficiency as workers. To shut them out from the public schools is a wicked absurdity, when there are no first-class colleges in the land, including the universities and colleges of California, which do not gladly welcome Japanese students and on which Japanese students do not reflect credit. We have as much to learn from Japan as Japan has to learn from us; and no nation is fit to teach unless it is also willing to learn. Thruout Japan Americans are well treated, and any failure on the part of Americans at home to treat the Japanese with a like courtesy and consideration is by just so much a confession of inferiority in our civilization.

Our nation fronts on the Pacific, just as it fronts on the Atlantic. We hope to play a constantly growing part in the great ocean of the Orient. We wish, as we ought to wish, for a great commercial development in our dealings with Asia; and it is out of the question that we should permanently have such development unless we freely and gladly extend to other nations the same measure of justice and good treatment which we expect to receive in return. It is only a very small body of our citizens that act badly. Where the Federal Government has power it will deal summarily with any such. Where the several States have power I earnestly ask that they also deal wisely and promptly with such conduct, or else this small body of wrongdoers may bring shame upon the great mass of their innocent and right-thinking fellows—that is, upon our nation as a whole. Good manners should be an international no less than an individual attribute. I ask fair treatment for the Japanese as I would ask fair treatment for Germans or Englishmen, Frenchmen, Russians, or Italians. I ask it as due to humanity and civilization. I ask it as due to ourselves because we must act uprightly toward all men.

I recommend to the Congress that an act be past specifically providing for the naturalization of Japanese who come here intending to become American citizens. One of the great embarrassments attending the performance of our

international obligations is the fact that the Statutes of the United States are entirely inadequate. They fail to give to the National Government sufficiently ample power, thru United States courts and by the use of the Army and Navy, to protect aliens in the rights secured to them under solemn treaties which are the law of the land. I therefore earnestly recommend that the criminal and civil statutes of the United States be so amended and added to as to enable the President, acting for the United States Government, which is responsible in our international relations, to enforce the rights of aliens under treaties. Even as the law now is something can be done by the Federal Government toward this end, and in the matter now before me affecting the Japanese, everything that it is in my power to do will be done, and all of the forces, military and civil, of the United States which I may lawfully employ will be so employed. There should, however, be no particle of doubt as to the power of the National Government completely to perform and enforce its own obligations to other nations. The mob of a single city may at any time perform acts of lawless violence against some class of foreigners which would plunge us into war. That city by itself would be powerless to make defense against the foreign power thus assaulted, and if independent of this Government it would never venture to perform or permit the performance of the acts complained of. The entire power and the whole duty to protect the offending city or the offending community lies in the hands of the United States Government.

## 3. Asiatic Exclusion League Argues Against Japanese and Korean Immigration, 1908

WHILE THE AMERICAN PEOPLE ARE BEING CHLOROFORMED BY DIPLOMATIC NEGOTIATIONS, PREPARATIONS ARE MADE TO OPEN THE GATES FOR THE COOLIE HORDES OF THE ORIENT.

Repeated efforts have been made to repeal or nullify the Chinese Exclusion Act.

Powerful influences, both in America and in China, have sought in past years to break down the barriers placed against the Oriental coolie. So far they have failed.

The infamous Foster bill was snowed under by the millions of protests from citizens, sent at the request of the Asiatic Exclusion League; President Roosevelt's message to the last session of the Fifty-ninth Congress, where he recommended the naturalization of Japanese, and threatened the people upon the Pacific Coast with all the power at his command, met with such a storm of protest that it aroused the entire nation.

As a result, the time established policy of the United States Government towards Chinese immigration has been rigidly maintained up to the present time, and promises have been made by the administration at Washington that this same policy would be extended to all Asiatic immigrants.

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From *Proceedings of the Asiatic Exclusion League, 1907–1913* (New York: Arno Press, 1977), 10, 16–19, 22–24.

The Californians especially have accepted these promises in good faith, and behaved exceedingly well. In fact, some of the leading papers in the State have even told us that the entire Asiatic immigration problem was settled and that we really had extended the exclusion policy to all the Oriental people.

But in this firmly rooted security there lurks the greatest danger. The signs which have been displayed from Washington and Tokio within the last few weeks ought to act as danger signals to the American citizens who are standing guard for the Caucasian civilization on the western border of our country.

Secretary Straus recommends, in his report to the President, that the Chinese should be treated under the general immigration laws. That is virtually a recommendation to repeal the Chinese Exclusion Act, although the Secretary of Commerce and Labor denies that such was his intention.

Yet, if Straus' views should prevail every able-bodied Chinese coolie, not a criminal, pauper, or anarchist, or suffering from infectious disease, would have free admittance into our ports.

There are over four hundred millions of them in China, and ten, twenty, thirty, forty or fifty millions would hardly be missed in the Celestial Empire, but they would make themselves felt in America in a manner that no intelligent white man or woman can have any doubt of.

Uncle Sam has a real serious race problem in the South. Is he to have one ten times more aggravated in the West? If the people permit themselves to be chloroformed by promises and diplomatic negotiations, the "yellow peril" will in the future threaten Europe not only from Asia but from America.

Last Saturday, the House of Representatives passed a bill for the greater protection of aliens. It was carried by the vote of the Speaker, as the votes of the members stood 100 against and 100 for the measure on a recapitulation.

We have not seen the full text of this law, but from what has been learned it appears that it is not only an invasion of State rights, but also intended as a club whereby native and naturalized citizens may be kept in subjugation while the Chinese and Japanese swarm and bask in the sunlight of favored nation's treaty rights.

Some day we may perhaps find that if we fail to patronize a Chink or a Jap that we will be indicted by a Federal Grand Jury and thrown into prison; and if your sweet little girl should murmur in protest because she had to sit in school side by side with a courteous, courting Japanese study boy, whose proficiency in the American language manifests itself in the writing of obscene letters, she might run the risk of having the United States marshal drag her off to the dungeon.

Simultaneously with all this comes the news from Tokio that the Mikado's Government has decided to prohibit all immigration of Japanese labor to the main land.

That is nothing new; a similar edict went forth from the Mikado in 1900. There is absolutely nothing binding, not even a treaty agreement. It is simply an announcement by the Nipponese Government of its intentions. However, it should be noted that the Japanese laborers are only prohibited from immigrating to the main land. They can go in hundreds of thousands to our "insular possessions," the Philippines and the Hawaiian Islands, and from these halfway stations

they can readily find a passage to California, Washington or Oregon, and then, there is nothing to stop them from coming in millions by way of Canada and Mexico.

These are among the danger signals that ought to arouse the American people to the peril that is threatening their existence and the fate of their children.

The conquest of a country can be effected more thoroughly by the spade and the hoe than by the sword or the musket.

## 4. Japanese Immigrants Oppose California Alien Land Law, 1913

### The Proposed Land Bills: The Other Side

During the last half century or more the United States has sustained a peculiarly close relation to Japan, for she it was that opened the doors of the Island Empire, introduced her to Western civilization and Christian ideals, and taught her her first lessons of fairness, freedom and equality. She it was that first recognized Japan as a member among the civilized nations and proposed to treat her as such.

In view of these past pleasant experiences and the favorable sentiment of a large part of the American public relative to Japanese affairs, it is almost unthinkable that so many bills of discriminatory nature should be introduced at this session of the State Legislature.

***Misunderstandings***

Without doubt this is largely due to a misunderstanding of the condition of the Japanese in this State. To not a few examples, it has been said that the Japanese congregate themselves in one quarter and do not assimilate. And it has also been said, on the contrary, that the Japanese are unlike the Chinese in that they scatter everywhere. They mix with American people. They go to the public schools. They learn American methods, and are in sympathy with American institutions and ideals. In other words, they become assimilated. These two conflicting theories are working side by side in the support of the proposed measures in Sacramento. Again it is said that the Japanese can live on almost nothing and work very cheaply. On the other hand, we hear that the Japanese are a most extravagant people and demand enormous wages for their services. These two statements are diametrically opposed, but they have been used as the reasons for the Anti-Japanese legislation.

Some claim that the Japanese make money and send it home. Consequently, they are in no way helping American industry and business. At the same time another argument is advanced that the Japanese make money, save it, and invest it in this country: hence certain people fear that they are going to buy up all the land.

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From Japanese Association of America, *The Proposed Land Bills: The Other Side* (San Francisco, CA: Japanese Association of America, 1913).

If one argument is right the other is wrong, but all these conflicting theories and reasons are working side by side to create sentiment against the Japanese. Why? Because there is a great deal of misunderstanding on the part of the American people.

***Misrepresentation***

The amount of land owned and leased by the Japanese in California is frequently greatly overstated. On page 633 of the latest, 1912, report of the State Bureau of Labor Statistics, we find that the total area of farm lands owned by Japanese is only 12,726 acres, cut up into 331 farms and assessed at $478,990. On page 635, we get the town lots so held as 218 in number and assessed at a beggarly $136,955. That is to say, there are 549 separate pieces of land, valued at $615,945. In all the years that Japanese have been coming here—and the number is decreasing—they have not acquired much more than half a million dollars' worth of California land.

Two years ago the State Legislature appointed a special commission to investigate Japanese conditions in California. The report was so favorable to the Japanese that it was suppressed from publication. The recently published Report of the United States Immigration Commission is equally favorable, and is well worthy of a careful study before final action is taken.

***Small Politics***

The real purpose of the proposed anti-alien land bills is clearly revealed editorially in the San Francisco *Wasp*, as quoted in the Los Angeles *Times* of April 20th. (San Francisco *Wasp*): "The ostensible purpose of this alien land law is to prevent Japanese from holding land in California. The real purpose is to create a new agitation and thus galvanize a lot of discredited professional agitators and decayed politicians. The anti-Japanese agitation in California has been kept alive by the efforts of a combination of professional politicians, known as the Anti-Japanese and Korean Society, of which that delectable patriot, Olaf Tveitmoe, has been the nerve center."

These men have been in political life sufficiently long to recognize that the resident Japanese, without the ballot, is a convenient subject for world-wide notoriety in connection with small politics, and further that there would be little political harm to the agitator himself.

***Business Interests Opposed***

Commercial interests are not advanced in this way, and far-sighted business men are opposing such legislation.

A recent United States Customs report shows that San Francisco's exports to Japan for 1912 were $18,182,316 or 33 per cent of the total, and that her imports from Japan were $25,844,698, or 41 per cent of the total.

At a conference of thirty-seven commercial organizations, covering the entire State, including Chambers of Commerce, Boards of Trade, Merchants Associations, etc., held in San Francisco February 20, 1913, action was taken opposing these land bills.

## 5. Californian Insists the Japanese Are a Race Problem, 1913

May 6, 1913.

WHILE IT IS SMALL.

The Columbia, South Carolina, "State" has an editorial on the Japanese question in California in which, while inclined to sympathize with any state on any race question, it tries to make out that the California problem is so much smaller than the South Carolina problem as to be ridiculous. California, according to the "State" has 10,000 Japanese and 2,300,000 white people, while South Carolina has 835,000 negroes and only 679,000 white men. All the negroes in South Carolina are voters, many of them are property holders and all of them have the right to be property holders. They constitute a majority of the whole population of the state. Their rights were given them by the bayonets of national troops, against the will of the white people of South Carolina, and the only reason they do not rule the state today is that South Carolina has managed, by a kind of peaceable secession, to defy the laws and the will of the United States. As compared with this problem the "State" says the California problem is too small to justify California in embarrassing the nation and the other states in their international relations.

Setting aside some errors in figures made by the "State", it still must be conceded that the California problem is insignificant as compared with that of South Carolina. But South Carolina's problem was insignificant once, also. The Chicago fire was once a spark. Every such problem has its small beginning, and some problems can be solved only while they are small. The "State" will not pretend that any solution whatever of South Carolina's problem is possible. It is not possible to solve it by dealing justly with the negroes, or by dealing unjustly with them; by educating them or by keeping them in ignorance; by methods of democracy or of aristocracy. Unanswerable arguments can be made against every possible course in South Carolina now and forever. It is simply and eternally a curse laid on that state by the forefathers who traded New England rum for African slaves and thereby imposed on that section forever a situation which offers no way out, and no way except the choice of wrong ways of staying in.

The very importance of California's problem is that it is now in a condition in which South Carolina's problem was in the sixteenth century, when it began. What would South Carolina now give if it could turn back the wheels of history and decree that the South Carolinans and their Massachusetts allies of three hundred years ago should have done for what was than a small problem what California now demands that the nation do for what is here still a small problem? If we deal with this race question now, our descendants will have no race questions to deal with. If Californians do not deal with it now, they, like, South Carolinans, will leave a race question which their descendants will have to deal with, and against which they will be helpless.

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From Chester Rowell, "While It Is Small," *Fresno Republican*, May 6, 1913.

## 6. Indian Immigrant Claims Group Is Assimilable, 1914

Dr. Bose. Mr. Chairman and gentlemen of the committee, on behalf of this delegation, which has been sent here by the Pacific Coast Khalsa Diwan Society and the Hindustan Association of America, I wish to invite your attention to a few facts on the subject of legislation on Hindu labor immigration. I have often been asked why the Hindus come to the country at all. I wish to say that the Hindus come to this country precisely for the same reason as the millions that come to this country from other countries. To us America is another name for opportunity. We come here to this country because of the opportunities we have for social uplift, intellectual betterment, and economical advancement. If you will pardon a personal allusion, I wish to say that a few years ago I came to this country as a laborer and if I had been in any other country I would not have had the opportunity of education that I have received in this country.

I mention this fact not in a boastful spirit, but to express my appreciation and gratitude for what I have received in this country. I am deeply indebted to it for all that I am. Only a short time ago I was speaking with a gentleman in this city, a high Government official, a gentleman for whom I have great respect, and he stated to me that the Hindus of all people are most undesirable. In the course of the conversation I found out that this gentleman had never studied a page of Hindu philosophy, had never turned over the first page of Indian history, had not the remotest conception of the contribution of India to the world's progress and civilization; and yet this gentleman stated that the Hindus are the most undesirable people in the world. So I am inclined to think that there are other people who have also a good many misunderstandings as to the standing of our people in the world.

Now, in the few moments which you have kindly given me. I wish to take up a few of the principal objections that are raised against Hindu immigration and answer them as well as I can. First, it has been asserted that Hindus undersell the white labor. Now, practically, there is no competition whatever between the American labor and the Hindu labor, because the American laborers are skilled laborers and the Hindus are nearly all unskilled laborers: that is, the Hindus who come here come from the rice fields of India. Now, the economic thinkers ever since the days of Adam Smith and John Stuart Mill down to our own time of Walker, Hadley, and Tostig, all say that there can be no competition between skilled labor and unskilled labor....

Now, it has been contended here that the Hindus are too frugal and too economical. Of course, I am aware of the fact that when we go to church, no matter what church it may be, we are always exhorted by the ministers to be careful and not to be spendthrifts. While we may not be Christians, we always practice these Christian virtues. I do not suppose anybody will criticise us for that. Nevertheless, I wish to say that the Hindus are good spenders. They spend their money in observing the various national festivals. In this country where we have such a step-lively business civilization we have not many festivals, but the Hindus have a good many

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From Sudhindra Bose, in Hindu Immigration, *House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1914).

festivals and they observe them carefully. They cost a good deal of money to observe; in fact, the Hindus suffer from imprudence in this respect. At all events, the Hindus are hospitable entertainers, and only too anxious to spend their money with the people among whom it has been made.

Now, it has been alleged that the Hindus become public charges. Now, Mr. Chairman, that accusation is based upon insufficient evidence, we contend. The Hindus in their personal habits are cleanly people. They bathe every day. Their religion requires them to take two baths a day. My folks at home, even my aged mother who is now nearly 70 years of age, bathe three times a day....

There seems to be a prevalent impression that the Hindus are of the Mongolian race. While I mean no reflection upon members of any other race, I wish to say that of all races the Hindus do not belong to the Mongolians. They are not of Chinese stock. The Hindus belong to the great Aryan family. The authorities on India say that the Hindus are a branch of the Aryan family. Before the great Aryan migration took place in the dim past the ancestors of India and of Europe lived together as members of one family in central Asia. All great thinkers on this subject have accepted that theory....

Now, I am speaking in general terms, but it is absolutely certain that there is no connection whatever between the Mongolian people and the Aryan blood that runs in our veins. It is possibly quite true that many of us who are here in this country have not yet adopted your customs and your institutions. It is quite likely that they are slow in changing their habits and their institutions. Gentlemen, all growth is slow.... You can not expect that they will drop all their habits overnight. But that does not mean that they are not capable of adapting themselves to new circumstances and new environment of living. Many of them have taken to the American way of living.

Again, if you will pardon me for mentioning a personal incident, I will refer to my case. I do not like to speak in the first person, but I think this illustration is just as good as any other, and it is typical. After I came to this country from India, for two years I insisted on wearing my turban and keeping on my beard, and so forth and so on, because I knew no better. For 20 years I had lived that way in India; and how could I change that all of a sudden? It would be nothing short of a revolution; but gradually I laid aside the customs of my country, because I realized that I had come here to do the very best I could do and to mix with the people of this country as best I could....

My training and my education does not permit me to compare myself with other people, because comparisons, as has been said, are always invidious. Nevertheless I will give you the facts. In the first place, the Hindus are entirely different from the Chinese and Japanese in regard to their clannishness. I have attended five or six universities, and, being at the head of a national organization, the Cosmopolitan Club, with four or five thousand members, with a chapter in every country. I have occasion to meet students from all the world, and never have I found a more cosmopolitan student than the Hindu student. I am not bragging: but these are actual facts, and I think the observation and experience of various college professors and presidents will bear me out thoroughly. Wherever you go you will find that the Japanese and Chinese students live together in

one room, but never do you find the Hindu students rooming together. They do not want to do that. If we stay among ourselves we will be liable to speak our own language instead of the English language, and we do not want to do that. I lived in one town where there were three or four Hindu students, and when I went to see them they never returned my visits. They said, "We are getting too much Hinduized: we are getting too much by ourselves. Let us absorb all we can while we are here....

Now, as to racial intermarriages. I do not think it is necessary to say much about that. Think of the Jews who have lived in Europe for hundreds of years and have contributed magnificently to European civilization, and they have never been detractors of European civilization. Of course, in this country there may be a racial prejudice—I do not know—but in India there is absolutely no barrier between a Hindu and an Englishman....

I do contend that assimilation is possible without racial intermixture. We will not try racial intermixture if it is not suitable. It is not our desire, and we do not ask for it, but we do know that those who have married into American families, as quite a few have done, have lived quite happy lives, and their children are a credit to this great nation and to India.

## 7. U.S. Commissioner General of Immigration Says Indian Immigrants Are Unassimilable, 1914

Mr. CAMINETTI. In relation to the able argument presented by Dr. Bose in behalf of his people, particularly his tribute to their good qualities, I will only say that he is possibly talking about a different class of people—a different race of people—from that which is now coming to our Pacific coast; and possibly, also, a different kind of people from those who have gone to British Columbia, because if they were of those of whom the doctor has so eloquently spoken ... possibly there might not be heard any objection here or elsewhere.

From what I know of the Hindu laborers who are in California they do not answer the description given here to-day....

At the time that this question first attracted attention on the Pacific coast of our country, in 1907 and 1908, the situation became acute in parts of Canada. The authorities there took it up in a very determined way; they did not allow politics or political conditions there or elsewhere to interfere with their endeavor to protect the people of British Columbia. One of the leading citizens of Canada, W. L. Mackenzie King, deputy minister of labor, was commissioned by the Governor General of Canada to go to England for the purpose of laying before the English Government the attitude and condition of the people and the dangers existing in the immigration of Hindus to the Provinces of Canada. This gentleman had been selected because of his experience in British Columbia in

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Anthony Caminetti, in Hindu Immigration, *House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1914).

investigating the subject of Hindu, Japanese, and Chinese immigration. By reason of that experience and the information he had thus gained he was peculiarly qualified for the mission. I have his report. All of it should be read in order to understand the question from the Canadian standpoint. Upon his authority I state that the distinguished gentleman's position [Dr. Bose's] is not well taken, because Mr. King speaks after four weeks of continued discussion and deliberation with those who represented the English Government at the very seat of the British Empire, and he came back to Canada and made a report sustaining the Canadian idea and the wishes and aspirations of the people of British Columbia in their endeavor to save their colony from these people.

Some of Mr. King's views and impressions are summarized in the following extracts from said report:

It was clearly recognized in regard to emigration from India to Canada that the native of India is not a person suited to this country; that, accustomed as many of them are to the conditions of a tropical climate, and possessing manners and customs so unlike those of our own people, their inability to readily adapt themselves to surroundings entirely different could not do other than entail an amount of privation and suffering which render a discontinuance of such immigration most desirable in the interest of the Indians themselves. It was recognized, too, that the competition of this class of labor, though not likely to prove effective, if left to itself, might none the less, were the numbers to become considerable (as conceivably could happen were self-interest on the part of individuals to be allowed to override considerations of humanity and national well-being and the importation of this class of labor under contract permitted) occasion considerable unrest among workingmen whose standard of comfort is of a higher order, and who, as citizens with family and civic obligations, have expenditures to meet and a status to maintain which the coolie immigrant is in a position wholly to ignore.

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Whilst effective as a means of restricting a class of immigration unsuited to Canada, it will be apparent that the arrangement as herein set forth is one which finds its justification on grounds of humanity as strong as are the economic reasons by which it is also supported. The liberty of British subjects in India is safeguarded rather than curtailed, the traditional policy of Britain in regard to the native races of India has been kept in mind, and the necessity of enacting legislation either in India or in Canada which might appear to reflect on fellow Bristish subjects in another part of the empire has been wholly avoided. Nothing could be more unfortunate or misleading than that the impression should go forth that Canada, in seeking to regulate a matter of domestic concern, is not deeply sensible of the obligations which citizenship within the empire entails. It is a recognition of this obligation which has caused her to adopt a course which by removing the possibilities of injustice and friction, is best calculated to strengthen the bonds of association with the several parts, and to promote the greater harmony of the whole. In this, as was to be expected, Canada has had not only the sympathy and understanding, but the hearty cooperation of the authorities in Great Britain and India as well.

As a result additional safeguards have been established in Canada leading up to the present restrictive conditions enforced there. With few exceptions and with some modifications all of the British colonies ... had preceded Canada in enacting laws and regulations of that character....

Of course, we do not want to exclude men like Dr. Bose; we do not want to exclude men like that who come from India or elsewhere; but we do want the laborers, the men who are denominated in this country as of the coolie class, excluded for economic reasons. Those are the people that Canada is after. They are practically excluded to-day from Canada, as well as from practically all the British colonies that have been named here to-day.

I come from the Pacific coast, where we have had two race problems which we have had to fight, and the third one about to be thrown upon us out there, and I have known practically and personally the patience of our people in waiting for diplomatic negotiations upon the Chinese immigration question, and I have known practically and personally the patience of our people in waiting....

## 8. Poems Describe Chinese Detention by U.S. Immigration Authorities, n.d. (1910–1930)

Imprisoned in the wooden building day after day,
My freedom withheld; how can I bear to talk about it?
I look to see who is happy but they only sit quietly.
I am anxious and depressed and cannot fall asleep.
The days are long and the bottle constantly empty; my sad mood,
even so, is not dispelled.
Nights are long and the pillow cold; who can pity my loneliness?
After experiencing such loneliness and sorrow,
Why not just return home and learn to plow the fields?

America has power, but not justice.
In prison, we were victimized as if we were guilty.
Given no opportunity to explain, it was really brutal.
I bow my head in reflection but there is nothing I can do.

## 9. Newspaper Issues Alert About Gambling in Chinatown, 1918

### Gambling in Vancouver

When a petition signed by eighteen Chinese citizens is addressed to a Canadian city it suggests something unusual, and this is certainly the case with the appeal recently made to the people of Vancouver by representative Chinese citizens,

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From H. Mark Lai, *Island: Poetry and History of Chinese Immigrants on Angel Island* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1991).

From *The Globe*, May 23, 1918, p. 4.

calling attention to the gambling evil which is said to be in full swing at the present time. The petitioners maintain that Chinatown is a menace to the health and morals of Vancouver, and they appeal for immediate and drastic action to be taken to clean up the Oriental quarters.

The signatories do not mince matters in their petition, as these words clearly show:

> "We must confess that we cannot understand your methods of administering law, which permit our fellow-countrymen to conduct organized gambling dens. They merely laugh at your insignificant fines and the short jail terms imposed by the local courts, and go on again with their law-breaking."

They also say that Chinese merchants and others have already made attempts to bring this matter before the Mayor of Vancouver and the Chief of Police, but, in spite of proofs that open gambling is being carried on, nothing has yet been done to deal with an evil which is said to have gone on to "an alarming and almost unprecedented extent."

Here are some of the facts and figures adduced in support of this urgent appeal:

> "(1) The men employed inside gambling dens, that is, men who give their whole time to the work inside the dens, and who are not otherwise employed in any kind of useful work, number no less than seven or eight hundred.
>
> "(2) Over three thousand Chinese practise gambling constantly in Vancouver alone, many of whom spend all their earnings in this way.
>
> "(3) Many representative Chinese who have given much time to the study of this problem state positively that there are over forty gambling dens in Chinatown to-day, and that many of these have advertisements in their windows for 'fantan' as above stated.
>
> "(4) Within the last few months, we understand from the local Press, many new licenses have been issued by the Attorney-General for Chinese clubs, so-called in order to evade the law, but which in reality are mere make-believe institutions, the same sort of clubs which have ever been notorious violators of the gambling law.
>
> "(5) Numbers of Chinese who, after many years of hard labor, have made good money in Eastern Canada, when they arrive in Vancouver in order to return to China, find the temptations of Pender street so great that they quickly lose every dollar they have earned.
>
> "(6) There are many attendant evils and products of this gambling business, such as idleness, opium smoking, licentiousness, stealing, and even suicides.
>
> "(7) Besides all these, gambling always draws crowds together and holds them in congested centres. Hence the unsanitary housing conditions with their appalling increase of tuberculosis, as reported by the Medical Health Officer of your city, are a direct result also of the gambling evil.

It is clear from these plain statements that a glaring and even gigantic evil is rampant in Vancouver and is ruining the bodies and souls of those who ought to be the objects of our special care. What is needed at once is a thoroughly stringent enforcement of Canadian laws among the Chinese of Vancouver, and at the same time, as the petition so well points out, "the time has arrived when a much greater interest should be taken by the Government of the Province and by the administrators of your city in the social betterment of our people, and that some constructive effort should be made to give the Chinese wholesome means of recreation and entertainment which would take the place of these harmful practices which now occupy their time."

Already the Churches are moving in the matter, and from two independent quarters, representing two of the most important denominations, appeals have come to call public attention in Eastern Canada to this evil. This is a matter affecting the whole Dominion. The urgency of the peril should meet with an instant and thorough response from those who are in authority in Vancouver.

## ESSAYS

In the first essay, Rutgers University, Newark, historian Kornel Chang explains the process of constructing the U.S.–Canadian border as a means to keep Asian immigrants in check during the era of exclusion. The heightened border patrol and surveillance of Asian immigrants existed as one side of a cat-and-mouse game in which the immigrants came up with ingenious plans to evade the policing. The second essay, written by University of Southern California historian Nayan Shah, explores intimate bonds within bachelor societies in which Indian immigrant men interacted with a wide variety of Americans. His description of a sodomy trial reveals both the criminalization of same-sex relations and stereotypes of Indian families as bastions of male authority and female subservience.

### Policing Borders in the Pacific Northwest

KORNEL CHANG

The rising emphasis on border control and surveillance in the Pacific Northwest was fueled by the intensifying migratory links between the North American West and the Asia-Pacific world. In 1907, the Northwest region experienced a record influx of Japanese and South Asian immigrants. From January 1, 1907 to September 12, 1907, more than eight thousand Asian immigrants landed at the British Columbia ports of Vancouver and Victoria, with more than half applying for admission to the United States. Among the Japanese arrivals, almost all were migrating from the recently U.S.-annexed territories of Hawai'i. In search of new sources of overseas labor, Japanese contracting firms in Seattle and

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Chang, Kornel. "Enforcing Transnational White Solidarity: Asian Migration and the Formation of the U.S.-Canadian Boundary." *American Quarterly* 60:3 (2008), 671–696. © 2008 The American Studies Association. Reprinted with permission of Johns Hopkins University Press.

Vancouver imported thousands of migrants as contract workers from the sugar plantations of Hawai'i throughout the course of the year. Seizing on the opening created by U.S. imperial expansion into the Pacific, they generated new global circuits of labor cutting across multiple imperial and national boundaries.

For the Seattle-based Oriental Trading Company, this was a complex, multiple-step process necessitated by an executive order issued by President Theodore Roosevelt several months earlier that elaborated a new form of sovereignty in an attempt to exert control over Asian migrants crossing the empire. It authorized the immigration bureau to refuse entrance to Japanese and Korean laborers whose passports were issued for any destination other than the continental United States. U.S. immigration authorities hoped this would end the practice among Asian laborers of using alternate routes through the empire to enter the country. To circumvent this measure and the new boundaries it delineated, the firm had migrant laborers from Hawai'i first shipped to British Columbia, where they were processed for admission into Canada, and kept in boarding houses in Victoria and Vancouver until runners hired by the company were ready to guide them over the border. This elaborate labor-recruiting scheme brought Japanese migrant laborers from Hawai'i through Canada to different points in the American West where they performed seasonal work in railroad construction, fishing, and salmon canning.

Meanwhile, U.S. immigration officials in Seattle watched this new wave of immigration to British Columbia with concern, predicting quite correctly that many of the new Asian arrivals would attempt to enter the United States surreptitiously via the border. Moreover, they worried that the influx of Japanese and South Asian immigrants would generate public agitation and social unrest, especially among the white working-class, reproducing the tumultuous scenes from twenty years earlier. One U.S. Immigration Inspector warned that

> the number of Japanese and other aliens who are now in British Columbia and the state of public feelings on both sides of the border in this vicinity against these aliens is such that an emergency has arisen, whereby it is absolutely necessary to have additional men appointed, if the border is to be properly guarded." In August 1907, the bureau responded to this threat by hiring six temporary watchmen and forming a border detail led by Immigrant Inspector C.A. Turner. This newly created unit patrolled and guarded the border between Steveston, British Columbia, and Point Roberts, Washington, on a full-time basis....

The problem of Asian migration to the Pacific Northwest evolved into an international crisis with the race riots of September 1907. While anti-Asiatic racism was already a constitutive feature of Northwest borderland culture, it reached, in the words of one Canadian minister, "almost hysterical" proportions by this time. This racial hysteria culminated with upheavals and demonstrations in the borderland cities of Bellingham and Vancouver, occurring within days of each other in September 1907. These hostilities were fueled by the prevailing belief that the dominant social order, founded upon the notion of a "white man's country," was under siege. One British Columbia newspaper played to these racial anxieties and fears when it asked rhetorically: "Are we to have this great big province—a

land virtually flowing in milk and honey—conserved for the best interests of the white British subject—English, Scott, Irish, Welsh, etc.—or must it be given over entirely to the yellow and brown hordes of China and Japan?"...

In Bellingham, tensions between white and South Asian laborers, already simmering for months, finally came to a spectacular head in the first week of September. Incited by sensational newspaper reports and the growing public hysteria over the so-called Hindu invasion, a mob of some four hundred to five hundred white men stormed the quarters of the South Asian community on the night of September 5 and proceeded to perpetrate acts of racial violence. This led to a mass exodus of South Asians from the city: some recrossed the border to the North traveling to Vancouver while others migrated southward to California. The following day, the Asiatic Exclusion League of Seattle sent an ominous letter to President Theodore Roosevelt threatening that "if something were not done soon the agitation started in Bellingham would spread all over the Sound country and massacres of the Eastern aliens were likely."

Two days later on September 7, the Vancouver branch of the Asiatic Exclusion League organized an anti-Asiatic demonstration in the city with the assistance of a number of white labor activists from south of border as well as across the Pacific world. Organizers hailed from Australia, New Zealand, Canada, and the United States. Assembled in front of City Hall, the protesters included about twenty-five thousand people and representatives from fifty-eight labor organizations. During the rally, several of the participants marched into the Chinese and Japanese districts in downtown Vancouver instigating a clash with Asian residents. This small flare up eventually led to several days of intense conflict between white laborers and Chinese and Japanese residents. When the dust finally settled, the Chinese and Japanese in Vancouver sustained tens of thousands of dollars in damages to their homes and businesses and several Chinese and Japanese reported physical injuries.

In an attempt to quell social unrest on the west coast, both the United States and Canada consummated agreements with the Japanese government, known as the "Gentleman's Agreements," which set numerical limits on immigrants coming from Japan. The Japanese government agreed to limit passports to certain categories of people including diplomats, merchants, students, and tourists. The U.S. Gentleman's Agreement became official policy in the summer of 1908 while the Canadian version, also known as the Hayashi-Lemieux Agreement, went into effect several months earlier.

As for the northern border, U.S. immigration officers lobbied for new powers and resources that would change the scale and nature of boundary policing in the Pacific Northwest. Efforts to control the boundary in a more systematic manner began with increasing the size of the border force and positioning them along the international line dividing Washington and British Columbia. Immediately following the riots, U.S. Commissioner-General of Immigration Frank Sargent secured funding for a new team of border inspectors. Sargent instructed the bureau in Washington to "utilize their services in guarding the British Columbia boundary, bending every effort towards preventing the illegal entry of Japanese." Despite this upgrade in border personnel however, local public opinion demanded even further state intervention....

A year after the anti-Asiatic riots and the initial augmentation of the border force, Inspector-in-Charge John Sargent wrote confidently to the commissioner-general of immigration that "the [northern] border is being better guarded than ever before." According to a 1910 roster, the immigration force in the Washington jurisdiction alone consisted of close to fifty full-time Immigrant and Chinese inspectors and border watchmen. To match the increase in the size of the force, the Service also expanded their facilities to include substations in almost every border town along the boundary.

The institutionalization of the border also involved the construction of a dense, state-organized system of surveillance. The bureau established regular contact with numerous government agencies in Washington and British Columbia regarding Chinese, Japanese, and South Asian communities. They also hired mobile informants who toured the borderlands—including Steveston, Vancouver, and Westminster on the Canadian side and Blaine, Anacortes, Bellingham, and the San Juan Islands on the U.S. side—in order to report on the movements and activities of Asian groups. Finally, the Service relied on the eyes and ears of the local population to help monitor the border. As one U.S. immigration inspector reported: "There are several thousand people living in Whatcom County ... many of whom are in possession of telephones and most of whom are willing to give our officers any information they may secure regarding aliens passing their residences or places of business." Similarly, in British Columbia, Canadian immigration authorities sought the cooperation of borderland residents by installing telephones along roads and byways thought to be traveled by illegal Asian migrants. Taken together, they formed an information network that enabled state bureaucrats to put Chinese, Japanese, and South Asian immigrants under surveillance with the objective of restricting their mobility....

The efforts to define and institutionalize the border invariably led to struggles between the state and the Chinese, Japanese, and South Asian immigrants who were intent on maintaining control over their mobility. Asian migrants, whether on their own or with the assistance of professional smugglers and guides, found creative ways to defy the borders and boundaries designed to keep them out. In one scheme, Japanese and South Asian immigrants in Washington State sold their passports to countrymen in British Columbia seeking to enter the United States. Once the Japanese or South Asian immigrant secured entrance, the individual would perpetuate the cycle by selling or circulating it to yet another immigrant across the border:

> Ten Japanese caught at the international boundary line in one week with bogus passports shows the wholesale extent to which coolie laborers of the Mikado's empire are attempting to deceive the United States Immigration department. The favorite system is that of the use of the same passport over and over again. Nine out of the ten men who were detained at the boundary last week and finally refused admittance to the United States confessed that they had been supplied with the passports of Japanese now in the United States. These had been mailed back to Vancouver and were resold at from five to twenty-five dollars each.

One of the more imaginative ploys to gain entry from Canada into the United States involved the complicity of unsuspecting border inspectors. Issei

Izo Kojima recounts how Japanese seeking entry from British Columbia deceived U.S. border inspectors into believing they were residents of the United States. "There were many iron bridges, and those who tried to get into America from Canada thought up many tricks to get across. There was the trick of walking backwards inconspicuously. Sooner or later such a walker would be discovered by the American guards, and when called he would turn around, as if trying to escape from America to Canada."

Border inspectors thinking that the Japanese immigrant was unlawfully crossing the border to Canada would apprehend the suspect and "return" the person to the United States. There was also the use of racial disguise in attempts to surreptitiously cross the border. "When questioned the Oriental gave his name as R. Abe and said he wanted to go to Seattle to look for work. Before crossing the line near Blaine, he smeared his face with grease and blackening, giving him the appearance of a Negro."

Some Asian transients in British Columbia relied on family and kinship networks to make it across the boundary. Take the case of Sahuro Iguchi, who traveled on the transpacific steamship liner "Athenian" and arrived in Vancouver on May 30, 1907. About a month later, he applied for admissions to the United States but was rejected on account of having contracted a degenerative eye-disorder known as trachoma. It is very likely that his intent all along was to immigrate to the United States, but Iguchi probably took the indirect route through Canada to avoid the stricter regulations of the U.S. Immigration Service. Unable to deport him back to Japan, the Service returned him to Vancouver where he received treatment for trachoma. He applied for admissions two additional times in October 1907 and March 1908 and each time U.S. immigration authorities denied him entry based on his medical condition. Desperate to gain entry, Iguchi contacted a friend in Seattle, Nada Tokujiro, "to find some way by which [Iguchi] could enter the United States." Tokujiro sent one Mr. Hashizume to Vancouver with the intention of having him escort Iguchi across the border and into Seattle, Washington. The plan comprised several steps. They took a train from Vancouver to Cloverdale, British Columbia and from there they walked by foot across the international line to Blaine, Washington and spent the night at a nearby hotel. In the morning, they left for Bellingham where they were supposed to take a boat to Seattle; unfortunately for them, U.S. border inspectors apprehended the Japanese migrants before they could complete the final leg of their journey.

Precisely because of cases like this, the U.S. government applied pressure on Canada to modify its immigration standards and regulations to conform to that of the United States. U.S immigration inspectors often complained that the less rigorous inspection standards encouraged Chinese, Japanese, and South Asian immigrants to exploit Canada as a back door into the United States. Eventually, the Canadian Immigration Bureau agreed to end the policy of allowing diseased Asian immigrants to receive treatment in their detention hospitals. In 1909, Canadian immigration authorities began to summarily reject Asian arrivals diagnosed with "loathsome disease" and prohibited them from landing at their ports of entry.

In the Pacific Northwest, professional smugglers and ethnic-labor contractors facilitated the cross-border trafficking of illegal Asian migrants. Prior to the

boundary enforcement buildup in the late 1900s, Chinese, Japanese, and South Asian immigrants could pay a small fee to be navigated across the international line. Native Indians in British Columbia, for example, piloted Chinese and Japanese transients to the United States for as little as three dollars. By 1914, Special Immigrant Inspector Roger O'Donnell testified before the House Committee on Immigration that the Chinese were willing to pay anywhere between one hundred and one thousand dollars to be smuggled into the United States. While inspector O'Donnell may have exaggerated the figures, he was accurate in suggesting that Asian smuggling had become big business in the new era of the border. Noted Asian smuggler George Nelson told authorities that he charged between $125 and $150 per Chinese alien. Working as a fireman for the Great Northern, Nelson concealed his human contraband in the tool box within the engine tender, and once his train made it safely across the border, Nelson delivered the immigrants to a Chinese labor agent in Seattle.

Asian labor contractors contributed to the cross-border flow of illegal immigrants by importing them as workers from across the international line. Labor agent T. Sengoku unknowingly confided to an informant for the U.S. Immigration Service that he had "taken three hundred Japanese across the Border at Blaine" and "placed [them] at work in the state of Idaho in the building of the Great Northern Railway." In the same conversation, Sengoku boasted that "he would be able to get Hindoos across the border without examination provided they were first taken down and put to work on the Canadian side for a few days' time."...

The seemingly intractable problem of Asian migration brought together officials from the United States and Canada who were equally intent on preserving a "White Man's Country."...

A number of U.S. and Canadian bureaucracies including local law enforcement, customs houses, and immigration departments coordinated joint efforts to address the problem of illegal immigration across the border. One U.S. official described the working agreement with Canadian officials to the Congressional Committee on Immigration and Naturalization in 1913. "American immigration officers board boats and examine passengers landing in Canadian ports, join in border patrols, and obtain the assistance of Canadian immigration officers in investigating records of immigrants coming from Canada."

The transnational process of raising the border both reflected and engendered racial ideas and practices in the Northwest borderlands. While the boundary emerged as a barrier to Asian migrants, it remained porous and open to white Euro-Americans and Canadians during this time....

U.S. and Canadian immigration officials stationed in the Pacific Northwest treated the cross-border flow of white Americans, Canadians, and European immigrants mostly with benign neglect and in some cases outright support....

Race also played an important role in the construction of the border on the Canadian side. When designing their immigration and border policies, Dominion authorities in British Columbia considered how they could meet the demands of the labor market without compromising the racial ideal of whiteness. Indeed, they endeavored to attract immigrant laborers, who were essential to economic development and growth, while maintaining a "White Man's Province" at the same time.

In 1908, the Dominion passed what was known as the Continuous Journey Act which barred immigrants not traveling directly from their country of origin. The legislation was a subtle attempt to exclude South Asians, as there was not a single steamship line at the time traveling directly from British India to Canada. However, the act, unbeknownst to those drafting the law, also prohibited Euro-Americans in the United States from entering Canada. Dominion authorities remedied the situation by passing an Order-in-Council allowing non-Asians to emigrate from places other than their country of origin, and in doing, so reopened the border to Euro-American migration while keeping it closed to Asian immigrants.

The Immigration Bureau in British Columbia also implemented more explicit measures in order to promote the migration of "desirable" groups. Immigration authorities, for example, distributed a departmental circular to all boundary inspectors in 1914 encouraging them to allow European migrants from the United States to enter Canada. More specifically, it authorized Canadian inspectors stationed in Washington and other bordering states to issue letters of entry to European immigrants interested in settling in Western Canada....

The intensifying movements and linkages with the Asia-Pacific ... led Canada and the United States to consolidate their respective national-state sovereignty, giving rise to a new emphasis on border policing and surveillance at the turn of the twentieth century. Yet ... delineation of the U.S.-Canadian boundary was neither about drawing rigid lines of division, nor enforcing strict notions of national difference between Canada and the United States. Rather, the process of border formation in the Pacific Northwest was primarily concerned with defining an outer limit against the encroachment of an Asia-Pacific world. North American regimes adopted political, diplomatic, and legal measures to restrict and regulate the transpacific as well as the transborder movement of Chinese, Japanese, and South Asian migrants. This binational effort to systematically control transnational Asian migration involved the construction of transpacific borders—a process that included enforcing an imaginary line between the Asia-Pacific world and the North American West, as well as consolidating a territorial boundary between the United States and Canada.

## Regulating Intimacy and Immigration

NAYAN SHAH

The churning of migrants through Vancouver and Seattle was directly related to the cycles of timber harvesting in locales spread like spiderwebs across the Pacific Northwest. In the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, western North America was not only a site of convergence for global streams of workers but also drew massive capital investment from eastern Canada, the United States, and Europe. Capital investment to build the railroads, roads, and harbors necessary for agriculture and the extraction of natural resources produced the material contours of the social geography of migrants' lives and livelihoods. Railroads

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Shah, Nayan. *Stranger Intimacy: Contesting Race, Sexuality and the Law in the North American West.*
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both brought workers and raw materials together and were sites of social contact. In the Pacific Northwest, men and boys found work in the instant towns that emerged along the main line and spurs of the Northern Pacific Railroad Line, which ran across the northern tier of the United States from Minneapolis–Saint Paul through North Dakota and Montana across the Cascade mountains and joined the line built in the late 1880s that hugged the coast of Puget Sound. The line ran from Blaine at the border with British Columbia, down through Bellingham, Seattle, Tacoma, and Lacey to Centralia and Portland, Oregon. In 1890, the Northern Pacific Railroad extended tracks south from Lacey to Centralia, and a train depot was built in Gate City, which became a thriving railroad center and mill town in the early twentieth century. Young European immigrant men eager for work in the lumberyards of Washington State came from Minnesota and Dakota towns in the early twentieth century. Asian immigrants traveled up and down the railroads of the Pacific Northwest coast looking for work in sawmills and cordage factories. In 1912, South Asian workers who had worked in Portland, Seattle, and Vancouver found work at the Gate City Lumber Company.

The circuit from train depot to bunkhouse was the social terrain that brought Clarence Murray, whose family had migrated from rural Minnesota, and Jago and Bram Singh, who came from India, together in Gate, Washington. On a Sunday afternoon in March 1912, Clarence Murray and his cousins Ed Murray and John McGuire got off the 2:30 passenger train at the depot at Gate. Clarence, nearly eighteen years old, worked at the Gate City Lumber mill for a couple of weeks. Standing at the rail depot, Clarence recognized two co-workers, twenty-three-year-old Jago Singh and thirty-two-year-old Bram Singh, among a group of "Hindu" men standing near the tracks. The two men invited Clarence and his cousins to their rooms to smoke and drink.

Since Gate had a local prohibition ordinance in effect, the men's retreat from the train depot to the bunkhouse was necessary to find a semi-private space to drink. The workingmen in Gate lived in hotels that had been converted to bunkhouses on either side of the railroad tracks, on the outskirts of the township of Gate, about a mile from the center of town. The long narrow buildings were partitioned into small rooms, six feet by six feet, where two men often bunked together. In one of the hotels, one side of the building housed "Hindus" and the other side "white" men. Although such rooms did not, of course, provide the privacy of a middle-class home, they served temporarily as domestic spaces and offered respite from the intrusive attention outdoors at the depot.

That Sunday afternoon, the South Asian and white men were in a revolving circuit of drinking, socializing, fighting, and reconciling, with different men coming in and out of the bunkhouse. Clarence Murray, his cousin Edward Murray and a friend, Clif Chamberlain, went into Bram's room on one side of the tracks. The white men were all from established families in Gate. The communal sharing of alcohol and the social encouragement of intoxication made the encounters between dissimilar males adhesive. The sharing of liquor enhanced social relations, freed submerged desires, and also made interactions between men fractious and violent. Their party broke up when a glass of whiskey broke and Bram chased Clarence out of the room, swearing that he had dropped the glass. Another of

Clarence's cousins, Jack McGuire, came upon the fight outside the "Hindu Camp" at about 3 P.M. Bram Singh was threatening to "lick" Clarence but Jago Singh and Don Singh held him back. In anger, Bram Singh ran off and began picking up rocks on the railroad track and throwing them aimlessly. Jago Singh reassured Clarence of his friendship and invited Jack and the others to their rooms for another drink, saying, "the other fellow couldn't do anything to him." They drank a quart of whiskey over about half an hour; then Jack, Ed and Clif prepared to leave, but Clarence decided to stay behind with the South Asian men. At 4 P.M. Dwight Murray, Clarence's older brother, saw Clarence outside the "Hindu Camp" and spoke with him. "The boy will be all right with me; I am his friend," Jago Singh assured Dwight, and so Dwight left Clarence with them. Dwight remembered that Clarence was "pretty well intoxicated but not drunk."

The men who gathered that afternoon over drinks and conversation saw themselves as social, convivial, passionate, liable to tease and fight, all in the process of "making friends." The intimacy between these strangers was enabled by the curiosity of working alongside one another and living nearby, allowing their social worlds to overlap. The men lived apart in "Hindu," Japanese, and white "camps" or bunkhouses by the depots, and the white single-family houses a half mile away from the tracks materially defined racial difference and spatial boundaries. The combination of liquor, desire, and violence would, however, rock the social gathering hours later.

In the court case that followed, the moral and ethical drama was between South Asian men. Rohmdlla and Aramo, two South Asian men who worked at the Gate City Lumber Company and boarded at the hotel, criticized Jago and Bram Singh's behavior that afternoon and alerted Clarence Murray's relatives to return to the hotel. Rohmdlla and Aramo observed a drunk Clarence Murray "crying" at about 4 or 5 P.M. Aramo claimed that Jago had pushed Clarence "by force," and that Bram had held his hand over Clarence's mouth to stifle any cries. At the court hearing, Aramo, intent to prove his morality and code of homosocial camaraderie, appealed to Bram Singh and Jago Singh "not to commit this crime ... I say it make us too unpopular in this country."

Three hours afterwards, both Aramo and Rohmdlla went to look for Dwight Murray after 8 P.M. in the evening. As Dwight followed the men to the bunkhouse, he met his cousins Ed Murray and Jack McGuire, who joined them in retrieving Clarence from the "Hindu camp." Each of Clarence's kin described discovering Clarence unconscious, partially undressed, and exhibiting telltale signs of sexual assault: "His pants were down, his shirt was pulled up, rolled up pretty nearly to the shoulder blades," and his clothes and body were "oily" and "all doped up with some kind of oil or grease" that seemed to "smell like Vaseline." In the same room, they found Don Singh laying on the bed asleep "with his pants open." While they were getting Clarence together to take him home, Bram Singh stormed in and allegedly yelled, "What the God Dam[n] business you fellows got in here.... Get to hell out of here and go home." They carried Clarence out, and he was vomiting on the way to the Company bunkhouse. Clarence remembered drinking with Jago and Bram, but he had lost consciousness and only could recall the trip back to the company bunkhouse at night. In the trial, the defense attorney

brought no witnesses, and the jury swiftly returned a verdict of guilty of sodomy against Jago, Bram, and Don Singh.

P.L. Verma, who had served as a translator for part of the trial, orchestrated a campaign for clemency for Don Singh. In addition to raising questions about court procedure and unreliable eyewitness accounts of Don Singh's presence at the scene of the assault, Verma offered the Parole Board an explanation of the sexuality and morality of "Hindoo" men. Verma attempted to reframe the prosecution of Don Singh, which relied upon guilt by association and proximity to the passed-out victim, to redeem Don's reputation. Verma characterized sodomy as a "great and unnatural sin among Hindoos" and it was unlikely that "a good Hindoo citizen is addicted of that habit." He quickly set aside the disturbing affronts to white masculinity by the revelations of South Asian men sexually penetrating a white male to focus on the status and behavior of the one married man in their company. Verma defined a "good Hindoo citizen" as a religious observant, married man. Marriage was a deterrent to the "addictive habit" of sodomy: "Don Sing[h] is married and married men do not like things like that, they are never addicted to such unnatural habits. They have to look far into the future. They are tied down by the weight of marriage." Verma presented exemplary "Hindoo" married men as possessing sexual self-restraint and monogamous morality, much like the images of respectable white American manhood. The practice of sodomy was coded as a habitual practice that could be addicting for the unmarried man whose unregulated behavior was ruled by irrational passion. Verma produced a moral code for married male migrants, for whom future responsibilities at home loomed large, that contained injunctions to avoid the entanglements, distractions, and costs of transitory sexual encounters. The imperative against sodomy was less about steadfast heterosexual preference than about the need for containment within and for marriage and the legitimate progeny that it would produce.

Verma skillfully marshaled compassion for Don Singh and his predicament and invoked a sympathetic hearing for Don's wife, including a letter from her to bolster the appeal for his parole, in which she wrote, "Life to me is not worth living, I have no body to support me." The pitiful wife was an archetype; her letter was translated for the parole board, but she was never named except as Don Singh's wife, his dependent. However, the success of the appeal to pity and compassion necessitated that she appear to be a worthy and helpless dependent.... In his letter, Verma emphasizes the wife's "miserable condition" and her "cries for help," because she is without means of male support and will become destitute. Don Singh's "misfortune ... has fallen on her head. She will ... starve to death unheeded, if no steps are taken for granting Don Singh his liberty." She feared that his case was "hopeless" and his imprisonment could last twenty years. Her letter articulated both despair and powerlessness, inviting the assistance of the empowered, both Verma's advocacy, and the parole authorities' sympathetic judgment....

Verma's campaign for Don Singh was enhanced by the sympathetic portrait of the pitiable wife as well as by the rehabilitation of Don's public reputation. Verma enlisted testimonials from Don's white employers and landlords in Portland, who praised him as an "honest, well-behaving gentleman" and a "trustworthy,"

"reliable and industrious" worker with a gentle, unassuming disposition. Twenty men, who had signed their names in either Punjabi or English, endorsed a petition of the "Hindoos of Portland" for Don Singh, drafted by Verma. The petition characterized Don Singh as "always a law-abiding citizen," "from a good family," and possessing "temperate habits."

These qualities of honesty, temperance, and industriousness were certainly values that the warden and parole board would uphold as evidence of Don Singh's character. However, the petition of his friends also revealed Sikh communitarian values that may for them have demonstrated a different vision of his humanitarianism. His friends considered Don Singh to be a devout man, who worshipped regularly and was considered a "missionary" for the charitable work he did. His generosity was legendary in his community in Portland, and he was known to help others financially in times of distress. The support of the community of South Asian laborers and Singh's employers in Portland created a credible portrait of a civic-minded and responsible immigrant in the United States and became crucial to Don Singh's appeal. The other two men who were convicted, Bram Singh and Jago Singh, had no such local support in Gate, Portland, or elsewhere.

The final and perhaps most crucial element in making Don Singh a subject for compassion was the assessment prison authorities made of his advocate, Verma. Certainly, Verma's English education and resourcefulness in soliciting and collecting testimonials, creating petitions, and meeting with the prison warden, Reed, made such an appeal strategically plausible.... In addition to his formal dress and respectfully articulate communication, Verma demonstrated his sentiments of justice and equity. In the florid conclusion of his appeal, Verma invoked the ideals of "American Justice ... Equality and Brotherhood" to win the intercession of the warden, whom he personally thanked for his "kind and philanthropic *[sic]* words that you love our nationality just as you love your own. Your words that Hindoos are treated by you as brothers still ring in my ears." The rhetorical invocation of American justice and cross-national brotherhood to dislodge racial antipathy appears to have assured the warden of Verma's integrity and shared values. If Verma could be trusted, then perhaps the warden and parole board could identify with the plight of Don Singh and his wife.

The moral empathy generated by Don Singh's good character and the pitiful condition of his incredulous wife in India may have loosened the suspicions of the warden and parole board about the trial testimony. Their decision was not based on Don Singh's character or Verma's sentiments, however, but on other legal criteria that Verma presented that disputed Don Singh's purported role in the crime. The board reflected on the conspicuous absence of eyewitness testimony that placed Don Singh in the bunkhouse room when the two other South Asian men were explicitly identified. Don Singh's participation in the crime had been implied because police had discovered him sleeping in the same room in which the unconscious "white victim" was found. The sympathetic treatment that Don Singh received from the prison warden and the parole board did not disrupt the judicial certainty that Clarence Murray had been sodomized, nor did it temper the conviction of Jago Singh and Bram Singh. In 1913, the Prison

Board determined that there was grave doubt that Don Singh had been present at the commission of the crime, and on October 14, Washington State Governor Ernest Lister commuted Don Singh's five-year sentence, of which he had served eighteen months.

Verma had succeeded in winning Don Singh's parole by casting the abstract category of "Hindu marriage" as producing moral and respectable manhood and then offering the canvas of Don Singh's public character as exemplary. Verma analogized the Hindu married man as the serial copy of the white (Christian) married man. He characterized such an individual as steadfastly faithful, circumspect, and responsible: a "good family man." The sympathetic judgment for Don Singh also protected the reputation of South Asian married men generally. His status as a married man offered Don Singh an alibi of respectable sexuality and morality. The power of "sympathy and morality," as Amit Rai has shown, both created and targeted the "heterosexual family" for compassionate assistance. It distinguished him from the two unmarried men, whose convictions were not in doubt. In rallying to support Don Singh, South Asian men in Portland distinguished reputable, moral men from disreputable men by ignoring the other two convicted men and disparaged the honesty of the South Asian eyewitnesses for falsely implicating Don Singh. Verma was able to present a unified reputation for Don Singh by emphasizing his personal commitment to his wife and his charity among his peers.

Verma's successful campaign enabled Don Singh to recover the property of a public self—his reputation. Singh's reputation was tied with the responsibilities of his overseas marriage and its demands of moral rectitude. His reputation's rehabilitation enabled the review of his conviction and his freedom from imprisonment. The public status of a married man, however, was contingent and uncertain in Singh's experience as a migrant laborer whose wife lived in India. In his file at the Washington State Penitentiary, there is a 1930 FBI report that catalogues a litany of public drunkenness and disorderly conduct convictions in Washington, Oregon, and California during the 1910s and 1920s. The spellings of the name of the man are different, but the FBI has catalogued them all as the same Don Singh who received clemency for a sodomy conviction in 1913....

The efforts by Verma to defend Don Singh and reclaim his married man's honor from lurid allegations and circumstances did not blunt the broader suspicions of South Asian unmarried men, and in particular Jago Singh's and Bram Singh's convictions. The campaign for Don Singh's clemency dissented against the overwhelming representation of South Asian immorality, but its horizons were limited. It did not directly contest hierarchies and in fact reinforced the public status hierarchies of married men over unmarried migrants. For Don Singh, the ensemble of his marriage, his suffering wife, and testimonials as to his spiritual devotion, piety, and charitable service provided a shield against suspicions of improper behavior. Verma's intercession to rehabilitate the reputation of Don Singh placed "Hindu" married men alongside Christian American men by challenging blanket suspicions of the immoral "Hindu sodomite." However, it could not completely dislodge police aspersions of interracial association with probable immorality and perversion.

In Gate during the 1910s, the police, immigration authorities and bystanders observed and acted upon interracial encounters in a spatial borderland where transient male workers converged....

The documented testimony in police court records reveal the texture and spaces of inter-ethnic social life, ranging from casual conversations begun in streets and alleys to bars, tram stations, and railroad depots. Public encounters and visibility enabled the street politics of public life. Men swiftly moved socializing from the streets to rented rooms, bunkhouses, and workers' shacks. These spaces were the settings for casual, fortuitous, and dangerous encounters between men and boys of different ethnicities and ages.

Through these encounters between strangers, South Asian migrants forged intimate possibilities around plural masculinities to engage in public life. They negotiated and assessed honor, reputation, authority, and strength in developing relationships between men. However it was social practices that gave the relationships substance. Men engaged in practices of gift-giving, visiting, mentorship, and sharing interests. Their forms of exchange encompassed buying drinks and their visits to bunkhouses and rooms, sharing observations and opinions, and transacting business deals. However, the exchange of money between working males became flagged as illicit transactions of hustling and prostitution. The jostling and confrontation of plural masculinities generated expressions of affection, friendship, care, and camaraderie in tension with feelings of distrust, duplicity, hostility, manipulation, and force. Males on the ground judged the ethics, conscience, and intentions of their peers. Court cases were rife with mens' and boys' assessments of trust, injustice, improper sex, violence, and fraud, with claims of robbery, extortion, duplicity, and entrapment, as well as companionship and sexual advances welcomed or rebuffed. The variety of social dependencies reinforced the fragility of male autonomy and the necessity of interdependence for survival.

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CHAPTER 6



# Politics Between the World Wars, 1918–1937

*After World War I, Asian immigrants experienced renewed hostility fueling vigilante violence, discrimination, and the push for exclusion. The Japanese remained the main focus of attention. In 1920 California strengthened its alien land law, and in 1924 Congress overrode the Gentlemen's Agreement by enacting Japanese exclusion through banning the entry of "aliens ineligible to citizenship." Two Supreme Court cases that sought to win naturalization rights for Asian immigrants failed as the Court upheld the nation's discriminatory naturalization law that left Asians as the only racial group barred from citizenship. The first Supreme Court case concerned a Japanese immigrant, Takeo Ozawa, while the second one focused on an Indian immigrant and World War I veteran Bhagat Singh Thind. The Court held that Ozawa, despite his assimilation to American norms and standards, was not a member of the "white race." In Thind's case, it ruled that while contemporary science viewed Indians technically as "Caucasian," the average American did not.*

*Closing the gate to Japan in 1924 was part of a program of comprehensive immigration reform that capped total immigration to the United States at 150,000 per year, a figure less than 12 percent of the roughly 1.3 million who had come during the peak year of 1907. Congress assigned every nation in the world an immigration quota, which varied depending upon the percentage of its people in the United States in 1890. This date was chosen to lower the allowable number of "new immigrants" from southern and eastern Europe. So while the national origins system excluded Asians entirely, it also discriminated against others who did not meet the white, Anglo-Saxon, or Protestant standard.*

*The one exception to Asian exclusion was U.S. imperial subjects from the Philippines. Filipinos, too, were ineligible for U.S. citizenship, but they were not subjected to exclusion per the 1924 Immigration Act because technically they were not "aliens." The United States followed the precedent that allowed colonial subjects free access to the metropolitan center of the empire known as the "metropole." As a result, Filipino migration began amid the long controversy over excluding the Japanese, as growers in Hawai'i and on the West Coast looked for alternative sources of labor. After 1924, Filipinos*

*became the main source of Asian workers. They also generated the same fears of Asian invasion that had targeted Chinese, Indian, and Japanese immigrants. In 1934, during the Great Depression, Congress granted independence to the Philippines (to begin ten years hence). In exchange for their country's freedom, the leaders of the Philippines agreed to the immediate exclusion of Filipino immigrants from the United States, which, to the leaders, was a small price to pay for independence. Thus Filipinos were excluded in 1934 when the timetable for independence began. Not long afterward, Congress sought to return unemployed and destitute Filipino residents in the United States to the Philippines through a repatriation program designed to lessen the burden on Depression-weary welfare agencies. This program failed as the vast majority of Filipinos opted to remain in the United States.*

*The expression of anti-Asian racism between the world wars stimulated opposition by a critical mass of educated white Americans. The leading edge of social scientists between the world wars rejected race-based science, and this allowed them to see Asians as capable of assimilation and thus able to become good Americans. Moreover, internationally minded Americans sought to overturn Japanese exclusion in order to prevent U.S.–Japan tensions from boiling over into a disastrous war in the Pacific.*

## DOCUMENTS

The multiethnic workforce in Hawai'i derived from the plantation owners expertise at dividing workers by ethnicity to exact more work and lower pay. The Great Strike organized in 1920 sought to overcome the divide-and-rule strategy as Japanese and Filipino workers joined forces against plantation bosses. Document 1 is a report written by an organization for the striking workers, while Document 2 provides a different view of race relations in Hawai'i in which the author, U.S. Official William Atherton Du Puy, praises the harmonious mixture of races in the islands as a positive indication of Hawai'i statehood.

Documents 3 to 8 focus on the issue of immigration exclusion. Document 3 presents perspectives on Japanese immigration written by prominent white Americans in response to a questionnaire sent by business leaders in Tokyo. The document reveals a diverse set of reasons for their supporting of Japanese exclusion and, in some cases, for opposing it. Document 4 is the U.S. Supreme Court decision regarding Bhagat Singh Thind, which upheld Indian immigrants' ineligibility for U.S. citizenship despite the Court accepting the scientific consensus that they are of the Caucasian race.

Documents 5 and 6 turn to the question of Filipino exclusion as debated at a congressional hearing in 1930. In Document 5, V. S. McClatchy, a prominent California exclusionist, testifies that the peoples on the West Coast fear Filipino immigrants in the same way they feared Japanese immigrants. He also alerts the committee to the sexual threat Filipino laborers pose to white women. McClatchy's push for exclusion took place in the shadow of the Watsonville Riots, in which a mob in Watsonville, California, angered by labor competition with Filipinos and intimate relations between Filipino men and white women, ransacked Filipino residences and killed one man. Document 6 is a congressional

testimony by Manuel C. Briones, member of the Philippines House of Representatives, who argues against the rationale for exclusion made by Californians like McClatchy and contained in the proposed legislation (Welch bill).

Document 7 is a request by Filipino immigrants for Congress to offer free passage back to the Philippines as a source of aide during the Great Depression, when there were few jobs and harsh anti-Filipino sentiment. While the repatriation program, to exclusionists like McClatchy, operated as deportation in disguise, this document underscores the degree of desperation that many Filipinos endured during this time.

## 1. Laborers Report on Hawai'i Sugar Strike, 1920

We are laborers working on the sugar plantations of Hawaii.

People know Hawaii as the paradise of the Pacific and as a sugar-producing country, but do they know that there are thousands of laborers who are suffering under the heat of the equatorial sun, in field and in factory, and who are weeping with 10 hours of hard labor and with a scanty pay of 77 cents a day?

Hawaii's sugar! When we look at Hawaii as the country possessing 44 sugar mills, with 230,000 acres of cultivated land area, as a region producing 600,000 tons of sugar annually we are impressed with the great importance of the position which sugar occupies among the industries of Hawaii. We realize also that 50,000 laborers who, together with their families number about 160,000, are a majority of the total population of 250,000 in Hawaii. We consider it a great privilege and pride to live under the Stars and Stripes, which stands for freedom and justice, as a factor of this great industry and as a part of the labor of Hawaii.

We love production. Fifty years ago, when we first came to Hawaii, these islands were covered with ohia forests, guava fields, and areas of wild grass. Day and night did we work, cutting trees and burning grass, clearing lands and cultivating fields until we made the plantations what they are to-day. Of course, it is indisputable that this would have been impossible if it were not for the investments made by the wealthy capitalists and the untiring efforts of the administrators. But we believe that the impartial public will not only magnify and praise the efforts of the capitalists, but will not hesitate to recognize the work of the laborers who have served faithfully with sweat on their brows. We are faithful laborers who love labor and production.

Look at the silent tombstones in every locality. Few are the people who visit these graves of our departed friends, but are they not emblems of Hawaii's pioneers in labor? Turn your eyes to the ever diligent laborers. They are not beautiful in appearance, but are they not a great factor of Hawaii's production?

We are faithful laborers, willing to follow the steps of our departed elders and do our part toward Hawaii's production. We hear that there are in Hawaii over a hundred millionaires, men chiefly connected with the sugar plantations.

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From Hawai'i Laborers' Association, "Facts About the Strike on Sugar Plantations in Hawaii," in House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization, *Labor Problems in Hawaii* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1921).

It is not our purpose to complain and envy, but we would like to state that there are on the sugar plantations which produced these fortunes for their owners a large number of laborers who are suffering under a wage of 77 cents a day.

When asked, "What is a laborer?" a certain plantation manager is said to have replied, "A laborer is an ignorant creature." We do not wish to believe such a statement, but when we look back over our own experience in Hawaii we regret to state that the above fact [of prejudice against laborers] is undeniable.

Impartial and just ladies and gentlemen, we are laborers working on the plantations of Hawaii. Certain capitalists may regard us as ignorant creatures, but as laborers working seriously and faithfully we wish it understood that we are willing to do our part toward Hawaii's production and welfare the best we know how, hoping for the progress of civilization and endeavoring to safeguard justice and humanity as members of the great human family....

## The Demands—Resolutions of the Assembly of Representatives

1. The wages of common man laborers, which at present are 77 cents per day, shall be increased to $1.25, and those of the higher-salaried men shall be increased in proportion:

And minimum wages for women laborers shall be fixed at 95 cents per day:

However, it is to be understood that the present bonus system shall be retained with changes hereinafter mentioned, and same to be paid in addition to the wages already mentioned above.

2. The present bonus system shall be changed in the following particulars, viz:

(*a*) That the principal of the bonus system shall be made so that the laborers may claim the same in court of justice as of right if it is not already so.

(*b*) That all men laborers who shall work 15 days or more and all women laborers who shall work 10 days or more per month, shall be entitled to the bonus; and that all cane-growing contractors who may be employed by the plantations to do work for them, shall be paid their bonus irrespective of number of days they work for the plantations:

(*c*) Seventy-five per cent of bonus shall be paid to laborers every month, the remaining 25 per cent to be retained by the plantation to be paid at the end of each bonus year: *Provided, however,* That whenever the laborers shall leave the plantations because of their intention of returning to Japan, or change of place of work, or of discharge, they shall be paid at once the whole remainder of the bonus, which has been so retained.

3. Eight hours shall constitute a day's work, with the wages and bonuses hereinabove mentioned.

4. Women laborers shall be excused from their work for two weeks before and six weeks after their delivery [childbirth], during which time, however, they shall be entitled to their wages and bonuses as if they were actually at work.

5. For work on Sundays, legal holidays, or overtime services the laborers shall be paid double their regular wages and bonuses.

6. Regarding the cane-growing contract, it is requested that the same be so changed, after deducting the marketing expenses, that the share of companies shall be 40 per cent and that of the planters shall be 60 per cent of the gross value of the market price of sugar.

7. That the price of cane paid to the cane-growing contractors be increased in proportion to the increase of wages and bonus as outlined hereinabove.

8. That the planters shall further improve the provisions made for the health and amusement of laborers.

## Resolutions Submitted to Planters' Association

The assembly of the representatives of Japanese laborers, which passed the above resolutions, submitted the same, accompanied by a letter, to the planters' association on December 4, 1919, through a delegation consisting of one representative from each island. It should be remembered that similar demands were also presented to the same association by the Filipino Laborers' Union on the same day.

It was our firm belief that a request so moderate in its nature as the one above referred to would naturally be accepted by the planters' association. This belief we held not without reason, for words and actions of the various plantation managers revealed in unofficial manner, the assurances that the demands would he accepted. But, contrary to our expectation, the annual meeting of the Hawaiian Sugar Planters' Association resulted in the total rejection of our demands, excepting that single clause relating to the bonus system.

It was an unexpected issue. However, we were not entirely disappointed. Believing that an honest explanation of our situation would cause our sincere desires to be acknowledged, we again submitted a similar request with the following reason in support of it on December 27, 1919.

## Reasons in Support of Request for Higher Wages, Shorter Hours, etc., for Plantation Laborers of Hawaii

There is something astonishing in the price movement of living staples. In order to ascertain what effect the present high prices have had upon the life of the plantation laborers, our federation has chosen 45 articles of provisions, clothing, and kindred commodities, and has investigated the retail prices thereof. We find that the highest has increased as much as 207.70 per cent and even the lowest 40 per cent, averaging an increase of 115 per cent as compared with normal prewar prices....

*Incomes of laborers.*—Now, turning to the incomes of laborers at the present time, men earning $20 per month are common and there are not a few who are working at 77 cents per day. Of course there is a bonus which increases quite materially their earnings. But the bonus is not sufficient to supply the discrepancy

between the increased cost of living computed at prewar rates and the low present wages. And for those who, from sickness or other reasons, can not obtain the benefit of the bonus, their difficulty is still more emphasized.

A laborer's wage should be sufficient to support him and his family in decency and in comfort. Only so can his physical energies be reasonably conserved. But a mere existence or subsistence is not enough, and the laborer who must spend his entire earnings for living expenses is insufficiently paid. There should always be available a reasonable margin of earnings in excess of necessary expenses to set aside as an insurance fund to provide against the hazards of misfortune and the approach of old age. To provide less than this for a laborer is to place him in a class beneath the beasts of burden which are used on the plantations, and to treat him with less consideration than is accorded to a working mule. The latter beast, whether from motives of selfishness or of humaneness, is fairly certain of not only adequate support during his working career, but of a humane provision for his needs when old age or accident shall have incapacitated him for further service. But where, let us ask, in the wages scale as now existing, can the plantation laborers in Hawaii find a guaranty or even a promise of provision for his maintenance when age or misfortune shall have placed a period upon his earning capacity? His condition in this respect compares unfavorably with that of the beasts of burden now in use upon your plantations. But if the laborer from the inadequate wage now in vogue should nevertheless endeavor to set aside something, even a trifle, each month to assist in such provision for the future, he can do so only at the sacrifice of his comforts, necessities, and even features of decency, of which he should not, upon grounds of morality and justice, be deprived. In short, then, and to epitomize the present situation, the plantation laborer is enabled to exist but not to live and support those dependent upon him in any just and reasonable sense of those terms.

## 2. American Official Extols Race Relations in Hawai'i, 1932

In continental United States the fundamental American stock has usually absorbed those elements that were introduced, except the Negro, and in the end they have become not noticeably different from it. In Hawaii, where the old American stock constitutes but some 6 per cent of the whole, this will, of course, be impossible. Here it would seem that there ultimately must be a fusion, and that in the end the Hawaiian-American will be a composite of all the peoples who have settled here as permanent residents. Careful examinations of these fusions by specialists at the University of Hawaii have refuted the old theory that unions of these unlike races produce inferior individuals. Careful mental and physical tests have shown that the results of these racial crosses come very near approximating a mean that is halfway between the two parents. So it seems safe to conclude that the ultimate

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United States Government Printing Office, Washington, D.C., 1932

Hawaiian-American will come to rest at a point that represents the mean of the blood in his veins. On the basis of the present populations he, therefore, will be something near one-third Japanese, one-fifth Filipino, one-ninth Portuguese, one-tenth Hawaiian, one-twelfth Chinese, one-fifteenth Anglo-Saxon, with a sprinkling of Korean, Puerto Rican, and what-not. This American will be some seven-tenths oriental, two-tenths occidental, and one-tenth Polynesian. He will be about as swarthy as a Sicilian, straight-haired, stocky, physically fit, industrious, efficient, athletic, vain, dressy, given to gambling. His women will be known around the world for a peculiar beauty found no place else.

One very remarkable educational fact already has been quite fully demonstrated through more than three decades of the exposure of the sons and daughters of these oriental cane-field workers to the influences of the American school. They acquire education with a facility that lags little, if any, behind children of the white races. Almost none of the barefooted parents of these youngsters had known anything at all of education, even in their own languages. Transplanted to the land of opportunity, however, they were anxious that their children should take advantage of all the opportunities that presented themselves. It was the old story of downtrodden peoples, long denied such advantages as America offered, and, therefore, when they were presented, more appreciative of them than the native born. The children of Chinese and Japanese particularly never miss the opportunity for an hour in school, and spare no whit of drudging application to master whatever is taught there.

Among the psychologists there long have been two theories as to the inheritance of intelligence. One school has considered that the individual is the heir to the culture and the capacity of the race from which he comes, and that his mental capacity is directly inherited from those who have gone before him. Race traits and peculiarities would thus come down from father to son. Another school holds that these capacities are a result of environment, and that if a Fiji baby were taken at birth and brought up in a Back Bay Boston family its chance of making a scholastic record in Harvard would be as good as that of the child honestly born of this same family.

The first of these theories would not offer much to the coolie's son, born in the laborer's cottage by the sugar mill. The tests at the University of Hawaii tend to add weight to the latter contention. These children of contract laborers who had remained beaten, suppressed, unbelievably poor, through the centuries in their native lands, who had known only unremitting toil, bloom out in the public schools of Hawaii, pass readily through the high schools, go on to the university, and meet the psychological tests as well as do the blonde sons of Nordics whose ancestors have been educated since Chaucer. Japanese, Chinese, Hawaiian, and Anglo-Saxon youngsters show capacities for study and the acquisition of knowledge that come so near being on the same level that the differences are of little importance....

So the population status in Hawaii to-day is something like this: The introduced laborers and their families live on the sugar and pineapple plantations in company houses. There are 105,000 of them on sugar plantations alone.

Families have individual cottages, and bachelors live in group houses. These are likely to be scientifically worked-out units, and have running water, lights, and fuel free of charge. There is a hospital on each plantation, and medical care costs nothing at all. I stopped at one of these hospitals one day and a young surgeon showed me a bright little Japanese baby, son of a laborer, that he had just brought into the world, with no charge for the service, by the Cæsarean operation route....

White men are comparatively more numerous in the towns but still in an inconspicuous minority. Practically all the tasks from the operation of the garage to the collection of the taxes are carried on by nonwhites. When the militia turns out for drill, for example, Chinese, Japanese, Hawaiian, Portuguese, and white types will be indiscriminately mixed. I listened one night to a Chinese top sergeant explaining the mechanism of a machine gun to his squad in language which to me smacked of the Philadelphia water front. Japanese girls make excellent maids and run many a household in Honolulu. For the sake of local color they are often required to wear Japanese clothes. The visitor may make the mistake of talking pigeon English to these young women but is likely to be answered in the perfect speech, quite without any accent, of the high-school graduate....

There is much talk in the continental press of race antagonisms in Hawaii. This talk is based on a lack of understanding of the relations between the races over there. In the States race conflicts and race prejudices are often intense. In the islands they are practically nonexistent. The masses are of a common, lowly, and unpretentious origin. The whites through a century have felt sympathetic toward them. The social question of race has never been raised. It does not exist. It is never raised except by some outsider who brings his prejudices with him or some continental newspaper which bases its interpretation of events in Hawaii on race prejudices that exist where it is published.

If this outsider had an appreciation of the beauty of the interracial relations of these islands he would hesitate long before taking any step that would interfere with them. Race prejudice is a mad, intense, unreasoning thing, and arousing it where it does not exist is an act as malicious as the introduction of the plague.

There is much apprehension lest groups in Hawaii based on race should come into political dominance. No tendency of this sort has yet developed, but active minds conjure up possibilities. It has not been shown that such groups, if they came into dominance, would not provide satisfactory government. It can hardly be argued, under the American form of government, that, as a majority, they would not have the right to rule. And all that any of these groups know of government is based on the American model.

It is a part of the beautiful experiment, here in the mid-Pacific, that self-government is to be tried out under conditions and with human material that is new. There is nothing so far to indicate that the experiment will not turn out to be as successful as it is interesting. America, obviously, should have sufficient courage to see to a conclusion her most novel venture in that type of government which she originated.

## 3. Americans Provide Diverse Perspectives on Anti-Japanese Racism, 1922

### Answers to the First Question

*Question: "What do you consider the principal reasons of the present anti-Japanese agitations in California: are they economic, social, or racial?"* ...

1. MR. MILTON H. ESBERG, San Francisco, Cal.:

"Anti-Japanese agitation in California is largely due to the non-adoption of American standards of living, working, and working hours, together with the fact that there seems to be no discrimination on the part of the Japanese as to whether the men, or the women do the work, as the same basis seems to apply for both sexes." ...

2. PRESIDENT TULLY C. KNOLES, San Jose, Cal.:

"I have lived in California for thirty-three years and my judgment is that the principal reasons for the present anti-Japanese agitation in California are political. I do not think that the economic situation is so serious as it is set forth by the [anti-Japanese] agitators, particularly as the Japanese give evidence of spending most of their surplus profits in the United States of America. There seems to be little ground for the somewhat prevalent idea that the Japanese problem should ever arise to the dignity of a social or racial problem, such as we have with the negroes already here."

3. PROFESSOR H. A. MILLIS, Lawrence, Kan.:

"I should say that the principal reasons for the anti-Japanese agitation in California have been economic, racial, and political.... The political reason has increased in importance. On the one hand it has been good politics for candidates for office to stand for most anything anti-Japanese and the very fact that prominent politicians have done so has made for further agitation. On the other hand I find a very general feeling that the Japanese government stands for power very much as Germany did before the war, and that this was well shown when the peace treaty and the League of Nations were under consideration. Without question there is much more fear of Japan's attitude than there was four or five years ago."

4. REVEREND U. G. MURPHY, Seattle, Wash.:

"The principal reason is racial. Other nationalities are doing the very same that the Japanese are doing, have always done these things, and yet very little is said about it, because these other aliens are of the white race, which means that ultimate physical assimilation is possible. Because the opposition to the Japanese is almost altogether racial, there is, of necessity, some degree of social antipathy." ...

5. PROFESSOR ROBERT E. PARK, Chicago, Ill.:

"Racial competition, i.e., competition between peoples different in culture, language, and race. Where racial differences are as marked as they are in the case of the Japanese and the American, public sentiment opposes intermarriage. Where intermarriage does not take place assimilation is never complete and the difficulty of the two races mutually accommodating themselves to one another,

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From Tasuki Harada (ed.), *The Japanese Problem in California: Answers (By Representative Americans) to Questionnaire* (San Francisco, CA: American Japanese Relations Committee of Tokyo, 1922), 14–31.

while maintaining each a separate racial existence, is bound to be very great. A racial group which is small in numbers, intimate, compact, and well organized, as is the case of the Jew and the Japanese, has, in the long run, great advantages in competition with a larger and less organized community. If there are already racial prejudices this kind of competition intensifies them." ...

6. Mr. Wm. T. Sesnon, San Francisco, Cal.:

"The principal reason for the present anti-Japanese agitation is the growth of a permanent population which is politically ineligible and which does not assimilate with our people. Naturally when the Japanese population grows to a sufficient extent and concentrates in colonies on our lands, and by its thrift and ability becomes competitively offensive, it furnishes a fertile ground for successful agitation upon the part of politicians and others who on conscientious and other grounds desire drastic and repressive legislation." ...

## Answers to the Second Question

*Question: "Will you mention some of the more important objections or grievances against Japanese in California, or in the United States?"*

1. Professor H. Cooley, Ann Arbor, Mich.:

"It is my observation that nearly all Americans like the Japanese. It is generally admitted that they are personally delightful, and they are much more popular in this regard than, say, the Jews. But many think they are collectively dangerous, either as a nation or as groups of settlers in America. My own opinion is that they are in no way dangerous to us so long as they do not settle here in large numbers. There is a widespread belief, based on experience, that if they did they would form unassimilated groups, and thus destroy the homogeneity of our population. Why this should be the case with Orientals more than with Europeans it is hard to say, but it seems to be a fact, and we must be guided by facts. Much as I like the Japanese I am opposed to their immigration." ...

2. Doctor David Starr Jordan, Palo Alto, Cal.

"Most of the criticisms are grossly exaggerated. It is true that the farmer-Japanese came generally from Hawaii; having been, then, serfs and coming originally from the homeless farmer class in Yamaguchi and Okayama, Japan, they are ignorant and perforce clannish, and non-naturalization keeps them so. The children are readily 'assimilated,' except in looks." ...

3. President Tully C. Knoles, San Jose, Cal.:

"The objection most frequently heard to the increase of the number of Japanese in California is that they are securing such large quantities of desirable agricultural and horticultural land by the process of purchase and leasing in the name of their children who are already citizens of the United States by virtue of the fourteenth amendment, and if their success in these fields continue, their standard of living, being lower than that of the American, will tend to racial competition disastrous for the higher standard of living.

"In the second place, the objection is quite seriously raised to the continuance of the Japanese picture-bride arrangement. I understand, however, that this project has been abandoned, but it must be met by earnest argument for many years.

"Incidentally, we hear the fact mentioned that all aliens are debarred from the ownership of real estate in Japan, and occasionally the objection is made that even though Japanese children born in the United States are technically citizens of the United States, attempts are being made to give them in Japanese schools such a training as will prejudice them against the United States and lead them as they approach their majority to continue their relations as citizens of the mother country of their ancestors."

4. REVEREND F. M. LARKIN, San Francisco, Cal.:

"First, economic competition growing out of the fact that unmarried men without families can underlive and consequently eliminate men with families. Social and racial differences which produce naturally race prejudice. I do not believe that any race naturally is without race prejudice. It is only overcome by the acceptance of the higher ideal as taught by Jesus Christ. The promotion of Buddhism among groups of Japanese which has essentially different standards of life from Christianity. I am not now asserting that one is better than the other, simply stating the fact that they are different and naturally the majority in any country think that they are right. History shows that whenever large groups of different races come together they quarrel." ...

5. MR. WM. T. SESNON, San Francisco, Cal.:

"I was one of the committee that went to Japan last spring and later had occasion to travel over the Orient. What I discovered there in the attitude of all races is so significant that I think the impression should be conveyed to you and your associates for what it is worth. This is done in no desire to offend the sensibilities of your people—quite the contrary, in the highest spirit of friendship. I honestly believe that the root difficulty is the military and commercial reputation which your nation is gaining throughout the world. However true or false this reputation may be, it naturally plays a large part in such an intense situation as exists in California, and as a sincere friend of your country I would earnestly urge you to address all your energies to the reëstablishment of good faith in the mind of the outside world." ...

6. MR. JULIUS WANGENHEIM, San Diego, Cal.:

"From the above it will be evident that I think the social objections are the only valid ones. These are based upon the fact that the Japanese, by their superior industry, thrift, and frugality, can overwork and underlive the average American so that in any section where he settles he is almost certain, sooner or later, to drive out the other inhabitants; and this is due to his virtues, not his vices."

## 4. *U.S. v. Bhagat Singh Thind*, 1923

MR. JUSTICE SUTHERLAND delivered the opinion of the Court.

This cause is here upon a certificate from the Circuit Court of appeals requesting the instruction of this Court in respect of the following questions:

"1. Is a high-caste Hindu, of full Indian blood, born at Amritsar, Punjab, India, a white person within the meaning of § 2169, Revised Statutes?"

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U.S. Supreme Court decision, Downloaded from: https://supreme.justia.com/cases/federal/us/261/204/case.html

"2. Does the Act of February 5, 1917 (39 Stat. 875, § 3) disqualify from naturalization as citizens those Hindus now barred by that act who had lawfully entered the United States prior to the passage of said act?"

The appellee was granted a certificate of citizenship by the District Court of the United States for the District of Oregon, over the objection of the Naturalization Examiner for the United States. A bill in equity was then filed by the United States seeking a cancellation of the certificate on the ground that the appellee was not a white person, and therefore not lawfully entitled to naturalization. The district court, on motion, dismissed the bill (268 F. 683), and an appeal was taken to the circuit court of appeals. No question is made in respect of the individual qualifications of the appellee. The sole question is whether he falls within the class designated by Congress as eligible.

Section 2169, Revised Statutes, provides that the provisions of the Naturalization Act "shall apply to aliens being free white persons and to aliens of African nativity and to persons of African descent."

If the applicant is a white person within the meaning of this section, he is entitled to naturalization; otherwise not. In *Ozawa v. United States*, 260 U.S. 178, we had occasion to consider the application of these words to the case of a cultivated Japanese, and were constrained to hold that he was not within their meaning. As there pointed out, the provision is not that any particular class of persons shall be excluded, but it is, in effect, that only white persons shall be included within the privilege of the statute.

"The intention was to confer the privilege of citizenship upon that class of persons whom the fathers knew as white, and to deny it to all who could not be so classified. It is not enough to say that the framers did not have in mind the brown or yellow races of Asia. It is necessary to go farther and be able to say that, had these particular races been suggested, the language of the act would have been so varied as to include them within its privileges"...

In the endeavor to ascertain the meaning of the [Naturalization Act] statute, we must not fail to keep in mind that it does not employ the word "Caucasian," but the words "white persons," and these are words of common speech, and not of scientific origin. The word "Caucasian" not only was not employed in the law, but was probably wholly unfamiliar to the original framers of the statute in 1790. When we employ it, we do so as an aid to the ascertainment of the legislative intent, and not as an invariable substitute for the statutory words. Indeed, as used in the science of ethnology, the connotation of the word is by no means clear, and the use of it in its scientific sense as an equivalent for the words of the statute, other considerations aside, would simply mean the substitution of one perplexity for another. But, in this country, during the last half century especially, the word, by common usage, has acquired a popular meaning, not clearly defined to be sure, but sufficiently so to enable us to say that its popular, as distinguished from its scientific, application is of appreciably narrower scope. It is in the popular sense of the word, therefore, that we employ is as an aid to the construction of the statute, for it would be obviously illogical to convert words of common speech used in a statute into words of scientific terminology when neither the latter nor the

science for whose purposes they were coined was within the contemplation of the framers of the statute or of the people for whom it was framed. The words of the statute are to be interpreted in accordance with the understanding of the common man from whose vocabulary they were taken.

They imply, as we have said, a racial test; but the term "race" is one which, for the practical purposes of the statute, must be applied to a group of living persons now possessing in common the requisite characteristics, not to groups of persons who are supposed to be or really are descended from some remote common ancestor, but who, whether they both resemble him to a greater or less extent, have at any rate ceased altogether to resemble one another. It may be true that the blond Scandinavian and the brown Hindu have a common ancestor in the dim reaches of antiquity, but the average man knows perfectly well that there are unmistakable and profound differences between them today, and it is not impossible, if that common ancestor could be materialized in the flesh, we should discover that he was himself sufficiently differentiated from both of his descendants to preclude his racial classification with either. The question for determination is not, therefore, whether, by the speculative processes of ethnological reasoning, we may present a probability to the scientific mind that they have the same origin, but whether we can satisfy the common understanding that they are now the same or sufficiently the same to justify the interpreters of a statute—written in the words of common speech, for common understanding, by unscientific men—in classifying them together in the statutory category as white persons. In 1790, the Adamite theory of creation—which gave a common ancestor to all mankind—was generally accepted, and it is not at all probable that it was intended by the legislators of that day to submit the question of the application of the words "white persons" to the mere test of an indefinitely remote common ancestry, without regard to the extent of the subsequent divergence of the various branches from such common ancestry or from one another.

The eligibility of this applicant for citizenship is based on the sole fact that he is of high-caste Hindu stock, born in Punjab, one of the extreme northwestern districts of India, and classified by certain scientific authorities as of the Caucasian or Aryan race. The Aryan theory, as a racial basis, seems to be discredited by most, if not all, modern writers on the subject of ethnology. A review of their contentions would serve no useful purpose. It is enough to refer to the works of Deniker (Races of Man, 317), Keane (Man, Past and Present, 445, 446), and Huxley (Man's Place in Nature, 278), and to the Dictionary of Races, Senate Document 662, 61st Congress, 3d Sess. 1910–1911, p. 17.

The term "Aryan" has to do with linguistic, and not at all with physical, characteristics, and it would seem reasonably clear that mere resemblance in language, indicating a common linguistic root buried in remotely ancient soil, is altogether inadequate to prove common racial origin....

The word "Caucasian" is in scarcely better repute. It is, at best, a conventional term, with an altogether fortuitous origin, which, under scientific manipulation,

has come to include far more than the unscientific mind suspects. According to Keane, for example (The World's Peoples 24, 28, 307 *et seq.*), it includes not only the Hindu, but some of the Polynesians (that is, the Maori, Tahitians, Samoans, Hawaiians, and others), the Hamites of Africa, upon the ground of the Caucasic cast of their features, though in color they range from brown to black. We venture to think that the average well informed white American would learn with some degree of astonishment that the race to which he belongs is made up of such heterogeneous elements....

It does not seem necessary to pursue the matter of scientific classification further. We are unable to agree with the district court, or with other lower federal courts, in the conclusion that a native Hindu is eligible for naturalization under § 2169. The words of familiar speech, which were used by the original framers of the law, were intended to include only the type of man whom they knew as white. The immigration of that day was almost exclusively from the British Isles and Northwestern Europe, whence they and their forebears had come. When they extended the privilege of American citizenship to "any alien being a free white person," it was these immigrants—bone of their bone and flesh of their flesh—and their kind whom they must have had affirmatively in mind. The succeeding years brought immigrants from Eastern, Southern and Middle Europe, among them the Slavs and the dark-eyed, swarthy people of Alpine and Mediterranean stock, and these were received as unquestionably akin to those already here and readily amalgamated with them. It was the descendants of these, and other immigrants of like origin, who constituted the white population of the country when § 2169, reenacting the naturalization test of 1790, was adopted, and, there is no reason to doubt, with like intent and meaning.

What, if any, people of primarily Asiatic stock come within the words of the section we do not deem it necessary now to decide. There is much in the origin and historic development of the statute to suggest that no Asiatic whatever was included. The debates in Congress during the consideration of the subject in 1870 and 1875 are persuasively of this character. In 1873, for example, the words "free white persons" were unintentionally omitted from the compilation of the Revised Statutes. This omission was supplied in 1875 by the act to correct errors and supply omissions. 18 Stat. c. 80, p. 318. When this act was under consideration by Congress, efforts were made to strike out the words quoted, and it was insisted, upon the one hand, and conceded upon the other, that the effect of their retention was to exclude Asiatics generally from citizenship. While what was said upon that occasion, to be sure, furnishes no basis for judicial construction of the statute, it is nevertheless an important historic incident which may not be altogether ignored in the search for the true meaning of words which are themselves historic. That question, however, may well be left for final determination until the details have been more completely disclosed by the consideration of particular cases as they from time to time arise. The words of the statute, it must be conceded, do not readily yield to exact interpretation, and it is probably better to leave them as they are than to risk undue extension or undue limitation of their meaning by any general paraphrase at this time.

What we now hold is that the words "free white persons" are words of common speech, to be interpreted in accordance with the understanding of the common man, synonymous with the word "Caucasian" only as that word is popularly understood. As so understood and used, whatever may be the speculations of the ethnologist, it does not include the body of people to whom the appellee belongs. It is a matter of familiar observation and knowledge that the physical group characteristics of the Hindus render them readily distinguishable from the various groups of persons in this country commonly recognized as white. The children of English, French, German, Italian, Scandinavian, and other European parentage quickly merge into the mass of our population and lose the distinctive hallmarks of their European origin. On the other hand, it cannot be doubted that the children born in this country of Hindu parents would retain indefinitely the clear evidence of their ancestry. It is very far from our thought to suggest the slightest question of racial superiority or inferiority. What we suggest is merely racial difference, and it is of such character and extent that the great body of our people instinctively recognize it and reject the thought of assimilation.

It is not without significance in this connection that Congress, by the Act of February 5, 1917, 39 Stat. 874, c. 29, § 3, has now excluded from admission into this country all natives of Asia within designated limits of latitude and longitude, including the whole of India. This not only constitutes conclusive evidence of the congressional attitude of opposition to Asiatic immigration generally, but is persuasive of a similar attitude toward Asiatic naturalization as well, since it is not likely that Congress would be willing to accept as citizens a class of persons whom it rejects as immigrants.

It follows that a negative answer must be given to the first question, which disposes of the case and renders an answer to the second question unnecessary, and it will be so certified.

## 5. Californian Testifies for the Exclusion of Filipino Immigrants, 1930

We had first the invasion by the Chinese, next the invasion by the Japanese, then by the Hindus, and now we are called upon to resist the invasion of the Filipinos.

The conditions with regard to the Filipinos are more serious than they were with regard to any of those other peoples, as will appear to you later, although they are less in number....

Hawaii offers herself as a terrible example of the penetration of colored races. Hawaii is hopelessly lost to the white race. Idealists may talk enthusiastically about the noble experiment being conducted in Hawaii, the melting pot

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V.S. McClatchy and Victor K. Houston, House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization, Exclusion of Immigration from the Philippine Islands (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1930).

and what it is producing; but the result is simply terrible to those who will look ahead....

There were about 60,000 Japanese in Hawaii in 1900. To-day the Japanese constitute two-fifths of the entire population of the Islands, and more than one half of the school registration is Japanese. The Filipinos constitute about one-fifth of the population. Only 6½ per cent of the entire population (not counting Portugese), are white. White labor is barred by conditions there. The American Federation of Labor posts a great notice on our West Coast warning all labor not to go to Hawaii, and telling them there is no place for a white man there in skilled or unskilled labor....

Let me impress upon the committee this thought: That continued Filipino and Mexican immigration into California will bring to California the condition which you now have in Hawaii. And, if California goes that way it will spread all over the United States. We are trying to maintain a white country in California for our own interests and for the interests of the Nation....

Now, why do we protest against Filipino immigration?

First, it is opposed to a basic principle of the restrictive immigration act of 1924. You will recall the provision of section 13, subdivision (c), excluding as immigrants all aliens ineligible to citizenship. The debates and hearings then held show that it was desired to restrict immigration materially in number and to exclude so far as possible unassimilable elements. Aliens ineligible to citizenship were held to be hopelessly unassimilable and therefore barred as a class. The principle thus established has been violated ... by a provision in section 28 of the act to the effect that citizens of tributary islands of the United States shall not be considered as aliens. That admitted the Filipinos....

The second reason for Philippine exclusion is that this violation to which I have referred is regarded as an act of bad faith by our friends the Japanese.

Congress in 1924 recognized Japanese immigration as an evil which must be remedied, but it was desired to do so without just offense to Japanese pride. Of all the plans suggested the one that best met the conditions was the one adopted, which made no mention of Japanese but simply declared that no alien ineligible to our citizenship should be admitted as immigrant. It was explained to the Japanese that the provision was not discriminatory and applied alike to all those ineligible to our citizenship.

As said before, the principle has been violated in wholesale manner in the case of Filipinos.... The matter has perhaps not come to the attention of this committee, nor has it perhaps been taken up diplomatically, but the violation is bitterly resented by the Japanese particularly, as is indicated by frequent reference thereto in their vernacular newspapers....

The third reason for Filipino exclusion is the extreme unassimilability of the Filipino people. I hope this will be taken by our Filipino friends in the spirit in which it is offered.

The Philippine Islands have about 12,000,000 population. Those inhabitants are of the Malay race which is an offshoot of the Mongolian, and they are ineligible to citizenship except where they have served in our Navy and hold honorable discharge. All the population of the islands is ineligible to

citizenship. All are permitted to come in as immigrants and to come in without discrimination....

In addition to the discordant and diverse character of the population of the islands, all elements of which have full liberty to come here, your attention is directed to the fact that the worst class are entering. R. W. Kearney, who supervises for the State the labor camps of California says that the contractors of Filipino labor tell him that in going back to the islands for labor they deliberately choose the less intelligent, because they are more easily controlled. The Manila Tribune says it is the "riffraff" that comes. And now you see more clearly what I have in mind....

I do not want to reflect upon any members of the class that come over here from the Philippine Islands for the purpose of study. Mr. Kearney tells me that in the labor camps he has found young Filipinos who, after working all day in the fields, would spend a couple of hours twice a week in night school; and he says there is not another race in the labor camps that will do that. So, while all elements over there are unassimilable with our people yet the worst of them are coming here to a greater extent now than before.

I have reports showing they have clashes in Hawaii and in California not only with whites but with other races. In California a Filipino married a Japanese girl in Stockton, and the Japanese inaugurated a general boycott against the Filipinos. Both races seemed to resent it. They have also had clashes elsewhere in the State with Mexicans. I saw the other day that in the city of Manila there was a riot, and an attempt to kill a number of United States sailors. That may have been due to fault on the part of the sailors. These instances are quoted, not with the assumption that the Filipinos are always to blame, but to demonstrate that they do not mingle well with other racial elements, and therefore that a continuance of this character of immigration must make for more or less trouble.

I now come to the most serious phase of this question, and that is the sex problem. I will read a statement by Dr. David P. Barrows, for a number of years director of our educational system in the Philippines, for four years president of the University of California and still attached to that institution, a friend of the Filipino, which appeared in the Commonwealth Bulletin, at page 322:

> Their vices are almost entirely based on sexual passion. This passion in the Malay—which includes practically all types of Filipinos—is inordinately strong; and in accordance with native customs it is rarely directed into the right channels or restrained by custom or by individual will. The irregularity of his conduct, and the social problem in American life which his presence aggravates is, in my opinion, entirely based on this phase of his character.
>
> The evidence is very clear that having no wholesome society of his own, he is drawn into lowest and least fortunate associations. He usually frequents the poorer quarters of our towns, and spends the residue of his savings in brothels and dance-halls, which in spite of our laws, exist to minister to his lower nature. Everything in our rapid, pleasure-seeking life and the more or less shameless exhibitionism which accompanies it,

contribute to overwhelm these young men who, in most cases, are only a few years removed from the even, placid life of a primitive native barrio.

As I said, the Filipino does not bring his females with him. In 1929 only 3 per cent of those who came were females.

You can realize, with the declared preference of the Filipino for white women and the willingness on the part of some white females to yield to that preference, the situation which arises. It is one of the phases which is at the bottom of the racial trouble in the State of California. Take, for instance, the Watsonville riot, which threatened to be quite serious. There was one death in connection with that matter. There was one incident perhaps not known outside the State, of a young girl 17 or 18 years of age who associated with a Filipino, and her parents endeavored to stop it but without avail. She was missing for two or three days and they started to hunt for her, and she was found hidden in a Filipino hotel. She made complaint that she had been mistreated and she was taken to the detention home. That was only one of the incidents which inflamed the public....

## 6. Leader of Philippines House of Representatives Reveals Trade-Off Between Exclusion and Independence, 1930

The questions involved in this bill are of extremely delicate nature. Economic considerations are intermingled with those of racial character. The economic phase permits a wide latitude for discussion; the racial angle is narrowed by embarrassing sensibilities provocative of resentment. You will, therefore, understand why we come before this committee with a great deal of reluctance and diffidence. For it is not easy to assert one's dignity and self-respect in the face of similar feelings and sentiments of others.

Our peculiar relations with America, however, justifies us in presenting our side of this question. Were it not for such relations, unsought by the Filipinos and imposed upon them by America, it would indeed be very embarrassing, even bad taste, to come before you. This will explain at the outset why, in opposing this measure, we have frequently to appeal to the innate sense of justice and fair play of the American people.

In all due respect, we submit that the exclusion of the Filipinos from the United States as provided for in the Welch bill, which in effect places us in the same category as the Chinese under the Chinese exclusion act of 1882 and as the Japanese under the Japanese exclusion act of 1924, can not be justified by any of the reasons so far publicly given in support of the measure, among which are the protection of American workingmen against alleged cheap Asiatic labor and the preservation of the racial and social integrity of the American Nation.

From the political and moral point of view the passage of this bill is even less justified. The very author of this measure, in one of his recent addresses on the floor or the House, himself admitted that the Filipino in America does not

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From Manuel Roxas, in House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization, Exclusion of Immigration from the Philippine Islands (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1930).

compete with the American laborer when he stated that the Filipinos do not come here as colonists; in other words, they do not settle permanently. This may be demonstrated by the fact that they only engage in transient and seasonal occupations. The reason is obvious. The great majority of the Filipinos coming to the United States are young men whose primary object is to study and gain experience by direct contact with American culture and civilization. To them, therefore, employment is only secondary and incidental. They work only sufficiently to earn enough with which to maintain themselves in school and pay their tuition fees and other necessary expenses. As an example we have the thousands of Filipinos who go to Alaska during the salmon fishing season, after which they return to the cities on the Pacific coast where they reside to continue their studies. A great many of these young men come from families who, in our country, own a small parcel of land and a few work animals. In many cases, their parents have had to sell a piece of their land or one or two "carabaos" in order to provide the money necessary to send them to America and maintain them until they have become self-supporting. In vain they have not learned the lesson taught them in school about Lincoln, the self-made "rail splitter." Many of these young men who come here are near relatives or intimate friends who hail from the same community and they mutually help one another by paying for each other's expenses in school by turns; that is, while one goes to school the other works for the other's maintenance. When the one studying has finished his course he in turn goes to work so that the other may go to school. These mutual arrangements do not surprise those familiar with the compactness of the Filipino family and with the spirit of helpfulness which is innate among the Filipinos—characteristics which Dr. David P. Barrows, of the University of California, himself could not help but admit as an excellent quality of our race. Once they have finished their studies or have learned enough to have compensated for the sacrifices they incurred in coming to this wonderful land of opportunity, they return to the Philippines to help their parents or establish themselves in their various callings or occupations....

It will be seen from these considerations that Filipino immigration to the United States is not really a menace to the welfare of the American workingman, much less to the racial and social integrity of this Nation. It does not constitute a third race problem that is to be added to those that you already have—the problems of the colored and the red races. The sociologist in California exaggerates when he envisions such danger. The Filipinos in America constitute a race problem only if one or two things happen—either a sufficient number of Filipino women must come to the United States to make possible a normal and well balanced Filipino community, or, if Filipino women are not available, the Filipino residents would have to intermarry freely with the American women of the white race.

The first is not possible. Immigration of Filipino women to the United States in large numbers is out of the question because of the enormous distance between America and the Philippines and the high cost of transportation, not to mention other one thousand and one inconveniences. The other is unthinkable. Intermarriage between Americans and Filipinos will always be a rare exception, never a general rule. The radical differences in race will never be bridged.

Aside from the existence of a public opinion here against Filipino marital incursions into the nordic circle, individual inclinations and differences militate against the success of such unions. For the purpose of marriage and the creation of a family the Filipino, in general, will prefer to return to his country where he can find a women who can understand him and in whom he can find complete identity in custom, manner, desire, education, habits, religion, etc. Similarly, the American woman will always feel inclined to find a life companion from amongst her race. The world has advanced greatly, but the time is yet far distant when humankind shall have become one great family; it is as yet composed of various great families denominated races whose tendency is to isolate themselves from one another.

To Dr. David P. Barrows, whom I have already cited, has been attributed the statement that the Filipino has a weakness to sexual propensity which makes him a racial menace in America. As an anecdote or as a mirth-provoking post-prandial sally, this observation is contagiously humorous; as a scientific formula, it is sublimely ridiculous. The very records and statistics of this country as well as those of the Philippines show that the contrary is exactly the truth. The records of the Quarantine Service of Seattle, were they consulted, would show that the result of the physical examination given to thousands of Filipinos that journey to Alaska is better than that of a similar group of men of the white race of the same age. Of course, there are not lacking Filipino immigrants of low moral character, but to judge the entire Filipino community in America or on the Pacific coast by the low standard of this type of Filipinos would be like judging the mortality of the American people by the low standard shown by some of the sailors and soldiers of the United States stationed in Manila or those who arrive in ports of call after a prolonged abstinence....

I will now discuss the moral phase of this question which to me is the most important of its various aspects. The Congress is urged to solve this problem once and for all taking only into consideration the welfare of the American people. Supposing, for the sake of argument, that this question is really a matter of life and death to the States of the Union alleged to be affected by Filipino immigration, we ask: Should it be solved solely in compliance with the pressure of the inexorable laws of necessity? Would it not be more noble and more magnanimous for the American people and just to the Filipinos, first to settle the principal question in the relations between the two peoples of which the problem of immigration is only incidental?

We are aware of the fact that this committee is not the one called upon to deliberate on the problem of [Philippine] independence. Much as we would like to avoid this issue the force of circumstances makes it impossible for us to evade it. The truth is that the present situation is very much more undesirable than it looks on the surface. For the cause of all these conflicts is our present state of dependency. Give us our liberty, grant us our independence, and this immigration problem, as well as the other problems arising from our present relationship, will solve themselves automatically. If despite all, you still decide to close your doors to us, we shall endeavor to drown our anxiety to come to your country, much as we desire to do so. We will not even utter a single word of protest against your

determination to exclude us. But may we be permitted to say, humbly but emphatically, that while we remain under political subjection; while American capital, American products, American citizens have free entry in our country, we believe that we are entitled to reciprocity [of immigration]. To do one and not the other is one sided, beneficial to one and prejudicial to the other.

## 7. Filipino Immigrants Petition Congress for Repatriation, 1932

### Resolution of the Filipino Communities Under the Auspices of the Legionarios Club

Whereas in pursuant to a resolution adopted by the Filipino community in a mass meeting held under the auspices of the Legionarios Club, a duly incorporated California corporation, on November 13, 1932, in the city and county of Los Angeles, State of California, that a nation-wide relief movement for unemployed Filipinos in continental United States be started; and

Whereas attached hereto a set of resolution approved on the above-mentioned date, which resolution is duly indorsed and subscribed to by 55 Filipino clubs and organizations and Filipino business men composing the great majority of Filipino residents in Los Angeles County, State of California, hereby make the same a part of this resolution; and

Whereas increasing unemployment is causing 65,000 Filipinos, native inhabitants from the Philippine Islands residing in continental United States have fallen into financial distress, are not employed; are in want for the necessities of life amidst a surplus of all things necessary to life and the maintnance of a high standard of living, is becoming a menace to the maintenance of orderly government; and is an indictment of our intelligence and capacity for self-government; and

Whereas practically all means of correction so far tried in government and industry have made the situation worse rather than better, by bringing about the curtailment of employment and reduction of wage scales, thereby further restricting buying capacity and causing further Filipino unemployment, who are now and have been beneficiaries of public and private charitable institutions; and

Whereas the owners of wealth and institutions which have control of a large volume of credit further complicate the situation by restricting credit and expenditures to 48,750 unemployed Filipinos; and

Whereas various small groups within the Filipino communities have devised ways and means to raise funds to defray the furnishing of food and shelter from those 16,250 employed Filipinos receiving meager income are without any success; and

Whereas the removal of these unemployed Filipinos of public and private charities would relieve the local burden now borne by the cities and communities in which they live; also will save these Filipino wards from the clutches of complete breakdown of their morale as well as the victims of degenerative

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From House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization, To Return to the Philippine Islands Unemployed Filipinos (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1933), 40–41.

crimes, thus insure peace and security and prevent riots and mob attacks in their respective localities, and

Whereas at this time 20,875 Filipinos who are unemployed and financially distressed are ready and willing to return to the Philippine Islands if a way could be provided for their passage, transportation, and maintenance en route from continental United States: Therefore be it

*Resolved*, That the Seventy-second Congress, second session, of the United States of America, now assembled, unanimously approve H. J. Res. 549 [a Filipino repatriation measure] introduced by the Hon. Samuel Dickstein and referred to the Committee on Immigration and Naturalization; and be it further

*Resolved*, That a copy of this resolution be sent to the honorable Secretary of War and the Philippine Resident Commissioners in Washington, D. C.; and both houses of the Philippine Legislature and the Governor General of the Philippine Islands; and also, be it further

*Resolved*, That President Roque E. de la Ysla of this Nation-wide relief movement be the representative and spokesman of our Filipino communities and to wait upon personally the honorable Committee on Immigration and Naturalization, House of Representatives, United States, for detailed facts of the Filipinos' economic, social, and political problems in continental United States.

[SEAL.] ROQUE E. DE LA YSLA, *President.*

Attested by:

FRANCISCO X. CARBONELL, *Secretary.*

# ESSAYS

The first essay, by Oberlin College scholar Rick Baldoz, examines the politics of Filipino exclusion and repatriation, focusing particularly on congressional debate. While the significance of race is clear in this essay, so is the complicated politics of Philippine independence that cannot be reduced to racism alone. In the second essay, Maile Arvin critiques the myth of Hawai'i as a "racial paradise" that was advanced by a consensus of local politicians, plantation owners, and social scientists. An assistant professor of ethnic studies at the University of California, Riverside, Arvin maintains that such a rosy impression of the islands masked the complexity of interracial relations in the islands and the existence of Native Hawaiian peoples and their claims to sovereignty over their homeland.

## Filipino Exclusion and Philippine Independence

RICK BALDOZ

By the time Congress held hearings on immigration from the Philippines, the desirability of Filipino exclusion was not really a matter of debate, with most

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From Baldoz, *The Third Asiatic Invasion: Empire and Migration in Filipino America, 1898–1946* (New York: NYU Press, 2011), 156–193. Reprinted by permission.

senators and representatives accepting the premise that immigration from the islands constituted a serious social problem. There were, however, significant differences of opinion on how to resolve the matter. On one side were advocates of outright immigration restriction, who believed Congress should bar Filipinos from the United States irrespective of their status as American nationals. Hardcore exclusionists worried that the issue of Philippine independence was a political hot potato that was best dealt with as a separate legislative matter. On the other side were those who believed that exclusion could be implemented in a more diplomatic and honorable way, favoring independence as a means to curtail immigration. The granting of Philippine independence, they argued, would allow the United States to avoid a rather ugly diplomatic precedent—being the first imperial state to ban its own political subjects from entering their sovereign state. The passage of an independence bill, moreover, would yield the added bonus of placing Philippine imports under tariff quotas. This was a major concern of mid-western congressional representatives from states with large sugar-beet and/or dairy industries, who had long railed against the import of cheap Philippine goods such as cane sugar and copra (coconut oil) that competed with their products.

The Shortridge bill was first introduced on the Senate floor as a standalone exclusion bill (S. 4183) on April 16, 1930, but Shortridge quickly shifted tactics and reoffered his proposal a week later as an amendment (S. 51) to Senator William Harris's Mexican-exclusion bill, which already had significant support in Congress. The Shortridge amendment was modeled on the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882. The senator explained that the "main and vital purpose" of his provision was to "prevent the coming of what may be called the laborer class," exempting students, merchants, and government officials from quota limits. The bill targeted only immigration to the "Continental United States," a proviso added to appease Hawaiian sugar planters, who opposed any legislation that would hinder the unfettered flow of Filipino labor to the islands....

Although many members of the Senate supported Filipino exclusion in principle, Shortridge had a difficult time securing votes for a stand-alone immigration bill that did not address the independence issue....

The Filipino-exclusion question received a more protracted deliberation in the House of Representatives, where Immigration Committee chairman Albert Johnson scheduled formal hearings on Representative Richard Welch's exclusion bill. This piece of legislation was even more malicious than the Shortridge amendment, seeking to reclassify Filipinos as "aliens ineligible to citizenship." This change was designed to strip them of their status as U.S. nationals, thereby subjecting them to the exclusionary quota system established by the 1924 Immigration Act. In Welch's speech introducing HR 8708, he warned his colleagues that Filipino migration and settlement in the United States constituted one of the "gravest problems that has ever faced the people of the Pacific Coast." He referenced the recent outbreaks of violence on the West Coast, which in Welch's view "reveal[ed] the intense jealousy and racial hatred which the Asiatic immigrants [in Watsonville, California and other sites] have aroused."...

The hearings on the Welch bill began on April 10, 1930. Among the witnesses invited to the proceedings were "distinguished Californians" U.S. Webb

and V. S. McClatchy, as well as a number of other restrictionists such as John Trevor of the American Coalition of Patriotic Societies and William Hushing of the American Federation of Labor. Welch kicked off the hearings by stressing the unique burden that the citizens of California and the American West had borne when it came to dealing with immigration problems. Unlike other parts of the country, this region faced an unceasing onslaught of aliens from both the southern and Pacific borders. He argued that California had become a "dumping ground for Filipinos ... and Mexicans" but promised that citizens of the western states were ready to play a vanguard role in shoring up the nation's borders as they had done in previous decades against the Chinese and Japanese....

## The Southern Strategy

Western nativists knew that they could not win passage of an exclusion bill without another large bloc of votes in Congress. Movement spokesmen saw southern Democrats as their natural allies on issues of racial exclusion, regularly invoking the specter of miscegenation in a bid to win support from the representatives from that region. Restrictionists portrayed Filipinos demands for social equality and minority rights in the United States as a thinly veiled smokescreen for their real agenda: interracial marriage with white women. This same accusation had long been levied by white leaders in the South to disparage the civil rights demands of African Americans, who, according to segregationists, possessed an irrepressible desire for conjugal access to white women. Nativist point men warned that Filipinos would soon be intermarrying with white women in the eastern and southern states if congressional leaders did not throw their support behind exclusion.

Restrictionists claimed that Filipino men had a peculiar talent for winning the affections of white women and had proven themselves adept at evading proscriptions on interracial marriage. J. Edward Cassidy reminded the committee that even though the number of Filipinos intermarrying with whites was small, the "mongrel stream" resulting from such unions multiplied rapidly, producing hybrid children "of the worst type." This point was underscored by V. S. McClatchy, who painted a grim picture of white racial decline in the face of unrelenting waves of Asian migration over previous decades. Admixture with Filipinos, he argued, violated the laws of nature and degraded the blood of the white race. The arrival of increasing numbers of Filipinos had pushed the situation to a crisis point, forcing western leaders such as McClatchy to demand from Congress "protection against the colored races of the Orient." He dismissed charges that recent campaigns to expel Filipinos from the West Coast were motivated by hate or malice, claiming instead that white citizens had acted in self-defense to reclaim their communities and their nation from an alien onslaught. The struggle to defend America's Pacific border was described as a high-stakes conflict that was already playing itself out in the Hawaiian Islands. McClatchy pointed to Hawaii as a "terrible example of the penetration of colored races" into an American domain. The demographic majority of Asians in Hawaii offered a cautionary tale that illustrated the dangers of laissez-faire immigration

policy. Hawaii, according to McClatchy, was "hopelessly lost to the white race" due to the lax attitude of federal lawmakers. The nightmare scenario that had unfolded in Hawaii was likely to be repeated in "white man's country" if lawmakers did not fortify the nation's western border. This scenario, he warned, was a matter of great urgency for American citizens, since if California went "colored," it would quickly "spread all over the United States."...

## The Opposition Speaks

Filipinos testifying on the Welch bill had their own agenda for the hearings. They saw the forum as an opportunity to make the case for independence and to challenge racist claims made by their adversaries. The Philippine delegation included Manuel Roxas, speaker of the Philippine House of Representatives; Camilo Osias, Philippine resident commissioner; Manuel Briones, House majority leader; and Pedro Gil, House minority leader. Joining them in opposition to the bill was a representative from the U.S. War Department and lobbyists from the Hawaiian Sugar Planters Association. Filipino leaders had two main objectives at the hearings: The first was to challenge the political and legal propriety of the United States' excluding its own colonial wards. Their second goal was to steer the debate away from immigration restriction and back to the question of Philippine independence, a legislative solution that would allow both sides to claim a measure of victory. Philippine officials had pressed the case for national self-determination for decades without making much headway, so the immigration hearings offered a timely, though somewhat awkward, opportunity to move their political aims forward....

Manuel Roxas laid out the key themes of the opposition strategy, engaging in a protracted back and forth with committee members, who at times seemed confused about the precise legal status of Filipinos in the United States. Roxas challenged a key premise of the Welch bill—that the U.S. Congress could legally reclassify Filipinos as aliens, as defined in the 1924 Immigration Act. Recalling earlier debates surrounding Filipinos' naturalization status in the United States, he pointed out that U.S. courts had definitively recognized that Filipinos were American "nationals" and not "aliens." To change their status now would give the term "alien" a "wholly arbitrary meaning" inconsistent with established legal precedent. Roxas reminded the committee members that American officials had always framed their role in the Philippines as a benevolent one, rooted in "principles of fair-play, righteousness, and justice." To enact restrictive legislation would call into question the "guiding norm[s] of American conduct" and would likely create resentment against the United States in the islands, upsetting cordial relations between the two governments. Roxas also drew on the rhetoric of American exceptionalism to defend the special status of Filipinos, noting that U.S. policymakers had always touted their brand of imperialism as a more munificent and progressive type of sovereignty, a tradition that could not be reconciled with the belligerent aims of the Welch bill.

Roxas spent significant time responding to nativists such as McClatchy and Webb, whose testimony was riddled with misinformation and specious claims.

He ridiculed Webb for suggesting that the United States might solve the problem of Filipino immigration simply by selling the Philippines to another imperial power. The notion that Filipinos were "owned as mere chattels, as a herd of oxen, and [might] be disposed of as such" was, according to Roxas, wholly inconsistent with political and moral norms undergirding American dominion in the islands. This was a compelling point, insofar as Filipinos had U.S. sovereignty imposed on them by force and were powerless to "disentangle themselves" from this imperial attachment. Other members of the Philippine delegation reminded the members of the Immigration and Naturalization Committee that Filipinos "owed allegiance" to the United States and lived under the American flag. Passage of the Welch bill, they argued, would set a troubling precedent, singling out the United States as the world's only imperial power to ban its own political subjects from entering the "mother country." Roxas drove this point home by highlighting the fact that Filipinos had never been excluded from Spain during its three centuries of colonial rule in the islands, even though Spain, unlike the United States, "was a selfish, imperialistic power!" This clever contrast between Spanish colonial policies and the ostensibly more humane character of American empire effectively communicated the odious nature of the Welch exclusion bill....

## Independence from the Philippines

Over the next two years (1932–1933), Congress considered a variety of bills aimed at conferring Philippine independence. Senator William King, who hailed from the sugar-beet-producing state of Utah, proposed a bill granting immediate independence to the islands, a change in status that would subject Philippine cane sugar to tariff restriction....

Support for Philippine independence picked up new momentum in 1932 with the introduction of concurrent bills by Harry Hawes of Missouri and Bronson Cutting of New Mexico in the Senate and by Butler Hare of South Carolina in the House. The Senate and House bills shared the same basic outlines and eventually merged into a single legislative proposal after some back and forth between the two legislative bodies. The American Federation of Labor, powerful agribusiness interests, and Philippine delegates Sergio Osmena and Manuel Roxas all testified at hearings on the new bill. The initial versions of the Hare and Hawes-Cutting bills did not directly deal with the issue of immigration exclusion, due to concern that such a provision would offend the Filipino people and derail support for the legislation in the Philippines. California congressmen Hiram Johnson (Senate) and Richard Welch (House) considered this issue to be a deal breaker and quickly inserted an exclusion clause into the Hare-Hawes-Cutting bill. That the motivations of American lawmakers in pushing this legislation forward were less than noble was not lost on Filipino leaders, who remarked that congressional support for national autonomy was as much about "independence of America *from* the Philippines" (emphasis added) as it was about independence for the Philippines....

The bill's supporters were caught by surprise when the Philippine legislature, which had long demanded independence, vetoed the bill in early 1933 after

Manuel Quezon, president of the Philippine Senate, raised strong objections. Not surprisingly, Filipino leaders wanted to begin their sovereign status on the most advantageous terms possible and were not happy with key provisions of the Hare-Hawes-Cutting bill. The issue was also complicated by the fact that Quezon was locked in a power struggle with Sergio Osmena and Manuel Roxas, as both camps jockeyed for control of the postindependence regime. Most Philippine leaders had reservations about the tariff and immigration provisions in the bill but figured that this was the price to be paid for independence. Some opponents of the Hare-Hawes-Cutting bill also expressed concerns about the continued presence of U.S. military bases in the islands, which for many Filipinos symbolized a threat to national sovereignty. Quezon believed that he could negotiate a better deal with the incoming Roosevelt administration, one that would adjust the restrictive immigration and trade quotas laid out in the Hare-Hawes-Cutting bill. Roosevelt's representatives informed Quezon, however, that these issues were not negotiable and that restrictionists might demand even harsher terms if Filipinos continued to press the issue. This seemingly endless political maneuvering did not sit well with nativist leaders, who believed that Filipinos were getting cold feet about the exclusionary provisions contained in the bill. They criticized Filipino leaders for reneging on the deal and called on federal officials to settle the matter once and for all. California labor boss Paul Scharrenberg wrote an article entitled "What Do Filipinos Want?" which voiced the concerns of exclusionists....

The only area in which Philippine leaders were able to win any concessions was on the issue of military bases, with Quezon negotiating the withdrawal of U.S. Army bases and gaining a promise to revisit the issue of Navy bases during the Commonwealth period. The revised Hare-Hawes-Cutting bill was reintroduced in 1934 by its new sponsors, Senator Millard Tydings of Maryland and Representative John McDuffie of Alabama, and it was passed by Congress in March 1934. The Tydings-McDuffie Act mandated a ten-year probationary period under which a Commonwealth government supervised by the United States would assist in the transition to self-rule. The Philippine legislature was instructed to draft a national constitution patterned on the U.S. republican system. The Philippine Constitution was approved by President Roosevelt in March 1935.

The ten-year probationary period mandated by the Tydings-McDuffie Act revealed the separation anxiety of American officials, who believed that the Philippines would descend into chaos without another decade of paternal supervision. And though formal independence would not be enacted for ten years, two important exclusionary provisions prescribed by the act would be put into force immediately. Section 6 of the act established quotas for Philippine products such as sugar, coconut oil, and cordage, and graduated tariff duties were placed on other goods, slowly limiting the access of Filipino products to the American market. Not surprisingly, the act contained no provision allowing the Philippine government to reciprocally levy any duties or quota restrictions on the entry of U.S. products, allowing American goods unfettered access throughout the Commonwealth period. More important, Section 8 of the Tydings-McDuffie Act

reclassified the Philippines as a "foreign country" vis-à-vis U.S. immigration law. American immigration authorities were now obliged to treat Filipinos "as if they were aliens" in all matters pertaining to their right to enter the United States. This change in status made them subject to the limitative restrictions established in the 1917 and 1924 Immigration Acts.

Federal officials granted the Philippines a quota of a mere fifty immigrants per year during the Commonwealth period. This meager quota reflected the lingering hostility to Filipino immigrants on the West Coast and was only half the number of entries allocated to other Asian nations such as China and Japan, which received one hundred slots per annum under the 1924 Immigration Act....

## A Problem Not Solved

While nativist leaders celebrated the new restrictions on immigration from the Philippines, they still expressed concern about the problems posed by the tens of thousands of Filipinos already in the United States. Racial antagonism toward Filipinos remained strong on the West Coast and had spread to other parts of the country by the mid-1930s....

Widespread unemployment during the early years of the Great Depression added to resentment ... about the continued presence of Filipinos in the United States. In April 1932, eighty-seven Filipino laborers were "driven out" of Banks, Oregon, by white laborers and farmers. Filipinos had been hired to harvest the area's strawberry crop but were ordered to evacuate the district after a "mass meeting of whites" declared them a menace to the local economy. The next year, a bombing campaign was orchestrated by residents of the Yakima Valley to drive Filipino agricultural workers out of the region. A local white Citizen's Committee "requested" that Japanese truck farmers on the Yakima reservation stop employing and/or subleasing agricultural land to Filipinos. The committee cited "unfair competition with white labor and mingling with white women" as its principal objections to Filipinos. The Japanese initially refused to cooperate with this order, and during March and April 1934, nightriders tossed dynamite and planted bombs on farms that employed Filipinos.

The growing labor militancy of Filipino workers also remained in the spotlight. A series of large-scale strikes and labor actions disrupted the agricultural industry in California and reinforced perceptions of Filipinos as a disruptive force in American political life. A major strike in 1933 saw workers across the state engaged in simultaneous labor actions.

## "A Disguised Form of Deportation"

Some of the key figures behind the campaign for Filipino exclusion launched a new campaign aimed at repatriating those immigrants still residing in the United States back to the Philippines. A mass deportation of Filipinos similar to campaigns carried out against Mexicans during the early 1930s was not practicable because of the unique political attachment between the United States and the Philippines. Congressional restrictionists and nativist leaders, however, got creative in their

efforts to facilitate a mass exodus of Filipinos. Lawmakers came up with a novel legislative solution that might achieve the result of a large-scale deportation without the political fallout. U.S. officials set about crafting a federal policy aimed at convincing Filipinos to leave the country voluntarily, with Uncle Sam providing financial and logistical assistance to facilitate their departure.

Representative Samuel Dickstein, who chaired the House Immigration and Naturalization Committee, proposed an early version of this legislation in 1933. The bill, House Joint Resolution 549, was specifically aimed at repatriating "unemployed" Filipinos back to the Philippines, with government assistance. The federal government would provide logistical support for transportation to the islands and a financial appropriation from Congress would pay for their one-way passage back to the islands. Dickstein's proposal was couched in humanitarian terms as an effort to help indigent Filipinos return home during a time of economic distress. Lawmakers also believed that the departure of large numbers of Filipinos would help to quell the racial antagonism on the West Coast, which continued to flare up on a regular basis through the mid-1930s. Among the notable witnesses appearing at the hearings in favor of the resolution were U.S. Secretary of Labor William Doak....

William Doak heartily endorsed HJ 549 and sent a special assistant, Murray Garsson, to Southern California to do some "heavy investigation" of the Filipino situation and then report his findings at the hearings. Garsson's testimony asserted that the number of Filipinos had reached epidemic proportions in California, a situation that reinforced the need for aggressive government action on the matter. He introduced wildly inflated estimates of the Filipino population in the United States and of the total number of those who were unemployed to inflate the scale of the problem. Garsson suggested that there were as many as 150,000 Filipinos living on the U.S. mainland and 60,000 residing in Los Angeles County alone, figures at odds with the Census Bureau's count of 45,000 total living in the continental United States. He estimated that 80 percent of the Filipinos in the United States were unemployed, a situation that caused severe hardships for the communities in which they resided. Garsson drove this point home by telling the committee about the dire conditions he discovered while investigating a "Filipino colony" in Los Angeles. He described visiting a Filipino home where fifteen or sixteen men lived together in a single room, "sharing beds in shifts of three" and rotating sleepers twenty-four hours a day. These practices, according to Garsson, were typical among Filipinos and posed a possible public-health risk to the communities around them. Other witnesses at the hearings on the Dickstein bill assured committee members that there was widespread support for repatriation among Filipino leaders, who recognized that economic and social competition in the United States had reached a crisis point. Committee members discussed the logistics and costs of a repatriation operation, even though Filipino leaders criticized the bill as a thinly veiled deportation act. Advocates of the Dickstein measure suggested that as many as thirty thousand Filipinos would voluntarily repatriate if their travel was subsidized by the federal government....

Although support for repatriation on the committee was unanimous, HJ 549 was eventually tabled, unable to secure a spot on the legislative calendar. The bill

was reintroduced again a few months later, with some minor revisions, as HJ 118. The proposal, however, did not contain a clear provision barring Filipino repatriates from returning to the United States, which became a sticking point for restrictionists, who wanted assurances that there would be no right of return.... On March 6, 1935, the indefatigable Richard Welch sponsored HR 6464, which contained clear-cut language prohibiting the return of Filipinos who had been "deported." Immigration and Naturalization Committee members Martin Dies of Texas and Thomas Jenkins of Ohio applauded Welch for putting together a bill that would "make it impossible for Filipinos to return to the United States." The only weakness of the legislation, according to Dies, was that it made repatriation "voluntary," a problem that allowed Filipinos to stay in the country even though they were no longer welcome. A final amended version of the bill, cosponsored by Hiram Johnson in the Senate, was signed into law on July 10, 1935.

Media observers extolled the virtues of the new policy, suggesting that the mass departure of the islanders was in the best interest of both Americans and Filipinos....

The Filipino Repatriation Act was extended two times through December 31, 1940, in a last-ditch effort to convince Filipinos to leave the country. A mass exodus of Filipinos, however, never materialized. By the end of 1938, *Time* magazine called the repatriation program the "Philippine Flop," characterizing the $237,000 spent on the operation as a disappointment. The magazine speculated that the campaign had failed because the "boys [were] loathe to leave a country, where as a California judge remarked, they boast of enjoying the favors of white girls because they are a very superior grade of lovers." This did not surprise renowned labor journalist Carey McWilliams, who predicted that very few Filipinos would apply for the act since they viewed the Welch bill as a "trick, and not a very clever trick, to get them out of the country" because of their labor militancy and political activism. The program officially ended during the fiscal year 1941, having repatriated 157 Filipinos in 1936, 580 in 1937, 502 in 1938, 392 in 1939, 425 in 1940, and 134 in 1941, for a total of 2,190. These numbers fell far short of the thirty to forty thousand predicted by exclusionists.

## Challenging the Construction of Hawai'i as America's Racial Laboratory

MAILE ARVIN

Beginning in the late 1920s, sociology solidified ideas about Hawai'i as a place of racial mixture.... The noted Chicago school of sociology at this time was particularly interested in Hawai'i as its many different races seemed to provide a

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From Maile Renee Arvin, "Pacifically Possessed: Scientific Production and Native Hawaiian Critique of the 'Almost White' Polynesian Race" (Ph.D. diss., University of California, San Diego, 2013). Reprinted by permission.

perfect site for modeling their theories about immigration and assimilation. This literature perpetuated viewing Native Hawaiians as largely a race of the past and routinely slotted Native Hawaiians as only a minor segment of Hawai'i's many races. Sociologists were interested in Native Hawaiians only insofar as they made up a piece of Hawai'i's racially patch-worked population and the heralded "neo-Hawaiian," which would be a new, uniquely American, "raceless" race....

Though the sociology of this period largely portrayed Hawai'i as an exceptionally racially harmonious place, there is ample evidence that many people (Native Hawaiian and non-Hawaiian, white and non-white, residents of Hawai'i and residents of the continental United States, academic and laymen) found Hawai'i anything but harmonious. For example, historian Christine Manganaro has demonstrated in her analysis of the sociological interviews of Hawai'i residents produced by graduate student researcher Margaret Lam in the early 1930s that many Hawai'i residents, even or especially those who were themselves in interracial marriages, found Hawai'i to have a great deal of "race prejudice" and generally disapproved of racial mixing. In the popular media of the United States in the early 1930s, images of Hawai'i as a "racial nightmare" were in fact being splashed over countless newspapers and magazines in response to the so-called Massie affair. The Massie affair involved a series of highly publicized court cases originating from the claims of Thalia Massie, the white wife of a naval officer stationed at Pearl Harbor, that she had been assaulted and raped by a group of Native Hawaiian and Asian American men in 1931. When these men failed to be convicted due to lack of evidence, enraged white Navy men engaged in vigilantism. One Japanese American man, Horace Ida, was severely beaten. Further, Massie's husband and mother along with two other Naval officers kidnapped, shot, and killed Joseph Kahahawai—a Native Hawaiian man identified as the "darkest" of the accused. Stopped on their way to dump Kahahawai's body in the ocean, they were caught and arrested. Massie's mother and husband were subsequently convicted of killing Kahahawai, but ultimately, under great pressure from the Navy and the yellow journalism of the U.S. mainland, the governor of Hawai'i commuted their sentences and they served only an hour under arrest—and not in jail but at tea in the governor's office.

The Massie case was widely reported on throughout the United States and the world, shocking readers with depictions of Hawai'i as a terrifying place where "roads go through jungles, and in those remote places bands of degenerate natives lie in wait for white women driving by." Some have argued that the furor over the Massie case and the racial fears brought on by the widespread media coverage of it were even responsible for delaying Hawai'i's entry into the United States as a state [though hearings on Hawai'i's statehood were held in the 1930s, it would not be secured until 1959]. This new image of Hawai'i as a "racial nightmare" was completely at odds with the idyllic, carefree image that local government officials of the Territory of Hawai'i wished to promote. It also flew in the face of social scientists' existing views ... of the Pacific as a benign and controlled "racial laboratory" for human biology. However, instead of destroying the racial laboratory ideal, after the Massie affair such sociological accounts only seemed to gain further importance....

Romanzo Adams was specifically hired by Hawaii Territorial officials to head the University of Hawai'i's studies of race relations, officially titled a "Station for Racial Research," which, beginning in May 1926, was funded by the Rockefeller Foundation. Accordingly, unlike eugenics studies that focused on the Pure and Part Hawaiian almost exclusively, Adams looked to Hawai'i's population as a whole as a model of race relations that had the potential to provide insights into racial problems on the U.S. mainland. Adams's research focused on what he defined as two central aspects of race relations in Hawai'i: first, the so-called Japanese Problem (his focus in the late 1920s) and second, interracial marriage (his focus in the 1930s).

Where sociologists on the U.S. mainland were eager to solve the "Negro Problem," that is, prevalent antiblack attitudes and the failure of black Americans to be integrated into mainstream society, the "Oriental Problem" or, more specifically, the "Japanese Problem," in Hawai'i was defined as anti-Japanese attitudes (those who, before during, and after World War II viewed Japanese as potential spies and traitors to the United States) and the Japanese's inability or unwillingness to assimilate to American norms. Adams's writing sought to answer the Japanese problem by illustrating that Hawai'i's Japanese population was not in fact a barrier to Hawai'i's Americanization. Through analyses of demographic shifts, he emphasized that though Japanese residents of Hawai'i were by far the least likely to intermarry with other races, they would likely follow the example of other Asian groups like the Chinese and eventually intermarry with whites and Native Hawaiians. Thus, Adams's scientific view backed up other nonacademic [accounts] of Hawai'i at this time as, in Honolulu minister Albert Palmer's words, "a bridge between Japan and America." Palmer concluded his 1924 book *The Human Side of Hawaii* thus: "After all that is just what Hawaii means—a human bridge of international good will and understanding between East and West!"

Given the Chicago School's understanding of race relations as primarily about attitudes and feelings, rather than [social] structures, interracial marriage between "East and West" was seen as a key bellwether of lessening racial prejudice. For Adams, Hawai'i's rates of racial intermarriage were exceptionally high relative to the mainland United States, and thus race problems seemed to him practically nonexistent there. Hawai'i's high rates of racial intermarriage also seemed to uniquely prove the achievement of assimilation (according to the Chicago race relations cycle) into American society....

Thus, though Hawai'i was exceptional, like the broader ideology of American exceptionalism, Adams thought Hawai'i should be used as racial laboratory because it promised a universal model for race relations everywhere. In his influential 1937 book *Interracial Marriage in Hawaii*, Adams argued "Hawaii presents an exceptional opportunity for the observation and study of a type of social process [namely, racial amalgamation] that has been going on in many parts of the world for a long time.... Since Europeans and Asiatics began to come to Hawaii there has been sufficient time to permit of many interesting changes...."...

Adams was interested in Native Hawaiians only insofar as they made up a piece of Hawai'i's racially mixed population. He took for granted the findings

of eugenics literature that Native Hawaiians were quickly dying out and that all residents of Hawai'i were therefore becoming part of a new mixed race of "Hawaiians" (non-Native, but unmarked as such). In this way, we might say that he could not think beyond the logic of possession through whiteness that had been formulated in the Polynesian Problem and eugenics literature that came before him. This stance was abundantly evident in a 1926 address Adams gave to the Pan-Pacific Research Institution, titled "Hawaii as a Racial Melting Pot." Subsequently published in the Mid-Pacific Magazine, Adams's address explained the import of racial intermarriage in Hawai'i by describing a hypothetical demographic equation:

> Take the 13 Japanese women who married other Caucasians, and if in the next 50 years they have 30 children, it will be more natural for them to marry out than for their parents, and finally you get 1/4 and 1/8 strains and finally the racial boundaries are obscured and within 3 or 4 hundred years people will not know what blood they have in their veins. In fact nearly everyone here will be entitled to go to Kamehameha Schools.
>
> In my own case, I hardly know what combinations I have represented in my ancestry. I found out on a trip to Ohio that I had German, Irish, English, Scotch and Dutch, and many of you are probably the same.

In this quote, we can see that although the racial and ethnic groups that Adams mentions do not include Native Hawaiians, he sees all of these races (and his Pan-Pacific Research Institution audience) as eventually being "entitled to go to Kamehameha Schools...." Kamehameha Schools was set up for Native Hawaiian children (as determined by genealogy, not by blood quantum fractions) and has retained a Native Hawaiian first admission policy. By projecting that in "3 or 4 hundred years people will not know what blood they have in their veins," Adams assumes that everyone will be fairly counted as Native Hawaiian, making Kamehameha Schools open to all. Adams therefore assumed that specific Native Hawaiian Indigenous ties to culture, land, ocean, and sovereignty in Hawai'i would naturally transfer to all settlers of Hawai'i. Although this transfer was ostensibly to be universal, including to Asian immigrants to Hawai'i, Adams's final emphasis of his "German, Irish, English, Scotch and Dutch" roots as a commonality with the audience (his quip that "many of you are probably the same") highlights the fact that white men would hold a particularly important kind of entitlement to Native Hawaiian-ness. In this way, the logic of possession through whiteness is also quite baldly a logic of commensurability—an understanding that everyone would eventually be the same, and racial or ethnic distinctions would cease to matter.

Yet this desired commensurability would benefit white settlers and dispossess Native Hawaiians of their own identities, along with their lands.... [S]ettler colonialism required not only the assimilation of Native Hawaiians into the United States but also relied upon changing the category of "Hawaiian" into something that white Americans who had settled or aspired to settle in Hawai'i would be able to inhabit, perform, and possess.... Thus, the "Hawaiian" was

implicitly or explicitly redefined as always, at base, a "Part Hawaiian"; someone who was always part something else too. And though that part something else could be Asian, it was the being part white that really mattered. Because, though ... [the image of Hawai'i as a melting pot] uses Hawai'i to show a unique fulfillment of America's foundational ideals of racial equality and democracy, it also shows that its ideal of multiculturalism was premised on the assimilation of "other" races into the white race.... Indeed, the discourses about racial mixture in Hawai'i were never fixed on the result of an even mix of racial, physical, and moral characteristics. Rather, as Pacific Islands Studies scholar Damon Salesa puts it in the context of racial amalgamation policies in colonial New Zealand:

> A proper amalgamation did not combine two races into a "new" race that was substantially mixed or intermediate; rather the process of amalgamation projected, very baldly, the disappearing of one race into another.... Yet, although the other race would then no longer exist as a race, race itself would still pertain, still visible in individuals.

Thus, if individuals in Hawai'i still demonstrated "threatening" racial characteristics or an affinity for identifying as "Native Hawaiian," this was not sufficient evidence to deny that the category of "Hawaiian" was becoming universal and that Hawai'i overall was becoming truly American. It also allowed a racial hierarchy to implicitly remain even as such multicultural equations seemed to gesture toward the end of racial distinctions altogether....

Adams encouraged a public image of Hawai'i as a racially harmonious place, actively publishing in popular journals and teaching classes not just for university students but the public (especially businessmen) in Honolulu. Even his most academic work, his text *Interracial Marriage in Hawaii*, he understood as important to nonacademic audiences. Manganaro notes that he planned:

> to send *Interracial Marriage in Hawaii* to all plantation managers first; then to principals of all schools, public and private, that had four or more teachers including language schools; territorial officers; members of the University of Hawai'i faculty; members of the Institute of Pacific Relations; universities on the department exchange list; pastors of churches; directors of sugar and pineapple companies; and members of the Hawaii Sugar Planters Association.

Adams's advocacy of Hawai'i as a model of race relations undeniably took on significance beyond academia; then—he saw his research as directly relevant to the economy, projecting that Hawai'i's lack of racial conflict would maintain social stability and encourage the growth of business.

Adams's views may have even influenced Hawai'i's eventual incorporation into the United States as a state. He submitted expert testimony to the first hearing on Hawai'i's statehood in 1935, where he pointedly deflected fears about the "Japanese problem," noting that the Japanese population in Hawai'i was declining. Okamura further notes the legacy of Adams's ideas in the persistent image of the "Hawai'i multicultural model," which first emerged in popular and academic literature of 1980s and continues to exert an influence today. The repetition of

tropes about Hawai'i as "the 'ethnic rainbow', 'positive example', and 'melting pot'" in the news media, Okamura argues, has influenced a "countless" audience of people around the world to understand Hawai'i in such simplistic, and erroneous, terms....

[For example,] The U.S. Department of the Interior published a booklet called Hawaii and Its Race Problem in 1932 [in response to the racial fears sparked by the Massie affair of 1931], which sought to reassure the public that "race antagonisms" in the islands were "practically non-existent." This booklet concluded:

> There is much apprehension lest groups in Hawaii based on race should come into political dominance.... It is a part of the beautiful experiment, here in the mid-Pacific, that self-government is to be tried out under conditions and with human material that is new. There is nothing so far to indicate that the experiment will not turn out to be as successful as it is interesting.

The rhetoric of Hawai'i as a racial laboratory or experiment station closely mirrored the sociological work of those like Romanzo Adams and is deployed in this government document to underline the fact that the United States was in charge of all "experimenting" and that the white population of Hawai'i had the racial masses under control.

In sum, ... Hawai'i's enduring image as a place of racial mixture and racial harmony was [first] constructed in the work of sociologists, trained in the Chicago School of Sociology and based at the University of Hawai'i from the late 1920s ... who understood Hawai'i as a racial laboratory.... While such accounts sought to prove Hawai'i's suitability, even destiny, to be American, ... discourses proclaiming the virtues of the coming "neo-Hawaiian-American race" were used to cover the continued existence of Native Hawaiian people and claims to sovereignty.

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CHAPTER 7



# Americanization and the Second Generation, 1924–1941

*The process of becoming American, or Americanization, has been a perennial concern in U.S. society and politics. Scholars, like the general public, have understood Americanization from three different perspectives. First is the conception of the melting pot, which at its most literal connotes the mixing of various peoples and cultures to create an entirely new one—the American. Related to, and often confused with, the melting pot is the idea of Anglo conformity, which has meant that newcomers must give up their cultures and adopt the mainstream culture. Note that one must pay close attention to what is meant by assimilation, because this term can mean either the melting pot or Anglo conformity. A third perspective, cultural pluralism, is best recognized in today's society. It casts the United States as a mosaic of irreducible ethnic, racial, and cultural differences. There are two versions of pluralism: a soft variety celebrates differences as a source of the nation's strength, while a hard one views such differences as the basis for persistent conflict, discrimination, and inequality.*

*An important interest among historians has been how Asian Americans have engaged the issues of Americanization. How could the immigrants prove to the white majority that they could become good Americans? As the documents and essays in Chapter 6 show, the answer to this question continued to evade Asian Americans into the 1920s. At this time, a profound demographic change—the coming of age of the immigrants' children, the U.S.-born second generation—was under way. This change would come to have major historical significance. As U.S. citizens, the second generation was legally immune from policies like exclusion or land laws that discriminated against immigrants. Another crucial difference from their parents was that the second generation usually had no cultural or linguistic handicaps to evoke misunderstanding and mistrust between themselves and whites. The foundation of their Americanization was public schooling, in which the second generation was taught to think and behave like Americans often by white teachers who were convinced they were good citizens.*

*The Americanization of the second generation did not shield its members from racial prejudice. Many abhorred the fact that the general society saw them as no more trustworthy*

*than their immigrant parents. But it was no coincidence that the second generation played a decisive role in dismantling anti-Asian racism after the start of World War II. The roots of this revolution in race relations reached back to the 1920s and 1930s.*

## DOCUMENTS

Documents 1 to 4 reveal the experiences and perspectives of various Asian American women. Document 1 is an excerpt of a transcribed interview conducted as part of a scholarly study in 1924 researching the conditions of race relations on the West Coast. Here the American-born Flora Belle Jan projects an image of iconoclastic youth rebellion that was popular at the time. While rejecting her parents' Chinese traditions, she is also rejected by mainstream white society. Document 2 excerpts an essay extoling the virtue of racial tolerance and cultural pluralism written by the celebrated novelist Pearl S. Buck, a white American who was born and raised in China and thus identified as a particular type of Chinese American. Buck's essay was written amid growing international sympathy for China. The United States opposed Japan's growing imperial conquests in China, and although the United States was technically neutral at the outbreak of the second Sino-Japanese War in 1937, President Franklin Roosevelt and the mainstream press supported the Chinese. Another source of sympathy for China came from the success of Buck's novel, *The Good Earth*, which won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1938. This novel offers a heroic depiction of Chinese peasants that contradicted the then-popular stereotypes of Chinese coolies in the United States.

The 1930s was a decade in which Filipino and Korean immigrants were putting down roots in the United States. In Document 3, Connie Tirona reflects wistfully upon her childhood in close-knit Filipino immigrant communities, while also addressing the race and class prejudice she experienced growing up in the San Francisco Bay area. In Document 4, the American-born Dora Yum Kim, a Korean American, looks back on her life growing up among Chinese and Japanese Americans. Unlike her Korean immigrant parents, Kim mixed easily with other Asian Americans; international conflicts in Asia did not prevent her from being friends with either Japanese or Chinese Americans. She had a harder time, however, gaining the trust of white classmates.

Documents 5 to 7 focus on the Americanization of Japanese Americans. Document 5 is a letter to the editor of the *New York Times* in which Sidney Gulick, a leading opponent of Japanese exclusion, supports the naturalization of Asian immigrants who served in the U.S. military during World War I. These men were promised citizenship upon their enlistment, but after the war they were denied it. The government finally made good on its promise of citizenship through an act of Congress in 1935, and Document 6 is an excerpt of congressional testimony related to this act. Here the leading proponent of granting citizenship to the immigrant veterans, Tokutaro Slocum, underscores his own Americanization as a Japanese who was raised by a white American family. Finally, Document 7 is an

editorial in a Japanese American newspaper that bemoans the lack of job opportunities for second-generation Japanese Americans or Nisei, as they were called. Nisei were, by far, the largest cohort of American-born Asians during the period, and they benefitted from working in the agricultural businesses of Japanese immigrants. But they were often frustrated because their schooling (some had college degrees) prepared them for work in the mainstream economy that was denied to them because they were not white.

## 1. American-Born Chinese Woman Longs for Unconventionality and Freedom, 1924

Interview with Flora Belle Jan, Daughter of Proprietor of the "Yet Far Low," Chop Suey Restaurant, Tulare St., and China Alley, Fresno

Miss Jan is a graduate of the Fresno High School and has taken two years in the Fresno State College. She is a leader among the native born Chinese, very much interested in writing, dramatics and social life.

She entertained me in her father's upstairs restaurant for about an hour. My first approach was through Miss Purcell, but was unsuccessful and I finally saw her by presenting my card directly.

She said, "Would you like to hear something about my life? I will tell you if you are interested. I was born here in Fresno Chinatown and attended the city schools and graduated from the High School and have had two years in the State College. When I was a little girl, I grew to dislike the conventionality and rules of Chinese life. The superstitions and customs seemed ridiculous to me. My parents have wanted me to grow up a good Chinese girl, but I am an American and I can't accept all the old Chinese ways and ideas. A few years ago when my Mother took me to worship at the shrine of my ancestor and offer a plate of food, I decided it was time to stop this foolish custom. So I got up and slammed down the rice in front of the idol and said, "So long Old Top, I don't believe in you anyway." My mother didn't like it a little bit.

As I grew older I came to see that American life is also full of conventionality and foolish customs and it has become a fad of mine to study these things and to write about them. I long for unconventionality and freedom from all these customs and ideals that make people do such ridiculous and insincere things.

I have written a good deal in local papers about Chinese life. Much of this had displeased the Chinese people of Fresno. My article on "The Sheiks of Chinatown," (a description of the young sports of China Alley), was a takeoff on certain well known native born Chinese. It made a terrible fuss in Chinatown. I have had three blackmailing letters sent me for writing so openly about Chinese life. One of the Chinese students from North China became very angry at my article on the Sheiks and wrote me a very long, fat letter attacking me and

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From "Interview with Flora Belle Jan...," June 5, 1924, Box 28, Folder 225, Survey of Race Relations Collection, Hoover Institution on War, Revolution, and Peace. Stanford University, Stanford, CA.

picking to pieces everything that I had said. He thought that I was trying to disgrace China, which I distinctly was not, but only trying to have a little fun with my Chinese friends. All Chinatown got very excited and two of the boys, one from North China and the other from South China fought a kind of a duel over it. North boy said that I had disgraced China. South boy said No, that we should [not] be too proud to let a little dust like this hurt us. A delegation of Chinese students met me at college and I challenged them to show what I had said that disgraced anybody or anything. They put on their spectacles and after ten minutes could not find anything. I said, "Ta ta, Kiddos, when you find any disgrace you just put me wise. I can't wait all day."

It is very funny to watch the snobbishness of the girls at the state college. I listen to the Sorority girls talk over possible candidates to membership in their sorority. "It runs something like this, "Girls, what do you suppose, Jane Smith whom we've been rushing, is impossible. We've just found out that her father once drove a delivery wagon. They live in such a nice house and she wears such pretty clothes, who would have dreamed it. My, she's such a nice girl, it is really too bad." I happen to know that some of these very girls have families where the men are working at shop work and day labor and where the mothers do their own work. They judge people entirely by the clothes they wear and the amount of money they spend, and they get awfully stung in this way sometimes. Of course being a Chinese girl, I'm not eligible to membership in a sorority, but some of the girls are awfully good to me.

I have written a sketch of American girls, called, "Old Mother Grundy and her brood of unbaptized nuns," which takes off some of the characteristics of the modern flapper in American society.

At the Community House last week our Chinese Club gave a play called, "Miss Flapper Vampire," that I wrote. I was the leading character and about five young men played in it with me. There was a large audience of Americans. Afterward we danced and the American girls danced with the Chinese boys and I danced with American young men.

## 2. Author Pearl Buck Identifies as Immigrant from China, 1937

I HAD LIVED ALL MY LIFE AN AMERICAN AWAY FROM America. Then I returned, a sort of immigrant among immigrants, except that I came to my native land. But it was as new to me as though I came from Sweden or from Italy or Greece. I knew almost as little what to expect before I landed.

But we all have pictures, we immigrants, of what the America is to which we come. They must be pleasant pictures, or we would not have come. People do not easily leave all they know unless they hope for something much better. Of course I suppose most of us hoped for a better chance for a living, for more

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From Pearl S. Buck, "On Discovering America," *Survey Graphic* 26, no. 6 (June 1937). Reprinted by permission.

money, for more education, for more room. Some of us came for freedom, freedom to think as we liked, to be ourselves unhampered by family and traditions. Some of us, like me, came because we wanted to come home, never having known what it was like to be at home, having lived always among an alien race, spoken a foreign tongue and walked the streets and roads of every day as a foreigner. We have all come to the America we each thought we saw.

I wish I could find out what other people have found in America. But I only know what I have found. I came from China, a land of long homogeneity and of unity, except perhaps for that least important of all, political unity. The Chinese are of the same general race. They have had an unbroken history of thousands of years. Their religions are the same, organized into three great types, mutually tolerant, non-evangelical, and mellowed by long human experience to a philosophy of humanism. Social customs are firmly fixed and such impacts as come from modern usages come against a solid whole which they can penetrate only gradually and therefore without great upset. Even the language is not really diversified, because three fourths of the people speak one language, or some form of it. Out of this great security of long established unit I came to America.

Now I had my picture of America, too. It was made up of visual images of my mother's much loved country home, of which she told me many stories, of a land of great plenty and ease, from which came money for the poor Chinese, because all Americans were rich and Christian. It would not have occurred to me that there were illiterate Americans, or unwashed or poor Americans, or criminals. As I grew older and understood better inevitable human nature this picture was modified and reason did indeed compel me to understand that heaven existed nowhere. But still something of this early picture persisted.

I BELIEVED, FOR INSTANCE, THAT IN LEAVING CHINA I WAS leaving forever the sight of hungry people whom I was powerless to feed. I thought I was leaving behind the sight of wasting floods and dried and sun-baked, treeless lands, swept by dusty winds. I thought I was coming to a country which had organized itself into economic plenty and moral clarity. I had heard all my life that America was rich, and I did not think of these riches as being selfishly gained or used. Money was poured generously out of America into China for famine relief, for Christian propaganda, for many and endless causes. Americans, then, though they were rich were generous, interested in a world culture, international-minded. I longed to meet my countrymen, whose idealism seemed almost fantastic to the materialistic philosophy of China.

When I first came here, then, I endeavored to find this recognizable country of my own. I looked first for Americans. But I could not find them. It seemed to me the country was full of foreigners. I found delightful people, for I came home under the best possible circumstances, having done a sort of work of my own which somehow made me friends. The people were wonderfully kind to me, but they seemed to me like English people, or Europeans. I kept thinking, "Where are the Americans?" It was very puzzling. I bored everybody by asking continually, "Where does one find the real Americans? What would *you*

consider the typical American?" To my bewilderment everyone replied the same way—that is, *he* was American, his ancestors had come over in the Mayflower or before the Revolution or before the Civil War or something, and *he* was the typical American if there ever was one....

I came to see that these true Americans I had been looking for did not exist at all, and there are no typical Americans. I have come indeed to feel that if there is a typical American it is the one least typical of anyone except himself. The one hundred percent American, for instance, is one hundred percent nothing except himself, and represents nothing else....

And everywhere I was hurt and confounded by the amazing hatred among all these Americans for each other. I have heard such hatred for black Americans from white Americans, such venomous sullen hatred for white Americans from black Americans, that in another country I would have been afraid of immediate race war. And the hatred burns like wildfire in a hundred different directions. There is the hatred of the Jew and the Christian, of the native-born and the foreign-born, of the Protestant and the Catholic, and these are only a few of the greater hatreds. It is true also that combating each separate hatred, like a leash upon a beast, is an organization of people working for peace between any two opposing groups. But it is a question whether the leash is strong enough for the beast. At least, a sensitive mind at first cannot but be frightened and oppressed by the fearful prejudices of race and creed which possess the feelings of the average American.

Thus afraid and oppressed, therefore, I began to delve into these dark feelings which few Americans, it seems to me, are willing to face and acknowledge. For feeling is the basis of these hatreds which take such strange and violent open expressions as lynching, as unjust treatment of aliens, as inhuman deportation laws. With my Chinese training, I cannot get excited over a particular individual or over a particular bill in Congress, but I can get deeply excited over why people should want to commit murder by lynching, or why people should want to deport, wholesale, persons who are honorably fulfilling their places as human beings in our country, if not as citizens. The reasons why we hate each other are very important indeed, and there is no cure for individual injustices until those causes are clearly understood.

From whence, then, do all these diversities of hatred come in our country.... Why then, do we Americans so hate each other and especially so hate those whom we consider aliens among us? I will not here dwell upon my complete astonishment in discovering that we, who are so generous to foreigners in their own lands, who rush relief to Belgium and Czechoslovakia and China and Japan, are so ruthless to the same foreigners who find themselves aliens in our own country. It must have bewildered others than I. A hundred reasons are given me for it. I am told by many that the chief one is economic. But I do not believe people hate each other in groups fundamentally because of economic conditions. Poverty and stress merely augment already existing hatreds. What I want to know is, why do the hatreds exist at all, and why do they burn with such fearful heat in America, still the richest country in the world?

I HAVE GONE BACK IN MY SEARCH, "CHINESE FASHION," TO our beginnings. I find we are all immigrants, we Americans. Not one of us is really native in any profound sense. Everybody in the United States, except the Indians, is now or was once, foreign-born. I find it ridiculous to hear a man whose great-grandfather came to this country look down on a man who comes in now, and call him "alien." For what is a hundred or two hundred years in the life of a nation? The nation is and will be for centuries to come made up of the foreign-born, that is, people from all countries. And looking at all these people, I discover in them all the diversities of the world in race, in culture, in religion. They have only one thing in common with which to become Americans. They are all restless....

BUT I KNOW VERY WELL THAT WHEN I THINK OF OUR America a thousand years from now and five thousand years from now that I am thinking Chinese and not American. The Chinese thinks instinctively in terms of centuries and he sees himself as a particle in time. But the American stretches his imagination to pain if he thinks two generations ahead to the grandchild that is an actuality or a possibility. That is a trait of the restless. We cannot and will not wait, though the truth remains that the only true view is the long one, and the present will not be right if it is an end in itself instead of being as well a foundation for the future. We Americans, that is, cannot and will not think of our nation as a whole in time and space and so choose nationally, though perhaps at immediate inconvenience, what permanent stuffs we want in our making. We demand to know what we shall do now, in our momentary situation, with "aliens," as we call them, in our jobs, on our relief rolls, and sending good American money out of the country.

Unfortunately for me as an American, I cannot froth about any of these things. I see these "aliens" first as human beings, and I observe that many, indeed most of them, are honest and industrious, or as honest and industrious as the upstarts who dare, at this early date in our history, to call themselves, "the Americans." Citizens or not, I cannot see why these good people should be deported. We need honesty and industry. No nation can have too many people with these qualities. I cannot see why they should not be relieved if they starve, nor why they should not send money back to Italy or anywhere else. I should think the more money circulates the better. The richer the Italians are, the better for American markets. And in return for this money the people have given good hard labor on roads and bridges and buildings and the money is theirs when they have earned it, my American spirit tells me. And America is still the richest country in the world and likely to remain so.

Nor can I get excited over the differences between us. Hatreds, yes—they are stupid and wrong. It is senseless to hate a man because he is different, and the fault is in our education which has not made us enough above the beast to see this. For though men hate each other when they come here, they should be taught as the basis for American citizenship that here we may differ each from the other, and that diversity is our strength and our nature, and each man is to believe what he feels true, and our one common belief is this.

## 3. American-Born Filipina Connie Tirona Recalls Growing Up in Immigrant Community, 1930s and 1940s (1995)

### *Childhood Memories of the* Manongs

When my parents landed on Angel Island in San Francisco Bay, their friends were in the Delano area working in the grape fields. My parents did not know where Delano was. A Japanese grower from Stanford decided to hire them. (Part of Stanford at one time was all a nursery owned by this Japanese farmer.) So my parents had a place to stay.

But their friends from Delano contacted them again and asked them to join them there, where they could earn more money. So my parents decided to move to Delano to be near their *kababayans* (countrymen) from Hawaii. My father said there was a lot of Bombays (East Indians) but not as many Mexicans in Delano. However, the Bombays were moving on to El Centro. My parents stayed in that area for quite some time, until I was born, and then my father decided to move the family back to northern California.

I was born in 1929 in Selma, which is right next to Fresno. I remember many Filipinos as I was growing up. They still had their cockfights. The cockpit arena was really the gathering place for all the Filipinos. Even if some didn't like to bet on the cockfights, everybody was there. I remember the women having little stalls, with their little tables filled with individual special delicacies they had cooked. And of course, the men who were single at the time were so happy to have Filipino food because they lived in these barracks, while the families lived in cottages and could prepare their own food. These cottages were really dilapidated shacks, but they were always kept neat and immaculate.

Even when they were following the seasonal crops, all of them—there were three families in my parents' group—would pitch in to buy a car so they could travel from camp to camp. And we would all go in that car, and I can remember sometimes there was not enough work for everyone, and the ones who got the work would buy the groceries. And everyone would pitch in to get a small place where we all lived together. It was somewhat crowded, but we always kept it clean. Everybody would cook and help.

I can remember one time, they were down to their last fifty cents. They were going to another place where there was an opening for pruning grapes. So, the other two families would stay behind in the place that they had rented, while the rest would go seek jobs. Well, they only had fifty cents. Two chickens crossed the road. Let me tell you, those chickens did not stay alive for very long. They plucked them and cleaned them that night. They gathered vegetables from their garden; they always had a garden wherever they went. They threw everything in a pot. Those two chickens fed three families that night. Soon they were able to get jobs again. Not one of us ever went hungry.

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From Connie Tirona, "Sometimes, I Am Not Sure What It Means to Be an American," in *Filipino American Lives*, ed. Yen Le Espiritu (Philadelphia, PA: Temple University Press, 1995), 66–71. Reprinted by permission.

When I was about four or five years old, my parents moved up to Oakland. With his experience working in the shipyard in Hawaii, my father eventually got a job at a shipyard. So he was able to leave the agricultural job environment. He was a rigger and retired from the Mare Island shipyard after twenty years. And guess what? He went back to work as a foreman in the fields again. I think he was one of the first who wanted to organize a union against the growers. He was always fighting for the rights of workers.

In the 1930s, most of the *manongs* were still on the farms. The *manongs* were those men who came here from Hawaii without any families. They were bachelors. And they were the best dancers, the best dressers. There was just something very suave about them....

There were about thirty *manongs* in the labor camps in the Sacramento—San Joaquin area that we would visit. Sometimes the *manongs* would come and visit us. They were so homesick for family. They always looked up to my father because he had a "government job" in the shipyard. We went to see them almost every week or every other week. My mother would bake all her delicacies all week long for such visits, and the *manongs* enjoyed eating them.

It was so beautiful there when we visited them. They built what looked like a Japanese bathhouse. They installed a huge metal tub with hot coals underneath to warm the water. Of course, you had to bathe outside first. That was the biggest treat! And the *manongs* would fix up their rooms immaculately. They scrubbed their place because "the families were coming!" They picked fresh corn and cooked good, wholesome food. Their big thing was fishing in the delta's rivers. We would go up there and fish, and they would be roasting pigs.

After eating they would play guitars and mandolins, and we, as little children of the families, would sing and dance. The *manongs* liked to hear the little kids sing. They had a small makeshift stage for us, and we would go up there with our curly hair and cute little dresses. And they would throw coins at us. It was the biggest thing for them. You could just see tears of joy on their faces. They would come up and hug us. And I was thinking, "Gosh! Just a little joy that we brought to them." But they were so happy.

I especially remember when we sang the Visayan songs. You could see the tears on the faces of those grown men. Usually, Filipino men are not like that. I don't think Asian men really show their feelings. I remember my younger sister had a beautiful soprano voice, and she would sing this one Visayan song that said something about how hard life was in a strange land. It was like a love song. As they listened to her song, tears would form and slowly flow from their eyes. They would drink their wine and cry softly. They would say to my parents, "Thank you for teaching your daughter to sing that song."

Soon it was time for us to go to bed. As I was drifting off to sleep, I could hear them laughing as they started to sing nostalgic songs from the Philippines. Lying on a small cot, it just lulled me to sleep. The next morning, we would go fishing again and do the same thing. Breakfast was prepared and served. We would leave for home on Sunday evening. After such weekends, the *manongs* prepared for another grueling week of hard work.

The *manongs* bought me my first bike. They wanted to have snapshots taken so they could send them back to their families in the Philippines. When they received mail from the Philippines, they would ask me to read it to them. Some of them did not read well. Their families probably had someone write the letters in English for them. One of the letters said. "Thank you for the picture of your adopted daughter with the bicycle you got her. Thank you for the money that you sent." And I would end up writing back to them. The *manongs* would keep the mail they received until it became so frayed and torn because of so many readings. You could tell that they read it at night when loneliness overcame them.

I wish for those days again. If I could relive one day in the past, I would love to see them again.

## Growing up in the 1930s and 1940s

At this time, Filipinos were experiencing much prejudice and discrimination. We could not buy homes in certain areas. My parents bought a home in Vallejo on the other side of town by the waterfront, where all of the people of color lived. We would take walks on Saturday nights to pass the time away. We could not afford anything else. We just wanted to see people. We could see all the Filipinos all dressed up with no place to go, except the dance halls. My mother would say, "No, no! We don't go this way," as if I didn't know what was down there.

Where we lived there was one certain block that you could go up to and feel comfortable. You could go to this one theater, and that was all right because that was where all the people of color would go. But if you went beyond to the next block, people would stare at you. They would look at you when you went into a department store. My father would say to us, "Well, we don't have to go there. Things are so expensive up there anyway."

Being foolhardy, I told my sister, "Well, I am going up there." She told, me that I should not. When I asked her why, she told me what had happened to her. She had gone into a department store because it fascinated her. The manager told her she did not belong in there and to get out. She told the manager she was just looking around and was not doing anything wrong.

I guess that when you are a child and curious, you would do anything. Since I could not go into that department store, I remembered that there was a Sees candy store in the same block. So I went there to buy a piece of candy. The lady in the store asked if I had any money. When I showed her my money and pointed to the piece of chocolate candy I wanted, I remember her taking double pieces of paper so she wouldn't touch my hands. Being the child that I was, I purposely dropped the money on the floor. She had to come around the counter to pick it up. I was about eight at the time.

Then I decided I would be more adventurous, so I went down to another block and into another department store. Again, I was kicked out. Then I went into a Chinese-owned store, and they welcomed me with open arms. They asked me what I was doing at that end of town. I told them I was just curious

and wanted to find out what it was like, since we were told that we could not go there.

Of course, I got a spanking afterward because I disobeyed my parents. My father sat me down and asked, "Well, what did you learn?" I replied, "Everything you said was true, Papa." He said, "I just wanted you to know that you can do these things. You can go anywhere; it's just that you may not be treated as good as other people. So you have to learn how to respond and react in that situation." I told him about dropping the money on the floor in the candy store, and he laughed.

I went to a Catholic school. The reason we were able to attend this school was because the sisters said that we only had to pay so much. Our home was five miles away from the school I attended. But that was all right, since I had many friends that I picked up on my way to school. I can remember walking to elementary school and being taunted at times.

My sister and I were the only ones of color in the school. But that never bothered me because I thought I could play just as well as anyone could, and I was equally as bright as the other students, if not brighter. I used to bring rice and fish to school for lunch because I love to eat both. It was a great meal for me. The little girls would not sit by me, and I wondered why, because their lunch was not as good as mine. The nuns would come over and say, "They don't understand."

In high school, some of my friends were Greeks and Italians. They were white people but never thought about color. The only problem that I had was when they had a school dance. They did not allow people of color to attend. My friend, who was the captain of the basketball team, invited me. I told him I could not go, and he said he would not go either. All my friends said they would not go also, but I told them it was the rule and rules are not made to be broken.

## 4. American-Born Korean Dora Yum Kim Recalls Growing Up in Chinatown, 1920s–1940s (1999)

I started going to school at Lincoln Grammar School in Oakland. Then we moved back to San Francisco when I was in second grade, where I started going to the Jean Parker School. When I started going to school, my mother told us that she had tried to take English lessons. She had gone to the ESL classes they had at a Chinese church located a block down from where we lived. But she said it just wouldn't go into her head, and so, ... I knew I was on my own. I ended up translating for my mother.... I don't remember how old I was, but I think by the time I was in second or third grade I was writing notes for my mother excusing me from school when I and, later, my brothers were sick.

When I was in grammar school, my mother had two Korean friends who spoke good English. And this one woman was just beautiful. This family

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From "Coming of Age" in *Doing What Had to Be Done: The Life Narrative of Dora Yum Kim* by Soo-Young Chin (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1999). Reprinted by permission.

owned a cleaning shop, and she sewed, so she dressed up her four daughters just beautifully. And her English ... I think I used to envy the girls because their mothers would come to the PTA meetings and talk with the teachers. My mother couldn't do that. She was so busy at the business that she probably couldn't have come anyway. But even if she did come, she couldn't communicate with anybody. In fact, most of the parents from Chinatown couldn't speak English and were fully engaged in minding their businesses. And I remember envying these girls because their mothers spoke English. When I was older, I learned that they spoke such good English because they were raised in Christian orphanages in Korea. But I didn't know that as a child. All I felt was the envy....

**What did going to school teach you about where you fit in America?**

Going to school was a real eye-opener. When I was young, before I went to school, I never thought about what I was or anything like that. But when I started going to school in Oakland, I realized I was different from most of the other kids at school—I was Oriental. But they never taught us about Orientals in America. I suppose by the time I was in second grade I already knew not to expect that. But what they did teach us about was China and Japan. I came to realize that there was no mention of Korea in geography or history. I couldn't find out anything about my background. So as a Korean I was invisible outside the small Chinatown Korean community. At that time the Koreans in the area were so actively involved in events in Korea, yet there was no mention of it in school.

I was really curious about my heritage, so I started cutting out anything I read in newspapers or magazines that had anything to do with Korea. These articles are where I learned how to talk about Korea and being Korean. I recall one picture of two Korean girls standing, instead of sitting, on a seesaw. I showed it to my mother, and she said, "I used to be real good at this. I could jump really high." ...

**I'm confused. Why did you rely on newspaper and magazine articles? I thought you said that your parents taught you about Korean heritage.**

My parents did teach us about Korea. I think they did a pretty good job of it. When I was growing up, I wanted to visit Korea because I felt proud to be Korean. But I wasn't quite sure what being Korean meant because we were different from our parents. Our parents' ideas of being Korean had to do with their experiences growing up and living in Korea. But we American-born Koreans didn't have that experience; all we had was secondhand information about it. Since I am Korean and not Chinese or Japanese, I found myself having to explain what I was at a young age. When I was in grammar school, it was hard for me to explain where Korea was and what the people were like. The articles

and clippings I saved in my scrapbook helped me explain these things in English to my classmates.

There are other differences between my parents' perspectives and mine. They were anti-Japanese because of the situation at home, but for the children it was different. It's different to be American. You know that your parents hate the Japanese, and that it's a sore point with them, but if your own experience doesn't support the hatred, it's all hearsay. Your parents tell you that in Japan the Japanese hate the Koreans and they still fingerprint them even though they have Japanese names and all that. But within the community of people we knew, we had a Japanese doctor, Dr. Clifford Uyeda, who went to Japan to try to fight against that. It didn't do any good, but as Americans we have different feelings than we're supposed to have. You can't tell what people believe based on appearance.

I also had close Japanese girlfriends. But as far as having Japanese friends, I was restricted. I couldn't bring a Japanese friend home. And I understood, and I just didn't bring them home. But I associated with lots of Japanese people.

**I know you can read and write Korean. When did you learn that?**

By the time I was in second grade, I could read and write Korean even though I couldn't understand everything I read. I don't actually remember learning to read and write, but I think my parents must have initially taught me. You know, from 1924 to 1965, when immigration laws were relaxed, no Koreans could come over except missionaries or students. The missionaries or students who did come over didn't have any money. So when they came to the restaurant, my parents felt so sorry for them and fed them. Anyway, I guess my dad must've made a deal with them. "Hey I'll feed you free if you'll teach my children Korean." So that's where I got some additional training in Korean. A few of them did come by to say hello after they got their Ph.D.'s.

I also remember going to Korean school with other Korean children. There were only about half a dozen kids of school age at any given time since there were no more than half a dozen total families here. I used to think that it was pretty terrible that the children would always cut classes. You would think that since we knew each other and their families they wouldn't just cut classes like that.... We had what they call *kuko hakyo* [Korean language school] at the church. The class was actually an organized tutorial. We tried to have that during summer vacations and other breaks. I don't remember studying very hard, but I remember all my Korean. In fact, even now I run into people who used to teach there. Not so long ago I ran into this man, and when we were introduced to each other, this guy says, "I taught her Korean." I remember reciting *kakya kokyo koekyoe ku kyu keu ki* [literally, the manner in which children recite the vowels with the first consonant (k/g) of the Korean alphabet] and all the other basics. I'm glad it stuck with me because I can read the Korean paper now and get the gist of it.

**Can you tell me more about going to school?**

In Chinatown we all went to the same grammar school, Jean Parker, school. It was on Broadway. We had the same teachers. I remember all the old maid teachers: Miss

Miller, the principal, Miss Guinasso, Miss Crowley, and all the other Misses. They were all old maid teachers in those days. We saw them as rather mean women who were strict and meted out punishment when you were bad. If you did something really bad, you were sent to Miss Miller. And we thought she was really mean! She would ask you to put out your hand and hit you with a ruler.

Actually, they were all nice when I think about it now. There was this Italian girl and myself who were Miss Valsangiacomo's pets. We used to clean up after school and we used to get a nickel and we all looked forward to that just for that nickel. It was amazing how much that nickel bought in those days. We used to run to a candy store called Splendid's, where you got five of this for a penny, five of that for a penny, and for a nickel you got a whole bunch of candy. Those were fun days.

At the Jean Parker school one student was always chosen to be captain of the traffic patrol they had at school, and one year my brother George was chosen to be the captain. He was the first Asian captain ever. You know, things like that are important. So many people today say, "What's so big about that?" It was a big deal. At that time they didn't hire Orientals even if you were born here, and our parents couldn't even buy property. Even in the schools, honors like valedictorian, which are supposed to go to the top student, weren't given to Asians. If you were an Oriental, you couldn't be a top student at that time. Forget it. Valedictorian? Are you kidding?

The Jean Parker school was the only school the kids from Chinatown could go to, and despite the limitations we faced as Oriental children, we had good teachers. When my three older children were in grammar school, they had all my teachers. Can you imagine? By then some of the teachers had gotten married, but they still remembered me. They taught my three kids before we moved out of Chinatown.

**What did you do after school and weekends other than work?**

Growing up in Chinatown, most of my girlfriends were Chinese, and they had to go to Chinese school after school. All the Chinese kids went to the Hip Wo school after school. So there wasn't really time to play with them. I have wondered if it's because they had to go to Chinese school every day that many of the Chinese who were born here still had accents. I actually think it's because the Chinese kids went to Chinese school that many of them really didn't have much time to study for American school.

In terms of the Korean girls, there were very few, and I was the youngest of the girls around my age. Often they wouldn't bother with me because I was younger than they were. So I didn't play with them much either. There were just a few girls who were younger, but they were much too young for me to play with.

So when I was growing up, I lived in the library. None of my girlfriends really used the library because they didn't have the time. But I would sometimes go twice a day. I'd read one book, bring it back, bring another book home. I was drawn to books. I enjoyed reading about other people's lives because I would get so absorbed when I read that I lived the parts. I still do. I remember being Jo in

Louisa May Alcott's *Little Women*. Maybe it was because there was nothing else to do in Chinatown in those days. The library was right down on Powell Street, where it still is. I used to like Nancy Drew books, the whole set, then the Five Peppers. I remember reading all of those. That's what I did after school when I didn't go down to my parents' restaurant ...

During high school ... [m]y social life was affected by discrimination. When I was at Girls' High School, there were dances. The girls used to be invited to dances at all boys' high schools. So my Chinese girlfriend and I decided to attend one of these dances just to see what it would be like. We talked about the fact that nobody was going to ask us to dance, but we decided to go just to see. Sure enough, every white girl was asked to dance, but this girl and I were never asked.

I didn't feel inferior or anything like that. I knew that not being asked to dance was part of discrimination and that it was a learned thing. And I knew that all those white boys were not going to have anything to do with Asians. I mean, my girlfriend and I were disgusted. I'm really glad I went with my girlfriend because imagine how I would have felt if I had gone there alone as the only Asian girl, being ostracized like that. It also could have been worse if we didn't know that we would be hurt. But we knew. We just went to see what it would be like anyway. And it hurt anyway. Back then I didn't think too long on being hurt. I thought it was just a part of life. We knew that we were Asians, and we couldn't do the things Caucasians did. We accepted that fact. And we were sheltered from the worst of the discrimination in Chinatown. But now I often think about these kinds of incidents that we had growing up when I read about the different effects of discrimination. When you grow up with it, it stays with you.

I didn't go to any more Girls' School functions. Instead, we went to the Chinese dances every Saturday night. I used to go around with a Chinese girl. All the high schools like Galileo High School, George Washington High School, Lowell High School, Commerce High School, Balboa High School, Polytechnic [a couple of those are no longer in existence] had a Chinese club with all Chinese members. And each week one club would give a dance with a live band. They, Chinatown, had a good band that played at the dances, and everybody [all the Asian teenagers] would look forward to that. It was mostly Chinese, and all the Koreans went, what few there were. Then toward the end of high school all the Japanese started to come because they didn't have anything like that. I would dance with any of the boys who would ask me—Chinese, Korean, Japanese.

## 5. Activist Supports Naturalization of Asian Veterans of World War I, 1925

On May 25, the United States Supreme Court handed down a judgment to the effect that Japanese who volunteered and served in the American Army during the World War are not entitled to the privileges of immediate citizenship on honorable discharge granted to other aliens under similar conditions.

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From Sidney L. Gulick, "Men Without a Country," *New York Times*, July 12, 1925.

An act of Congress, it seems, provided (May 9, 1918) that "any alien serving in the military or naval service of the United States during the time this country is engaged in the present war may file his petition for naturalization without making the preliminary declaration of intention and without proof of the required five years' residence within the United States."

This act was generally understood to be all-inclusive, free from any trace of race discrimination. On the basis of this law many thousands of aliens who had served in our armies secured citizenship papers from the appropriate courts. Among these were a few hundred Japanese.

The Court now declares that it was not the intention of Congress to extend these special privileges of naturalization to any except "free white persons" and persons of "African nativity" and "African descent" and that, therefore, all soldiers of other races serving in our army who have become American citizens have done so illegally. It follows that they are now to be deprived of this citizenship.

The Chief Justice dissented from the decision, but it is now the policy of our land to say that, though a Japanese or Chinese [or person from India] may serve in our army and may even give his life in support of our Constitution and our flag, he is not worthy to be an American citizen.

This surely is a reductio ad absurdam of the law passed by Congress. Reactions are beginning to come from Japan. The Yamato of June 2, 1925, discussing America's Immigration law, declares, as translated by the Japan Advertiser:

"As long as America assumes such an insolent attitude toward this country, the outbreak of war may be beyond our control. Our relations will be gravely jeopardized. The United States deceived the Japanese who joined the expeditionary forces and unjustly deprived them of the citizenship she once willingly granted them." ...

The seriousness of the situation is increased by the fact that these Japanese who became American citizens in so doing renounced allegiance to their former Government. What, it may be asked, is their status when their American citizenship is taken away? Will the Japanese Government accept them back again? Can she in good face receive back a man who has renounced allegiance and does not voluntarily return to it?

Should not Congress pass a law covering such cases—where citizenship was both given and taken in good faith? Should the judgment of the Supreme Court be in effect retroactive?

## 6. Japanese Immigrant Veteran Argues for U.S. Citizenship, 1935

Mr. SLOCUM: Honorable Mr. Chairman and honorable members of the committee, I come to you to appeal in behalf of oriental veterans, who served honorably during the late war in the American

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From Tokutaro Slocum, *House Immigration and Naturalization Committee*, Oriental Veterans (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1935).

forces, for the recognition of the certificates of naturalization which were granted to us.

I do not know, sir, that there is much more that I could say other than what has already been said by those that are in favor of the appeal that I am making. I appeal to you, members of the committee, to kindly consider this in a favorable light. The less I say the better, but I certainly will be grateful and I will do my very best to justify your faith in us.

The CHAIRMAN: Do all of these veterans speak English as well as you?

Mr. SLOCUM: Most of them speak English, sir. Perhaps I do not speak very good English. I am from North Dakota. [Laughter.] I think we try to put the spirit of sincerity in our language instead of correct English, but we mean well and we certainly would like to get citizenship, and we certainly appreciate it if you vote on this favorably.

I am too full of emotion to tell you how I feel, but I sure am grateful, particularly in view of the fact that such initiative as this was taken in the spirit of fairness and a gesture of good will from the very State that has been against the people of my native country. Well, I am just too full of gratitude for expression, but I sure would appeal to you for favorable consideration. That is all I can say, Mr. Chairman.

MR. BLACKNEY: How long have you been working on this?

Mr. SLOCUM: I have been working on this for a long time, sir; I reckon about 7 years.

The CHAIRMAN: You went to school in this country?

Mr. SLOCUM: Yes, sir; I went to school in this country. I have done everything, because I had to cover 48 States, and every State said, "I am in favor of you, Slocum, but you have to go to California and get their O. K." So I had to go to California.

The CHAIRMAN: Since when does California control this committee?

Mr. SLOCUM: But then the opinion of California must be respected, as you know, sir. That is the reason I went to California.

Mr. KRAMER: You do not mean that because there is a member from California on this committee that controls the committee?

Mr. SLOCUM: No, sir; but I respect your views, too, Mr. Kramer.

Mr. MILLARD: You are a professional man?

Mr. SLOCUM: I have been for this work. I had to do almost anything and everything, because you cannot take very good job in order to carry on appeal from one State to another. I have done everything.

Mr. MILLARD: Are you a college graduate?

Mr. SLOCUM: No, sir; I am not a college graduate, but I attended college 5 years.

Mr. MILLARD: What college?

Mr. SLOCUM: Minnesota and Columbia.

Mr. KRAMER: How long were you in the service?

Mr. SLOCUM: I was in the service not quite 2 years; I served in the same regiment with Sergeant York of Tennessee. I am proud to say I had the honor of being the only oriental sergeant major in the A. E. F. I did not abuse your confidence and I do not intend to abuse it now if you trust me in the future.

I speak in behalf of a few hundred orientals. They look rather forlorn. I told them, "Have faith; perhaps some day the American people will vindicate our faith in them and give us our citizenship." So I kept on.

I am mighty grateful to California, the Veterans of Foreign Wars, to the American Legion, and particularly to Mr. Lea, who believed in me, and Mr. Nye in the Senate, who believed in me, and at least gave me a break to be heard. I sure would like citizenship.

Mr. MILLARD: You would give up your citizenship in Japan if you become an American?

Mr. SLOCUM: We have already given up our citizenship, when we went in the American Army.

Mr. MILLARD: You have no responsibility to Japan, then?

Mr. SLOCUM: No, sir; no, sir. When we went into the American Army, we swore allegiance to America. We have given up our allegiance to Japan.

Mrs. O'DAY: How old were you when you came over?

Mr. SLOCUM: I was 10 years old.

Mr. MILLARD: You have been released by Japan, have you, so that if you become an American citizen you are released?

Mr. SLOCUM: Yes, sir. The law of Japan says that the minute you take allegiance to another country you are automatically released.

The CHAIRMAN: That is a good, sensible law.

## 7. American-Born Japanese Bemoans Limited Job Opportunities, 1937

I am a fruit stand worker. It is not a very attractive nor distinguished occupation, and most certainly unappreciated in print. I would much rather it were doctor or lawyer ... but my aspirations [were] frustrated long ago by circumstances, social and financial.... I am only what I am, a professional carrot washer.

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From Taishi Matsumoto, "The Protest of a Professional Carrot Washer," *Kashu Mainichi* [newspaper] (Los Angeles), August 4, 1937, English Language section, editorial page.

My work can be very pleasant at times. That is, if [I] make no complaints of long hours and little pay, thereby impressing my subdued qualities upon my employer who so approves of this virtue among his employees. He often goes out of his way to humor me, for he realizes that I am of a rebellious nature. He approaches me beaming, and plants a hearty slap on my shoulder ... attempting to create a comradely atmosphere. He attributes this familiarity to his and my parent's prefecture, Hiroshima, of which he may take advantage once too often. After all, what is Hiroshima ken [prefecture] to me? It is a mere name without meaning only that my parents had drifted from thence seeking a livelihood here in America. What so important connection is there here that my employer should make so much of it? I can almost say without due contempt that the man [i]s exploiting my labor in the name of an alien country. What sort of spineless fool am I to be accepting this daily hypocrisy?...

Disillusioned men, well on in their years, work with me side by side. They make no complaints; they make no progress; they accept the days as they unfold, following [in their] wake as though it were their undisputable lots. Yet what can they expect and what can be expected of them with their underdog complexes? Will I, and the rest of the nisei youths contract their attitude and inherit their lot?

I grit my teeth at the drudgery, the unending hours of the hopelessness of fruit stand work, and its meagre compensation. This cannot go on forever, much less can I go on.

It seems that I started out in life on the wrong foot. I feel [like] a square peg in a round hole.... An optimist would undoubtedly make the best of it, but even the most optimistic, after several years of market work[,] will begin to notice the hole.

I understand my position and realize that I am stagnating; that I am making no progress, and most keenly do I realize that ... I am getting older.

The little optimism that is left in me refuses to accept my ever increasing conviction that market work may have to be my career after all. It goads me on with the hope that when I have a few shekels saved that I can call my own, and only God knows when that will be, I will invest it in an enterprise which will be, through habit and familiarity rather than choice, most likely another market.

But until then, and it will be a long time till then, [are] there no inspired Messia[h]s, no strong organizations to whom I can appeal not only for myself, but for others like me, so that life will be less miserable, that we may bear fewer blisters on our hands and less corns on our toes?

## ESSAYS

The first essay, by Arizona State University historian Karen J. Leong, explores the complicated ethnic identity of film actor Anna May Wong. Leong reveals how Wong crafted a particular image as a Chinese American that was meant

for Hollywood and her fans, while keeping her personal identity private. In the second essay, University of Southern California historian Lon Kurashige addresses another type of biculturalism intended for public consumption—a festival in Little Tokyo. He argues that this event was a means for the Nisei to define themselves as good Americans while compelling their generation to shop in Little Tokyo.

## The Racialized Image of Anna May Wong

KAREN J. LEONG

### Hollywood's Narrative of White Heterosexual Romance

Hollywood's most established and popular plot narrative is that of the white heterosexual romance—white boy meets white girl, loses girl, wins girl back, and lives with her happily ever after. According to Hollywood's racial logic, and that of American society in general, nonwhites naturally desired whites, while those whites who desired nonwhites were obviously morally and emotionally deficient. Interracial erotic attraction—which was never honest, but based on deception, threats, or violence—inevitably complicated the plot. This diversion from the ultimate "happy ending" consummation of white heterosexual romance was only temporary, however. The white male protagonist's discipline—his mastery over his own or the nonwhite male's deviant desires—ultimately would triumph, demonstrating his moral right to the white female protagonist. As a Chinese American, Anna May Wong was not able to participate fully in portrayals of American femininity and whiteness; true womanhood continued to be defined as white and virtuous, and American orientalism assumed that Chinese (American) women lacked virtue.

Such was the case in Paramount's *Forty Winks* (1925), in which Anna May Wong earned a feature role as the pivotal character, Annabelle Wu. Wu's desire to be white and to win the love of a white man is a central theme in the story, further emphasizing whiteness as fundamental to the central romance between the American heroine and English hero. The screenplay makes stunningly clear the author's perception of a "typical" Asian woman in the scene where Annabelle Wu first appears:

> We intend to characterize Anna as a girl who would give her last drop of blood to be considered a "white" girl. She loves to think of herself as looking thoroughly American. To point this [out], we must make certain that all her dress (negligees, etc.) and her head-dress, in fact everything intimate and personal about her be done in American fashion. [But h]er instinctive reactions are *always* Oriental.

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Karen J. Leong, "Anna May Wong," in *The China Mystique: Pearl S. Buck, Anna May Wong, Mayling Soong, and the Transformation of American Orientalism* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2005), 57–67. Reprinted by permission.

These "Oriental" reactions, according to the screenplay, include wanting to be white and acting in a conniving and duplicitous matter. Yet no matter how much she strives to fashion herself as American in dress and makeup, Anna—as Annabelle appears in the scenario—will always remain innately Oriental.

In one revealing scene, Anna peers into the mirror, then looks intently at the magazine on her dressing room table. An advertisement on the open page promises. "For the thoroughbred American GIRL—a skin as white as milk! You can have it!," and features a full-length figure of the "Typical" American young woman on the margin. Her gaze drawn back to her reflection, Anna frowns at her "brown" arm and, directing her attention again to the mirror, attempts to "massage out her Oriental lines." Finally she reaches for a bottle of lotion, "Malhofsky's Milk White Magic." Gazing in the mirror, she imitates the pose of the "Typical American girl" pictured on the lotion's label. Annabelle Wu hopes that by achieving whiteness she will also win the love and adoration of Le Sage. But this cannot be. After Le Sage realizes she has failed him in his attempt to blackmail the heroine into marriage, he is furious. "You yellow fool! Do you know what this means to me? It means prison—for life!" When Anna hysterically indicates that they should flee together, his response, as written in the scenario, is to fling her from himself and out of the picture. "You! I hope I may never see your stupid, slant-eyed face again—you damned Chink!"

As the scenario suggests, definitions of femininity and whiteness mutually reinforce each other. White females—with the aid of cosmetics, fashion, and women's magazines—demonstrate femininity in their appearance, dress, and manners. The culmination of white femininity is to be desired by a white Euro-American male who is equally accessible for a heterosexual, romantic relationship and the security of marriage. The screenplay also exemplifies the racial violence that Wong, as the Oriental subject of the camera's gaze, regularly experienced. One film critic ruefully observed that Wong's complexion directly reflected the character of the women she portrayed: "Miss Wong is invariably conscripted when a moving picture demands Oriental intrigue. Her dark beauty appeared sinister by contrast with Nordic fairness of Laura La Plante in *The Chinese Parrot* and Dolores Gatella in *Old San Francisco*. She has been a villainess and a vampire, *but her appearance will never let her be heroine, although occasionally she manages to achieve a sympathetic role.*"

## The Intertextual Oriental

The celebrity-making apparatus of Hollywood extended Wong's romantic life offscreen to "an existence already laid out in films." Wong's hybrid identity formed the basis of her unique star personality: she was the one recognizably Chinese American female in films during the twenties and thirties. Her publicized "personal" life, an essential ingredient of celebrity, only confirmed and entrenched expectations from producers (and possibly even audiences) of the characters Wong could convincingly portray. Wong's conflict of cultures and her attempt to reconcile her American and Chinese backgrounds were central to her picture personality as developed in movie magazines and in her film

roles. Articles about Wong in film magazines, then, emphasized similarities, or intertextuality, between Wong's celebrity personality and the characters.

By the 1920s movie magazines marketed at movie fans constituted a particularly important mechanism for perpetuating personalities. Articles about film personalities promised their readers a glimpse into the real life of celebrity and a virtual relationship with particular actors inside and outside the movie theater. Interviews and articles "revealed" personal details of the star's ostensibly private life, individualizing his or her identity.... Hence publicists serve up stories to fulfill the audience's perceived desire to focus on, and identify with, the celebrity, to find out what made the individual unique and what kept her ordinary.

In this way, they projected onto Wong's private life Americans' fascination with Oriental exoticism and the stereotypical "all-American" (heterosexual) girl's desires of love, romance, and marriage. Discussions of her "real-life" cultural conflict set up a divergence of Chinese and American identities for Wong and the fanzine reader. For example, Wong discussed her family's reaction to her rather un-Chinese choice to become a film actor. "[My father] said I was disgracing his family and all that sort of thing, but I told him that I was determined to be independent some day, that I just couldn't be like the girls who live in China and it was no use trying to make me over." On the one hand, readers might partly identify with Wong's story of wanting to make choices independent of her parents. On the other hand, few readers could identify with the object of Wong's conflict—her Chinese ancestry.

These publications consciously appealed to middle-class and white adolescent women, who constituted the target audience for their advertisers' health and beauty products. Features about Wong affirmed white privilege and heterosexual same-race romantic relationships. The authors—many of them Euro-American women—implied that not being white resulted in suffering, and that any subsequent interracial relationships would be unfulfilling and tragic. In contrast to most movie magazine features, which focused on successful romances, features about Anna May Wong emphasized her romantic failures. A magazine article titled "The Tragic Real Life Story of Anna May Wong," was subtitled "Oriental Beauty Compelled to Choose Between Heritage of Race and Her Preference for an American Husband." Throughout this article the question of why Wong had to choose between race and nationality never presented itself. A caption in the same article read, "Anna May Wong finds it difficult to keep *her real Chinese self* separate from her westernized personality.

The conspicuous absence of publicized romance, a topic that immediately connoted a private life, became the core of Wong's public image. Discussions about Wong's romantic life emphasized gendered difference between the cultures of the West and those of the East. Helen Carlisle of *Motion Picture Magazine* reported Wong's conjectures about her marital status, heightening her privileged status as confidante and Wong's Oriental status. "In a burst of confidence, exceedingly rare among her people, she said to me one day: 'I don't suppose I'll ever marry. Whom could I marry? Not a man of your race, for he would lose caste among his people and I among mine.'" Another writer noted that

this "strange problem," which "seemingly has no solution," fastened itself to Wong's image. "Yet, Hollywood wonders, what true romance—and romance should go hand in hand with youth—can come to this girl who is a part, yet not a part?" Melodramatic articles portrayed her as continually divided and terribly lonely. The taboo against interracial romance offscreen translated into the prohibition of on-screen interracial romance and suggested that Hollywood's form of fulfillment was accessible only within the discourse of whiteness.

## Performing Orientals

Wong herself recognized a key distinction between her own embodiment of difference and Euro-American actors who performed Asians. Discussing her desire to portray the Asian wife of an Englishman in *Java Head*, she explained, "I know I will never play it. The captain, you see, *marries* the woman.... But no film lovers can ever marry me. If they got an American actress to slant her eyes and eyebrows and wear a stiff black wig and dress in Chinese culture, it would be allright. But me? I am really Chinese. So I must always die in the movies, so that the white girl with the yellow hair may get the man." As Wong acknowledged, her presence in a film as a publicly and visibly Chinese American actor maintained the distinctions of white/nonwhite in the midst of a perpetual play on appearance and served as a reminder that markers of Oriental exotica might adorn a non-Asian actor's body bur not ultimately affect his or her innate identity or character.

Hollywood's practice of *yellowface*, or making up Euro-American actors to "look Oriental," manifests another way in which whiteness constrained her opportunities in film. The ideology of whiteness as manifested in the film industry assumed that Euro-American actors were talented enough to perform roles that did not reflect their own identities or experiences: it also assumed that nonwhite actors could not perform roles beyond their social identities and lived experiences. In addition to competing with Euro-American actors for any Asian female protagonist roles, Wong also confronted the devaluation of her performance. For example, when Loretta Young played the Chinese ingenue and protagonist in First National's *The Hatchet Man* (1932), *Photoplay* featured a full-page photo spread, "Loretta Goes Oriental." "Intimate portraits of a smart, young American girl being turned into a Chinese woman" showed Young with adhesive and "fish skin" pulling back her eyes. The caption suggested, "The finished job might make you think Loretta was Anna May Wong." Additional captions explained that it was not necessary to cast a real Chinese "girl" like Anna May Wong because Loretta, who was already under contract with Republic, had made "tests ... as excellent as the make-up, so they thought you wouldn't know the difference." Yet "they"—the studio—clearly wanted "you"—the audience—to know the difference. The magazine hence discussed and displayed the two-hour process for its readers, differentiating the actor—"a smart, young American girl"—from the Chinese woman she portrayed on screen. Silk robes and a fan complemented Young's makeup of slanted eyes, pale skin, and black hair. These pan-Asian cues—music, lighting, scenery, costumes, and accents—all conveyed an Oriental aesthetic. The feature thus emphasized Young's acting

capabilities as an actor and her embodiment of white femininity while simultaneously undermining Wong's acting ability by focusing on her racial identity, implying that Anna May Wong could not overcome the limitations of her racial identity but Young could....

The use of yellowface continued the film industry's tendency to cast Euro-American actors as persons of African, Asian, or Latino heritage. The notion that Euro-American actors could reproduce any culture and ethnicity also presumed cultural superiority; members of "more civilized" cultures could pass as racialized others, but members of "primitive" or "backward" cultures could only *attempt* to do so, with either tragic or comic results, as was the case with Annabelle Wu. Indeed, one of Wong's greatest frustrations was repeatedly witnessing how the few female Asian roles available were awarded to Euro-Americans. For example, although Anna May Wong reportedly was the leading contender for the starring role in the screen adaptation of *The Son-Daughter*, the role was awarded to Helen Hayes.

Moreover, even when Wong gained a role, she was pressed to play it according to directors' preconceptions of Asian mannerisms. Bessie Loo, a Chinese American woman who also worked in the film industry during the thirties and forties, recalled, "there were no important parts ... for Chinese because they thought Chinese were passive, they did not have any emotions." In most of her speaking roles Wong appeared stiff, her expressions inscrutable, and her voice a monotone. Perceptions about Asian behavior influenced how non-Asian actors portrayed Asian characters as well. Myrna Loy portrayed an "Oriental" slave girl opposite Wong, her fellow inmate of the House of a Thousand Daggers, in the silent film *Crimson City* (1928). Loy, who is not at all inanimate in other roles, appears to have been directed to express little feeling. One reviewer even observed, "Miss Loy has the sloe eyes, the exotic feature which, it would seem, would make her well suited for her role. However, she is strangely unemotional."

American expectation about "Oriental" behavior thus reached beyond casting decisions to restrain Anna May Wong's moving and talking image onscreen. In silent films like *Piccadilly* or *Toll of the Sea*, Wong's expressiveness had distinguished her performances. A change in her carriage and presentation accompanied Wong's transition to the talkies. Wong's acting ability is undeniable in *Shanghai Express*, which provided one of Wong's few sympathetic, complex, and almost heroic roles. Paramount invested this film with the time and resources that would befit a celebrated actor, Dietrich, and an equally respected director, von Sternberg. As a result, Wong's character is more fully developed, providing Wong with the material for one of her best performances.

## The Global Politics of Film Representations

The glowing reviews Wong enjoyed for her work in *Shanghai Express* came from American film critics comfortable with China as a space of marginal morality. Wong confronted different reviews from Chinese already critical of Hollywood and American attitudes toward China. Chinese nationalism became even more internationally focused in the aftermath of the Mukden (Shenyang) Incident of

1931, when Japan occupied Manchuria in northeastern China. In January 1932 the United States, deeply mired in the Depression and isolationism, stated its "Non-Recognition Doctrine," asserting that it would not take sides. In March, Japan created a puppet state called Manchukuo (Dongbei) and even displayed Pu Yi, the last Qing emperor, as the head of state. While the League of Nations did not recognize Manchukuo as an independent state, the league did not actively oppose Japan's aggression.

Demonstrations against imperialism increasingly pointed out the presence of Western culture that depicted China in less than flattering ways. Chinese worldwide angrily sought to halt the film depictions of China's civil strife as a backdrop to foreign romance and adventure. Demonstrations took place in the streets of Chinese cities, and in the campuses of schools, and in movie theaters. During the filming of *Shanghai Express* one 1932 Chinese newspaper editorial decried that the film, "when completed, will further expose all evils of Chinese society, and as the Occident knows very little of Chinese and always entertains a contempt for things Chinese, the pictures always exaggerate the truth." This article entitled, "Paramount Utilizes Anna May Wong to Produce Picture to Disgrace China," reserved its most scathing criticism for Wong. "The Oriental star in Hollywood, Anna May Wong, is working as a featured player in America. Her specialty is to expose the conduct of the very low caste of Chinese, such as when she played the part of a half-robed Chinese maid in *The Thief of Bagdad [sic].* Although she is deficient in artistic portrayal, she has done more than enough to disgrace the Chinese race."

Chinese officials had long complained about China's depiction by Hollywood (as early as Harold Lloyd's work in silent films), but Anna May Wong was the target of particular ire because she herself was Chinese. Chinese speaking the language of nationalism were particularly fluent in translating the effect of gendered images. Half-dressed women prostitutes reflected on a nation's morals. Just as imperialism relied on ideas of proper feminine behavior to legitimize colonization as a civilizing project, some Chinese Nationalists—many themselves the products of Western education and thus doubly inculcated with norms of "proper civilization"—sought to legitimize the new, modern China through the representation of Chinese women. As Cynthia Enloe has noted, many communities seeking to affirm their national stature assign "ideological weight" to women's clothing, behavior, and sexuality, precisely because women are viewed as possessions of community, transmitters of culture, and mothers of the nation.

Hollywood and British film executives assumed that audiences expected a certain representation of Asian women. Because she was of Chinese descent, however, some Chinese interpreted Wong's representation, specifically her sexuality and ethnicity, as a reflection on China. According to Chinese officials, Wong's roles onscreen perpetuated negative stereotypes of Chinese women and damaged China's international reputation. Stereotypes propagated by missionaries in China—that the Chinese hated baby girls, abused and exploited women, and were immoral—flourished in Americans' imaginations. When asked how Wong was perceived in China, General Tu, the Chinese government's official

advisor to MGM for *The Good Earth*, replied, "Very bad. Whenever she appears in a film, the newspapers print her picture with the caption: "Anna May Wong again loses face for China." The general himself added, "I feel sorry for her ... because I realize that she has to play the part assigned her. It is the *parts* China objects to. She is always a slave—*a very undressed slave*. China resents having its womanhood so represented."

As a Chinese American woman performing American orientalism, Wong was caught in crosscurrents of nationalism, racism, and sexism. Paralleling the imperial culture that Helen Callaway describes as functioning through "its cognitive dimension," the American film industry circulated its hierarchy of race and nationhood worldwide through the technology of mass culture and the dominant status of its government. In an attempt to refute negative historical perceptions and images, some Chinese critics further entrenched the gendered division of a masculine nationalism and a feminine propriety and civility....

## Travel

Anna May Wong first discovered travel's transformative potential in the late 1920s. According to Wong's account, she met Dr. Karl Vollmoller, a German author, in Hollywood. After he returned to Berlin in 1927 Vollmoller arranged for a German studio to hire her for a feature role. Wong traveled outside the United States for the first time in 1928 when she sailed to Germany. There she starred in three silent films. After completing those films, Wong sailed to England in late 1928 to star in *Piccadilly* for British International....

Yet unlike Americans, who viewed her Chinese American identity as a liability, European audiences seemed to appreciate the complexity of her identity. When she made her London stage debut in *Circle of Chalk* in 1929 and was criticized for her flat voice, Wong worked with a vocal coach to improve her speaking voice and adopted a cultured English accent in the process. During Wong's return to England in 1930 the columnist Margery Collier observed that Wong combined stereotypes of both Chinese and American women and featured "the face and figure of a Chinese girl and the mind of an American flapper." The novelty of exotic appearance, careful speech, and carefree manner contributed to Europeans' fascination with Anna May Wong. Ironically, while Wong's celebrity inspired Oriental fashions in England, with women powdering their faces to "get the 'Wong complexion'" and "[g]orgeously-embroidered coolie coats" became the rage among the theater set, Wong herself wore "the smartest Paris clothes." Photographs of Wong in Berlin and in London show her continental attire and elegant companions; her scrapbooks indicate an avid social life, attending sports events and the theater. She was a modern cosmopolitan whose hybridity could not be easily categorized.

Whereas audiences in Europe marveled at her ability to be simultaneously American and Chinese, those in the United States perceived her as more cultured, sophisticated, and Western after her sojourn in Europe. Wong confided to American movie magazine writers how people told her she had "changed so much since my European experience, and that I don't look like a Chinese girl

anymore.... My face has changed because my soul has changed. I think like the people of the West." Another article credited Europe with transforming her. "The Chinese flapper has an English accent now. She thinks in Western terms. Her manners, her dress, her humor, her attitude, are Western. She loves tea—but an English brand. Her face no longer looks very Chinese." ...

## Oriental Mystique

Wong consciously chose to exoticize herself even more as an "Oriental" celebrity. After *Picturegoer* reported that Wong received (but refused) an offer from "an Eastern plastic surgeon, who said he could take the slant out of her eyes, thereby allowing her to play European roles," perhaps it made sense to transform what some perceived as her "liability" into marketability. One of her mentors, Rob Wagner, had suggested that Wong could actively increase her value in the culture of film and celebrity by "being different." "Among other things," Wagner recalled, "I urged her to 'can' her Hollywood feathers and be Chinese. I suggested that she even burn incense in her hotel room, to add to her exotic charm." Wong followed Wagner's advice and, by all accounts, provoked curiosity, attention, and acclaim in Europe.

Rejecting the pathologies the American public associated with the Chinese, Wong drew on more exotic qualities in her self-representation. Vivien North described for the British readers of *Picturegoer Weekly* the mysterious quality surrounding the actor, "sitting there against the Oriental background of her room, with its bowls of big flowers, its mirrors and soft lighting, her hands—with their lacquered finger nails matching the Chinese red of her jumper—folded, her ankles crossed and every feature composed—almost physically feeling her complete stillness." John K. Newnham noted Wong's ability to emphasize both the American and Chinese aspects of her identity in her self-promotion and suggested that Wong's unique combination of American initiative and Asian allure enabled her to "play Hollywood's game well. She retains a deliberate atmosphere of subtle mystery. There is always a faint aroma of perfume about her. But in her conversation and outlook on life, she is smartly Western. No genuine Chinese woman could boast the attribute she possesses: women haven't been emancipated long enough in China. So you can see," Newnham continued, "why Anna May Wong is so unique and why she can always step back to starring roles. She has a corner which is uniquely her own."

Newnham's shrewd analysis suggested that Wong succeeded because she could use her multiple identifications to locate herself in the unique position of representing Chinese even as she maintained a Western outlook. Presenting herself in self-consciously orientalist fashion, Wong relied on a racialized identity to establish the uniqueness of her star persona. Although this strategy appears to contradict her earlier claims of realistically portraying China, Wong may also have persuaded herself that the exotic China she evoked was indeed authentic. Wong's willing participation in the Occident's orientalism provided her with a public platform in London from which to critique the treatment and perceptions of Chinese Americans in the United States.

# The Problem of Japanese American Biculturalism

LON KURASHIGE

## Buy Cultural

A surge of advertising was the first sign that Nisei Week was about to begin. Little Tokyo merchants flooded the vernacular press with sales announcements and redesigned display windows to appeal specifically to the second generation. In 1934 one retailer proclaimed that preparations were done "All for the Satisfaction of the Nisei!" Such appeals masked a fear among Little Tokyo merchants that the second generation had developed consumption tastes that lured them outside the enclave, particularly to department stores whose economies of scale allowed them to undercut small businesses. Some shop owners criticized Nisei who, they said, were embarrassed to wear clothing made in Japan. Others simply bemoaned the loss of an estimated half a million dollars a year that could be spent by Nisei shoppers. How would the merchants stop the hemorrhaging of money from the ethnic enclave?

That was the question that pushed the Issei leadership to place unproven second-generation businessmen in charge of Nisei Week. Never before had Little Tokyo been turned on its head, with the Nisei—albeit temporarily—in command. Sei Fujii, an Issei leader and newspaper publisher, challenged the JACLers "to show their old folks how much of an asset they are instead of being [a] burden as they used to be." The youngsters, for their part, welcomed the chance to run what they called the "greatest civic project undertaken by a second generation group." Nisei Week was a rite of passage that continued the JACL's initiation into community leadership. With solid Issei backing, the organization was founded in 1930 and mirrored the extensive and tightly organized network of Japanese immigrant associations throughout the West Coast. By 1936 thirty-eight chapters, governed by a national headquarters in San Francisco, supported the older generation's economic endeavors and efforts to fight anti-Japanese discrimination. "The early devices of the rising Nisei organization," one member observed, "were in many instances mild imitations of the Issei."

While the JACLers patterned themselves after the immigrant leadership, they differed significantly from the bulk of their own generation. They were overwhelmingly male despite equal numbers of Nisei women in Los Angeles and were about a decade older than the majority of their peers in the second generation. Moreover, they were almost twice as likely to have attended college and to be in management positions than most of the Nisei men their age. Thus the organization was made up of the second-generation elite—lawyers, dentists, medical doctors, and entrepreneurs who relied upon the ethnic enclave for their businesses and practices and therefore had vested interests in enhancing and protecting Little Tokyo. The exceptional status of the JACLers was doubly

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From Lon Kurashige, "The Problem of Biculturalism: Japanese American Identity and Festival Before World War II," *Journal of American History*, 86, no. 4 (March 2000): 1636–1640, 1650–1654. Copyright © 2000 Journal of American History. Used by permission.

true for the organization's leaders. Consider the success story of Keiichi "Kay" Sugahara, the first president of the Los Angeles chapter. Born in 1909, Sugahara was thirteen when he and his younger siblings were orphaned. To help provide for his brother and sister, he worked at a fruit stand from junior high through his years at the University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA). In 1932, as a senior, the young Sugahara teamed with white partners to launch the first customs brokerage firm in Little Tokyo. As someone who could bridge American and Japanese cultures, he capitalized on the needs of businesses importing goods from Japan. The success of this venture, he claimed, made him a millionaire before the age of thirty.

Under Sugahara's command, the theme of the first Nisei Week festival was "Buy in Lil' Tokyo." Sugahara's brother, Roku, promised his generation that Little Tokyo stores would have the lowest prices and the highest-quality Japanese and American merchandise. Just in case competitive prices and products were not enough, the JACLers linked enclave purchases with Nisei Week participation. Admission to festival events required receipts from Little Tokyo stores, and by the late 1930s, purchasing merchandise enabled shoppers to cast votes for their favorite beauty contestants.

But even the most successful of such gimmicks ended with Nisei Week. In order to secure year-round patronage, the organizers of Nisei Week strove to give the second generation a stake in the future of the immigrant enclave. The logic was straightforward: If the Nisei benefited materially from Little Tokyo, they would have more reason to shop there. The most compelling incentive Issei merchants could offer the younger generation was employment. While free to patronize white-owned businesses, Nisei usually could not work for them. Most white employers refused to hire Japanese Americans, and major labor unions denied them membership. One field open to the Nisei was higher education, but only a select few followed this route since even college graduates faced racial barriers that forced them back to the restricted world of the ethnic enclave. On the eve of World War II, most Nisei were working in the ethnic enclave's primary sectors: agricultural production, retail enterprise, and domestic service. While Issei leaders looked to them to calm anti-Japanese antipathy in white America, the Nisei relied upon the older generation for employment opportunities.

Yet most Little Tokyo retailers refused to hire Nisei for sales positions because of their inability to meet the needs of Japanese-speaking clients. To spur Nisei employment, Nisei Week organizers persuaded enclave merchants that Nisei salespersons would boost their businesses by attracting second-generation shoppers. In 1934 the festival's employment bureau placed thirty-five workers in just three days, and although their jobs, like the sales and the beauty pageant, typically ended with Nisei Week, the employment agency attained a permanent place in Little Tokyo.

The strongest appeals for Nisei patronage relied upon a sense of fictive kinship. According to Roku Sugahara, Little Tokyo offered a pleasanter shopping experience than the stores outside its protective borders. There was, he suggested, "a better understanding, a feeling of freedom and congeniality, and friendliness" because the "seller knows the background and characteristics of the buyer much

better." The winner of the Nisei Week essay contest in 1938 also viewed Little Tokyo as an ethnic sanctuary. Answering the question "Why I should buy in Little Tokyo," he listed the enclave's unique benefits for Nisei customers:

> Japanese can serve Japanese people with good taste. They know what type of clothing or merchandise would be best suited, whereas an American firm naturally would not. And, too, they are inclined to be more personal and understanding, as there are no barriers of speech or race. This results in friendly, sociable business tactics, and not cold ruthless negotiations.

Festival leaders used ethnicity as both carrot and stick to attract Nisei shoppers. While they played up the "natural" affinities among Japanese Americans, they also stressed the obligations that such ties entailed. "If the Nisei expect to see Lil' Tokio exist and rise out of its present depression," the *Rafu Shimpo* newspaper commanded, "they must cooperate and help build Lil' Tokio by putting some funds into the businesses" and "buy all necessities at Japanese stores and only buy those things which are not carried in Lil' Tokio at American stores." The result of "this extensive trading," explained the 1938 essay contest winner, "will be a closer union of our race—drawn together by the cohesive force of economic and social dependency." Roku Sugahara's do-or-die scenario best characterized the invocation of group obligation: "It all depends on the nisei, whether they will aid in strengthening our economic foundation or will stand idly by while it crumbles into oblivion."

Despite these appeals, Nisei Week leaders were aware of the pitfalls of attempts to attract second-generation customers. The *Kashu Mainichi* newspaper cautioned against any business strategy that promoted ethnic insularity as not only unfeasible, but "un-American." During the depression, the paper insisted, hoarding money within Little Tokyo was "un-American," since the nation's recovery required pumping money into the broader economy. Carl Kondo, the runner-up in the Nisei Week essay contest in 1935, criticized the futility of the "buy in Lil' Tokio" campaign. He warned that Japanese merchants should not rely on Nisei consumption because their mom-and-pop establishments could not compete with the department stores in nearby downtown Los Angeles. Even if prices were slashed in Little Tokyo, Kondo argued, the Nisei were too influenced by American culture to be interested in Japanese merchandise or to be swayed by invocations of racial responsibilities.

Kondo maintained that Japanese businesses should cultivate external, rather than internal, markets. He believed that the nation's increasing interest in Japan as a rising world power and United States trading partner created a favorable climate for purveying Japanese artifacts, services, and cultural displays to the exotic tastes of white America. The *Kashu Mainichi* also championed the benefits of the tourist market. It pointed with envy to Chinatown and the Mexican-inspired Olvera Street as two of Los Angeles's successful ethnic attractions and lamented that "one cannot immediately feel the foreign atmosphere or distinction upon entering Lil' Tokyo."

Nisei Week proved the optimal occasion to dress up Little Tokyo for white consumption. Here the Oriental-styled street displays, decorations, music, dance, and fashions assumed dual meanings: symbols of ethnic pride for Japanese Americans but also exotic enticements for outsiders. The kimono, in particular, attracted so much interest that Nisei Week leaders in 1936 added a second fashion show, where those Japanese garments were modeled exclusively for white Americans. The festival booklet billed the event as "an exhibition of Japanese pajamas and lounging clothes" with refreshments served by "petite Japanese maidens in picturesque kimonos." The JACLers invited hundreds of "leading women in Los Angeles society" and selected kimono styles that would "appeal particularly to American women."

Enclave merchants also proposed that Nisei women wear kimonos while serving as tour guides who provided a "night of adventure to Americans in Little Tokyo." The hostesses were to greet tourists as they entered the enclave, answer questions about Japanese culture, including flower arrangements and the tea ceremony, and assist them in purchasing merchandise. Nisei Week leaders in 1940 redesigned the festival booklet to increase the enclave's tourist appeal. A glossy full-page advertisement especially greeted white Americans. "WELCOME TO LITTLE TOKYO" appeared in orientalized script inserted within a photograph of the community's main thoroughfare. The night scene featured a group of well-groomed, entertainment-seeking white Americans chaperoned by four smiling, kimono-clad women. Fluorescent Little Tokyo storefronts, particularly the Fujikan Theater's elaborate neon marquee, in front of which the group stood, radiated an energy and enthusiasm that seemed to overwhelm the tourists. The smiling Japanese women reflected the enclave's warmth and hospitality, while the flood of bright lights and signs symbolized its entrepreneurial vigor—a shopper's paradise....

## American Front

The economic motives that began Nisei Week and the concerns about Little Tokyo's Americanization were inexplicably tied to the demonstration of the second generation's civic virtue and political allegiance. "Through the medium of this festival," John Maeno declared in 1936, "the JACL hopes to present, acquaint, and connect you directly with the young Japanese American citizen, his life and environment." Maeno, the organization's second president, was one of the few Nisei lawyers in Little Tokyo. A graduate of the University of Southern California, he used his college ties to make inroads into Los Angeles political circles. He explained that as a "new American," the Nisei was a "true and loyal citizen of the United States" who sought to take "part in civic development and community progress."

The JACLers used the Nisei's citizenship to gain advantages in the political arena. They, like the leaders of African Americans and many urban immigrant groups, attempted to gain electoral power by combining Japanese American votes into one large ethnic bloc. This way, as increasing numbers of Nisei came of age, they could expand their impact on local elections. A flock of white office seekers took the Nisei vote seriously and showed up at the festival's inauguration

in 1934, their large numbers even raising concerns in Little Tokyo that the festivities would turn into a "political rally." Nisei Week was also an occasion to pay respects to the highest elected official in Los Angeles. In the opening ceremony in 1936 a colorful procession moved through the streets of Little Tokyo on its way to Los Angeles's city hall two blocks away. The ethnic community's "leading citizens" accompanied the Nisei Week queen and "her pretty and charming attendants" as they were carried along in Japanese rickshaws. The ceremony concluded with these "kimono-clad, dark-eyed beauties" presenting the mayor of Los Angeles "with an official invitation to attend this gala event in Lil' Tokyo."

Such a visible display of goodwill toward the Los Angeles community illustrated the type of citizenship the JACLers espoused. Being American, to them, meant not just possessing legal entitlements, but performing a wide range of civic duties. The winner of the JACL's oratorical contest in 1938 placed the responsibility of resolving "our race problem" squarely on the Nisei's shoulders. He encouraged the Nisei to engage in "active citizenship" by voting and involving themselves in public affairs. Civic involvement, he asserted, would prove that the Nisei are a "racial group worthy of being accepted on an equal plane" because "it will show to the white citizenry that we are not a culturally or mentally inferior race ..., that we are beneficial to America's social and economic welfare, and that we desire to cooperate with the white race in solving our community and national problems." The ultimate significance of active citizenship, the orator explained, was that eventually it would compel "the white race, themselves, to take down the racial barriers that have been erected against us."

But the JACLers did not equate proving loyalty to the United States with severing ties to Japan. Despite America's opposition to Japanese imperialism, they sided with their parents, who, like most expatriates, reveled in the military victories of their homeland. The formal declaration of the second Sino-Japanese war in 1937 heightened ties to the motherland, as both generations sent money, supplies, and well-wishes to Japanese soldiers. Issei leaders called upon the JACLers to counteract the American public's overwhelming support for the Chinese (President Franklin D. Roosevelt, in fact, disobeyed his own policy of neutrality in foreign wars by sending American arms to Chinese troops). The older generation, with assistance from the Japanese consulate, briefed the young leaders on the necessity and righteousness of Japan's foreign policies and helped to establish a Nisei "speakers bureau" to inform Americans about Japan's side of the story. Togo Tanaka, writing in the 1940s, confirmed that the English section of his newspaper, *Rafu Shimpo*, based its editorials and coverage of the Sino-Japanese war on information provided by Issei who blamed Japan's negative image on Chinese propaganda. The staff of the paper's Japanese section prepared pamphlets for their Nisei colleagues about Japan's plight in the West—the subtitle of one read, "How about Giving Japan a Break?" Thus Tanaka concluded that the JACLers, despite their strong commitment to American political institutions, were mindful "not to disparage the cultural values of Japan, nor to antagonize Issei feelings in the latter's sympathies for Japan. JACL leaders even rationalized their Americanism as being rooted in Japanese culture."

But opposition in the United States only grew when Japanese troops captured Beijing and pressed on to victory. In 1939 FDR abrogated the treaty that had safeguarded United States—Japan trade and, a year later, in response to Japan's Tripartite Alliance with Germany and Italy and its apparent movement into Southeast Asia, threatened to cut off the shipment of about 80 percent of the island nation's war supplies. The growing opposition to Japan buoyed antagonism to Japanese Americans. By 1938 Lail Thomas Kane was in the habit of sharing his opinions with *Rafu Shimpo* editor Togo Tanaka, who duly noted them as an alarming indication of popular sentiment. "By this time," Tanaka later noted, "Kane's attitude toward the Nisei as 'Jap-stooges' appears to have crystallized." This was evident in Kane's telling Tanaka, "I'm rapidly being convinced that the JACL which represents the Nisei leadership is nothing more than an instrument of the Issei. You really take your orders from Japan." Thus Kane, still backed by the American Legion, continued to lobby for legislation against Japanese American fishermen. He told Tanaka that if the JACLers, whom he referred to as "jackals," were really loyal "you would support this fishing bill which is a national defense, patriotic proposal"— "you should know that the security of the United States is menaced by the presence of fishing boats manned by naval reserve officers of the Imperial Japanese Navy." These fears reached a national audience through Kane's publications, including an article in the *Saturday Evening Post*, and spread beyond the issue of Japanese American fishermen. The immediate problem for Little Tokyo was that increasing anti-Japanese sentiment gave rise to boycotts against Japanese businesses that placed the depression-weary enclave in even further jeopardy.

"A direct correlation exists," asserted Togo Tanaka in an analysis of JACL history he wrote in the 1940s, "between the growing intensity of America-Japan friction and the increasing frequency of Nisei and even Issei loyalty pledges." The Issei old guard responded to anti-Japanese affronts as they had done before: they had the Nisei reassure Americans that their support for Japan was in no way at odds with their commitment to living and raising their children in the United States. But mounting United States—Japan hostility forced Nisei Week's leaders to retreat from the idea of biculturalism. The *Rafu Shimpo*'s English-language staff, for example, veered away from Japanese nationalism. Togo Tanaka claimed that the decision was based on both the fallout from the rescinding of the trade agreement and the results of a survey that revealed the impressive Nisei commitment to the United States. The English section split from the paper's Japanese staff to launch an editorial policy encouraging the Nisei to drop biculturalism in favor of a "single American political loyalty." The Nisei were urged to support the JACL's Americanism, buy United States defense bonds, and forgo dual citizenship with Japan.

Nisei Week now became a forum to ensure that Japanese Americans would not be confused with their relatives overseas. The *Kashu Mainichi* in 1940 assured the people of southern California of the Nisei's eagerness to participate "in the building of this great country, to assume responsibility for its defense against all enemies and to safeguard its great institutions." A year later the Nisei Week crowd was steered away from dressing in Japanese garb. "From the American

point of view," the leading vernacular newspaper asked, "how can one be expected to be impressed by any profession of loyalty via a 'native Japanese kimono'? The two don't jibe." The call for patriotic expression was especially evident in the festival's parade. Old Glory replaced the "rising sun" flags so prevalent at earlier celebrations, while beauty contestants, draped in white evening gowns, floated through the streets of Little Tokyo perched beneath a replica of the Capitol dome. A sedan resplendent with red, white, and blue streamers carried a flowered marquee that left the Nisei's identity unambiguous. Displayed beneath the facsimile of a spread-winged dove were the words "USA, Our Home."

It was difficult to gauge the extent to which these patriotic activities paid off. No amount of flag-waving or swearing of loyalty oaths could convince Kane and other die-hard racists that the Nisei were trustworthy. But the JACL's patriotism made such a favorable impression on Kenneth Ringle, the naval intelligence officer responsible for assessing the loyalty of the ethnic community, that he concluded "the entire 'Japanese Problem' has been magnified out of its true proportion, largely because of the physical characteristics of the people." Japanese Americans also received support from the *Los Angeles Times*, which encouraged its readers to attend Nisei Week because its sponsors "had no part in and no responsibility for causing war clouds to gather in the Orient." Fletcher Bowron, the mayor of Los Angeles in 1941, echoed this sentiment. In the speech that opened what became the last Nisei Week before World War II, the mayor not only implored Japanese Americans to show their patriotism but reassured them, "we know you are loyal."

Yet after the bombing of Pearl Harbor and the United States' declaration of war on Japan, Bowron did not hesitate to call for the mass evacuation of 110,000 Japanese Americans from the West Coast. The mayor, along with most public officials in California and other western states, confessed his utter distrust of Japanese Americans and did not think twice about denying them their constitutional rights. In early February 1942, he warned a radio audience about the Japanese American threat: "Right here in our own city are those who may spring into action at an appointed time in accordance with a prearranged plan wherein each of our little brown brothers will know his part in the event of any possible attempted invasion or air raid." Two weeks later, despite intelligence reports that deemed the overwhelming majority of Japanese Americans loyal to the United States, President Franklin Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066, sanctioning their removal to concentration camps. Not long after that, over 33,000 Japanese Americans were forcibly removed from southern California, and with their departure ended a chapter in Nisei Week history.

During World War II the JACLers took control of the ethnic community precisely because they had failed to fulfill Nisei Week's twin goals of ameliorating anti-Japanese racism and securing the future of the ethnic enclave. While neither biculturalism nor the switch to Americanism could prevent the internment, the latter identity proved more pragmatic amid the extreme anti-Japanese sentiment that gripped the nation during World War II. The JACLers, pushed by government officials, adopted a new language of identity predicated on the eradication, not celebration, of ethnic difference. To prove their loyalty to the nation, they, as an

organization and individually, cooperated with American intelligence agencies by informing on "suspicious" elements within the ethnic community. Their surveillance activities, which the ethnic press highlighted often, generated deep animosities against the JACL (particularly its most boisterously anti-Japanese leaders) that led to the intimidation, beating, and attempted murder of JACLers within the internment camps. While military authorities saw the ethnic group as a monolithic (enemy) race, Japanese Americans experienced World War II more divided than ever.

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CHAPTER 8



# The Mass Removal and Detention of Japanese Americans, 1942–1948

*Japan's destruction of Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, incited public calls for revenge against the "treacherous" Japanese and unleashed a new wave of anti-Japanese racism in Hawai'i and on the West Coast. President Franklin Delano Roosevelt authorized martial law in Hawai'i, and for nearly three years residents of Japanese ancestry in Hawai'i endured curfews, property loss, restrictions on travel and work, and the internment of nearly 2,000 individuals. The military commander of Hawai'i and business leaders, however, resisted calls to remove all Hawaiian Japanese from the islands because, as more than a third of the population, they were vital to the islands' economy. On the West Coast, anti-Japanese groups and prominent politicians campaigned for the mass removal and incarceration of Japanese Americans. California's attorney general and future civil rights icon Earl Warren even went so far as to claim that the lack of espionage and sabotage by Japanese Americans on the West Coast was evidence of a vast conspiracy. Repeating this illogical charge, Lieutenant General DeWitt, the military commander on the West Coast, justified mass exclusion by stating, "The very fact that no sabotage has taken place to date is a disturbing and confirming indication that such action will be taken."*

*On February 19, 1942, President Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066 authorizing the designation of areas as military zones and clearing the path for the forced removal of Japanese Americans. Most were given less than a week's notice before they had to report for what the government euphemistically called an "evacuation." Allowed to bring only what they could carry, Japanese Americans were taken to "assembly centers" and then transferred to more permanent camps, called "relocation centers," in remote areas of the country with extreme temperatures, harsh conditions, barbed wire, and armed guards.*

*The mass incarceration of 40,000 immigrants and 70,000 American-born citizens without evidence or trials violated Japanese Americans' civil liberties. Japanese Americans responded to this forced detention in different ways. Some advised the War Relocation Authority (WRA), the government agency that managed the internment camps, through channels of internee governance or as camp researchers into internee life. Some second-generation*

*Nisei fought along with the WRA for their right to join the armed forces to demonstrate their patriotism and improve the public image of Japanese Americans. Japanese American Citizens League (JACL) leaders lobbied the War Department for more than a year to reclassify Nisei from "enemy aliens," prohibited from serving in the nation's armed forces, to citizens who could fight for their country. The outstanding training record of Japanese Americans in the 100th Infantry Battalion and the Varsity Victory Volunteers, both from Hawaii, contributed to President Roosevelt's decision on March 23, 1943, to establish the all-Nisei 442nd Regimental Combat Team. While nearly 10,000 young men volunteered for the unit from Hawaii, only about 1,500 volunteered from the internment camps. Nevertheless, the 442nd, reinforced by the 100th, became the most decorated U.S. military unit for its size and length of service during World War II.*

*In contrast to the backers of the 442nd combat team, other Nisei protested against the internment by refusing to sign a loyalty questionnaire, failing to comply with draft procedures, and in some cases even renouncing their U.S. citizenship. Conflicts between pro- and antiadministration groups among the internees led to mass demonstrations, violence, and an incident at the Manzanar camp that ended with a group of soldiers firing into a crowd of protesters, killing two and injuring many others. Dividing families and groups within the ethnic community, the internment left deep wounds.*

## DOCUMENTS

These documents present different views of Japanese American loyalty, patriotism, and citizenship during World War II. In Document 1, written two weeks after Pearl Harbor, naval intelligence officer Kenneth Ringle argues against mass removal based on evidence from the surveillance of the Japanese American community, a network of ethnic informants, and a break-in at the Japanese Consulate in Los Angeles. In Document 2, West Coast military commander John L. DeWitt urges the War Department in February 1942 to remove all Japanese Americans from the West Coast because he assumes that racial ancestry determines loyalty. Document 3 presents selections from the 1942 congressional testimony of Nisei Mike Masaoka, national secretary of the ultrapatriotic JACL, urging the recognition of Japanese Americans' citizenship rights and pledging cooperation with the government's removal order.

Documents 4 and 5 provide two Japanese American responses to internment. Document 4, an anonymous poem circulated at the Poston camp, constructed on the Colorado River Indian Reservation in southwestern Arizona, evokes the frustration and anger many internees experienced at being imprisoned behind barbed wire. In Document 5, immigrant leader Yamato Ichihashi, a Stanford University professor interned at the Tule Lake camp in northern California, writes department colleague Payson Treat a critique of the camp director's inability to understand internee decision making. Ichihashi explains why some internees deemed "loyal" choose to remain at this camp after it is converted into a segregated facility for supposedly disloyal Japanese Americans. He also criticizes as racist and hypocritical

the government's refusal to let loyal internees leave the internment camps and return to their homes.

Documents 6 and 7 address Japanese Americans and military service. Document 6 recounts how the 442nd rescued a "Lost Battalion" from Texas after two other units failed. The five days of intense combat cost the 442nd several times the number of men they rescued, but the unit's heroism made headlines back home and improved the public image of Japanese Americans. Inside the internment camps, however, alienated Nisei men denounced government attempts to draft them into the military. In Document 7, the "Fair Play Committee," led by Kiyoshi Okamoto, Frank Abe, and other internees at the Heart Mountain camp, condemns the mass incarceration and the recruitment for the 442nd combat team. Urging the draftees to defend the constitution and democracy "here at home," the committee calls on them to protest the violation of their citizenship rights by resisting the draft. Document 8 reveals that the Heart Mountain protesters were not the only ones to stand up for the Nisei's rights as U.S. citizens. In a searing dissent to the 1944 Supreme Court opinion upholding the constitutionality of the mass removal, Associate Supreme Court Justice Frank Murphy argued that the removal and incarceration denied Japanese Americans' constitutional rights.

Document 9 examines the experiences of Japanese Americans after leaving the camps. The WRA advised them to resettle in midwestern states like Illinois, Michigan, and Ohio. The American Friends Service and other charitable agencies helped find jobs and housing for Japanese Americans who relocated to Chicago and other cities, where many resettlers found the people to be much friendlier than on the West Coast. Anti-Japanese antagonism in the West is the subject of Document 9, an oral interview conducted in 1999 in which Esther (Takei) Nishio recounts the hostility, threats, and media frenzy she encountered when she became the first Japanese American student to return to California in September 1944. Nishio remembers how certain liberally minded white Americans were instrumental in sponsoring her return and enrollment in college. They also paved the way for the return of many other Japanese Americans once President Roosevelt rescinded West Coast exclusion orders on December 17, 1944.

## 1. Chief of Naval Operations Kenneth Ringle Reports on Japanese American Loyalty on the West Coast, December 30, 1941

**From:** Lieutenant Commander K.D. RINGLE, USN.
**To:** The Chief of Naval Operations.
**Via:** The Commandant, Eleventh Naval District.
**Subject:** Japanese Question, Report on.

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Serial No. 01742316 30 December 1941, Navy Department Library, http://www.history.navy.mil/library/online/jap intern.htm

The following opinions, amplified in succeeding paragraphs, are held by the writer:

(a) That within the last eight or ten years the entire "Japanese question" in the United States has reversed itself. The alien menace is no longer paramount, and is becoming of less importance almost daily, as the original alien immigrants grow older and die, and as more and more of their American-born children reach maturity. The primary present and future problem is that of dealing with these of whom it is considered that least seventy-five percent are loyal to the United States. The ratio of these American citizens of Japanese ancestry to alien-born Japanese in the United States is at present almost 3 to 1, and rapidly increasing.

(b) That of the Japanese-born alien residents, the large majority are at least passively loyal to the United States. That is, they would knowingly do nothing what ever to the injury of the United States, but at the same time would not do anything to the injury of Japan. Also, most might well do surreptitious observation work for Japanese interests if given a convenient opportunity.

(c) That, however, there are among the Japanese both alien and United States citizens, certain individuals, either deliberately placed by the Japanese government or actuated by a fanatical loyalty to that country who would act as saboteurs or agents. This number is estimated to be less than three per cent of the total, or about 300 in the entire United States.

(d) That of the persons mentioned in (c) above, the most dangerous are either already in custodial detention or are members of such organizations as the Black Dragon Society, the Kaigun Kyokai (Navy League), or the Heimusha Iai (Military Service Men's League), or affiliated groups. The membership of these groups is already fairly well known to the Naval Intelligence service or the Federal Bureau of Investigation and should immediately be placed in custodial detention, irrespective of whether they are alien or citizen.

(e) That, as a basic policy tending toward the permanent solution of this problem, the American citizens of Japanese ancestry should be officially encouraged in their efforts toward loyalty and acceptance as bona fide citizens that they be accorded a place in the national effort through such agencies as the Red Cross, U.S.O., civilian defense, and even such activities as ship and aircraft building or other defense production activities, even though subject to greater investigative checks as to background and loyalty, etc., than Caucasian Americans.

(f) That in spite of paragraph (c) above, the most potentially dangerous element of all are those American citizens of Japanese ancestry who have spent the formative years of their lives, from 10 to 20, in Japan and have returned to the United States to claim their legal American citizenship within the last few years. These people are essentially and inherently Japanese and may have been deliberately sent back to the United States by the Japanese government to act as agents. In spite of their legal citizenship and the protection afforded them by the Bill of Rights, they should be looked upon as enemy aliens and many of them placed in custodial detention. This group numbers between 600 and 700 in the Los

Angeles metropolitan area and at least that many in other parts of Southern California.

(g) That the writer heartily agrees with the reports submitted by Mr. Munson [Curtis B. Munson].

(h) That, in short, the entire "Japanese Problem" has been magnified out of its true proportion, largely because of the physical characteristics of the people; that it is no more serious that the problems of the German, Italian, and Communistic portions of the United States population, and, finally that it should be handled on the basis of the individual, regardless of citizenship, and not on a racial basis.

(i) That the above opinions are and will continue to be true just so long as these people, Issei and Nisei, are given an opportunity to be self-supporting, but that if conditions continue in the trend they appear to be taking as of this date; i.e., loss of employment and income due to anti-Japanese agitation by and among Caucasian Americans, continued personal attacks by Filipinos and other racial groups, denial of relief funds to desperately needy cases, cancellation of licenses for markets, produce houses, stores, etc., by California State authorities, discharges from jobs by the wholesale, unnecessarily harsh restrictions on travel, including discriminatory regulations against all Nisei preventing them from engaging in commercial fishing—there will most certainly be outbreaks of sabotage, riots, and other civil strife in the not too distant future.

## 2. Lieutenant General John L. DeWitt Recommends the Removal of Japanese Americans from the West Coast, 1942

The area lying to the west of the Cascade and Sierra Nevada Mountains in Washington, Oregon and California, is highly critical not only because the lines of communication and supply to the Pacific theater pass through it, but also because of the vital industrial production therein, particularly aircraft. In the war in which we are now engaged racial affinities are not severed by migration. The Japanese race is an enemy race and while many second and third generation Japanese born on United States soil, possessed of United States citizenship, have become "Americanized", the racial strains are undiluted. To conclude otherwise is to expect that children born of white parents on Japanese soil sever all racial affinity and become loyal Japanese subjects, ready to fight and, if necessary, to die for Japan in a war against the nation of their parents. That Japan is allied with Germany and Italy in this struggle is no ground for assuming that any Japanese, barred from assimilation by convention as he is, though born and raised in the United States, will not turn against this nation when the final test of loyalty comes. It, therefore, follows that along the vital Pacific Coast over 112,000 potential enemies, of Japanese extraction, are at large today. There are indications that these are organized and ready for concerted action at a favorable

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From United States Department of War, *Final Report: Japanese Evacuation from the West Coast, 1942* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1943), 34–37.

opportunity. The very fact that no sabotage has taken place to date is a disturbing and confirming indication that such action will be taken.

## Disposition of the Japanese

(1) *Washington.* As the term is used herein, the word "Japanese" includes alien Japanese and American citizens of Japanese ancestry. In the State of Washington the Japanese population, aggregating over 14,500, is disposed largely in the area lying west of the Cascade Mountains and south of an east-west line passing through Bellingham, Washington, about 70 miles north of Seattle and some 15 miles south of the Canadian border. The largest concentration of Japanese is in the area, the axis of which is along the line Seattle, Tacoma, Olympia, Willapa Bay and the mouth of the Columbia River, with the heaviest concentration in the agricultural valleys between Seattle and Tacoma, viz., the Green River and the Puyallup Valleys. The Boeing Aircraft factory is in the Green River Valley. The lines of communication and supply including power and water which feed this vital industrial installation, radiate from this plant for many miles through areas heavily populated by Japanese. Large numbers of Japanese also operate vegetable markets along the Seattle and Tacoma water fronts, in Bremerton, near the Bremerton Navy Yard, and inhabit islands in Puget Sound opposite vital naval ship building installations. Still others are engaged in fishing along the southwest Washington Pacific Coast and along the Columbia River. Many of these Japanese are within easy reach of the forests of Washington State, the stock piles of seasoning lumber and the many sawmills of southwest Washington. During the dry season these forests, mills and stock piles are easily fired.

(2) *Oregon.* There are approximately 4,000 Japanese in the State of Oregon, of which the substantial majority reside in the area in the vicinity of Portland along the south bank of the Columbia River, following the general line Bonneville, Oregon City, Astoria, Tillamook. Many of these are in the northern reaches of the Willamette Valley and are engaged in agricultural and fishing pursuits. Others operate vegetable markets in the Portland metropolitan area and still others reside along the northern Oregon sea coast. Their disposition is in intimate relationship with the northwest Oregon sawmills and lumber industry, near and around the vital electric power development at Bonneville and the pulp and paper installations at Camas (on the Washington State side of the Columbia River) and Oregon City, directly south of Portland).

(3) *California.* The Japanese population in California aggregates approximately 93,500 people. Its disposition is so widespread and so well known that little would be gained by setting it forth in detail here. They live in great numbers along the coastal strip, in and around San Francisco and the Bay Area, the Salinas Valley, Los Angeles and San Diego. Their truck farms are contiguous to the vital aircraft industry concentration in and around Los Angeles. They live in large numbers in and about San Francisco, now a vast staging area for the war in the Pacific, a point at which the nation's lines of communication and supply converge. Inland they are disposed in the Sacramento, San Joaquin and Imperial Valleys. They are engaged in the production of approximately 38% of the

vegetable produce of California. Many of them are engaged in the distribution of such produce in and along the water fronts at San Francisco and Los Angeles. Of the 93,500 in California, about 25,000 reside inland in the mentioned valleys where they are largely engaged in vegetable production cited above, and 54,600 reside along the coastal strip, that is to say, a strip of coast line varying from eight miles in the north to twenty miles in width in and around the San Francisco bay area, including San Francisco, in Los Angeles and its environs, and in San Diego. Approximately 13,900 are dispersed throughout the remaining portion of the state. In Los Angeles City the disposition of vital aircraft industrial plants covers the entire city. Large numbers of Japanese live and operate markets and truck farms adjacent to or near these installations....

I now recommend the following:

(1) That the Secretary of War procure from the President direction and authority to designate military areas in the combat zone of the Western Theater of Operations, (if necessary to include the entire combat zone), from which, in his discretion, he may exclude all Japanese, all alien enemies, and all other persons suspected for any reason by the administering military authorities of being actual or potential saboteurs, espionage agents, or fifth columnists. Such executive order should empower the Secretary of War to requisition the services of any and all other agencies of the Federal Government, with express direction to such agencies to respond to such requisition, and further empowering the Secretary of War to use any and all federal facilities and equipment, including Civilian Conservation Corps Camps, and to accept the use of State facilities for the purpose of providing shelter and equipment for evacuees. Such executive order to provide further for the administration of military areas for the purposes of this plan by appropriate military authorities acting with the requisitioned assistance of the other federal agencies and the cooperation of State and local agencies. The executive order should further provide that by reason of military necessity the right of all persons, whether citizens or aliens, to reside, enter, cross or be within any military areas shall be subject to revocation and shall exist on a pass and permit basis at the discretion of the Secretary of War and implemented by the necessary legislation imposing penalties for violation.

## 3. Japanese American Mike Masaoka Vows to Cooperate with Government Removal Plans, 1942

We have been invited by you to make clear our stand regarding the proposed evacuation of all Japanese from the West coast. When the President's recent Executive order was issued, we welcomed it as definitely centralizing and coordinating defense efforts relative to the evacuation problem. Later interpretations of the order, however, seem to indicate that it is aimed primarily at the Japanese,

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From Testimony of Mike Masaoka, House Select Committee Investigating Defense Migration, 77th Cong. 2nd Sess. (1942), 1137. Reprinted in *Asian Americans: Opposing Viewpoints*, ed. William Dudley (San Diego, CA: Greenhaven Press, 1997), 151–154.

American citizens as well as alien nationals. As your committee continues its investigations in this and subsequent hearings, we hope and trust that you will recommend to the proper authorities that no undue discrimination be shown to American citizens of Japanese descent.

Our frank and reasoned opinion on the matter of evacuation revolves around certain considerations of which we feel both your committee and the general public should be apprised. With any policy of evacuation definitely arising from reasons of military necessity and national safety, we are in complete agreement. As American citizens, we cannot and should not take any other stand. But, also, as American citizens believing in the integrity of our citizenship, we feel that any evacuation enforced on grounds violating that integrity should be opposed.

If, in the judgment of military and Federal authorities, evacuation of Japanese residents from the West coast is a primary step toward assuring the safety of this Nation, we will have no hesitation in complying with the necessities implicit in that judgment. But, if, on the other hand, such evacuation is primarily a measure whose surface urgency cloaks the desires of political or other pressure groups who want us to leave merely from motives or self-interest, we feel that we have every right to protest and to demand equitable judgment on our merits as American citizens....

## We Cherish Our American Citizenship

I now make an earnest plea that you seriously consider and recognize our American citizenship status which we have been taught to cherish as our most priceless heritage.

At this hearing, we Americans of Japanese descent have been accused of being disloyal to these United States. As an American citizen, I resent these accusations and deny their validity.

We American-born Japanese are fighting militarist Japan today with our total energies. Four thousand of us are with the armed forces of the United States, the remainder on the home front in the battle of production. We ask a chance to prove to the rest of the American people what we ourselves already know: That we are loyal to the country of our birth and that we will fight to the death to defend it against any and all aggressors.

We think, feel, act like Americans. We, too, remember Pearl Harbor and know that our right to live as free men in a free Nation is in peril as long as the brutal forces of enslavement walk the earth. We know that the Axis aggressors must be crushed and we are anxious to participate fully in that struggle.

The history of our group speaks for itself. It stands favorable comparison with that of any other group of second generation Americans. There is reliable authority to show that the proportion of delinquency and crime within our ranks is negligible. Throughout the long years of the depression, we have been able to stay off the relief rolls better, by far, than any other group. These are but two of the many examples which might be cited as proof of our civic responsibility and pride.

In this emergency, as in the past, we are not asking for special privileges or concessions. We ask only for the opportunity and the right of sharing the common lot of all Americans, whether it be in peace or in war.

This is the American way for which our boys are fighting.

## 4. An Anonymous Poet Denounces the Incarceration of Japanese Americans, 1943

THAT DAMNED FENCE
(anonymous poem circulated at the Poston Camp)

They've sunk the posts deep into the ground
They've strung out wires all the way around,
With machine gun nests just over there,
And sentries and soldiers everywhere.

We're trapped like rats in a wired cage,
To fret and fume with impotent rage;
Yonder whispers the lure of the night,
But that DAMNED FENCE assails our sight.

We seek the softness of the midnight air,
But that DAMNED FENCE in the floodlight glare
Awakens unrest in our nocturnal quest,
And mockingly laughs with vicious jest.

With nowhere to go and nothing to do,
We feel terrible, lonesome, and blue;
That DAMNED FENCE is driving us crazy,
Destroying our youth and making us lazy.

Imprisoned in here for a long, long time,
We know we're punished–though we've committed no crime,
Our thoughts are gloomy and enthusiasm damp,
To be locked up in a concentration camp.

Loyalty we know, and patriotism we feel,
To sacrifice our utmost was our ideal,
To fight for our country, and die, perhaps;
But we're here because we happen to be Japs.

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Anonymous

We all love life, and our country best,
Our misfortune to be here in the west,
To keep us penned behind that DAMNED FENCE,
Is someone's notion of NATIONAL DEFENCE!

## 5. Yamato Ichihashi Writes a Letter Describing the Segregation of Supposedly "Disloyal" Japanese Americans at Tule Lake, 1943

YAMATO ICHIHASHI TO PAYSON TREAT

July 25, 1943

Dear Payson:

A mention has been made, in a previous report, of the newly adopted WRA policy of segregation between those who are "loyal" and "disloyal" to the United States among the Japanese who are now residing in the various WRA projects. This note is a continuation of the same report on what has followed since then, but let me repeat briefly as a preliminary what has already taken place. On July 15th, seven of the Japanese "leaders" were called in by [Camp Director Harvey] Coverley to meet in a conference with him and three of his colleagues who hold the key positions. It was stated by Coverley that about 4,500 were directly affected by the definition of the "disloyal," or roughly one-third of the entire population of this project. Thus numerically alone it is a big problem.

On the following Monday, July 19th, Coverley was informed by the chief director of the WRA, Dillon Myer, that the Tule Lake Project was designated as the camp for the segregates or black-sheep; this was more or less anticipated by some of us, but nonetheless it proved to be a bomb shell to the majority, especially to those who are "loyal" and who are compelled to move again. On the 22nd, a second conference was held between the same groups already indicated, to inform one another concerning reactions of the residents at large and to discover the best method of meeting the situation, which will likely lead to the development of a series of troubles.

At this conference the following facts, observations, opinions, etc., were revealed:

(1) Why was it that the changes made so far in the WRA policy always resulted in imposing beatings on the loyal ones, the present case being no exception? These loyal ones constitute two-thirds of the population, and will be forced to move again. These are indignant because the disloyal ones not only escape inconveniences and hardships attending a mass movement, but also suffer no real restrictions, the declared restriction being that they will not be allowed to re-settle outside for the duration. Herein is found the source of dissatisfaction on the part of loyal ones; let me make this point clear.

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Letter from Yamato Ichihashi to Payson Treat, July 25, 1943, ed. Gordon H. Chang, *Morning Glory, Evening Shadow: Yamato Ichihashi and His Internment Writings, 1942–1945* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1997), 241–244. Reprinted by permission.

(2) The restriction to be imposed on the disloyal ones is interpreted by the WRA as a stigma of the worst kind, but the Japanese do not see it in that light. By far the great majority of the issei are now too old to adventure again; they had worked hard from 30 to 45 years to build up such foundations which they had been capable of; but they were mercilessly and completely uprooted from these foundations. They have no hope, are afraid of strange and hostile environments, and they are now physically and mentally incapable to repeat what they were able to do in the prime of their life. These are the reasons why they do not wish to re-settle outside, and therefore the so-called stigma is no stigma at all to such people. Such being the case, the issei whether loyal or disloyal are united in disagreeing with the WRA interpretation.

(3) Moreover, the people have lived in this project for a year or more, striving to re-adjust themselves, and have succeeded remarkably well in this respect. The surrounding nature and the prevailing climatic condition have previously been described: barren, monotonous, desolate and without vegetation to speak of, and yet many have created "gardens" with such available rocks, weeds, sage-brush, etc.; they have converted their bare and furnitureless one-room tenements into somewhat decent and habitable "homes" by improvising all sorts of household articles out of scrap-wood. They have developed new friendships. They have even adjusted themselves to an unnatural, communistic, community life, and have created a more or less tolerant human society. Consequently they have become attached and devoted to their own created "city," and they do not want to be broken up again and scattered in small numbers among the nine remaining projects which are to them strange lands; wherever they go, they will be treated as green-horns, and they do not like it. Sentiments? Maybe, but their feeling is intense.

(4) From the foregoing observations, vou may easily surmise that the proposed policy as it affects this project is apt to cause a general rebellion on the part of the loyal people even to the point of deliberately making themselves disloyal because of their intense desire to remain here or of avoiding the necessity of going elsewhere. The local administration has emphatically been told of such a possibility, and this time it appears that the administration appears to be sympathetic with the Japanese stand. In fact, its personnel seem to dislike to see this project made into the segregation camp, but of course because of their own selfish interests. Black-sheep will not be easy to manage.

(5) So they asked for our advice in order to present effectively their/our case at the conference to be held at Denver on the coming Monday–Tuesday, at which will gather delegates from the ten projects to thresh out various problems attendant on the policy. Therefore our delegates, all the administration men, may work for some modifications of the policy, but my own personal feeling is that they will not succeed in modifying the policy so as to make this project other than the black-sheep camp.

(6) But to me by far the worst implication of the segregation policy, which was no doubt adopted because of the pressure brought about by cheap politicians and interested parties, appears as follows:

a) The wholesale evacuation of the Japanese as a people was carried out by a military necessity, and because there was no time for the differentiation of individuals. At the same time, those who were suspected of being hostile or dangerous to the interests of this country, were thrown into concentration camps. These are called internees, but the meaning of which has never been clearly defined except in a negative sense. For that matter, the status of evacuees, Japanese citizens and aliens, remains undefined to this day, resulting in technical confusion between municipal and international law. Citizens are denied their constitutional rights and aliens of their international legal protection. In this respect, prisoners of war and internees are better off because they are being governed according to the provisions of the Geneva Protocol.

b) When the segregation is effected, how could the American government continue to justify the present policy of keeping the loyal citizens and aliens in the relocation centers? It conflicts with the fundamental reason given for the wholesale evacuation. Why are those who have proved themselves to be loyal to the American interests to be denied their right of returning to their respective homes wherever they may be, and be allowed to resume their legitimate trades, businesses or professions? Such desire and aspiration are quite natural with any people, and thus they can make contributions to America; the gains resulting from such treatment are mutual and avoid the necessity of wasting public money which should not be wasted in a meaningless enterprise. What rational reasons are there of further subjecting the poor devils to an unnatural communistic life, the life [abhorrent] to Americans and to any normal peoples?

c) If the policy is continued, there can be [but] one explanation, but which, in principle, has been denied and is now being denied everyday, namely, [there is] no discrimination because of color, race or religious belief. Why [then] are Italians and Germans (aliens) given such freedom and rights or privileges, and why are loyal Japanese citizens and aliens denied the same freedom, etc.? Obviously, as individuals, Japanese are no different from Italians or Germans. Surely the American government cannot afford to be so glaringly inconsistent; a few days ago, an appeal came from the Army to Japanese citizens and their parents that the former join the Army Language School, denying racial discrimination as an established principle. What are the Japanese people to do in such circumstances? Besides, the present treatment of the Japanese on racial grounds carries bad implications for all the colored peoples of the world, including Chinese and Indians.

## 6. Nisei Soldiers Help Rescue A Lost Battalion, 1944

WITH SEVENTH ARMY IN FRANCE, Nov. 6, (U.P.)—A combat unit made up of Japanese American fighting men, who already had distinguished

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Nisei Soldiers Help Rescue Lost Battalion, *Los Angeles Times*, November 7, 1944. Reprinted by permission.

themselves in the bitter Italian campaign, was disclosed today to have led the drive which resulted in the rescue of the "lost battalion" behind the German lines in France.

These Japanese—Americans, members of the 442nd Regimental Combat Team, had been in action in the central area of the 7th Army front for only three weeks when they launched an attack on Oct. 15 through a forest three miles west of Bruyeres [France] where the "lost battalion"—270 infantrymen of the 36th (Tex.) Division—had been trapped for more than a week.

### Foodless for Days

For five days the Texans had been without food until rations and medical supplies were dropped by low-flying Thunderbolts and they had all but given up hope when the 442nd unit and other American groups broke through Nazl lines to capture Bruyeres and reach the encircled infantrymen.

Members of the lost battalion left no doubt that the 442nd rated as their favorite regiment and a strong move was afoot to declare them all honorary Texans.

### Southlanders in Action

The 7th Army disclosed that Pfc. Nakada of San Bernardino Cal., whose parents live at the Gila River Relocation Center, and Staff-Sgt. Pak Senvaki of Los Angeles, whose parents are at another relocation center at McGeehee, Ark., were among the first to reach the encircled battallion.

## 7. The Fair Play Committee Calls on Nisei, Second-Generation Japanese Americans, to Resist the Draft Within the Heart Mountain Internment Camp, 1944

We, the Nisei have been complacent and too inarticulate to the unconstitutional acts that we were subjected to. If ever there was a time or cause for decisive action, IT IS NOW!

We, the members of the FPC are not afraid to go [to] war—we are not afraid to risk our lives for our country. We would gladly sacrifice our lives to protect and uphold the principles and ideals of our country as set forth in the Constitution and the Bill of Rights, for on its inviolability depends the freedom, liberty, justice, and protection of all people including Japanese? Americans and all other minority groups. But have we been given such freedom, such liberty, such

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From Frank Abe, "One for Al—All for One," 1944; reprinted at www.resisters.com. Reprinted by permission of the author.

justice, such protection? NO!! Without any hearings, without due process of law as guaranteed by the Constitution and Bill of Rights, without any charges filed against us, without any evidence of wrongdoing on our part, one hundred and ten thousand innocent people were kicked out of their homes, literally uprooted from where they have lived for the greater part of their life, and herded like dangerous criminals into concentration camps with barbed wire fences and military police guarding it, AND THEN, WITHOUT RECTIFICATION OF THE INJUSTICES COMMITTED AGAINST US NOR WITHOUT RESTORATION OF OUR RIGHTS AS GUARANTEED BY THE CONSTITUTION, WE ARE ORDERED TO JOIN THE ARMY THRU DISCRIMINATORY PROCEDURES INTO A SEGREGATED COMBAT UNIT! Is that the American way? NO! The FPC believes that unless such actions are opposed NOW, and steps taken to remedy such injustices and discriminations IMMEDIATELY, the future of all minorities and the future of this democratic nation is in danger.

Thus, the members of the FPC unanimously decided at their last open meeting that until we are restored all our rights, all discriminatory features of the Selective Service abolished, and measures are taken to remedy the past injustices thru Judicial pronouncement or Congressional act, we feel that the present program of drafting us from this concentration camp is unjust, unconstitutional, and against all principles of civilized usage. Therefore, WE MEMBERS OF THE FAIR PLAY COMMITTEE HEREBY REFUSE TO GO TO THE PHYSICAL EXAMINATION OR TO THE INDUCTION IF OR WHEN WE ARE CALLED IN ORDER TO CONTEST THE ISSUE.

We are not being disloyal. We are not evading the draft. We are all loyal Americans fighting for JUSTICE AND DEMOCRACY RIGHT HERE AT HOME. So, restore our rights as such, rectify the injustices of evacuation, of the concentration, of the detention, and of the pauperization as such. In short, treat us in accordance with the principles of the Constitution. If what we are voicing is wrong, if what we ask is disloyal, if what we think is unpatriotic, then Abraham Lincoln, one of our greatest American President[s,] was also guilty as such, for he said, "If by the mere force of numbers a majority should deprive a minority on any Constitutional right, it might in a moral point of view justify a revolution."

Among the one thousand odd members of the Fair Play Committee, there are Nisei men over the draft age and Nisei girls who are not directly affected by the present Selective Service program, but who believe in the ideals and principles of our country, therefore are helping the FPC in our fight against injustice and discriminations.

We hope that all persons whose ideals and interests are with us will do all they can to help us. We may have to engage in court actions but as such actions require large sums of money, we do need financial support and when the time comes we hope that you will back us up to the limit.

ATTENTION MEMBERS! FAIR PLAY COMMITTEE MEETING SUNDAY, MARCH 5, 2:00 P.M. BLOCK 6?30 MESS. PARENTS, BROTHERS, SISTERS, AND FRIENDS INVITED.

## 8. Justice Frank Murphy Criticizes the Supreme Court's "Legalization of Racism," 1944

Mr. Justice MURPHY, dissenting

This exclusion of "all persons of Japanese ancestry, both alien and non-alien," from the Pacific Coast area on a plea of military necessity in the absence of martial law ought not to be approved. Such exclusion goes over "the very brink of constitutional power" and falls into the ugly abyss of racism.

In dealing with matters relating to the prosecution and progress of a war, we must accord great respect and consideration to the judgments of the military authorities who are on the scene and who have full knowledge of the military facts. The scope of their discretion must, as a matter of necessity and common sense, be wide. And their judgments ought not to be overruled lightly by those whose training and duties ill-equip them to deal intelligently with matters so vital to the physical security of the nation.

At the same time, however, it is essential that there be definite limits to military discretion, especially where martial law has not been declared. Individuals must not be left impoverished of their constitutional rights on a plea of military necessity that has neither substance nor support. Thus, like other claims conflicting with the asserted constitutional rights of the individual, the military claim must subject itself to the judicial process of having its reasonableness determined and its conflicts with other interests reconciled....

The judicial test of whether the Government, on a plea of military necessity, can validly deprive an individual of any of his constitutional rights is whether the deprivation is reasonably related to a public danger that is so "immediate, imminent and impending" as not to admit of delay and not to permit the intervention of ordinary constitutional processes to alleviate the danger.... Civilian Exclusion Order No. 34, banishing from a prescribed area of the Pacific Coast "all persons of Japanese ancestry, both alien and non-alien," clearly does not meet that test. Being an obvious racial discrimination, the order deprives all those within its scope of the equal protection of the laws as guaranteed by the Fifth Amendment. It further deprives these individuals of their constitutional rights to live and work where they will, to establish a home where they choose and to move about freely. In excommunicating

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From Korematsu v. United States, 323 U.S. 233, 235, 239–242; reprinted in *Racism, Dissent, and Asian Americans from 1850 to the Present a Documentary History*, ed. Philip S. Foner (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 1993), 254–257.

them without benefit of hearings, this order also deprives them of all their constitutional rights to procedural due process. Yet no reasonable relation to an "immediate, imminent, and impending" public danger is evident to support this racial restriction which is one of the most sweeping and complete deprivations of constitutional rights in the history of this nation in the absence of martial law.

It must be conceded that the military and naval situation in the spring of 1942 was such as to generate a very real fear of invasion of the Pacific Coast, accompanied by fears of sabotage and espionage in that area. The military command was therefore justified in adopting all reasonable means necessary to combat these dangers. In adjudging the military action taken in light of the then apparent dangers, we must not erect too high or too meticulous standards; it is necessary only that the action have some reasonable relation to the removal of the dangers of invasion, sabotage and espionage. But the exclusion, either temporarily of permanently, of all persons with Japanese blood in the veins has no such reasonable relation. And that relation is lacking because the exclusion order necessarily must rely for its reasonableness upon the assumption that *all* persons of Japanese ancestry may have a dangerous tendency to commit sabotage and espionage and to aid our Japanese enemy in other ways. It is difficult to believe that reason, logic or experience could be marshalled in support of such an assumption.

... The main reasons relied upon by those responsible for the forced evacuation, therefore, do not prove a reasonable relation between the group characteristics of Japanese Americans and the dangers of invasion, sabotage and espionage. The reasons appear, instead, to be largely an accumulation of much of the misinformation, half-truths and insinuations that for years have been directed against Japanese Americans by people with racial and economic prejudices—the same people who have been among the foremost advocates of the evacuation. A military judgment based upon such racial and sociological considerations is not entitled to the great weight ordinarily given the judgments based upon strictly military considerations. Especially is this so when every charge relative to race, religion, culture, geographical location, and legal and economic status has been substantially discredited by independent studies made by experts in these matters.

The military necessity which is essential to the validity of the evacuation order thus resolves itself into a few intimations that certain individuals actively aided the enemy, from which it is inferred that the entire group of Japanese Americans could not be trusted to be or remain loyal to the United States. No one denies, of course, that there were some disloyal persons of Japanese descent on the Pacific Coast who did all in their power to aid their ancestral land. Similar disloyal activities have been engaged in by many persons of German, Italian and even more pioneer stock in our country. But to infer that examples of individual disloyalty prove group disloyalty and justify discriminatory action against the entire group is to deny that under our system of law individual guilt is the sole basis for deprivation of

rights. Moreover, this inference, which is at the very heart of the evacuation orders, has been used in support of the abhorrent and despicable treatment of minority groups by the dictatorial tyrannies which this nation is now pledged to destroy. To give constitutional sanction to that inference in this case, however well-intentioned may have been the military command on the Pacific Coast, is to adopt one of the cruelest of the rationales used by our enemies to destroy the dignity of the individual and to encourage and open the door to discriminatory actions against other minority groups in the passions of tomorrow.

No adequate reason is given for the failure to treat these Japanese Americans on an individual basis by holding investigations and hearings to separate the loyal from the disloyal, as was done in the case of persons of German and Italian ancestry.... It is asserted merely that the loyalties of this group "were unknown and time was of the essence." Yet nearly four months elapsed after Pearl Harbor before the first exclusion order was issued; nearly eight months went by until the last order was issued; and the last of these "subversive" persons was not actually removed until almost eleven months had elapsed. Leisure and deliberation seem to have been more of the essence than speed. And the fact that conditions were not such as to warrant a declaration of martial law adds strength to the belief that the factors of time and military necessity were not as urgent as they have been represented to be.

Moreover, there was no adequate proof that the Federal Bureau of Investigation and the military and naval intelligence services did not have the espionage and sabotage situation well in hand during this long period. Nor is there any denial of the fact that not one person of Japanese ancestry was accused or convicted of espionage or sabotage after Pearl Harbor while they were still free, a fact which is some evidence of the loyalty of the vast majority of these individuals and of the effectiveness of the established methods of combatting these evils. It seems incredible that under these circumstances it would have been impossible to hold loyalty hearings for the mere 112,000 persons involved—or at least for the 70,000 American citizens—especially when a large part of this number represented children and elderly men and women. Any inconvenience that may have accompanied an attempt to conform to procedural due process cannot be said to justify violations of constitutional rights of individuals.

I dissent, therefore, from this legalization or racism. Racial discrimination in any form and in any degree has no justifiable part whatever in our democratic way of life. It is unattractive in any setting but it is utterly revolting among a free people who have embraced the principles set forth in the Constitution of the United States. All residents of this nation are kin in some way by blood or culture to a foreign land. Yet they are primarily and necessarily a part of the new and distinct civilization of the United States. They must accordingly be treated at all times as the heirs of the American experiment and as entitled to all the rights and freedoms guaranteed by the Constitution.

## 9. Esther (Takei) Nishio Describes Returning to the West Coast, 1944

ESTHER (TAKEI) NISHIO: Organizations like the American Legion, Daughters of the American Revolution, Sons and Daughters of the Golden West, that sort of organization would all protest my return. But I never ran into anyone in particular. But I did run into ordinary citizens, and they would spit at me or call me "Jap" or something in that order. But my friends would ask them, "Why are you doing that?" They would say because—well one person said, "Well, when I went to a vegetable stand before the war and bought cauliflower or something, it made me sick!" It was very stupid! So it was just ignorance.

And there was one little old lady, in particular, who[m] I would run into at the bus stop. She would always call me, "Jap", and [say,] "Get out of here!" And one day she slapped me. One of my school friends said, "Why did you [do] that!" She said, "Because she's a Jap!" And he said, "Well, she's a better American than you are!" So there were people who stood up for you. And I understand that the other girls who came after me to school had the same experience. Some people would stare at them, call them names, and slap them. One girl said she even received a threatening phone call. So I guess things still hadn't settled down yet

DARCIE IKI: So about how long do you think the controversy continued after you first—?

ESTHER NISHIO: Well, I'm not sure. It didn't last too long, maybe a month or so. And there were letters pro and con, and a lot of servicemen would write to me and they would encourage me. I understand that when the American Legion was in Glendale it announced that they would march on Pasadena and protest. The Pasadena American Legion ordered them to stay away because their veterans—some of them had served in the Pacific—and they said they had fought for the rights of people like us. And they didn't want anybody interfering with citizen's rights.

IKI: And this is the Pasadena American Legion?

ESTHER NISHIO: Um hm. Well they were against my returning at the beginning but I think, after all this controversy, they came to realize that they were fighting the wrong war. I guess when things were really hot and heavy, students who had been in the South Pacific that returned to school were in an organization called the Amvets. And they kind of acted as a—not an honor

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*REgenerations Oral History Project, Volume 2: Los Angeles Region* (1999).

guard, but they would escort me from class to class just to be sure that I was safe during that time.

IKI: Mmm. That's amazing.

ESTHER NISHIO: Mmhm. And, I guess, during that time Mr. [Hugh] Anderson's family had received many threatening calls. One of the papers in Pasadena had apparently printed their home address in every issue. So there would be streams of cars driving past their home to catch a glimpse of me, or Mr. Anderson's family, and so they had a very rough time. Dr. [John] Harbeson, who was the principal of the school, also received threatening calls. According to Mr. Anderson, Dr. Harbeson called one night [and said] that he received a bomb threat, and would I please—would he please ask Esther Takei to leave Pasadena, and go to Nebraska to attend school. He said, "I'll arrange it so they'll accept her there."

IKI: This is what Mr. Harbeson said?

ESTHER NISHIO: Dr. Harbeson asked Mr. Anderson. And so during that period, I guess when it was really bad, Mr. Anderson had his family visit relatives in another city. I stayed with another family [that] happened to be Mr. Walt Raitt's family. He was the advisor of the Student Christian Association. So I stayed with him for about five to 10 days, during the worst time.

IKI: So what is this like for you? You're nineteen years old and all of this is happening all around you? And, I mean it must have been such an adjustment on so many different levels?

ESTHER NISHIO: Well, I can't remember exactly, but it must have been difficult to study and go to school (laughter). It was interesting reading the articles and seeing how they would argue about having someone like me coming back, because they would consider me an alien. And it took servicemen to point out that there is a difference. [They pointed out] that they were treating an American citizen in a very terrible way, and they were fighting for all citizens. They were trying to protect the rights of people like us to, you know, go to school where they wanted to go to school.

IKI: That's really great. I mean that's really amazing, because at the same time, there were veterans in other parts of the country who had a completely opposite reaction to the situation.

ESTHER NISHIO: I was really impressed. Because a lot of these servicemen had served, or were serving, in the South Pacific—fighting the Japanese. Yet they were standing up for my rights. And I thought that was so wonderful. I don't remember their names, but lots of servicemen would read about my story. They would either call the Anderson family to see how I was doing, or they would hitch a ride and come to visit me, to protect me. They thought I was being overrun by all these protesters. They were really great!

IKI: Can you tell more about that one young soldier?

ESTHER NISHIO: Well, there was one gentleman who decided he was going to come and rescue me, and so he hopped on a train. I thought he was from the Midwest, but he was from the East Coast, and he came all the way to LA. I met him at the Union Station, and I reassured him that I was fine. I took him to lunch at Philippes* for a beef dip sandwich, and put him back on the train, and he went home. (laughter)

IKI: How did you know he was coming? He had written you?

ESTHER NISHIO: Well, I think he had either written or called me, so we had this date. And then another gentleman that I didn't get to meet was stationed up [in] northern or central California, along the coast. I forgot the name of the station, but he hitchhiked all night and came to Pasadena. Since I was asleep, he met Mr. Anderson. Mr. Anderson reassured him that I was fine, and he hitchhiked his way home again. So there were soldiers like that who really believed in protecting the rights of American citizens. I was so lucky that they were like that!

IKI: And these are—are these Japanese Americans?

ESTHER NISHIO: No, these were Caucasian soldiers. And then, also, I met a lot of 442nd soldiers who had been wounded and were recuperating at a hospital in Pasadena. It was formerly a very ritzy hotel called the Vista Del Arroyo Hotel, right by the Colorado Street Bridge, but they had converted it into an army hospital. So we would go visit these soldiers there. And there were other soldiers who had been wounded and were recuperating. I think they were from Palm Springs or somewhere in that area. They would come to town to see me and encourage me, and then I would, you know, try to take them to see a movie or something while they were in Pasadena.

IKI: Well that must have been incredibly encouraging for you to have all these people—

ESTHER NISHIO: Well, it was uplifting, really, to learn of the human spirit and how people will help you. There were so many people who were so brave. You know, during the war, it was not popular to be pro-Japanese or pro-Japanese American. Yet Mr. Anderson and Mr. [William] Carr who had founded The Friends and the American Way and their group—I think they had about twenty members—they went against public opinion to help the Japanese Americans. And they, I understand wrote letters to all the former Pasadena Japanese families in all the camps and offered to send them whatever they needed. [It was] just to let them know and they would provide it.

*Philippe's Original Sandwich Shop was established in 1908.

And, you know, they did things like that and they were—when I was having my problems on my return, conscientious objectors would write letters to the editor [of] all the papers in support of my going to school here. So a lot people were so good to me. I've said it before, but when I first returned, the members of the black community were so kind to me, and they made things so easy for me to come back. And the Latino churches were so welcoming. It was really nice. I went to the Pasadena Methodist Church. They had all been so good to us.

IKI: So what types of things did the African-American community do?

ESTHER NISHIO: They would invite me to their potluck suppers and things like that. They made me feel welcome. They were really nice.

IKI: That's so great. Were there other organizations or individuals—?

ESTHER NISHIO: The Quakers were very, very cognizant of the plight of the Japanese American, and they were very, very helpful.

## ESSAYS

The following two essays examine the multiple perspectives of Japanese Americans during World War II. The first essay, by Alice Yang, a University of California, Santa Cruz, historian, examines the causes and consequences of Japanese American internment. Yang discusses the role of anti-Asian racism and hysteria following Pearl Harbor in the decision to incarcerate Japanese Americans, and she describes the tense and conflicted conditions within the camps. The second essay, by Michael Jin, an assistant professor of history at the University of Illinois, Chicago, examines the transnational experiences of Kibei, Japanese American citizens born in the United States and educated in Japan, who were branded by U.S. government officials and JACL leaders as disloyal supporters of imperial Japan. While some Kibei protested the mass removal and internment, others cooperated fully with these government orders and were some of the most patriotic internees within the camps. Jin notes that over generalized suspicion of Kibei influenced debates on Japanese American loyalty, the development of internment policies, the creation of a segregation center, and government attempts to strip Kibei of their U.S. citizenship.

### The Internment of Japanese Americans

ALICE YANG

#### From Pearl Harbor to Mass Incarceration: A Brief Narrative

On the morning of December 7, 1941, Japanese Americans learned the shocking news that Japan had attacked Pearl Harbor in Hawaii. Like most Americans, they

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were stunned by the surprise assault that destroyed America's Pacific fleet. As Americans of Japanese ancestry, however, these immigrants and their children, American citizens by virtue of their birth in the United States, also feared retaliation. Even before the smoke had cleared from the ruins at Pearl Harbor, Federal Bureau of Investigation agents began rounding up suspected "enemy aliens" throughout Hawaii and the West Coast. Most of those arrested were male immigrants put under surveillance a year before the attack because they were leaders of the ethnic community—Japanese Association officials, Buddhist priests, Japanese-language teachers, and newspaper editors. In the weeks following the declaration of war, the FBI arrested more than two thousand of these Japanese immigrants and ten thousand immigrants from Germany and Italy suspected of belonging to pro-Nazi or fascist organizations.

The FBI interrogated these immigrants and sent those considered "dangerous" to internment camps administered by the Department of Justice.... The largest of these camps, the one in Crystal City, Texas, also interned many of the 2,264 Japanese Latin Americans deported from their countries so that the United States might exchange them for Americans held by Japan in 1942 and 1943.

The Justice Department camps held about 10 percent of all Japanese immigrants from the West Coast. Many of these immigrants questioned the fairness of their hearings.

All hopes of returning home, however, were dashed when they learned in March 1942 that all Japanese Americans on the West Coast would be interned in separate camps run by the War Relocation Authority (WRA).

Ultimately, 120,000 Japanese Americans, two-thirds of whom were citizens, were interned in one of ten WRA camps. Why did the U.S. government decide to remove and confine people from the West Coast solely on the basis of their Japanese ancestry? Most scholars now agree that this decision was not simply the product of wartime hysteria but reflected a long history of anti-Japanese hostility fueled by economic competition and racial stereotypes....

The attack on Pearl Harbor and the rapid succession of victories by Japanese forces in the Pacific rekindled the embers of anti-Japanese sentiment.

As Americans struggled to make sense of these losses, news accounts of the attack on Pearl Harbor fanned the flames of hatred against Japanese Americans. Secretary of the Navy Frank Knox told the press of an effective "fifth column"* in Hawaii, even though his official report contained no such charges. The report remained classified, and the government did nothing to allay the fears spawned by Knox's remarks as headlines blared "Secretary of Navy Blames Fifth Column for the Raid" and "Fifth Column Treachery Told." Further misleading the public and contributing to the "official" validation of sabotage suspicions were declarations by a committee of inquiry on Pearl Harbor, led by Supreme Court Justice Owen J. Roberts, that Japanese spies had helped the enemy during the "sneak" attack. Newspapers began reporting wild rumors about the bombing of Pearl Harbor as "facts." The *Los Angeles Times*, for example, announced that

* *fifth column*: a covert group or faction of subversive agents.